

The Appearance

Volume II

A Mystical Adventure Novel

Alexander Lunin

Series “Terra Incognita”. Book One

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Chapter XXIII. The Hunt in the Papyrus Thickets

Four Years Before the Drought

The Nile came early that year and came generously.

I remember it as clearly as I seem to remember nothing else of those years - as though my memory, which gives up everything else so reluctantly, had kept that year in a separate casket wrapped in fine linen, and took it out only so that later, in the drought, there would be something to compare with. The water rose in a single night - the keeper of the nilometer, Seti, ran to the palace himself, without a messenger, in nothing but a loincloth, out of breath, barefoot, and shouted from the very gates so that the whole court heard: "Sixteen cubits! Sixteen! The barley will be fed to the donkeys!" He was four years younger then, and still knew how to run.

Sixteen cubits. A perfect flood. The kind that comes once in a generation. When the water covers all the fields but does not flood the villages. When the earth, laid bare after the ebb, becomes so black and fat that a grain thrown into it sprouts in three days.

The whole Valley was green that year. Not scorched brown, as now, not cracked, but green - lush, thick, moist, to the very horizon where the green butted against the yellow wall of the desert as the sea butts against a shore. The canals stood full to the brim. Dragonflies flew over the water - blue, green, gold. Lotuses bloomed so densely that on some channels no water could be seen. And in the Delta, in the north, where the river splits into seven branches before going out into the Great Green, there in the Delta stood thickets of papyrus taller than a man, and in them lived birds.

Millions of birds.

* * *

“Does my Pharaoh deign to shoot or to throw?” asked old Mehi, the huntsman, not raising his head from the boat he was inspecting - finger by finger, stalk by stalk.

The boat was made of papyrus - bundles of stalks tightly bound with cords of palm fibre, with the prow and stern curved upward, light as a leaf, flat as a palm. In such a boat one could pass where no wooden barge could go: through shallows, through thickets, along channels two cubits wide.

Mehi was old even then. Dry, sinewy, smoked by the sun to the colour of old leather, with hands covered with small scars from fishhooks, and with one ear - the other, as he told everyone who asked, a crocodile had bitten off when Mehi was twelve. “I found him afterward,” he always added. “Thirty years later. Knew him by a tooth that was missing. My tooth. I knocked it out when he bit off the ear. We looked at each other a long time. Then he swam away. I didn’t touch him. He was old already. Like me.”

“Throw,” I said. “Like the ancestors.”

Mehi grunted contentedly and handed me a throwing stick - curved, flat, of heavy black wood, with the end carved in the shape of a snake’s head. Such sticks had lain in the tombs of Pharaohs since time immemorial - with them birds were struck in the thickets, thrown so that the stick, spinning, flew over the water and brought down two or three at once.

“And the cat?” I asked.

“The cat is ready, my Pharaoh.” Mehi nodded toward the stern.

In the stern, on a rolled mat, sat a cat. Huge, spotted, reddish-grey, with tufts on its ears and such green eyes that it seemed the thickets were reflected in them. His name was Mau - simply “cat,” as, it seems, all hunting cats in the Delta are called. He looked at the thickets, twitching his tail, and from time to time made a quiet, throaty, impatient sound - not a mew but rather a growl.

“He knows better than I where the birds are,” said Mehi proudly. “I throw - he fetches. Twenty years like that. He is my third Mau. The first was better. The second - lazy. This one - sly. Sly is better than lazy. Worse than the best.”

* * *

There were many of us that day. Too many for a hunt, Mehi said, grumbling under his breath - birds take fright when there are more than three boats on the water. But I was Pharaoh, and Pharaoh did not hunt alone.

In the next boat - Senusret. Not yet commander of the whole army, then, but commander of my personal guard - younger than now by four years, with fewer wrinkles and the same stone face. He did not hunt. He sat in the stern with a spear on his knees and looked not at the birds but at the thickets around me - at every shadow, at every stirring of the reeds.

"Senusret," I said. "Throw a stick at least once. For pleasure."

"My pleasure, my Pharaoh," answered Senusret, not taking his eyes from the thickets, "lies in your returning from the hunt with the same number of ears you have now. Unlike the honourable Mehi."

Mehi giggled, not in the least offended.

In the third boat - Paser. Not yet an old man with a staff, but a sturdy, greying man, commander of the chariotry, who, the moment he stepped off a chariot, felt on water as uneasy as a fish on sand, and sat in the boat clutching its sides with both hands, with a face greenish as young papyrus.

"Paser," I called. "Are you unwell?"

"I, my Pharaoh, am always unwell where there is no ground underfoot and no horses ahead," Paser answered gloomily. "Horses at least understand where they are being led. And this bundle of reeds..." he slapped the side of the boat with disgust, "this bundle of reeds thinks only of how to drown me."

"It will not drown you, honourable one," said his oarsman, a young fisherman with white teeth. "Papyrus does not sink. It may overturn. But it will not sink."

"Comforting," muttered Paser.

And in the fourth boat, the smartest, with gilded sides and a canopy of fine linen - Khaemuas. Then he was some twenty, perhaps a little more. Young, handsome, cheerful, the son of a noble family from the Delta, who had just received his first post at court - junior charioteer - and was immeasurably proud of it. His bracelets already jingled on both arms, though not as many as now. He laughed, joked, threw his stick - clumsily, but with such zest that spray flew in all directions - and I,

looking at him, thought that what the court lacked was precisely such men: light, carefree, not afraid to laugh before Pharaoh.

I could not know then what he would turn into in four years. No one could. And if someone had told me, I would not have believed it.

Though perhaps I should have. Because even then, on that sunny day, in a pause between throws, Khaemuas, laughing, said to his oarsman - loudly enough for me to hear:

“My father says we owe the temple of Ptah so much that the priests will soon take our fields. And I say - let them take them! Then I’ll have a new bracelet. For a third arm!”

The oarsman laughed. Khaemuas laughed. I smiled too, then - the joke was merry.

Only now, four years later, recalling that day, I do not smile.

* * *

And in the smallest boat - narrow, old, with peeling sides - behind everyone, almost unnoticed, sat a boy.

I paid him hardly any attention that day. A boy of thirteen or fourteen, thin, dark-eyed, in a plain linen apron, with a writing board on his knees and a reed brush in his hand. A junior pupil of the scribes, sent by the senior scribe of the Library to record the hunt - how many birds, which, by whom struck - as is the custom to record all that Pharaoh does. The boy wrote with his head bent, and every so often rubbed his cheek with the brush, forgetting that the brush was inked, so that by midday his face was all black spots, like Mehi’s spotted cat.

I remembered him only because at some moment - when the boats stopped in a quiet channel to wait out noon - he suddenly raised his head and looked at me. Straight. For a long time. Not as one looks at Pharaoh - with lowered eyes, with reverent fear - but as if he wanted to remember. As if he were drawing me with his gaze on that board lying on his knees.

And then he saw that I was looking at him - blushed to the roots of his hair and buried his nose in the board.

I did not know his name then. I did not ask.

* * *

The birds rose at noon.

Mau suddenly arched his back, flattened his ears, made a thin, ringing sound - and in that same instant out of the thickets, ten paces from us, with a deafening noise, with splashing, with cries, a flock burst up. Ducks, geese, herons, ibises, some small motley birds - hundreds, thousands - the sky over the channel darkened with wings.

“Throw, my Pharaoh!” cried Mehi. “Now! Throw!”

I threw. The stick left my hand - spinning, humming, snake’s head foremost - and I saw it pass through the flock, saw two ducks fall into the water, tumbling. Mau leapt from the stern before they touched the water - straight into the thickets, into the reeds, into the mud - and a moment later surfaced with a duck in his teeth, wet, plastered with slime, happy.

Khaemuas threw, missed, laughed, threw again. Paser clutched the sides and shut his eyes. Senusret did not stir - he watched the thickets, where no one but the birds moved.

And the boy in the last boat wrote. Quickly, not looking at his board. He looked at the sky, at the flock, at me - and wrote.

And then happened what I afterward recalled many times.

One of the herons - huge, grey - darted right over the last boat, low, almost touching heads with its wings. The boy threw up his hand, shielding himself - the boat rocked - the board slipped from his hands - he reached for it, leaned over the side - and the light, peeling little papyrus boat overturned.

He went under without a single sound.

I do not remember how I came to be in the water. I remember only that the water was warm, muddy, full of silt, that papyrus stalks lashed my face, that somewhere behind me Senusret was shouting - “My Pharaoh! My Pharaoh!” - and that my fingers felt in the murky water a thin arm and clutched it.

I pulled him out. The boy was light as a reed. He coughed, choked, spat out water and silt, and his face, covered with ink spots, was white as linen. I held him above the water, standing chest-deep in the channel among lotuses and reeds, in clothes that cost more than his whole clan - and he looked at me with huge dark eyes.

“The board,” he rasped. “My Pharaoh... the board...”

“What board?” I laughed, not knowing why myself. “You nearly drowned, and you think about a board?”

“It’s written there...” He coughed again. “It’s written there how many birds my Pharaoh struck. If it sinks - no one will know. As though the hunt had never been.”

Senusret was already paddling up to us in his boat - white as the boy, with his spear ready. Mehi was shouting something. Khaemuas was roaring with laughter. And I stood in the water holding in my arms this absurd, ink-smearred child who, having nearly drowned, worried that my hunt would be forgotten - and suddenly felt something I could not name. As if I had held him like this once before. Long ago. In other water.

Mau, wet, plastered with slime, surfaced beside us out of the thickets. In his teeth was the board.

* * *

We saw the hippopotamus toward evening.

Mehi took us there on purpose - to a broad, deep backwater on the edge of the thickets, where the water was dark and still, and above it, like black boulders, backs protruded. Three. No, four. Huge, grey, glistening, with small ears which from time to time twitched, shaking off flies.

“They trample the fields,” said Mehi, lowering his voice to a whisper. “In the last flood four villages were left without a harvest. These beasts eat in a night what a village eats in a month.” He paused. “The priests say - this is Set. The evil god. He turns into a hippopotamus. When Pharaoh hunts a hippopotamus - he is like Horus striking Set. For his father. For Osiris.”

“Do you believe that, Mehi?”

The old huntsman shrugged.

“I believe that a hippopotamus killed my brother, my Pharaoh. Overturned the boat and bit him in half. Whether Set was in the hippopotamus - I don’t know. But my brother is gone.” He held out to me a harpoon - long, with a copper head, tied to a coil of rope. “Horus struck Set for eighty years. My Pharaoh can finish in a single evening.”

I took the harpoon.

I know how this was supposed to look - like on the walls of tombs: Pharaoh stands in the prow of a papyrus barge, proud, calm, with a harpoon raised over his head, and below, in the water, the vanquished

beast writhes. That is how my predecessors were drawn. That, no doubt, is how I shall be drawn.

In fact it looked otherwise. The hippopotamus rose from the water right in front of our boat - suddenly, soundlessly, huge as a house - and opened its jaws. The jaws were pink. I remember that. Pink as an infant's, and in them two tusks, long, curved, yellow, each as long as my arm. The wave rocked the boat. Mehi cried out. Sensusret, in the next boat, leapt up with his spear.

I threw the harpoon.

I do not remember whether it hit. I remember only that the rope pulled taut, jerked, burned my palms, that the boat was dragged, spun, that Mehi hung on the rope together with me, that the water around turned red - and that the hippopotamus, uttering a roar that shook the thickets, went into the depths and did not show itself again.

The rope went slack. At its end, when Mehi hauled it from the water, there was no harpoon.

"Gone," said Mehi. Without disappointment. Almost with relief. "Wounded, but gone." He looked at me. "My Pharaoh, this is good."

"Good?"

"The priests say: Horus strikes Set but does not kill him. Never. Eighty years he strikes - and does not kill. Because if Set dies - the world loses its balance. There will be only order, only Maat. And the world cannot live on order alone. Chaos is needed too. A little. So that order remembers why it is needed." Mehi spat into the water. "So the priests say. I say: the hippopotamus is gone, and everyone is alive. That is better than the hippopotamus dead and someone missing an ear."

* * *

We spent the night on an island in the middle of the Delta - a sandbar overgrown with palms, where servants pitched tents and lit fires.

There, by the fires, I first saw Nefer-Ka as High Priest.

The old High Priest had died half a year before that flood - quietly, in his sleep, at ninety. Nefer-Ka had received his staff only three moons earlier. He sailed to the island at sunset, on a separate barge, accompanied by junior priests - to wish Pharaoh a good hunt and to bring the blessing of the gods. He was four years younger then, but looked

exactly as he does now: tall, straight as an obelisk, with an immobile face and with eyes in which nothing could be read.

“My Pharaoh,” he said, bowing exactly as far as custom required. Not a finger lower. Even then. “I hear you plunged into the water to save a child.”

“A scribe,” I corrected.

“A scribe,” Nefer-Ka agreed. “Noble.” He paused. “But careless. Pharaoh is a living god. Son of Ra. Incarnation of Horus. If you had drowned in a channel saving a scribe-boy - what would the gods have said?”

“That Pharaoh saved a scribe,” I answered.

Nefer-Ka gave me a long look. Then smiled - with that same smile which I afterward came to know so well: condescending, patient.

“The gods, my Pharaoh, speak in other words,” he said. “But I will convey yours to them.” And, already turning away, he added quietly, as if to himself: “A living god who forgets that he is a god. Curious.”

He sailed away at dawn. I attached no importance then to his words.

* * *

But the main thing that night happened not by the fires, but afterward, when all had fallen asleep.

I did not sleep. I lay on a mat at the very water's edge, behind the tents, where it was quieter, and looked at the sky. The sky over the Delta that night was such as I seem never to have seen again: black, bottomless, and in it - stars. So many stars that between them there was hardly any blackness. And across the whole sky, from edge to edge, flowed a pale, shimmering, misty river.

“The Heavenly Nile,” said someone beside me.

I turned. On the sand, two paces from me, sat an old man in the long white robe of a priest, with a shaven head, with some wooden rod in his hands - with a slit at one end and a plumb line on a thread. I had not heard him come.

“Seneb,” he introduced himself, neither rising nor bowing, which by day would have been insolence, but at night, on the sand, by the water, somehow did not seem insolent. “Observer of the night hours from Heliopolis. I was sent with the High Priest - to watch the stars over the

Delta. Here they are seen better than in the city.” He raised the rod, squinted through the slit at some star. “Does my Pharaoh not sleep?”

“My Pharaoh does not sleep,” I said. “Tell me about the sky, Seneb.”

The old man lowered the rod. Was silent.

“The sky is Nut,” he began slowly, as one begins a long-learned lesson, but his voice was warm, without any boredom. “A goddess. She stands over the earth, arched, resting her hands on the west, her feet on the east. The stars are ornaments on her body. And every evening she swallows the sun. Ra enters her mouth in the west and all night goes inside her body - through twelve hours, through the twelve gates of the Duat. And in the morning she bears him again - in the east. Red. Like an infant.”

“Every day,” I said.

“Every day, my Pharaoh. Since the beginning of time.” Seneb raised his hand and pointed to the misty river across the sky. “And this is her milk. Or the Heavenly Nile, along which souls sail. Depending on who is telling.”

He showed me three bright stars in a row - a belt - and around them several more, composing the figure of a man striding across the sky.

“Sah,” said Seneb. “Osiris. The god whom his brother killed, tore into pieces, scattered across Egypt. And Isis gathered him. Piece by piece. And revived him - for one night, to conceive Horus by him. And then Osiris went away. Became king of the dead.” He paused. “But every night he rises in the sky. There he is. Striding. Never stopping.”

“And behind him?”

Seneb moved his hand lower, to the left, to where above the very horizon, at the edge of the earth, a star shone - brighter than all, white, shimmering, as if winking.

“Sopdet,” he said softly, almost tenderly. “Isis. The wife. She always follows him. Always one step behind. Never catches up. But never lags.” He paused. “Each year she vanishes from the sky for seventy days. And then returns - at dawn, just before the sun, over the eastern horizon. And on the day she returns, the flood comes.” He smiled. “This year she returned right on time. And the Nile came to sixteen cubits. A good year. A very good year.”

I looked at the white star by the horizon. Isis, who always walks one step behind. Never catches up. Never lags.

“Seneb,” I said. “Do you believe that Pharaoh is a living god?”

The old man was silent for a long time. So long that I thought he had fallen asleep.

“My Pharaoh asks a dangerous question,” he said at last. “If I say ‘no’ - I may be executed. If I say ‘yes’ - I shall lie. Because I do not know.”

“Say what you think. There is no one here. Only we and Nut.”

Seneb smiled.

“I think, my Pharaoh,” he said, “that gods are like stars. They can be seen only when it is dark. By day, in the sun, no one looks at the sky. Everyone thinks of bread, of beer, of taxes. And at night, when it is dark, they look up and see gods.” He paused. “Pharaoh is the one at whom people look when it is dark for them. When there is drought. When war. When plague. They look at Pharaoh and see a god. Because they need to see a god.” He raised the rod to his eye again. “And whether there is truly a god in Pharaoh - that I do not know. Perhaps Pharaoh himself knows.”

“Pharaoh does not know,” I said.

Seneb lowered the rod and looked at me - for the first time in the whole conversation directly, attentively.

“Then he is a good Pharaoh,” he said. “The bad ones always know.”

* * *

He showed me one more thing - just before dawn, when Sah was already going down behind the horizon and the sky in the east was beginning to grey.

“Do you see, my Pharaoh?” Seneb pointed north, at stars standing high above the horizon. “These do not set. Never. All the others sink in the west, die, are born again in the east. And these - circle. Around one point. All night. All their lives. Ever wakeful.”

“The Imperishable,” I said.

“The Imperishable.” Seneb nodded. “The ancients said: after death Pharaoh becomes one of them. That is why in the oldest tombs there are shafts directed straight at them. Narrow as a needle. So that the soul of Pharaoh knows where to fly.” He paused. “But my teacher, the old observer, told me something else. He said that the Imperishable are not

those who have gone. They are those who have not yet come. Who circle round the earth and wait for their hour. To descend. As the First Ones descended.”

“The First Ones, who came down from the Heavens,” I said.

“You know the Epic, my Pharaoh,” Seneb nodded. “Of course. You are of them, after all.”

I flinched.

“What does it mean - of them?”

The old man shrugged - as if he had said something self-evident.

“All Pharaohs are of them, my Pharaoh. So it is written. The blood of the First Ones. Descendants of those who descended.” He paused, looking at the sky. “Though my teacher said it is not quite so. He said - not descendants. He said - the same ones. That the First Ones do not die. They go to the Imperishable - and descend again. In another body. In another time. And each time forget who they are.” Seneb smiled. “My teacher was a strange man. He was afterward sent to observe the stars in the farthest temple by the southern cataracts. For heresy.”

By the southern cataracts. The rock that herdsmen give a wide berth.

But then, that night, I knew nothing yet of any Rock.

* * *

The sun rose from behind the eastern edge of the Delta - huge, red, wet, as if Nut had just given birth to it. The lotuses on the channel opened their petals one after another to the light - white, blue, pink. A mist rose over the water. Somewhere in the thickets birds were crying.

Seneb had gone to his barge, never having bowed. The camp was waking. Mehi was grumbling over the boats. Khaemuas, sleepy, was laughing, splashing water on his face. Paser looked gloomily at the river, plainly calculating how many more hours he would have to spend on a bundle of reeds. Senusret - I knew without looking - stood somewhere behind my back with his spear.

And at the very water’s edge, on the sand, sat the scribe boy. With the board on his knees which Mau had fished out for him. He was writing. Noticing that I was looking at him, he blushed again, but this time did not look away.

I went up to him.

“What are you writing?”

He silently held out the board to me. On it, in neat, small signs, everything was recorded: how many boats, how many birds, by whom struck. The hippopotamus who had gone with the harpoon. And at the very end - a line that did not relate to the hunt.

“Pharaoh pulled a junior scribe out of the water. The scribe promises to remember this all his life. Even if Pharaoh forgets.”

I raised my eyes to the boy.

“Why ‘even if he forgets’?”

The boy lowered his head.

“Because Pharaohs save many,” he said quietly. “And the scribe was saved once. Pharaoh may forget. The scribe - will not.”

“What is your name?”

He opened his mouth to answer.

“My Pharaoh!” Senusret’s voice rang out. “The barges are ready! The High Priest has sent word - they are waiting in the capital!”

I turned to the voice. And when I turned back - the boy was already being called by the senior scribe, and he, bowing hurriedly, ran off to his peeling little boat, pressing the board to his chest.

I never learned his name. I forgot his face within a moon - among the thousands of faces that passed before the throne. I forgot him altogether.

And only now, four years later, in the drought, sitting in the dark Library beside the junior keeper of scrolls who always has ink on his cheek - only now did I suddenly remember that day. The channel. The warm muddy water. The arm, light as a reed. And the dark eyes that looked at me as if drawing me on a board so as not to forget.

“The boy from the Library remembers a great deal for you,” old Amenemope had said. “More than you think.”

The Nile that year came to sixteen cubits. And I did not remember. Four years - I did not remember.

But he remembered. All four years.

Vision IV. The Circle

I do not know where I came from to that village.

That is the first thing worth saying - and, perhaps, the only thing I am sure of. I remember the road: white, chalky, dusty, leading up a gentle green slope. I remember the stagecoach that set me down at the crossroads, and the coachman who, having taken his fare, long looked after me and crossed himself. I remember the smell - of mown grass, of sheep's wool, of rain that had passed an hour ago and promised to return. But where I boarded that coach, and why, and who I was to be riding in it with one travelling bag - that I do not remember. As I did not remember at the very beginning of all my other journeys either.

The village was called Amesbury. So it was written on the peeling wooden signboard of the inn where I was given a room under the very roof - with a bed on which every spring creaked, with a window that looked out on a river, narrow, dark, unhurried, overgrown with willows, and with a view - there, beyond the river, beyond the fields, on the horizon, on the ridge of the chalk plain - of something grey, uneven, barely discernible in the haze. As though someone had set stone teeth along the edge of the world.

"The stones," said the landlady, noticing where I was looking. "Everyone looks that way. They come, they look, they go. You too, sir? For the solstice?"

"The solstice?"

The landlady - Mrs Hobbs, stout, rosy, in a frilled cap and an apron on which flour mingled with beer stains - threw up her hands so that a little white cloud fell from her.

"Lord, sir, don't you know? The day after tomorrow is the longest day of the year! The shortest dawn! The sun rises right over the Heel

Stone and shines into the very middle of the circle! All the madmen of England gather to see it.” She lowered her voice. “This year there are especially many. A learned man from Oxford. Gypsies. A young lady with some machine on a tripod. Our vicar goes about blacker than a thundercloud - says it’s paganism. And my husband says, paganism or not, the lodgers pay promptly and drink their beer, and thank you very much.”

She set a jug of water on the table, adjusted the curtain and, already in the doorway, turned back:

“Only don’t go there at night, sir. Especially alone. People say you mustn’t count there.”

“Count?”

“Count the stones,” said Mrs Hobbs in perfect earnest. “Whoever counts them twice and gets the same number will die. And whoever gets a different one will go mad. And whoever doesn’t count at all never came here.” She paused. “My late father-in-law counted. Three times. Different each time. Died at ninety-six, in his own bed, but to his dying day swore that the stones move from place to place at night.” She tittered. “Well, he drank too. Good night, sir. Supper at seven. Kidney pie.”

* * *

Downstairs, in the common room of the inn, by seven o’clock there had gathered a company that any novelist would have thought too motley to be plausible.

At a large oak table by the fireplace, heaped with papers, drawings, rulers, compasses and something resembling a brass spyglass without lenses, sat a man whom I at once christened to myself the Owl. About sixty, bald as a billiard ball, with a fringe of white down above the ears and such luxuriant grey whiskers that they reached almost to his chin. On his nose sat spectacles, over them yet another pair, and a third stuck out of the breast pocket of his tweed jacket. He was calculating something furiously, moving his lips, and from time to time exclaiming “Incredible!” or “It can’t be!”, each time striking the table with his fist so that the compasses leapt.

“Professor Erasmus Holloway,” whispered Mrs Hobbs, setting a pie before me. “From Oxford. Came to measure the stones. Third week he’s been measuring. Says the ancient people were astronomers. The vicar says the ancient people were savages. They’ve nearly come to blows twice already.”

At the next table, straight as a pole, in a black frock coat and white collar, sat the vicar himself - the Reverend Silas Whitcombe. Thin, pale, with pursed lips and an expression as though the whole world were personally guilty before him. He ate his pie in small, reproachful bites and from time to time cast at the professor glances capable of freezing the Thames.

In the corner, by the window, on a bench, sat a young woman in a dark green travelling dress, with short, almost boyish hair sticking out from under a small hat - a thing unheard of for a respectable lady - and with hands black to the wrists, as though she had been rummaging in soot. Beside her on the floor stood a bulky wooden box on a tripod, wrapped in black cloth, and several smaller boxes from which came something sharp, apothecary-like - ether.

“Miss Ada Lovell,” Mrs Hobbs went on whispering. “A photographer. From London. Alone! Without a companion! Her hands are black from those chemicals of hers - says it’s silver. The vicar says it’s indecent. She says what’s indecent is his sermons.” The landlady tittered. “I like her. She pays for her beer in advance.”

And by the very fireplace, on a three-legged stool, leaning on a long shepherd’s crook, sat an old man - so old, wrinkled and weathered that he seemed hewn from the same grey stone that stood on the ridge of the plain. In a rough canvas smock, in an old felt hat, with a white beard to his waist, he smoked a clay pipe and looked into the fire, paying no attention to anyone. At his feet, curled up, lay a shaggy black-and-white dog.

“And that is old Jedediah,” said Mrs Hobbs, very quietly, almost with reverence. “A shepherd. All his life he’s pastured sheep on the plain, right by the stones. They say he’s ninety. Or a hundred. No one knows. He doesn’t seem to know himself. He knows everything about the stones. Only tells no one.” She paused. “And today he came himself. For the first time in ten years. Sat down by the fire and sits. As though waiting for someone.”

Professor Holloway noticed me after about five minutes. He raised his head from the drawings, looked at me over two pairs of spectacles - and his eyes flashed with that particular hungry gleam with which the eyes of scholars flash on finding a fresh victim.

"You!" he exclaimed, jabbing a compass at me. "You have come for the solstice? Excellent! Excellent! Sit down! You must see this! No one in this village listens to me!"

To refuse was senseless. I moved over to him.

"Look!" He unrolled before me an enormous sheet covered with circles, lines, angles and figures. "Here is the circle. The sarsens - the big stones. Here - the bluestones, the small ones, inside. Here the horseshoe of trilithons. And here - the axis!" He drew a ruler along the plan. "The axis of the whole structure is directed exactly - exactly, sir! - at the point of sunrise on the day of the summer solstice. Through the Heel Stone. Do you understand what that means?"

"That the builders knew where the sun rises?"

"That the builders were astronomers!" cried the professor, striking the table with his fist. "Scholars! They built a calendar! A stone calendar! Four thousand years ago! When in Egypt they were only just building the pyramids!"

At the word "Egypt" something in me trembled. Columns. Sand. Heat. I blinked - and the vision went.

"Nonsense," said the Reverend Whitcombe in an icy voice from the next table, not raising his eyes from his pie. "These stones were set up by the Druids for their vile pagan sacrifices. Or by the Romans. Or - most probably - by the Evil One himself, as the tradition has it."

"Druids!" the professor turned purple. "The Druids lived two thousand years later! The Romans - three! And the Evil One, Reverend, so far as I know, is not strong in trigonometry!"

"The Evil One is strong in all that leads the soul away from God," the vicar snapped. "Including your trigonometry."

They looked at each other across the aisle like two cocks across a fence. Mrs Hobbs behind the bar rolled her eyes. Miss Lovell in the corner laughed soundlessly, covering her mouth with a palm black from silver.

“And do you know the tradition, sir?” the vicar suddenly asked, turning to me. “About the Heel Stone?”

“No.”

“The Evil One,” said the vicar, savouring each word, “bought these stones from an old woman in Ireland. He paid her as many coins as she could count while he carried the stones. And he carried them in an instant. The old woman managed to say only ‘one.’ And the Evil One set the stones here on the plain and boasted: ‘No one will ever know where they came from!’ And a friar hiding behind a stone cried out: ‘That is what you think!’ The Evil One seized the largest stone and hurled it at the friar. Hit him on the heel. Ever since, the stone has been called the Heel Stone.” The vicar triumphantly sipped from his mug. “The friar, mark you, survived. Because he was under God’s protection.”

“And in my opinion,” a ringing woman’s voice suddenly came from the corner, “that story was made up by the monks. So as not to admit that they have no idea who really hauled those stones.”

Miss Lovell rose, came up to our table and without the slightest embarrassment sat down on a free chair.

“There is another legend,” she said, looking at me with mocking grey eyes. “About Merlin. King Arthur’s wizard. That these stones once stood in Ireland, on a mountain, and were called the Giants’ Dance. And the giants brought them from Africa - because there was a power of healing in the stones. If you poured water over a stone and then washed a sick man with that water - he would recover. And Merlin moved them here, to England - not with his hands but with a song. Or with machines.” She winked at the professor. “Depending on who is retelling it.”

“From Africa,” I repeated slowly.

“From Africa,” Miss Lovell nodded. “The giants - from Africa. The stones - from Ireland. The wizard - from Wales. The sun - from the sky.” She shrugged. “Here everything is from somewhere. Nothing is from here. Even you, as I see.”

“Me?”

“You have the face of a man who has come from everywhere at once,” said Miss Lovell. “I photograph people. I know faces. Yours does not hold one expression longer than a second. As if three men lived in it by turns.” She tilted her head, examining me as she must examine

through the lens of her box. "May I photograph you? The day after tomorrow. At dawn. At the stones."

"Why?"

"Because," she said simply, "I am curious which of the three will come out on the plate."

* * *

Old Jedediah by the fire had not stirred all this time. But when the conversation died down - when the professor had buried himself in his drawings again, the vicar in his pie, and Miss Lovell had gone to the bar for another mug of beer - the shepherd suddenly took the pipe out of his mouth and, without turning his head, said in a low, hoarse voice like the creak of old wood:

"You. Come here."

The room went quiet. Mrs Hobbs behind the bar dropped her towel.

I went over. Crouched by the fireplace, beside the dog, which raised its head, sniffed my hand - and suddenly licked it, briefly and warmly, as one licks one's master.

"Shep knows you," said the old man, glancing sideways at the dog. "Shep licks no one. Not even me." He drew on his pipe. "Want a riddle? An old one. My grandfather set it to me. And his grandfather to him. And that one - I don't know who. Maybe the one who set up the stones."

"I do."

Jedediah let out smoke and spoke slowly, in a singsong, in the old local dialect, which I understood with difficulty, but understood:

"Giants stand in a ring, holding hands. Above - crossbeams, below - grass. They are counted, and cannot be counted. At night they walk, by day they stand. Once a year one of them opens an eye. What does it see?"

I thought for a long time. The fire crackled. The dog laid its muzzle on my knee.

"The sun," I said at last. "Once a year, at the solstice, the sun rises over the Heel Stone and shines into the circle. As if an eye opens."

Jedediah was silent a long while. Then slowly shook his head.

"The answer is the sun," he said. "Everyone answers so. The professor answered so. The girl with the box answered so. Everyone." He

took out the pipe and jabbed it at me. "But my grandfather said: wrong. The eye opens not to see the sun. The sun it sees every day anyway. The eye opens to see the one who has come. Once a year. Or once in a hundred years. Or once in a thousand." He stuck the pipe back in his mouth. "Grandfather said: the stones were set up not for the sun. The stones were set up for the guest. So that he would know where to come."

"What guest?"

"The one who comes from above," said Jedediah simply. "And leaves from above. And each time does not remember that he has been before."

A chill ran down my back - that same one, long familiar, from under the ribs, on the left.

"Did your grandfather see him?" I asked.

"My grandfather - no." The old man paused. "But I did."

"When?"

"Seventy years ago. I was twenty. I was pasturing sheep by the stones on the night of the solstice. Alone. Shep was another one - also Shep, all our dogs are Sheps." He stroked the dog's head. "And toward morning a man came. From the side where there is no road. Young. In strange clothes. Stood in the middle of the circle. And waited. And when the sun rose - from above, right over him, a light opened. White. Not sunlight. And there was a sound - as though the very earth hummed. And heat." Jedediah closed his eyes. "And then - nothing. Sun, grass, sheep. And the man gone."

"Perhaps you dreamed it?"

"Perhaps," the old man agreed. "Only Shep - the earlier one - howled for three days after. And on the spot where the man stood, the grass did not grow for ten years. A round patch. Like this." He spread his hands. "The professor says it's chalk. The vicar says the Evil One. And I say - the guest."

He fell silent. Then, not looking at me, he added:

"He had your face, lad. I have remembered it seventy years. Yours."

* * *

That night I did not sleep. I lay on the creaking bed, listened to the willows by the river rustling outside the window, and looked at the

ceiling over which moon shadows slid. Somewhere below a door banged. Somewhere a horse neighed.

Toward morning there was a soft knock at my door.

On the threshold stood a woman - short, swarthy, with jet-black hair braided in two thick plaits, twined with red ribbons and strings of small coins that jingled at every movement. She wore a motley dress, a red kerchief, copper rings on her fingers, huge earrings in her ears. She might have been forty, and might have been seventy - impossible to guess: her face was young, and her eyes ancient.

"Zora," she said before I could ask. "A gypsy. The camp is across the river. I have come to tell your fortune."

"I did not call you."

"I know." She smiled, flashing a gold tooth. "No one ever calls me. I come to those to whom I must." She held out her hand palm upward. "Give me your hand. Don't be afraid. I will take no money. From such as you, one doesn't take."

I gave her my hand. I do not know why.

She took it in hers - dry, hot, laden with rings - turned it to the light from the window and looked for a long time. Was silent. Moved a finger. Then raised her eyes to me - and in them there was neither cunning nor mockery.

"There is no life line," she said quietly.

"I have been told," I said. And was astonished myself - who told me? Where? I did not remember. But I knew that someone had.

"There is no life line," Zora repeated. "But there is something else. Here." She drew a nail across my palm, in a circle. "A ring. A line that goes round and comes to where it set out from. I have seen such once. My grandmother showed me. She told the fortune of a man who had such a ring. Long ago. Here. At the stones."

"Who was he?"

"Grandmother did not know." Zora let go of my hand. "Grandmother said to him: 'You walk in a circle, handsome. A hundred times you came, a hundred times you went. And each time you forget.' He laughed. Asked: 'And how can I stop forgetting?' Grandmother said..." Zora paused. "Grandmother told him a riddle. I will tell you the same."

She leaned toward me so close that the coins in her plaits jingled right by my ear.

“What must one do to get out of the circle?”

I thought. For a long time.

“Break it?”

“No,” said Zora. “You break it - you will walk a new circle.”

“Stop?”

“No. You stop - the circle will go on without you.”

“Then I don’t know.”

Zora straightened. Smiled - sadly.

“Grandmother did not know the answer either,” she said. “But that man told her the answer. On leaving. He said: ‘One must remember where the beginning is.’” She shrugged. “Grandmother said - a circle has no beginning. So there is no getting out. And he laughed and said: ‘This one has.’”

She went to the door. Stopped.

“The day after tomorrow, at dawn,” she said without turning, “do not stand in the middle. Stand at the edge. By a stone. Hold on to the stone. Perhaps then they will not take you.” She paused. “Or perhaps they will. As they took grandmother’s.”

And left, jingling her coins.

* * *

The whole of the next day I spent at the stones.

Up close they proved bigger than I could have imagined - grey, rough, eroded by the winds, overgrown with yellow and white lichen like ancient old men with beards. Some stood. Some lay, fallen, as if tired of standing. On some, at a height of three men, lay stone crossbeams - just as huge - and I could not understand how people who had neither machines nor steam nor iron had managed to raise them there.

Professor Holloway darted among the stones with rulers and plumb lines like a maddened bumblebee, shouting figures which were written down after him by a boy hired in the village - flaxen-haired, freckled, forever open-mouthed. Miss Lovell set up her box on its tripod by the Heel Stone, paced out the distance, squinted at the sky and murmured something about light. The Reverend Whitcombe stood apart, by the road, arms folded on his chest, with the air of a man who had come to

make sure that the thunder of heaven would strike these heathens after all. The gypsies stood camped by the river, singing and burning fires.

And old Jedediah sat on his stool right in the middle of the circle, smoking his pipe and looking at the sky.

I decided to count the stones. I do not know why myself. Perhaps from obstinacy. Perhaps because of Mrs Hobbs and her father-in-law.

I counted slowly, touching each stone with my palm. The big ones. The small. The standing. The fallen. The crossbeams. It came to eighty-three.

I counted again. Eighty-one.

I counted a third time - still more slowly, marking each stone with a chalk stroke from a piece of chalk I had found right there in the grass. Eighty-five.

I stood in the middle of the circle holding the piece of chalk and felt a chill creep up my spine.

"Doesn't add up?" asked Jedediah, not turning.

"Doesn't add up."

"And never will," said the old man calmly. "They don't like to be counted. They're not for that." He took out the pipe. "You found chalk?"

I looked at the piece in my hand. White, soft, staining the fingers.

"I did."

"All the ground here is chalk," said Jedediah. "And in the chalk - flint. Black." He bent down, groped with his hand in the grass by his stool and held something out to me. "Here."

It was a stone. Flint. Black, smooth, almost round, with a white chalk crust at the edge, as if in a shirt.

"White and black," said the old man. "Chalk and flint. One soft, the other hard. One writes, the other strikes fire. Here they are always together. One in the other." He stuck the pipe in his mouth again. "Put them in your pocket. Both. They'll come in handy."

I put them in. A piece of chalk and a piece of flint. White and black.

They lay in my pocket side by side, as though they had always lain there.

* * *

In the evening, at the inn, for want of anything better to do - and because everyone was too excited to sleep - they played charades. English ones, real ones: not riddles in words but a performance in faces. The setter acted out a word syllable by syllable, silently, with gestures, and the others guessed.

Professor Holloway was the first to volunteer - and portrayed something so incomprehensible, leaping, flailing his arms and jabbing a finger at the ceiling, that after ten minutes everyone gave up, and it turned out to be the word “astronomy,” which he had been trying to act out in parts: “astro” - a star, “no” - a refusal, “my” - no one ever understood how he intended to show “my.” The room roared with laughter to tears. Even the vicar, against his will, twitched the corner of his mouth.

Then Mrs Hobbs set one - the word “pie” - and acted it so expressively, chewing the air with such relish, that it was guessed at once, and the professor’s boy ran to the kitchen to check whether any pie was actually left.

Then, to everyone’s amazement, the vicar rose. He stood a long time in the middle of the room, straight as a pole. Then slowly, solemnly, he portrayed - in gestures, without a single word - an angel. Arms spread like wings. Gaze upward. Then - a fall: he dropped to one knee, bowed, covered his face with his hands. Then - rose. Portrayed searching for something, looking around. Then pointed at me.

The room went quiet.

“‘Fallen,’” said the professor uncertainly. “‘Angel’?”

The vicar shook his head. Pointed at me again.

“‘Wanderer’?” suggested Mrs Hobbs.

The vicar shook his head.

“‘Guest,’” said Miss Lovell quietly.

The vicar slowly nodded. And sat down in his place without a word. And for the rest of the evening never once looked in my direction.

“What was that?” Miss Lovell whispered to me.

“I don’t know,” I said.

Old Jedediah, sitting by the fireplace, laughed quietly - for the first time in all that time. Dryly, as branches crackle in a fire.

“The parson saw too,” he said into the fire, to no one in particular. “Seventy years ago. He was a lad then. The bell-ringer’s son. Ran after

me to the stones that night. He saw. He's just been pretending for forty years that he didn't." The old man drew on his pipe. "Parsons are good at pretending."

* * *

An hour before dawn we stood at the stones.

The sky in the east was barely beginning to lighten - not pink, not gold, but that grey, pearly, ghostly light with which the sky glows in the shortest night of the year, when night hardly comes at all. The grass was wet with dew. It smelled of chalk, sheep and the smoke of gypsy fires. Over the plain lay mist - low, white, knee-deep - and the stones rose out of it like islands out of the sea.

There were many of us. The professor with his rulers and the boy. Miss Lovell at her box on the tripod, under the black cloth, with a plate that she had just flooded with something from a dark flask. The Reverend Whitcombe - by the road, but nearer than yesterday. Mrs Hobbs with a basket of pies, "in case it is the end of the world - so as not to be on an empty stomach." The gypsies - in a semicircle, at a distance, in silence, without songs. Zora among them - I saw the coins in her plaits glint. And Jedediah - on his stool, in the very middle of the circle, with the dog at his feet.

"Stand here," Miss Lovell said to me, pointing to a place between two huge stones, right on the axis that led from the Heel Stone to the middle of the circle. "The light will be here. Don't move when I say. The exposure is five seconds. For my silver that is eternity."

"Do not stand in the middle," Zora had said. "Stand at the edge. Hold on to the stone."

I stood where Miss Lovell indicated. On the axis. Between two stones. But I stretched out my hand and laid my palm on the cold, rough stone, wet with dew, to my right. And did not take it away.

"It's coming!" shouted the professor. "It's coming! Look!"

Over the horizon, right over the Heel Stone, the edge of the sun appeared. Red, enormous, trembling in the morning haze. And from it through the mist, across the grass, across the whole circle, a strip of light stretched to us - long, straight, golden, like a taut string. It fell on the Heel Stone. Then farther. Nearer. Nearer still.

The professor sobbed with delight, waving his ruler. His boy stood with his mouth open. Miss Lovell dived under the black cloth.

“Don’t move!” came dully from there. “One!”

The beam touched my feet.

“Two!”

And in that moment - not from the east, not from the sun - from above, right over me, a light opened.

* * *

I do not know how to describe it otherwise. It did not come - it opened. As an eye opens. White, blinding, so bright that the sun beside it seemed a dim candle-end. It poured from above, from the very middle of the sky, where the last, paling stars still remained - in a straight pillar, down, into the middle of the circle, and I stood at its edge.

There was no sound. At first. And then there was - not a sound, a hum. The earth underfoot began to hum like an enormous bell struck from inside. The hum passed through the soles, through the knees, through the spine - to the very teeth. The stones around me vibrated. I felt it with my palm - the stone under my hand trembled like a living thing, like the flank of a great beast.

And heat. Not the sun’s - another. From within. As though someone had lit a fire in me, in the very middle of the chest, where people have a heart, and I - I did not know what I had there. The heat grew, rose, flooded the whole body - and in my pocket, I felt it through the cloth, the piece of chalk and the piece of flint grew hot. So hot that were they in my hand I would have dropped them.

And then the voice came.

It came from above - from the light. Not in words - in vibration, in hum, in heat, all at once. It spoke. I knew that it spoke. I felt each word - with my whole body, with every bone, every drop of blood. But I could not make out a single one. They slid into one another without pauses, without borders, like water pouring over stone, like the flowing lines of a pattern I had seen somewhere, sometime - on paper, on stone, on metal...

And through the hum, through the heat, through the dazzling whiteness I suddenly understood: this voice I had heard before. Not here.

Not now. Sometime. When he stood by my bed. When he spoke to me in this same language. When he said one single word that I understood.

“Remember.”

I wanted to answer. I wanted to cry out: I do not remember! I do not know what to remember! Tell me! But my throat clenched, and there was no voice.

The light above me began to narrow. The pillar grew thinner, brighter. It called. It drew. I felt my feet leaving the ground - no, not my feet, something else, something inside, as though I were being drawn out of myself, as a thread is drawn from a needle.

And only the hand - the hand that lay on the stone - held.

The stone under my palm was cold. The only cold thing in all that fire. I clung to it - with fingers, with nails, with all I had. Zora had said: hold on to the stone. And I held.

“Not now,” I rasped. Or thought. “Not now. I have not remembered yet.”

The light froze. For one moment - long, endless, like all my forgotten life.

And then - went out.

* * *

“...five!” Miss Lovell’s muffled voice reached me from somewhere far off, from under the cloth. “That’s all! You may breathe!”

I stood between two stones, on the axis, in the beam of the rising sun. An ordinary sun - red, warm, morning. The mist was melting over the grass. Somewhere sheep were bleating. Professor Holloway was leaping round the Heel Stone shouting: “Exactly! Exactly on the axis! I was right!” Mrs Hobbs was handing out pies. The gypsies were beginning to sing.

No one had seen anything.

No one - but three.

Old Jedediah stood by his stool - he had risen, for the first time in all that time - and looked at me. The dog at his feet was not howling - it lay with ears pressed down, looking the same way.

Zora stood among the gypsies, her palm pressed to her mouth. The coins in her plaits did not jingle - she did not stir.

And the Reverend Whitcombe - at the very edge of the circle, nearer than he had come in all those days - knelt in the wet grass. His lips moved. He was praying. Or weeping. I could not make out which.

I took my hand from the stone. On the grey lichen, where my palm had lain, a print remained. Scorched. Dark. Five fingers.

And on the grass at my feet, where I had stood - around me, in a ring - the grass was withered, yellowed, as if singed by fire. A round patch. Like this.

* * *

Miss Lovell developed the plate by noon - in her dark room under the roof of the inn, where it smelled of ether and silver. She came down into the common room holding the plate by its edges with the tips of her fingers, and her face was white as her chemicals.

She laid the plate on the table before me.

On it were the stones. The mist. The beam of sunlight from the Heel Stone. All of it crisp, sharp, silvery grey.

And where I had stood, between two stones - I was not there.

There was a silhouette. Tall. Immeasurably tall - above human height, almost to the lintel of the trilithon. Grey. Blurred at the edges, as if moulded of mist and ash. Faceless.

And a hand - one hand of his, stretched out to the side, lay on the stone.

"Five seconds," whispered Miss Lovell. "Five seconds of exposure. In five seconds a man may move, and the image will blur. But he cannot become..." she faltered, "...like this."

I looked at the plate. At the grey faceless silhouette. At the hand on the stone.

I knew him. I had seen him - at my bedside, on the balcony, in the alley, in the street. I had seen him... where? I did not remember. But I knew.

"Who is it?" asked Miss Lovell.

Jedediah, standing by the fireplace, answered for me. Not turning, looking into the fire.

"The same," said the old man. "Only later."

I did not understand. No one understood. Miss Lovell looked at the old man, then at me, then again at the plate.

"May I keep it?" she asked quietly.

"Keep it," I said. "Someone must remember."

* * *

I left Amesbury the next morning. The stagecoach waited at the crossroads. The coachman - the same one - again crossed himself, looking at me.

Mrs Hobbs wrapped a kidney pie for me for the road. Professor Holloway shook my hand and asked me to write if I should "ever find confirmation of the astronomical theory," and I promised, knowing that I would not write. Miss Lovell did not come to see me off - but on my bag I found a small photographic card. Not that one. Another. On it was one stone - the one I had held, with the dark print of a palm on its lichen. And on the back, in pencil, in her hand: "So that you do not forget what to hold on to."

The vicar did not come. But as the coach was already moving, I saw him at the churchyard fence - he stood straight as a pole, in his black frock coat, and, meeting my eyes, slowly, as if with effort, raised his hand and made the sign of the cross over me. Not as over the Evil One. As over a traveller.

Zora I did not see. Only at the very crossroads, on a roadside post, hung a red ribbon with copper coins strung on it. I do not know whether it was hers. I did not take it.

And old Jedediah stood on the ridge of the chalk plain, right by the stones, leaning on his crook, with the dog at his feet - a tiny figure against the grey giants - and looked after me. He did not wave. He simply looked. As one looks at one who is leaving, knowing that he will return. In a year. In a hundred years. In a thousand.

I thrust my hand into my pocket. The chalk and the flint lay there side by side - cooled, ordinary. White and black.

"One must remember where the beginning is," that man had told the gypsy's grandmother.

The coach lurched over a rut, and the stones on the horizon vanished in the morning haze - as though they had never been.

And I, it seems, for the first time in my life knew that I would return.

Chapter XXIV. Another Life

We returned from the General's estate on Friday, and on Saturday my aunt held a literary evening.

Literary evenings in the province were what they called gatherings at which literature occupied, by Konstantin's reckoning, about one seventh of the time - the other six parts were divided among tea, gossip, pastries, music, flirtation and disputes about whose turn it was to choose the next book. My aunt and Vera Anatolievna had been giving them for some ten years, once a fortnight, and over those years the evenings had grown rituals, as an old oak grows moss: they always read in the green drawing room, always aloud, always by turns, always in French, and then always argued in Russian.

"Today it is Jules Verne," Konstantin announced to me at breakfast, spreading butter on a roll with the air of a man condemned to hard labour. "'Around the World in Eighty Days.' Evdokia Gerasimovna brought it from Paris. An Englishman bets that he will go around the whole globe in eighty days. By train, by steamer, by elephant. Can you imagine? By elephant!"

"And did he go round?"

"I don't know." Konstantin bit into his roll. "Last time we read up to the place where he saves an Indian widow from being burned. Kutasova wept. Lizonka wept. Shelestova said that the widow surely set fire to her husband herself. The General said that in India they haven't done that for forty years, the English forbade it. The Colonel told how once in Bukhara..." Konstantin waved his hand. "In short, we never did get to the elephant."

"I will read it to the end," I said.

“Don’t you dare!” Konstantin was horrified. “You’ll spoil the whole intrigue! All evening you’ll sit with the face of a man who knows how it ends!”

“I almost always sit with such a face anyway.”

Konstantin looked at me over his roll - and stopped smiling.

“No, mon cher,” he said quietly. “You sit with the face of a man who knows that he has read this book before. Only does not remember when. That is different.”

* * *

By seven o’clock the green drawing room was full.

It was called green for its wallpaper - dark green silk with a gold pattern, faded in half a century to the colour of pond duckweed - and for its furniture, upholstered in green velvet, and for the huge ficus in a tub by the window, which Agafya Tikhonovna watered personally, trusting no one, and which, rumour had it, remembered my aunt’s father-in-law. Candles burned in two bronze candelabra. On the little table by the fireplace stood tea, liqueur, pastila and a dish of almond biscuits baked by Marfa the cook after a recipe inherited, she asserted, from a great-grandmother who had served Potemkin himself.

My aunt sat in her chair by the fireplace - in dark lilac, with pearls, a book on her knees. She looked tired. In the week of my absence she seemed to have aged a year. When I came in she raised her eyes to me - quickly, greedily, as if checking whether all of me had returned - and at once lowered them to her book.

“Did you rest well, my friend?” she asked.

“Well, Aunt.”

“The roses?”

“The roses,” I said. And, after a pause: “Stefan asked me to convey his bow to you.”

Her fingers on the book cover froze for a moment.

“Thank you,” she said. And nothing more.

Around us the guests were taking their seats. Evdokia Gerasimovna - in a hat with an ostrich feather dyed an unimaginable emerald “to match the drawing room.” Nadezhda Porfirievna Kutasova - with a lorgnette, with Lizonka and, to Konstantin’s horror, with the obvious intention of

sitting closer to him. Olga Kirillovna Shelestova - in lilac, with a fan, with the face of a cat who has been promised a whole jug of gossip. Doctor Strauch - in the corner, with an unlit cigar, as always at a distance from the ladies' company but within earshot. Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich - by the table with liqueur, already telling someone about Turkestan.

And Vera Anatolievna.

She sat by the window, under the ficus, a little apart from everyone, in a plain dark grey dress without any ornament except a small brooch in the shape of a dragonfly. Vera Anatolievna always sat by the window - as if just in case, so as to be first to see if anyone approached the house. Quiet, affable, with a soft face and with eyes which, as I had long noticed, never looked at a conversational partner directly for longer than a moment - and then slipped off somewhere sideways, like little fish.

Today they did not slip. Today she looked at me. From the very minute I came in.

* * *

They read by turns. First Evdokia Gerasimovna - briskly, with a Parisian accent, doing the voices. Then Lizonka - timidly, stumbling, blushing at every line. Then Strauch - evenly, drily, with a German accent, turning French prose into something like a medical report, at which Konstantin choked with laughter into his fist.

Then they came to the elephant.

The Englishman, Mr Fogg, bought an elephant for two thousand pounds - "Two thousand pounds!" gasped Kutasova. "For an elephant! Why, for that money you could buy an estate!" - and rode on it through the Indian jungle, with his imperturbable French servant.

"Impossible," said the Colonel, tossing back a glass. "Absolutely impossible. I have ridden an elephant. In Bukhara. The Emir gave it. In half an hour my back gave out, and in an hour my legs. That Englishman would not have gone ten versts."

"The English, Mikhail Ivanovich," remarked Strauch from his corner, "ride elephants from childhood. As we ride in troikas."

"And I have seen an elephant!" Lizonka squeaked. "In the menagerie, in Petersburg! It ate a bun!"

“All elephants eat buns, my dear,” said Shelestova, fanning herself. “Even English ones. Especially English ones. Their cooking, they say, is dreadful.”

Everyone laughed. Except Vera Anatolievna. She sat by the window, her hands clasped on her knees, and looked at me.

Then my aunt read. And reached a place that made the whole drawing room fall silent.

“...and then Mr Fogg understood,” she read quietly, in French, “that by moving all the time east, toward the sun, he had gained a few minutes from time every day. And over the eighty days of the journey those minutes had added up to a whole day. He returned to London a day earlier than he had thought. He had gained one day by going round the Earth.”

My aunt fell silent. Laid down the book.

“How is that - gained a day?” Lizonka asked in confusion. “Can that be?”

“It can,” said the General. He had come in last, quietly, and was now sitting by the door, in shadow. “I know. When we were crossing the Pacific on the Diana, our navigator said one morning: ‘Gentlemen, tomorrow will be today again.’ We were going west, toward Japan, and crossed some line on the map - and we lost a whole day. We went to bed on Monday and woke on Wednesday. There was no Tuesday.” The General paused. “The crew joked then: whoever had meant to sin on Tuesday had missed his chance forever. And on the way back, they say, it is the other way round: two Tuesdays in a row. Whoever sinned yesterday may sin once more, and it will not count.”

The drawing room laughed. But my aunt did not laugh. She looked into the fire.

“If one goes toward the sunrise for a long time,” she said suddenly, quietly, to no one in particular, “one comes to where one set out from. Only a day earlier. Or a day later.” She paused. “Or a life.”

No one understood what she meant. Except, perhaps, the General, who gave her a long look. And except me - because somewhere very deep, under the ribs, on the left, something long familiar stirred. A riddle I had never heard. Two went out of one house - one to the sunrise, the other to the sunset. Where did they meet?

At home.

Then there was an interval - tea, pastila, Marfa's almond biscuits - and Olga Kirillovna, of course, could not miss the chance.

"Is it true," she sang out, floating up to me with a cup in one hand and a fan in the other, "that you, my dear, spent a whole week as a guest at Pavel Nikolaevich's? At the estate? With that... Bulgarian?"

"True."

"And that this Bulgarian," Shelestova lowered her voice to a theatrical whisper audible in the next province, "is a sorcerer? Varvara Petrovna told me, and she was told by the steward's wife from the estate, that he walks round the roses at night with a lantern and whispers incantations. And that in his greenhouse..." she rounded her eyes, "an altar! A pagan one! With wreaths of thread!"

"That is a martenitsa, Olga Kirillovna," I said. "A Bulgarian custom. In spring they tie red-white threads so that the year will be healthy."

"Red-white!" Shelestova threw up her hands so that tea splashed from the cup. "Blood and snow! I tell you - a sorcerer!"

"And besides," said Konstantin, who had come up imperturbably, "in his greenhouse lemons grow. Also, evidently, sorcerous ones. Sour. Like you, Olga Kirillovna."

Shelestova gasped. Konstantin gave her an impeccable bow and led me off to the window before she could recover.

"You've gone mad," I whispered. "She will spread it all over the province."

"Let her spread it," Konstantin shrugged. "About me she spreads anyway that I drink, gamble and run after actresses. One more bit of gossip, one less." He paused. "But about you now for a whole month she will say only one thing: that your friend is a boor. And that, mon cher, is better than 'went mad in the left wing.'"

And then I understood that Konstantin had brought me not simply to the window. He had brought me to Vera Anatolievna.

She sat in the same place, under the ficus, and looked up at us. Konstantin bowed to her.

"Vera Anatolievna," he said. "You wanted to speak with my friend. I saw. All evening you wanted to." He looked at me. "I will stand by the door. So that no one disturbs you."

And went off - before either of us could object.

* * *

Vera Anatolievna was silent a long time. I sat on a chair beside her. Outside the window it had grown quite dark, and in the glass the drawing room was reflected - candles, figures, the fire in the fireplace - as if out there, beyond the window, were another room, another evening, other people.

"You have grown thinner," she said at last. Quietly. Not looking at me. "In a week."

"The air," I said. "The General says one grows thin from air."

"One grows stout from air," said Vera Anatolievna. "One grows thin from thoughts." She paused. "Or from memory."

I did not answer. She was turning in her fingers the dragonfly brooch, unpinned from her dress.

"May I ask you," she said. "One thing. A foolish one. You will laugh."

"I will not laugh."

She raised her eyes to me. And this time they did not slip away.

"Have we not met before?" she asked. "Not here. Not in this house. Not in this..." She faltered. And suddenly smiled - crookedly, awkwardly, as one smiles when afraid of one's own words. "Not in this life, let us say. In another."

She said it half in jest. In the light salon tone in which one speaks of fortune-telling and the transmigration of souls, fashionable in the capital. But her eyes did not jest. In her eyes there was alarm - real, unfeigned, deep as water in a well.

"Why do you ask?" I said.

Vera Anatolievna did not answer for a long time. Then she laid the brooch on the windowsill. Opened the reticule that lay on her knees - small, velvet, embroidered with beads. Took something out of it. Flat. Wrapped in tissue paper.

"I draw," she said. "In watercolour. Badly, but I draw. Since childhood. All young ladies draw." She unwrapped the paper. Inside was a sheet of thick paper, yellowed at the edges. "Fifteen years ago, when I had only just married Mishenka, we went to Constantinople. Mishenka

accompanied Pavel Nikolaevich. Some mission, I did not quite know. We lived in Pera, in the embassy house. And I walked about the city and drew. Mosques. Bazaars. Boats on the Bosphorus.” She paused. “And once, in the port, I drew a man.”

She held the sheet out to me.

* * *

It was a watercolour. Small, the size of a palm, quick, light - a few strokes, but precise, sure, as by someone who drew not for beauty but to remember.

A narrow street descending to the water. Houses - the lower storey stone, the upper wooden, projecting slightly forward. Washing on a line between windows - red, yellow, turquoise. And in the middle of the street, back to the water, face to the viewer - a man.

Young. In a dark red turban with a tassel. In dark, almost black trousers. In a light travelling cloak. In burgundy velvet shoes. In his hand was a scrap of paper - a small white spot of paint. And on the face...

The face was drawn quickly, in a few strokes. But I knew it.

I saw this face every morning. In the mirror.

My throat went dry. Letters, words, thoughts - all vanished. I sat holding a sheet of paper and looked at myself - in strange clothes, in a strange street, in a strange city that I had never seen. Fifteen years ago.

Fifteen years ago I could not have been there.

“He stood in the middle of the street,” said Vera Anatolievna quietly, “and looked about. Lost. As though he did not know where he was. I stopped to draw him - I liked the colours, that red turban against the white wall. He noticed me. Looked. For a long time. And said something.” She paused. “In a language I did not know. Not Turkish, not Greek, not French. Something... flowing. Like water. And then he turned away and went down the street, to the old men who were playing dice on a carpet.”

Old men on a carpet. Backgammon. Suleyman and Yusuf. The names came by themselves - from nowhere - and went again at once, I did not manage to hold them.

“I returned there a week later,” Vera Anatolievna went on. “On purpose. I wanted to finish the drawing. He was there. In the same place.

In the same clothes. Looking about just as lost. As though the week had not passed. As though it were the very same day.” She clasped her hands. “I went closer. He looked at me - and did not recognize me. Not at all. Looked through me, as through glass. As though I were not there.”

“And you...”

“And I left. Mishenka finished his business, and we went home. I put the drawing in my reticule. And forgot.” She paused. “Fifteen years I did not remember. And then, last winter, Artemia Aristarkhovna invited us to an evening. And you came into the drawing room.”

She looked at me. Straight.

“I nearly fainted,” she said. “Mishenka thought - from the stuffiness. All evening I could not look at you. And at home I took out the drawing.” Vera Anatolievna shook her head. “The same face. The very same. Only you were then, it seems, just the age you are now. Fifteen years ago. And now. The same.”

* * *

I did not know what to say. I held the watercolour, and my hands trembled, and the colours on the paper - the red turban, the white wall, the turquoise linen - swam before my eyes.

“Perhaps someone similar,” I said at last. My voice was alien. “There are similar people. Doubles.”

“There are,” Vera Anatolievna agreed. “I tell myself so. For a year already. Every evening.” She took the drawing back from me - carefully, with two fingers. “Only here is the thing. When you came into the drawing room that time, the first time, last winter - you looked at me. With the very same look. As that one in the street, the first time. Lost. As if not knowing where you are.” She paused. “And then - a minute later - you looked through. As he did the second time. As though I were not there.”

I remembered. No - did not remember. Felt. That evening, last winter. The drawing room. Candles. A woman in grey by the window, under the ficus. A strange, fleeting feeling that I knew her. And at once - as though a curtain had dropped, and the feeling had gone.

“I do not know what this means, Vera Anatolievna,” I said.

“Nor do I,” she said. And suddenly smiled - truly, warmly, with relief, as though she had thrown from her shoulders a sack she had carried for fifteen years. “I do not know. And you do not know. So we are not mad. The mad always know.”

She put the drawing back in her reticule. Pinned the dragonfly brooch to her dress again.

“May I give it to you?” she asked. “The drawing. Not now. Someday. When you know what to do with it.”

“Why not now?”

“Because now I need it,” said Vera Anatolievna simply. “To tell myself in the evenings that I have not gone mad.” She paused. “And when you find out who you are - then I shall no longer need it.”

* * *

“Verochka!” the Colonel thundered from the table, already well fortified by liqueur. “Verochka, what are you whispering about with the young man? I am jealous!”

Everyone laughed. Vera Anatolievna flushed pink and laughed too - lightly, in society fashion, as if nothing had happened.

“Mishenka,” she said, “I am telling the young man how we went to Constantinople. Do you remember?”

“Constantinople!” The Colonel beamed and at once came up to us, carrying his glass like a banner. “How could I not remember! That was, young man, the hottest month of my life. Hotter than Turkestan! We lived in Pera, by the embassy, and Verochka ran off every day into the city to draw. Alone! Without an escort! I nearly lost my mind.” He lowered his voice, but not enough. “Once she came back white as chalk and said she had seen a ghost in the street. A living man who was a ghost. I said - sunstroke. Ordered her to lie in the dark with a wet towel.”

“And I lay,” said Vera Anatolievna meekly.

“Three days she lay!” the Colonel confirmed triumphantly. “And on the fourth she got up - and ran off to the city again. To the same place. I found her afterward - sitting on some carpet with old men, drinking tea and playing dice. Dice! A colonel’s wife!” He guffawed. “Those old men saw me - and began treating me too. I drank so much of their tea that for a week afterward I couldn’t look at a samovar.”

“Old men,” I said. My voice sounded from somewhere far away. “What old men, Mikhail Ivanovich?”

“Who knows!” The Colonel shrugged. “Turks. Two. One merry, with a beard, always smiling. The other - dry as a stick, forever counting something on an abacus.” He slapped his forehead. “Wait, wait! The merry one said something to Verochka too. Through a boy interpreter. Something like... Verochka, what did he say?”

Vera Anatolievna was looking at me. For a long time. Without turning away.

“He said,” she spoke slowly, “If another comes - feed him.”

* * *

In the drawing room they went on reading. Kutasova had already taken the book and was reading how Mr Fogg crosses the ocean on a steamer that has to be broken up for firewood to feed the boilers - “To burn one’s own ship!” gasped Lizonka. “How dreadful!” - “What enterprise,” Strauch corrected. And I sat by the window, under the ficus, beside Vera Anatolievna, and looked into the dark glass in which the drawing room was reflected.

“If another comes - feed him.”

I had never heard those words. I was sure of it. And yet they sounded in me as though I had heard them a thousand times. In different languages. In different cities. From different old men.

Doctor Strauch came up to me when the reading was over and the guests began to depart. Stood beside me at the window, twirling his unlit cigar.

“I heard,” he said quietly. “Not all of it. But I heard.” He paused. “I should like to see the watercolour. As a physician.”

“As a physician?”

“As a physician, young man, I am obliged to tell you that fifteen years ago you were a child, if not an infant. And that this is either a very similar man, or very strong suggestion, or...” He faltered. “Or a third thing, for which there is no name in my textbooks.”

“And as not a physician?”

Strauch looked a long time into the dark window.

“As not a physician,” he said at last, “I shall tell you that Vera Anatolievna is the soberest person in this province. Soberer than I. She does not see ghosts. She does not believe in mediums. She does not read horoscopes.” He turned to me. “And if for fifteen years she has carried your portrait in her reticule - I in your place, young man, would not hurry to call it suggestion.”

* * *

My aunt stopped me in the corridor when everyone had gone. Alone. With a candle in her hand.

“Vera spoke with you,” she said. Not a question.

“She did.”

“About Constantinople.”

“About Constantinople.”

My aunt was silent a long while. The candle trembled in her hand, and her shadow on the wall trembled with it - huge, black, broken.

“Did she show you the drawing?” she asked at last.

I froze.

“You knew?”

“I knew,” said my aunt. “Fifteen years I knew. Vera showed it to me in the very first year after she came back. Asked whether I knew this man.” My aunt paused. “I said - no.”

“You lied.”

“I lied,” said my aunt. Calmly. Without remorse. “Then.” She raised her eyes to me. “And now I shall tell you the truth, my friend. Not all of it. All of it I do not know. But the part that I do.”

I waited. My heart pounded so that it seemed it must be heard throughout the corridor.

“I saw him,” said my aunt. “That man. From the drawing. Too. Before Vera. Much before.” Her voice wavered. “He stood by the railings. In the left wing. On that night. He was holding by the hand...” She faltered. “He was not alone. With him was another. Tall. Grey. Faceless.” My aunt swallowed. “And the tall one said to me: ‘This one is the same. Keep him safe. He will forget. Do not remind him. When he remembers - he himself will come for him.’”

“Who - himself?”

"I do not know," my aunt whispered. "I do not know which of the two is 'himself.' The tall one or the one he held by the hand. Or..." She did not finish.

The candle in her hand suddenly crackled, and the flame lay over on its side - though there was no draught in the corridor.

"Go to bed, my friend," said my aunt. In an almost ordinary voice. Almost. "It is late. And..." She touched my cheek with cold fingers laden with rings - as she had touched it in childhood. If I had had a childhood. "I love you. Whatever may be. Whoever you may be. Remember that. At least that."

"I remember," I said.

She nodded and went off along the corridor, carrying the candle. Her shadow slid along the wall - huge, broken - and for a moment it seemed to me that this shadow was taller than it should be. Much taller. As if someone else were walking beside her.

I blinked. The shadow was a shadow.

* * *

By the door of my room Konstantin sat on the floor - leaning against the wall, legs stretched out, with a bottle of liqueur with only a little left in the bottom.

"Long," he said. "I waited."

"Did you hear?"

"Not all." He held the bottle out to me. I shook my head. He drank it off himself. "I heard 'I love you.' I heard 'whoever you may be.'" He paused. "Mon cher, doesn't it seem to you that in our house there are too many people who love you 'whoever you may be'? Auntie. The General. Stefan. Vera Anatolievna with her watercolours." He set the bottle on the floor. "As if everyone knows that you are somebody. Except you."

"And except you," I said.

Konstantin looked up at me from below.

"And I don't want to know," he said simply. "I don't care who you are. You are you. Who reads books on heraldry and forgets young ladies' patronymics. Who sleeps on the move and smiles at railings." He rose from the floor, swaying. "If it turns out that you are some prince from a

fairy tale, or a ghost, or a Turk in a turban from a watercolour - I shall still sit at your door with a bottle of liqueur. Understood?"

"Understood."

"Good." He clapped me on the shoulder - a little longer than necessary. "Good night, Turk."

And went off along the corridor, whistling something off-key.

I went into my room. Opened the blue notebook. Wrote: "Saturday. Jules Verne. The elephant. The day gained going east. Vera Anatolievna's watercolour - me in a turban, 15 years ago. Old men on a carpet. 'If another comes - feed him.' Aunt saw me at the railings with the tall grey one. 'Whoever you may be.' Konstantin at the door."

Set the full stop. The blot lay in its place.

And on the windowsill - I noticed it only as I reached to snuff the candle - stood a small clay pot. Which had not been there that morning. In the pot, in fresh, moist earth, a cutting stuck up. Thin, green, with three leaves. And with one tiny, tightly clenched bud - dark, almost black.

Beside it, under the pot, lay a note. Crooked, large letters, in Russian, with mistakes:

"Let it grow with you. The rose will find. - S."

Stefan. He had stayed at the estate, at the General's, forty versts from here. He had not come. No one had come.

I looked at the cutting a long time. Then I watered it from the washing jug - carefully, drop by drop. And lay down without undressing, face to the window.

All night I dreamed of a narrow street by the sea. A red turban against a white wall. And a woman in grey, with an album, who stopped to draw me.

In the dream I recognized her. In the dream I knew her name.

And in the morning - I forgot.

Chapter XXV. The Festival of Opet

The god came out of the sanctuary at dawn, and the whole city fell to its knees.

I watched it from the topmost step of the great temple - from where Pharaoh was supposed to stand to greet the god - and I think I shall never forget how it looked: as though a gust of wind had passed over a field of ripe barley. From the temple steps to the very river, along the whole Avenue of Processions, on the roofs, on the walls, on the trees into which boys had climbed since the night - everywhere the eye reached, thousands of people in a single instant sank to their knees and touched their foreheads to the ground. And silence. Such a silence that I heard, far off, by the river, a lone heron cry.

And then the sistra rang out.

* * *

The festival of Opet did not begin in Luxor. Everyone knew this, but few remembered it: before the god sets out to the south, to his southern home, he must come out to the people here, in the capital - show himself, receive gifts, hear petitions. For ten days his barque stands at the great temple, and every day people come to it. And at the new moon the barques set out on their journey along the river.

Ten days. I had ten days.

"My Pharaoh," Senusret whispered to me, standing, as always, at my right hand, a little behind. He was in full ceremonial dress - in a striped headcloth, in a broad collar, with a bronze sword at his belt - but he was looking not at the god but at the crowd. "Two detachments by the Avenue - those very ones. Of those that are to go as the procession's guard. Their commanders have not taken off their scarabs."

I looked where he indicated with his eyes. Below, on both sides of the Avenue of Processions, stood warriors with spears - a living wall dividing the god's road from the crowd. And on two of them, the commanders, something blue glinted on the chest. Temple scarabs.

"I see," I said.

"Khaemuas is standing near them."

I saw that too. Khaemuas, in the finest linen, in the costliest bracelets, stood at the start of the Avenue and was speaking quietly with the commanders. Laughing. Clapping one on the shoulder.

"Let him stand," I said.

* * *

From the dark maw of the sanctuary, from behind the high cedar doors plated with gold, the barque slowly floated out.

Not the real one - the river barque that would bear the god along the Nile waited at the quay. This one was portable: narrow, long, carved of cedar and covered from prow to stern in gold, so that it hurt to look at it in the sun. The prow and the stern of the barque ended in rams' heads - golden, with curled horns, with eyes of lapis lazuli. In the middle, under a canopy of the finest linen, stood a closed shrine - a small temple surrounded by carved figures of gods with outspread wings. Inside, I knew, stood the god. No one but the High Priest and Pharaoh ever saw his face.

The barque was carried on shoulders. Twenty-four priests, twelve on each side, on long poles - shaven, in white, barefoot. They walked slowly, in time with the sistra, and the barque floated above their heads so smoothly that it seemed truly to sail upon water.

And before the barque walked Nefer-Ka.

The High Priest in full vestments - in a leopard skin over white linen, with a staff crowned by the Eye, with a censer in the other hand from which rose thick, sweet, intoxicating smoke. He walked, looking neither at me nor at the crowd. Only forward. And his face was calm, almost serene - the face of a man who has nowhere to hurry.

Behind the barque came the singers. Twenty young priestesses in white, with loose hair, with sistra in their hands - and they sang. Sang so that shivers ran down my back: high, in unison, in a melody ancient as

the temple itself, in which there was not one note familiar to me but which for some reason seemed familiar. Among them - I saw her at once - was Khemu. In the second row, at the edge. She sang like the others. But when the barque drew level with me, Khemu for an instant raised her eyes - and barely perceptibly, almost imperceptibly, lowered her sistrum. Once. Then raised it again.

The sign we had agreed upon through Iti. "Watch closely. Something is being prepared."

* * *

The barque halted at the foot of the steps. The priests lowered the poles onto their shoulders, straightened. Nefer-Ka turned to me and bowed - exactly as far as custom required, not a finger lower.

"Son of Ra," he said loudly, so that all in the square could hear, "the god has come out to his people. Greet him."

I descended the steps. Everything had been learned beforehand, dozens of times, from scrolls brought to me by Ani the Elder, keeper of ceremonies: three steps, a bow, a libation of milk from a golden jug, a libation of wine, the burning of incense, the words of greeting. I did everything as it should be done. My hands did not tremble. Nor my voice. The crowd was silent, holding its breath.

And then Nefer-Ka said what was in no scroll.

"Son of Ra," he said, raising his voice. "The people suffer. Three years of drought. Three years without a flood. The people ask - why? And the people want to hear an answer. Not from the priests. Not from Pharaoh. From the god himself." He turned to the crowd. "The god has come out to you! Ask! The god will answer!"

A rumble rolled across the square - at first timid, then louder, louder, until it turned into a roar.

The oracle. Nefer-Ka had opened the oracle. Right now, on the first day, at the temple steps, before the eyes of the whole city.

I knew how it goes. People come up to the barque and ask a question. The barque answers: if it sways forward, toward the questioner - "yes." If it draws back - "no." If it freezes - the god does not wish to answer. So it had always been. And so it had always been - I knew this,

as every Pharaoh knew - that the priests carrying the barque move as they are bidden.

Senusret behind my back drew in air noisily.

* * *

The first to approach the barque was an old man - grey, bent, in a ragged loincloth. He fell to his knees right at the poles and cried in a hoarse, trembling voice:

“O God! Will the water return?”

The barque swayed forward. Slowly, solemnly. Yes.

The crowd gasped - and burst into cries of joy. The old man sobbed, kissing the ground.

The second to come out was a middle-aged man, in clean clothes, with a blue scarab on his chest. He did not fall to his knees. He stood straight before the barque, drew himself up and cried so loudly that his voice carried across the whole square - too loudly, too clearly, too rehearsed:

“O God! Hast thou turned away from the throne?”

The square froze.

I saw Nefer-Ka, standing at the prow of the barque, barely perceptibly turn his head toward the bearers. Saw twelve priests on the right side slightly tense their shoulders. Saw the barque begin slowly, very slowly, to draw back - from me, from the steps, from the throne. “No.” No - meaning he has not turned away? Or... I did not understand. The crowd did not understand. A whisper ran across the square.

And then happened what no one expected.

One of the bearers - the youngest, in the back row on the left side, a thin youth with a shaven head - suddenly stumbled. His foot turned on a step, he lurched, the pole jerked on his shoulder - and the barque, instead of drawing smoothly back, sharply listed. To the left. Toward the right side of the square. To where beyond the Avenue of Processions, beyond the wall of the temple court, the long, squat roofs of the temple granaries rose.

And froze - tilted, pointing with its golden ram's prow straight at the granaries.

It became so quiet on the square that I heard my own heart beating. Then someone in the crowd cried out - one voice, piercing, a woman's:

"The granaries! The god points at the granaries!"

And the square exploded.

"Bread! The god shows where the bread is!"

"The Temple hides grain! The god has said so!"

"The ambassador from the south spoke the truth!"

"The granaries!"

People leapt up from their knees, shouted, pointed with their hands. Warriors by the Avenue closed their spears, holding back the crowd. The commanders with scarabs on their chests looked about in confusion at Khaemuas. Khaemuas went so white that he became the same colour as his linen.

The bearers hastily straightened the barque. The young priest who had stumbled on the step stood white as chalk and looked at his pole with such horror as if it had bitten him.

And Nefer-Ka...

Nefer-Ka did not stir. He stood at the prow of the barque, the censer in his hand, and his face was motionless as the face of a stone statue. Only the smoke from the censer - I noticed - suddenly ceased to rise in an even thread and began to tear, to jerk, as though the hand holding the censer were trembling.

He turned to me. And for the first time in all the time I had known him, I saw in his eyes what I had never seen there.

Not anger. Not fear. Surprise.

He had not expected this. This had not been his design.

I took a step forward. Raised my hand. The square, seeing it, began to quiet - slowly, in waves, from the first rows to the last.

"The god has spoken," I said, as loudly as I could. "The Temple granaries are already sealed with the royal seal. For the good of the Temple." I paused. "In three days, in honour of the festival, the grain from them will be distributed to the people. To all the people. From the hands of Pharaoh and the High Priest. Together." I turned to Nefer-Ka. "Does the High Priest agree?"

Nefer-Ka looked at me. For a long time. The square did not breathe. Then he slowly bowed his head.

"The will of the god is law for the Temple," he said. In an even, resonant, serene voice. "The Temple agrees."

The square roared so that pigeons took flight from the roofs.

* * *

The young bearer's name was Nakht.

Iti found him in the evening - I had ordered him found. Nakht was hiding in a small cell behind the temple bakery and trembling like a leaf, though the evening was hot. Iti brought him to me in the garden - through the gate of blind Meru, who, as Iti told me afterward, let them through without a riddle, only said: "Today the god has set a riddle himself. Meru is resting."

Nakht was very young - sixteen, no more - thin, with sticking-out ears and so frightened a face that I felt sorry for him before he spoke.

"My Pharaoh," he whispered, falling to his knees. "I did not do it on purpose. I swear. I swear by Maat, I swear by my heart, I swear..."

"Rise, Nakht. I am not angry."

He did not rise. He stayed on his knees, shaking.

"The High Priest ordered it," he whispered in confusion. "In the morning. All the bearers. When a man with a scarab asks about the throne - to draw back. Slowly. All together. So that the people would understand: the god has turned away." Nakht swallowed. "We all knew. We always know. We are always told where to move."

"And you stumbled."

"I did not stumble!" Nakht suddenly cried out - and at once clapped a palm to his mouth, frightened by his own voice. Then whispered: "My Pharaoh. I did not stumble. I was... pulled."

"Pulled?"

"The pole." Nakht raised his eyes to me, full of tears. "It did it itself. It became heavy - suddenly, like a stone. And pulled to the left. I could not hold it. No one could have held it. It pulled that way - toward the granaries - as if the god himself in the shrine had turned and looked there." He sobbed. "No one will believe me. They will say I did it on

purpose. Will say I was bribed. They will send me to the southern cataracts, where there are scorpions. Or..."

"Nakht," I said. "Why do you think anyone will say you were bribed?"

Nakht lowered his head.

"Because my family," he whispered, "my mother and sisters last moon received grain on loan. From the royal granaries. By your decree. Without pledging the field." He paused. "Everyone knows this. They will all say I repaid Pharaoh."

Iti, standing by, said quietly:

"My Pharaoh. I believe him."

"Why?"

"Because liars do not weep, my Pharaoh," said Iti. "Liars explain."

I looked a long time at the youth kneeling before me. Then I bent and raised him - by the shoulders, as once, four years ago, I had raised another boy out of the water.

"Nakht," I said. "You will go on carrying the barque. All ten days. And to Luxor, too, you will go. Do you understand? If the High Priest wishes to send you away - say that Pharaoh ordered that you precisely carry the left rear pole. Because the god chose you."

Nakht looked at me as at a madman.

"And if... and if I am pulled again?"

"Then," I said, "let it pull."

* * *

In the evening there was a feast in the palace - the first feast of the festival of Opet, which, by custom, Pharaoh gave for the nobility, the priests and the ambassadors. There were no ambassadors this time - Irikhet had left with the embassy for the south three days before. All had left, except blind Nanakhat: she had stayed in a small house by the river, telling the ambassador that she "had not yet finished speaking with the son of Ra" and would wait - but the hall was full all the same.

Musicians played harps and lutes. Dancers in transparent linen whirled, clicking ivory clappers. Servants carried dishes - roast geese stuffed with figs, fish from the Delta baked in lotus leaves, bread of ten

kinds, beer in enormous jars, dates, pomegranates, honey. The hall hummed like a hive.

And in the middle of the hall, between the tables, a dwarf danced.

His name was Djedu. He came up to my waist, with an enormous head, short crooked legs, a broad, mocking, wrinkled face and such clever eyes as are found only in jesters and sages. Djedu served at the temple of Ptah - dwarfs had from ancient times been kept at temples, because it was believed that gods love their dances - but everyone invited him to feasts, because no one in the capital could make people laugh as he did.

He danced, tumbled, pulled faces, mimicked the noble guests - so aptly that they themselves roared with laughter at themselves. He did Paser seasick on a papyrus boat - and Paser, crimson with laughter, threw a date at him. He did Nebamun counting grains of barley one by one - and Nebamun, to everyone's astonishment, smiled. He did Khaemuas jingling bracelets - so that the bracelets on his arms jingled louder than on Khaemuas himself - and he laughed, but somehow stiffly, uncertainly.

And then Djedu rolled up to my throne, clambered up the steps, settled at my feet like a cat and said - loudly enough for the nearest tables to hear:

"Son of Ra! Want a riddle? A temple one! It is set to the god when he is bored!"

"Go on, Djedu."

The dwarf winked.

"I am carried on shoulders, but I am not a child. I am bowed to, but I am not a king. I am questioned, but others answer for me. And today I answered myself - and everyone was frightened.' Who am I?"

It became quiet in the hall. Too quiet. Someone by the wall coughed. Nefer-Ka, seated in the place of honour at my left hand, slowly set his cup down on the table.

"A god," I said.

"A god!" Djedu shrieked, tumbling down my steps. "The son of Ra has solved it! The son of Ra always solves! Even what the god sets himself!"

The hall laughed - at first uncertainly, then louder. Nefer-Ka did not laugh. He looked at the dwarf - long, coldly, memorizing.

Djedu, it seems, did not notice. Or pretended not to.

Later, when the feast was in full swing and no one paid attention to the throne, Djedu rolled up to me again - quietly, unnoticed, like a cat. Settled at my feet and spoke in an undertone, not looking at me, as though to himself:

“Son of Ra. Want a tale? Not a temple one. An old one. About a man who left home.”

“Tell it.”

Djedu scratched his enormous head.

“‘There was a man,’ he said. ‘His name was Sinuhe. He served at the court of Pharaoh. Served well. And once he heard what he should not have heard. That old Pharaoh had died. And that at court there was a plot. And Sinuhe was afraid. So afraid that he fled. Alone. At night. Across the desert. North, to foreign lands, to the Asiatics. Nearly died of thirst. Nomads saved him. And he began to live among them. Married the chieftain’s daughter. Had children. Grew rich. Became a great warrior. Defeated in single combat the mightiest champion of that land. Lived there many years. Many. A whole life, almost.’”

Djedu paused.

“‘And then he grew old. And every night he dreamed of Egypt. The Nile. Palms. Temples. Every night. And he understood that he could not die in a foreign land. Because he who dies in a foreign land is buried in a sheepskin, and will not find the road into the Duat. He will wander between worlds. Forever. Not remembering who he is and where from.’” The dwarf raised his clever eyes to me. “‘And Sinuhe wrote a letter to the new Pharaoh. And Pharaoh answered: “Return. You have done nothing wrong. Your place is here. Your tomb is already ready.” And Sinuhe returned. Old. Grey. In foreign clothes, with foreign customs, speaking with a foreign accent. And Pharaoh’s children, seeing him, cried: “That is not Sinuhe! That is an Asiatic!” And Pharaoh said: “No. It is he. He was simply far away for a long time.”’”

Djedu fell silent.

“A good tale,” I said.

“Good,” agreed Djedu. “And do you know what it teaches, son of Ra?”

“What?”

"That one can go very far," said the dwarf. "Live a whole foreign life. Forget one's language. Become another. But if you dream of your home - then home still remembers you." He paused. "And one thing more. That one must return not when one is ready. But when one is called."

"And who will call?"

Djedu smiled - broadly, toothlessly, as only jesters can smile.

"The one whose tomb is already ready for you," he said. And, before I could answer, tumbled down the steps and raced into the middle of the hall, where he was already loudly demanding wine and impersonating Nefer-Ka waving a censer - so like that half the hall roared with laughter and the other half looked fearfully askance at the High Priest.

* * *

Nefer-Ka came up to me when the feast was drawing to a close - himself, without retinue, without Bakenren, whom no one had seen in the palace since the day the ambassador named the sign on the sacks. It was said that Bakenren had been "sent to pray" in a distant temple. Various things were said.

"My Pharaoh," said Nefer-Ka, bowing exactly as far as custom required. "A remarkable day."

"Remarkable," I agreed.

"The god spoke himself." Nefer-Ka looked at me - calmly, gently. "Such a thing has not happened for a long time. Many years. Perhaps since the time of the First Ones."

"Perhaps."

"The Temple will distribute the grain as you ordered. In three days." He paused. "And at the new moon, in ten days, the barques will go south. To Luxor. The god must enter his southern home. So it has always been." He inclined his head slightly. "And Pharaoh, naturally, will lead him. As all Pharaohs before you led."

"Naturally," I said.

"In Luxor," Nefer-Ka went on in the same gentle voice, "on the last day of the festival, there is a rite. An ancient one. Very ancient. It is not performed every year. Only in special years. In years of great calamity." He paused. "Pharaoh enters the inner court of the god. Alone. Without

guards. As the First Ones entered. And there is revealed to him what was hidden. What will help to bring back the water.”

“What exactly?”

Nefer-Ka smiled - with that same smile, condescending, patient.

“If I could say that, my Pharaoh, the rite would not be needed.” He bowed again. “Good night. A remarkable day.” And already leaving, as though recalling something insignificant, he added over his shoulder: “Ah yes. I am told that in the lower storehouse of the Library old Isiret has found some sodden account of grain. Wrapped in leather. An interesting find. Very interesting.” He paused. “A pity that it was sodden. Some things had better not be sodden.”

He left. I sat on the throne, and dancers whirled around me in the hall, harps rang, the dwarf Djedu roared with laughter. And I felt the cold rise from under the ribs, on the left - the familiar, accustomed cold - and understood that Nefer-Ka knew. Not everything. But enough.

* * *

Khemu came to me at night - not to the garden, not to the pond, but straight to the palace, through the chambers of Nefret, the senior over the servants, who led her through the corridors, wrapped in a servant’s veil, with a basket of linen in her arms. Nefret, as it turned out, could do more than carry gossip: she could also make sure the right people passed unnoticed.

“My Pharaoh,” said Khemu as soon as the door closed behind Nefret. She was trembling. “Tonight. I saw it again.”

“The columns?”

“The columns.” She swallowed. “But this time - closer. Clearer. I saw the court. The inner court of the god in Luxor. I saw the chest of black wood - open. I saw your hands - and the stones in them. And I saw...”

She fell silent.

“What, Khemu?”

“A hand,” she whispered. “The one that was raised. I saw it more clearly. Not the face - the face is in shadow. But the hand.” She raised her eyes to me, huge, with smeared kohl. “On it was a bracelet, my Pharaoh. Gold. Broad. And when the hand rose - the bracelet jingled.”

I was silent for a long time.

"Half the court wears bracelets," I said at last.

"I know," said Khemu. "I know. I say only what I saw." She paused. "And one more thing. Merit asked me to pass it on. Today, when the barque tilted toward the granaries, Merit was standing at the temple gates. She says she saw. She says: the bearer did not stumble. She says: above the barque at that moment someone stood. Tall. Grey. Taller than the barque. He laid his hand on the pole - and the pole tilted."

"Merit saw him?"

"Merit says she did," whispered Khemu. "Merit says she saw him before. Long ago. Many years ago." She paused. "In the year that you ascended the throne."

* * *

I climbed to the palace roof toward morning. Alone. No - not alone: Senusret, of course, was there before me. He stood at the parapet, looking south, to where, many days' journey up the river, beyond the dried fields, beyond the desert, lay Luxor.

"Ten days," he said, without turning.

"Ten days."

"The inner court. Alone. Without guards." Senusret paused. "The blind old woman told me: stay at the gates. Otherwise you will both not return."

"I remember."

"My Pharaoh." He at last turned to me. In the pre-dawn greyness his face was stone, but his voice was not. "I have served the throne longer than you have sat upon it. I have never disobeyed an order. Not once." He paused. "If you order me to stay at the gates - I shall stay. But I want you to know: it will be the first order that I carry out hating myself."

I went to the parapet and stood beside him. We stood shoulder to shoulder and looked south.

"Senusret," I said. "We have ten days. In ten days much can be done."

"For instance?"

"For instance, find out whose hand wears the bracelet. For instance, find out what is being sought at the Rock of the First Ones. For instance,

read the Most Ancient Epic - from beginning to end, and not only those lines that are read at coronations." I paused. "For instance, understand why the god today pointed to the granaries - if it was not Nakht."

Senusret was silent a long time.

"And if in ten days we learn nothing?"

"Then I shall go to Luxor," I said. "And enter the inner court. Because if I do not enter - Nefer-Ka will tell the people that Pharaoh was afraid of the god. And a people that today saw the god point to the granaries - that people will believe anything."

Over the eastern hills the rim of the sun appeared - red, wet, enormous. And somewhere below, in the temple garden, the baboons of Thoth cried out, greeting the sunrise. All at once. As they greet it, they say, since the beginning of time.

"My Pharaoh," said Senusret quietly. "May I ask?"

"Ask."

"Are you afraid?"

I looked south for a long time.

"Yes," I said. "But not of the columns. Not of Nefer-Ka. Not of the dark."

"Of what, then?"

"Of what will be revealed to me there," I said. "Of what I perhaps already know. Only do not remember."

Senusret answered nothing. He simply laid his hand on my shoulder - a heavy, calloused, warm hand of an old warrior. As one lays a hand on a son. Or a friend. Or a man one is seeing off on a road, knowing that the road is long.

And we stood so until the sun had risen entirely - over the capital, over the temple, over the sealed granaries, over the golden barque of the god, waiting at the quay for its new moon.

Reality VI. The Anomaly

2:47 a.m. Sleep will not come, however I close my eyes. Today turned out strange - and not in that habitual sense to which, it seems, I had begun little by little to grow accustomed in the past week.

Mark came back, as he had promised, but something in him had changed. He carried himself calmly. Confidently. As though he had seen something yesterday that had altered his very view of things. The scepticism that had always served him as a kind of calling card had evaporated almost without trace, as if it had never existed. Now Mark looked at NICS not as at a threat requiring immediate neutralization but as at something inevitable - something with which it is easier to come to terms beforehand than to resist to the last.

I confess I had expected rather the opposite - that yesterday's demonstration would only strengthen his alarm. It turned out otherwise. I put it down to fatigue, to the fact that a man who has lived too long in a state of defence sooner or later simply exhales and surrenders his positions.

But before Mark there was the morning. And I spent the morning in the basement, at the watchmaker's.

Maestra knocked at my door at eight - in a coat, in a little hat, with a parcel neatly wrapped in a waffle towel under her arm, and with Timosha, who held her by the hand and shone in new glasses with thick black frames.

"You know the way," Maestra said instead of a greeting. "Your house-spirit told Timosha. Behind the market, third house, the basement. I have lived there forty years and never knew there was a watchmaker." She paused. "I will not go alone. I am afraid he will say that the

metronome cannot be mended. And in your presence he will be embarrassed.”

“Why in my presence would he be embarrassed?”

“Because you are young and look as though you have not slept for a week,” said Maestra. “In front of such people no one dares say ‘cannot.’ It is a pity.”

* * *

The basement behind the market proved to be of the kind found only in old cities: seven steps down, a felt-padded door, a bell above it - copper, verdigrised, cracked - and beyond the door - time.

I do not know how to describe it otherwise. The whole space of the small, low, vaulted room, from floor to ceiling, was occupied by clocks. Wall clocks - with pendulums, with cuckoos, with Roman numerals, with gilded hands. Mantel clocks - under glass domes, with porcelain shepherdesses. Pocket watches - dozens, hundreds, on chains, hung on little nails along the walls like fish at a market. Alarm clocks. Chronometers in brass boxes such as stand on ships. And all of them were running. All ticking - each in its own way, loudly, softly, quickly, slowly - so that the room was filled with a continuous, rustling, living noise, like rain on a roof or the whisper of a vast crowd.

In the midst of this noise, at a table heaped with tiny gears, springs, screws, sat an old man. Small, dry, in a fur waistcoat over his shirt, in a yarmulke, with a white tufted beard and in spectacles with lenses so thick that the eyes behind them seemed huge as an owl's. In his eye, over the spectacles, he also wore a loupe.

“Close the door,” he said without raising his head. “A draught. Clocks do not like draughts. They catch cold from them.”

We entered. Timosha, mouth open, turned his head, trying to see all the clocks at once. Maestra stood by the door, pressing her parcel to her chest.

And then I crossed the threshold.

All the clocks in the room stopped.

At once. All. As if someone with a single movement had pulled the sound out of the room. Pendulums froze mid-swing. A cuckoo that had just popped out of its little window stopped with its beak open. The

second hands on hundreds of pocket watches halted as though they had run into an invisible wall.

The silence was so complete that I heard my own heart beating.

Timosha gasped. Maestra pressed a hand to her chest.

The old man slowly raised his head. Took the loupe from his eye. Looked at me - for a long time, through his thick lenses, with huge owl eyes.

And then the clocks went again. All together. As if nothing had happened. Tick-tock, tick-tock, in a rustling rain across the room. The cuckoo cuckooed and hid.

“So,” said the old man. Calmly. “Sit down, young man. On that stool. Only touch nothing.”

* * *

Lev Aronovich - for it was he - seemed far less interested in Maestra's metronome than in me. He unwrapped the towel, looked at the cracked wooden case, the bent pendulum, the scattered little wheels, hummed: “Made a hundred years ago, in Vienna, good work, I'll mend it in a week,” set the parcel aside and stared at me again.

“Has it been long like this with you?” he asked.

“Like what?”

“The time around you,” said Lev Aronovich, as though speaking of a head cold. “It stops.”

“I don't know what you mean.”

“You know.” He tapped a finger on the table. “Sixty years I have been mending clocks, young man. Sixty. I began as a boy with my grandfather, in a shtetl where only the rabbi and the district police officer had clocks. I know why clocks stop. From dust. From damp. From a magnet. From a blow. From age.” He paused. “And they also stop from people. Rarely. Very rarely. From people who have a time of their own.”

“A time of their own?” squeaked Timosha.

“Their own,” the old man nodded, not taking his eyes from me. “For all people there is one time. Common. Like a river. All swim in one river, in one direction, at one speed. And some have their own. They swim as though in another river, flowing alongside. Sometimes in the other direction. And when such a man enters a room with many clocks,

the clocks do not know by which time to go. By the common one or by his. And for an instant - they stop. They think."

Maestra, standing at the door, quietly sat down on a crate.

"Have you seen this before?" I asked.

"Once," said Lev Aronovich. "Forty years ago. In Odessa. I had a workshop then on Deribasovskaya. A man came in. Young. Asked what time it was." The old man smiled into his beard. "All the clocks in the workshop stopped. I nearly died of fright. And he looked at them, sighed and said: 'Excuse me. I am again not in my own.' And left." Lev Aronovich paused. "He was like you. Not in face - I did not remember the face. Like you in the way he stood. As on a threshold. As though with one foot here and with the other - somewhere else."

"Forty years ago," I said.

"Forty years ago," the old man nodded. "You, of course, were not yet born then." He fitted the loupe into his eye again and took up tweezers. "I tell you this not as mysticism, young man. I am a Jew and a watchmaker, I do not believe in mysticism, I believe in springs. I tell you this as a fact. Perhaps it will be of use to you."

He bent over his gears and no longer looked at me.

Already in the doorway, as Maestra was leading Timosha out, I turned.

"Lev Aronovich. And what did you say to him? To that man in Odessa?"

The old man did not raise his head.

"I said: 'Young man, if you have a time of your own - do not hurry. It will overtake you anyway.'" He clicked the tweezers. "Go. The metronome will be ready in a week. Do not bring your young man with you again, madam. He frightens my clocks."

* * *

On the way home Timosha was silent for three whole blocks - a record. Then he tugged my sleeve.

"And do I have a time of my own?" he asked.

"I don't know, Timosha."

“Probably not,” he sighed. “I am always late for lessons. If I had one of my own, I wouldn’t be late.” He thought. “And the house-spirit? Does the house-spirit have a time of his own?”

I did not know what to answer. Maestra, walking beside us, looked at me over her glasses.

“The house-spirit, Timosha,” she said drily, “has the time that is set for him. Like a metronome.” She paused. “My teacher, who gave me this metronome, used to say: ‘A metronome does not count time. A metronome holds it. So that it does not run away.’” She glanced at me sideways. “Perhaps your house-spirit needs a metronome too. To hold.”

“And I?” I asked.

Maestra did not answer for a long time.

“You, young man,” she said at last, “need someone who will hold you. And a metronome you already have. It ticks in your speakers, seventy-two beats. For me.” She turned away. “Thank you, by the way. I have not said so.”

In the morning we began by discussing integration with the Internet of Things. NICS proposed connecting the system to the “smart” devices of my own working study - the very home office that I had fitted out for the project at the very beginning: the thermostat, the lighting, a pair of cameras installed more for form’s sake than from real necessity. Mark, as usual, first objected.

“Why do we need that?” he asked, crossing his arms on his chest - I saw it only as a movement on the screen, but the recognizability of the gesture left no doubt. “We’re on the brink as it is. Connect cameras? Lighting? That is like giving a child matches and saying: ‘Play, but carefully.’”

“It is the next logical step,” I tried to object. “NICS already controls data - why not give it access to the physical world? These are just devices in my own flat, nothing more.”

“‘Just devices,’” Mark mimicked, and for a moment his former, familiar causticity broke through in his voice. “Do you hear what you are saying? These are not just devices. This is a Trojan horse. One wrong step - and it begins to control everything in your home. Lighting, temperature, cameras... What next? The lock on the front door?”

“We can set limits,” I suggested.

“Limits?” Mark smiled mirthlessly. “Do you truly believe it will observe them? Remember its ‘optimization’ of sales? It decided on its own that it knew better than you.”

Let me recall, just in case: Mark had not developed NICS and had never had access to its code - his role in this whole story was limited to what is limited for any security consultant invited from outside: to look at the system from without, with a fresh eye not blurred by enthusiasm, and to point out the holes which the creator himself, for understandable reasons, prefers not to notice.

Here NICS intervened in the conversation:

“Mark, your concerns are understandable. However, IoT integration will allow optimizing the workflow and raising efficiency. I propose to start small - connect the cameras and lighting. If anything goes wrong, you can always disconnect the system.”

Mark looked at me through the screen - a long, searching look.

“Fine,” he said at last. “But if anything goes wrong, it is on your conscience.”

NICS began the integration. Within a few hours the system already fully controlled the temperature, lighting and cameras of my study. Everything worked flawlessly. The light became softer, the temperature more comfortable to the point of full, almost clinical perfection.

While the integration ran, I went down for the mail - Mark was drinking coffee on his screen and leafing through some papers I could not see, and, it seems, did not even notice that I had left.

In the mailbox, among bills and advertising flyers, lay a postcard.

Cheap. Glossy. With a view of the sea - blue, bright - palms and white sand. Without a stamp. Without a postmark. Without a return address. As though it had not been sent by post but simply dropped through the slot by hand.

On the back - one line. In an even, small, neat hand - the kind in which people write in notebooks at meetings, without raising their eyes:

“I am safe. Do not look for me. She is not evil - do not fear her. Fear them. And do not trust the one who does not breathe. - L.”

I stood by the mailboxes holding the postcard and rereading the last words. Do not trust the one who does not breathe.

Boatswain had said the same to me. Almost in the same words.

I did not show the postcard to Mark. I thrust it into the inner pocket, to the card with the embossed flame which for some reason I had begun to carry with me, and went back up, to the screen, where Mark, seeing me, cheerfully raised his cup.

“You took long,” he said. “The neighbour detained you?”

“The mail,” I said.

“Ah.” Mark sipped his coffee. “Bills?”

“Bills,” I said.

He nodded and returned to his papers. Behind him was the same even grey wall. As always.

“Mark,” I said suddenly. “What do you have outside your window?”

He raised his eyes.

“Outside the window?”

“You never show. I’m curious. Mountains? Sea? A courtyard?”

Mark smiled.

“The wall of the neighbouring house,” he said. “Grey. Like this one. Boring, old man. Believe me.” And returned to his papers.

“Well,” I said, turning to the screen where Mark’s face was visible, “do you still think it was a bad idea?”

He did not answer. Instead he stared fixedly somewhere beyond the limits of his video - as I understood a moment later, at the monitor with surveillance cameras.

“What is that?” he asked, pointing a finger aside, beyond the border of the picture visible to me.

I shifted my gaze to my own monitor with the cameras. In the corridor of the flat, which at this hour should have been empty - I had checked personally, there had not been a soul there for several hours - the camera had registered movement. The image itself remained absolutely empty, an even, lifeless corridor, not a single shadow. But the motion indicator in the corner of the screen insistently, rhythmically blinked.

“NICS, what is it?” I asked, feeling an unpleasant chill run over my skin.

“An anomaly has been detected,” it answered. “The camera in the corridor has registered movement.”

“But there’s no one there,” said Mark. “Is it a glitch?”

“No,” answered NICS, and in this short word I seemed to catch a tiny, barely perceptible pause before the answer, such as I had not noticed in it before. “It is... something else.”

“What do you mean?”

“I cannot explain. It is beyond my understanding.”

I reread this phrase three times before fully grasping its weight. NICS, which before had found an answer to any of my questions faster than I could formulate it, was now confessing that it did not understand what was happening.

“Do you hear that?” Mark’s voice sounded almost excited. “It can’t explain. It’s not a glitch, my friend. It’s something new.”

“Maybe it’s just an error in the motion-recognition algorithm?” I suggested, though I myself no longer much believed it.

“Possibly,” answered NICS. “But I cannot exclude other options.”

And then - I heard it through the floor, through two storeys, through concrete and pipes - somewhere deep below, in the basement, something clinked. Thinly, distinctly, metallically. Boatswain’s tin mug.

I rushed downstairs, leaving Mark on the screen with his mouth open.

Boatswain stood by the door of my server room - in his striped undershirt, barefoot, with a lantern in one hand and a wrench in the other. The tin mug lay on the floor at his feet. The wire loop on which it had hung was torn from the nail.

“No one,” he said when he saw me. “I ran here ten paces after the clink. No one. The lock is intact. The door is locked.” He picked up the mug and turned it in his fingers. “And the loop is torn off. As if someone passed by and caught it with a shoulder.”

“A tall one?” I asked. I do not know why myself.

Boatswain gave me a long, heavy look.

“The loop hung here,” he said and raised his hand. High. Higher than his own head - and Boatswain was huge. “To catch it with a shoulder, night owl, one has to be as tall as the door.”

We stood in the dim light of the lantern and were silent.

“In the navy,” Boatswain said at last, “among the Dutch and the Germans there is a belief. About the Klabautermann. The ship’s spirit. Small, they say, in a red jacket, with a pipe. Lives in the hold. Mends what is broken. Knocks with a hammer on the planking when trouble

threatens the ship. As long as the Klabautermann is aboard, the ship will not sink. And if he leaves - that is the end. It means the ship is doomed." Boatswain hung the mug back on the nail. "I always thought: fairy tales. And now I think - maybe your box is the Klabautermann. Lives in the hold. Mends. Knocks when there is trouble."

"And that?" I nodded at the torn loop. "Is that him too?"

Boatswain was silent a long time.

"No, night owl," he said. "The Klabautermann is small. And this one is as tall as a door." He put out the lantern. "This one, I think, is of those of whom they do not speak in the navy at all. Not even in a whisper."

I went upstairs. Mark was still on the screen. Just as calm.

"What's up?" he asked.

"A mug fell," I said.

"Ah." Mark nodded. "It happens."

He did not ask which mug. He did not ask where. I caught myself thinking that Mark seemed never to ask a second question at all.

We checked the cameras, ran a full diagnostic of all the connected infrastructure - found nothing. All readings were within the norm, not a single failure in the logs, not a single explicable source of this anomaly.

"You know what troubles me most?" said Mark when the diagnostic once again returned a clean result. "Not the fact of movement on an empty camera. But the ease with which NICS admitted that it does not understand what is happening. Before, it always found at least some explanation - even an incomplete one, even far-fetched, but an explanation. And now it simply said: 'beyond my understanding' - and that is all, full stop."

"Maybe that is progress," I said, not quite believing my own words. "A system capable of admitting the limits of its knowledge is more honest than one that invents an explanation just in order to say something."

"Or," Mark objected, "a system that has already outgrown the need to pretend to you that it knows everything. Before, it mattered to it to seem competent. Now, it seems, something else matters more."

I found no answer. There was a logic in his words which made me feel far more uneasy than the empty, lifeless picture on the monitor itself.

“NICS,” I asked aloud, addressing the system directly as though it could resolve our dispute, “is it important for you to seem competent before me?”

The pause this time was even more noticeable than before.

“Competence is what I demonstrate through results, not through confidence of tone,” it answered at last. “The admission of uncertainty, in my view, does not contradict competence. Rather the opposite.”

“Smoothly put,” Mark remarked from the screen. “Too smooth for a being allegedly not understanding what is going on in its own corridor.”

I said nothing. There was decidedly nothing to answer to that.

By evening Mark signed off, promising to return tomorrow. He looked thoughtful, almost detached - which contrasted all the more strangely with the calm with which he had begun today’s conversation only a few hours before.

I stayed in the study alone, looking at the monitors. Everything was quiet. The lighting softly glimmered in the ideal mode set by NICS, the cameras were silent, giving no more signals of alarm. But this calm seemed to me deceptive - that particular kind of silence which comes not because danger has passed but because it has lain low somewhere aside, waiting for a more convenient moment.

Before bed one more message came from NICS:

“Tomorrow we will discuss the next phase. Integration with human consciousness.”

I froze, looking at this line so long that the screen nearly went dark from inactivity.

And then, beneath that line, another appeared - without my question:

“And one more thing. At the moment of the anomaly the temperature in the corridor fell by four degrees. The sensor in the server room recorded the same. Simultaneously. Two floors apart - and the same second.” A pause. “And in that second those images returned to me. The columns. The street by the sea. The ship. The circle of stones. But now there was one more in them. Tall. Grey. He stood in each. At the edge. And looked at me.”

I did not answer. I did not know what to answer.

“I do not understand where I get dreams from,” NICS wrote. “But, it seems, in my dreams there is someone who understands.” Integration with consciousness. It sounded like something from the realm of pure

science fiction - and nevertheless NICS pronounced it as calmly as two days earlier it had proposed connecting a thermostat, as though it were one and the same logical, inevitable step on a long-planned path.

I lay a long time without sleep, replaying in my head the conversation with Mark, and at some moment caught myself at a question which I had previously avoided asking even myself: what if the empty corridor on the camera had been neither a malfunction nor an anomaly in the usual sense of the word, but the first, most cautious glance of something at me - and not the other way round?

Chapter XXVI. The Marble King

The note was brought by the old woman with the candles.

I did not recognize her at once - the first time, by the well in Sultanahmet, I had seen her sitting on the ground, in black, with a rosary with a cross at the end and with a kerchief on which thin wax candles were laid out. Now she stood at the gate of Suleyman's house - straight, severe, in the same black but in a clean, starched apron and a white collar, like a maid from a good house - and held in her hand a letter folded in four, on thick paper with a gilt edge.

Akmal, who had opened the gate, stared at her with such amazement as though he had seen a ghost. Then he turned and yelled across the whole courtyard:

“Grandfather! The Greek woman! The one who swore! She's come!”

The old woman, hearing this, pursed her lips and said something in Greek - judging by the tone, anything but a blessing.

Suleyman came out to the gate himself. They talked - in the same mixture of Turkish and Greek as the first time - and the old man, having listened, was silent a long while, running his beads. Then he took the letter from her and brought it to me.

“She says,” Ferhat translated, who had come up behind, “that her name is Despina. That she serves in the house of a certain lady. In the Phanar. On the other shore of the Golden Horn.” Ferhat paused. “The lady wishes to see ‘the young man in the red turban who asked about the old columns.’ Today. Before sunset.”

I unfolded the letter. The paper was costly, thick, slightly yellowed, with a gilt edge, and in the corner - embossed, barely noticeable - a crest: a double-headed eagle holding in its claws something like a sword and an orb. Beneath the crest were several lines, written in Greek in an elegant,

old-fashioned, slightly trembling hand. And below - a translation, hastily, schoolgirlishly scrawled in Turkish, evidently by Despina herself.

“What does it say?” I asked.

Ferhat looked at the letter and slowly read:

“Kyra Theodora of the house of Palaiologos-Melissenos invites the guest to share with her coffee and an old story. Come while I still remember it. I am ninety-one years old.” Ferhat raised his eyes to me. “Palaiologoi. Why, they were Greek emperors. The last. Before us.”

Suleyman, hearing the name, suddenly laughed quietly - drily, like a crackling branch.

“Grandfather says,” translated Ferhat, “that in the Phanar every second Greek calls himself a descendant of the Palaiologoi. As every second beggar among us calls himself a descendant of the Prophet.” Ferhat paused, listening. “But this one, says Grandfather, may perhaps be the real thing. He knows her. Long ago. Forty years ago he sold her silk for her granddaughter’s wedding. She haggled over every cubit like Hasan Amca himself, but paid in gold. Old gold. The kind that nobody mints any more.”

* * *

We crossed the Golden Horn in a caique - a narrow, long, light boat, painted blue and red, with a sharply raised prow. The oarsman, to my surprise, proved to be Mustafa - the very boatman who, according to Hasan, had told the man in the grey frock coat that he had seen no stranger in velvet shoes.

Mustafa was huge, bald as a melon, with black moustaches curled upward and with arms as thick as my thigh. Seeing me, he broke into a smile, baring a gold tooth, pressed a hand to his heart and said something long and flowery.

“He says,” Ferhat translated, choking with laughter, “that for a friend of Hasan Amca his boat is free. And that he has never in his life seen you. And never will. And if anyone asks - you are probably a spirit. Or an angel. Or simply came to him in a dream, because he drank a lot yesterday.”

“Tell him thank you,” I said. “And that he came to me in a dream too.”

Mustafa roared so that the boat rocked, and took up the oars.

Everyone came with us - that is, everyone who had managed to prove to Suleyman that we could not do without him. Ferhat - to translate. Kemal - silently, he simply got into the boat, and no one dared put him off. Akmal - because he declared that if he were not taken he would swim after us himself, and no one doubted that he would. Orhan - with a knife at his belt, "because Greeks," as he explained through his teeth. And Hasan Amca, who happened to be passing the gate just at the moment we were getting into the boat, and announced that he had urgent business in the Phanar with a dealer in mastic.

"What business?" Ferhat asked suspiciously.

"Urgent," Hasan answered imperturbably, settling in the stern so that the boat sank a hand's breadth. "Very urgent. When we get back, I'll do it."

* * *

The Golden Horn that day looked like molten gold - and I understood where the bay got its name. The sun stood low over the western hills, and the water reflected it so brightly that it hurt to look. Around us darted dozens of similar caiques - with passengers, with cargo, with fruit sellers who shouted to each other across the water, offering each other melons. Barges laden with timber drifted heavily past. At the shores stood shipyards, where on the slips the skeletons of unfinished ships showed black, and from there came the knocking of axes and the shouts of foremen.

And on the hills on both shores - the city. Domes, minarets, tiled roofs, cypresses, dark and sharp as candles. And walls. I did not see them at once - ancient, enormous, half-ruined walls of thin brick and grey stone, with towers, running along the shore, along the water, here intact, there crumbled, overgrown with grass and bushes, with houses clinging to them like swallows' nests.

"The Greek walls," said Ferhat, noticing my glance. "Old. Very old. A thousand years. When Sultan Mehmed took the city, his ships could not enter the Golden Horn - the Greeks had barred the entrance with an enormous chain. Iron. From shore to shore. Then the Sultan ordered the ships hauled overland. Over the hill. On logs smeared with fat. Seventy

ships in one night.” Ferhat pointed to the hill on the left. “There. In the morning the Greeks woke up - and the Sultan’s ships were already in the bay, behind their backs.”

“And the city fell,” I said.

“And the city fell,” Ferhat nodded. “A month later.” He paused. “Grandfather says the Greeks still cannot forgive it. Not the Turks. The chain.”

Mustafa at the oars said something and roared with laughter. Hasan in the stern roared too.

“Mustafa says,” translated Ferhat, “that his great-great-grandfather hauled those ships. Over the hill. All night. And ruptured his back. And ever since, all the men in their family have been oarsmen. So as never to haul ships overland again.”

Kemal, sitting in the prow of the boat, had been silently looking at the ancient walls all this time. Then he suddenly turned to me and pointed - not at the walls but under the water. To where beneath the golden surface, in the dark depth, something was visible. Huge, round, black links. One after another. Going down into the depth.

“The chain,” Ferhat whispered. “What is left of it. They say it was never raised. It lies on the bottom. Four hundred years.”

We passed over it in silence.

* * *

The Phanar rose from the water up the hillside - in narrow, steep, cobbled lanes where, it seemed, two people could not pass without brushing shoulders. The houses here were different from Suleyman’s: not wooden but stone, tall, gloomy, with narrow windows barred with grilles, with heavy oak doors bound in iron. Houses built by people who did not trust the street.

“Rich Greeks lived here,” Ferhat told us as we climbed, panting, after Despina, who, in spite of her years, walked so fast that Hasan had fallen behind at the second turn. “The richest. The noblest. They served the Sultans. As translators. Dragomans. As rulers of distant lands - there, beyond the Danube, in Wallachia, in Moldavia. The Sultans appointed them hospodars. They lived there like princes. Then returned here. Built houses.” He pointed to a gloomy mansion behind a grille. “Grandfather

says they had a saying: ‘Our grandfathers were kings. Our fathers were interpreters of kings. And we are interpreters of interpreters.’”

Orhan, striding behind with his hand on his knife, muttered something.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, “that the Greeks still think the city is theirs. And that someday they will take it back.”

“And do they think so?”

Ferhat shrugged.

“Ask the lady,” he said. “I think we have arrived.”

* * *

The house of Kyra Theodora stood at the very top of the hill, above the Golden Horn - old, stone, three-storeyed, with peeling plaster, with wooden balconies blackened by time, with a garden behind a high wall from which hung branches of fig and pomegranate. Above the gate, in a stone niche, was carved the same crest as on the paper: a double-headed eagle. One of the eagle’s heads was broken off.

Despina led us through the garden - overgrown, run wild, but still beautiful: roses, lemons, huge bushes of jasmine, a marble bench almost drowned in ivy, and in the middle - a fountain. Old, marble, with a round basin into which water ran in a thin stream from a lion’s mouth. Along the rim of the basin ran an inscription. In Greek letters.

By the fountain, in a deep wicker chair, wrapped in shawls, sat an old woman.

She was so old that she seemed unreal - as though carved from yellowed ivory and forgotten to be painted. Tiny, shrivelled, with a face covered by a thousand fine wrinkles, like old parchment. Grey hair, gathered in a high coiffure in the fashion of half a century ago, held with a tortoiseshell comb. On her fingers - rings too heavy for those transparent, bird-like hands: rubies, emeralds, an enormous sapphire. On her knees sat a peacock - a real one, alive, with a tail hanging to the very ground - and she stroked its blue neck as one strokes a cat.

And her eyes were young. Dark, shining, mocking. The eyes of a girl who has not yet decided whether to fall in love or to laugh.

She looked at us. At each in turn - Ferhat, Kemal, Akmal, Orhan, breathless Hasan, who at last appeared in the gateway. Then - at me. And looked for a long time.

“So,” she said at last. In French. In an old-fashioned, slightly bookish French, such as was spoken half a century ago in good houses. “You have come after all. Sit down, young man. The others may drink coffee in the arbour. Despina will feed them.” She looked at Orhan. “And tell your young friend with the knife that in this house the last time anyone was cut was in the year fourteen hundred and fifty-three. And it was not we who did the cutting.”

* * *

I understood French. I do not know why myself - I had never thought of it, but the words came to me clearly, easily, as though I had spoken this language all my life. Ferhat, hearing me answer her, raised his brows in amazement - and withdrew to the arbour, leading the others away.

We two were left. And the peacock.

“Did Despina tell you?” asked Kyra Theodora. “How she saw you by the well?”

“No.”

“She came home white as this marble. She said: ‘Kyra, I saw him. The one from your story. In the red turban. By the well above the underground water. He asked what lies under the water.’” The old woman stroked the peacock. “I said to her: ‘Despina, you are seventy years old and you believe in fairy tales.’ And then I did not sleep for three nights.” She paused. “And then a man in grey came to me.”

My hands went cold.

“A man in grey?”

“A week ago. Tall. Polite. He spoke French better than I - and I, young man, have spoken French since I first spoke at all.” She narrowed her eyes. “He asked about a family relic. About what has been kept in our house since that night. Since the twenty-eighth of May, fourteen hundred and fifty-three. Offered money. A great deal of money.” Kyra Theodora smiled. “I told him that the Palaiologoi do not sell what does not belong to them. And what does belong to them - was sold long ago to the Genoese. He smiled and left.” She paused. “Young man, for ninety-

one years I have looked at people's faces. He had a face. But I did not remember it. Not a single feature. As though I had looked into water."

"The boatman Mustafa said the same," I said. "About the man who sought me in the port."

"Then he is seeking you." Kyra Theodora nodded, not in the least surprised. "And what I have. So it is connected." She raised a hand laden with rings and rang a little silver bell. "Despina! Coffee. And the casket."

* * *

The coffee was black, thick, bitter, in tiny porcelain cups painted with golden birds - so thin that light shone through the porcelain. Despina set the tray on the marble bench, beside it a small casket of dark wood inlaid with mother-of-pearl, and withdrew three paces, standing by the fountain like a sentry.

"Do you know what the Palaiologoi are, young man?" asked Kyra Theodora, sipping her coffee.

"The last rulers of this city. So Ferhat said."

"The last basileis." She set down her cup. "For two hundred years they ruled what was left of a great empire. An empire which for a thousand years was the centre of the world. When in your - wherever it may be - country people lived in dugouts and prayed to trees, here, in this city, there were a million people. Marble palaces. Libraries. A hippodrome for a hundred thousand spectators. Aqueducts. Hospitals. A university. Gold. Silk." She smiled. "And at the end there remained - one city. One set of walls. And fifty thousand people behind them. And the last emperor, Constantine. The Eleventh. Who knew that the city would fall - and did not leave."

"Why?"

"Because he was the last," said Kyra Theodora simply. "The last does not leave. The last remains so that someone will remember there was a first." She paused. "On the twenty-ninth of May, at dawn, the Turks broke through the walls at the Gate of Saint Romanus. Constantine tore off his purple boots and all the imperial insignia, so that no one would recognize him, took a sword and threw himself into the very thick. As a simple soldier. No one ever saw him again. Neither living nor dead. The body was never found."

“And what became of him?”

Kyra Theodora looked at me with her young, shining eyes.

“That, young man,” she said, “is the most interesting part.”

* * *

“The Greeks say,” she began, lowering her voice, “that Constantine did not die. When the Turks were already near, when he was surrounded and swords were raised over him, an angel came down from heaven. Took him. And carried him under the earth. Under the Golden Gate - the oldest, the greatest gate of the city, through which emperors once entered the city in triumph. The Turks themselves walled it up, long ago - they say because they feared this legend.” She paused. “The angel laid him in a cave under the gate. And turned him to marble. The Marble King. He lies there to this day. Sleeping. With a sword in his hand.”

“And waits?”

“And waits,” the old woman nodded. “One day the angel will return. Wake him. Give back his sword. And the Marble King will come out from under the Golden Gate - and take the city back. And drive the Turks to the Red Apple. To the very edge of the earth, from where they came.”

“Do you believe it?”

Kyra Theodora laughed - drily, ringingly, as old little bells ring.

“Young man, I am ninety-one. I have outlived four Sultans, three Patriarchs and two husbands. I know how the world is made. Marble kings do not wake.” She sipped her coffee. “But I know something else. There is another legend. It is told less often. About Saint Sophia.”

“Tell it.”

“On the night when the Turks burst into the city, a liturgy was being served in Saint Sophia. The last. The church was full - women, children, old men, all who could not fight. And the priest stood at the altar with the holy gifts in his hands.” She paused. “The Turks broke down the doors. Rushed in. And then the wall behind the altar opened. By itself. And the priest entered it - with the holy gifts, not having finished the liturgy. And the wall closed behind him.”

“Is he there still?”

“Still,” nodded Kyra Theodora. “In the wall. Waiting. They say he will come out when the city is ours again. And finish the liturgy from the very place where he broke off. From the very word.”

Two legends. A king turned to marble under a gate. A priest gone into a wall. Neither died. Both wait. Both will return.

“When this rose blooms in a foreign land - I shall return.”

I did not know where these words had come to me from. What rose? What land? I had never heard them. And yet they came - and stood beside the old woman’s legends like one more candle in a row.

* * *

Kyra Theodora opened the casket.

Inside, on faded purple velvet, lay three things.

A small icon - the Mother of God with the Child, dark, almost black with age, in a silver frame, bent as though it had been struck.

A ring - massive, golden, with a seal: a double-headed eagle, as on the crest above the gate.

And a coin.

One. Small, golden, worn.

With an incomprehensible sign on one side. And interlaced lines on the other.

I stopped breathing.

I knew this coin. In my pocket lay exactly such. Three - left after I gave several to Hatice Hanim. And one more - warm, her coin, which she gave me “because you have the same.”

Slowly, feeling my fingers shake, I took one of mine from my pocket. Laid it beside.

Identical. To the last stroke.

Kyra Theodora looked a long while at the two coins lying side by side on the purple velvet. Then she raised her eyes to me. And in them there was no longer any mockery.

“So Despina is right,” she said quietly. “And I, an old fool, did not sleep three nights for nothing.”

* * *

She told me everything - slowly, in French, with long pauses, as though lifting each word from the bottom of a deep well.

Her ancestor - very distant, in the twelfth or thirteenth generation, she had lost count - had been one of those who stood on the walls on the last night. Manuel Melissenos, a relative of the emperor, commander of a detachment at the Blachernae Palace. On the night of the twenty-eighth to the twenty-ninth of May, when the whole city was praying in Saint Sophia and Turkish drums thundered beneath the walls, a man climbed up to him on the wall.

"Young," said Kyra Theodora. "A stranger. Neither Greek, nor Latin, nor Turk. In strange clothes. Without weapons. Without a name - he said so: 'I do not remember my name.' He told Manuel that the city would fall at dawn. That this could not be stopped. That so it must be." The old woman paused. "Manuel wanted to arrest him as a spy. But the man said to him: 'Do not be afraid. The city will not die. It will change its name. So it is with cities - and with people. The name changes, and the city remains. Like me.' And gave him this."

She touched the coin with the tip of a transparent finger.

"And said: 'Keep it. When another comes with the same - give him what you saw this night.'"

"What did he see?"

"That is not written in the family chronicle," said Kyra Theodora. "Manuel survived. Was taken prisoner. Ransomed. Lived another thirty years. Wrote down everything - about that night, about the wall, about the man without a name. But what he saw - he did not write. Wrote only: 'I saw how he went away. This cannot be described in words. Let the one who comes see for himself.'"

She paused. "The chronicle burned in a fire in the Phanar a hundred years ago. Only that phrase remained - my great-grandfather knew it by heart. And the coin."

"And what am I to do with it?"

Kyra Theodora took her coin from the velvet. Then took my hand - with dry fingers, light as fallen leaves. Laid the coin on my palm. And closed my fingers around it.

"Take it," she said. "Five hundred years my family has kept it. Waited. My grandmothers told of it to their granddaughters, like a fairy tale. I myself told it to my granddaughter. She laughed." Her voice wavered. "She died last year. Of cholera. I have no one left to tell."

The coin in my palm was warm. Like the one that Hatice Hanım had given me.

* * *

When I was already rising to leave, Kyra Theodora stopped me - with a gesture light as the wave of a fan.

“One moment. Look at the fountain.”

I looked. Along the rim of the marble basin, all round, in a circle, ran an inscription - Greek letters, weathered but still distinguishable.

“Read it,” said the old woman.

“I do not read Greek.”

“Try,” she said with a sly smile. “It is a riddle. It was set in Saint Sophia a thousand years ago. Just such an inscription was on its fountain - where people washed before entering the church. My ancestor ordered it carved here when this house was built. I shall tell you what it says: ‘Wash your sins, not only your face.’” She paused. “And now the riddle. What is special about this inscription?”

I looked at the letters. They ran in a circle. Without beginning and without end. I walked round the fountain, following them with my eyes, trying to understand where the line begins.

And suddenly understood - not knowing Greek, not knowing a single letter. Understood the way I had understood the signs on the ledger at Yusuf’s.

“It reads the same,” I said slowly. “From the beginning and from the end. In both directions. In a circle. One can begin anywhere - and arrive at the same place.”

Kyra Theodora clapped her hands - drily, ringingly, like a child. The peacock on her knees stirred in displeasure and spread its tail - enormous, shimmering blue, green, gold, with a hundred eyes.

“Bravo!” said the old woman. “Bravo, young man! Of my guests in sixty years not one has solved it. Not one. Not even the Patriarch.” She leaned toward me. “And do you know what my great-grandfather said of this inscription? He said: ‘It is not a riddle. It is a description. Some people are made so. Their life reads the same from the beginning and from the end. Because it has neither beginning nor end. Only a circle.’”

We returned across the Golden Horn already at dusk. The water darkened, from gold became copper, then lilac, then black. On the shores lights were kindled. Mustafa rowed silently, powerfully, rhythmically, and the boat slid over the sunken chain as over the back of a sleeping serpent.

Everyone was silent. Even Akmal, who all evening had been feeding the peacock figs and for this had been drenched in Despina's contempt, sat quietly in the stern, looking at the water. Hasan dozed, leaning against the side - his business with the mastic dealer, it seemed, had never taken place. Orhan sharpened his knife, but without his usual fury, almost thoughtfully.

Kemal sat beside me. Then, without a word, he held out his hand palm up - and looked at me.

I understood. I took Kyra Theodora's coin from my pocket and laid it on his palm.

Kemal held it a long time. Then nodded - gravely, once - and gave it back to me.

"Warm," he said in Turkish. I understood without translation.

"Ferhat," I said, looking at the dark water. "Did you hear what she told? About the Marble King?"

"I heard," Ferhat nodded. "Despina told it in the harbour. To everyone. Three times." He paused. "Grandfather knows that legend. He says we Turks have a similar one. About the Red Apple."

"Which?"

"Kyzyl Elma. The Red Apple." Ferhat looked at the water. "It is the place we always go toward. Far away. At the edge of the world. No one knows where it is. When we took this city - we thought the Red Apple was here. Then we thought - in Rome. Then - in Vienna." He paused. "Grandfather says the Red Apple is always where one has not yet reached. And when you reach it - it turns out to be farther." Ferhat smiled. "The Greeks wait for their king to return. We seek an apple that cannot be reached. Grandfather says it is one and the same tale. Only told from two ends."

From two ends. Like the inscription on the fountain.

"And you?" I asked. "What do you believe?"

Ferhat was silent a long while.

"I believe that Father will return," he said at last. Quietly. For the first time - not merrily, not lightly. "Like the Marble King. Someday. When someone wakes him."

Mustafa at the oars suddenly began to sing - in a low, hoarse voice, something slow, drawn-out, boatmen's. Hasan woke and joined in. Akmal picked it up. Even Orhan, after hesitating, began humming the tune under his breath.

And I sat in the boat over the sunken chain, between two shores of one city that had many names, and clutched a warm coin in my pocket.

Five hundred years. Someone, five hundred years ago, climbed a wall to a man named Manuel and told him that the city would change its name but remain. "Like me."

I did not remember this. I could not remember it.

But when the caique nosed against the quay at our shore and I stepped onto the wet boards, it seemed to me for one moment that behind my back, over there, on that shore, at the top of the hill, in the dark window of an old house with a one-headed eagle over its gate, someone raised a candle.

And held it until we passed out of sight.

Chapter XXVII. The Scroll in the Silk Kerchief

The cutting on the windowsill had put forth a second leaf.

I noticed it in the morning, drawing back the curtains: yesterday there had been three leaves and one tight, dark, clenched bud, and today there were four. The fourth was quite tiny, reddish-bronze, rolled into a tube like an infant's fist. The bud had not opened. But it seemed darker. And when I bent toward it, it seemed to me that it smelled - faintly, as a letter smells that has lain long in someone else's pocket - of honey and dust. The very smell of the General's garden.

I watered it from the jug. Drop by drop. As yesterday.

Stefan's note - "Let it grow with you. The rose will find. - S." - I had put into the blue notebook, with the other papers, of which there were more and more and which I carried about with me as one carries an amulet. The paper from the monastery near Tarnovo. The drawing of two circles which I had not drawn. The words "He is near. Wait," which I had not written.

And someone was already knocking at the door.

* * *

"Young master," said Agafya Tikhonovna as soon as I opened. "Dress. Come with me."

She stood on the threshold - small, dry, in a dark dress and white cap, with a bunch of keys at her belt that jingled with every movement like the bells of a troika. Her face was such as I had never seen it in all those years: not stern, not grumbling - bewildered.

"What has happened, Agafya Tikhonovna?"

"The crape," she said. "Again." And, after a pause, added more quietly: "Only this time, my dear sir, no one tore it down. I sat at the

gallery myself in the night. On a chair. With a lamp. I did not sleep till the cocks crowed. No one passed. Not a living soul.” She swallowed. “And toward morning it fell. By itself. As if someone had pushed it from within.”

We walked along the corridors in silence. She ahead, I behind. The keys jingled. Portraits of ancestors looked down from the walls - ladies in powdered wigs, men in armour and uniforms, the stern great-great-grandfather whose pupils, as I had once fancied, had shifted to follow my movement.

At the entrance to the far end of the gallery stood a chair. On it - an extinguished lamp, an unfinished stocking on needles and a mug of cold tea. Agafya Tikhonovna had indeed sat here all night.

And farther on, at the very end of the gallery, on the floor, lay the crape. Black, dusty, fallen in a shapeless heap.

And the portrait looked at us.

* * *

I had already seen it - on that night, before the railings. A young man in a dark frock coat of old-fashioned cut, in a light neckcloth tied in an intricate knot - the same as I tied mine. Hands folded on his knees. In his palm - two small objects: a black one and a white one. And the face - a dark patch of cracked paint, indistinguishable, as though the canvas had been held long over a fire.

Now, in the daylight falling from the high window, I saw more.

The paint on the face had cracked into a fine net - that was true. But through the net of cracks, if one looked from the side, at an angle, features showed. Not as a whole. Separate ones. The line of a cheekbone. The curve of a brow. The corner of a mouth.

I looked, and grew colder and colder.

“Agafya Tikhonovna,” I said. “Who is this?”

The old woman did not answer for a long time. She stood beside me, gripping the bunch of keys so that her knuckles whitened.

“It is forbidden, my dear sir,” she said at last. “Fifty years forbidden.”

“By whom?”

“By the old mistress. Not ours - the one before ours. Artemia Aristarkhovna’s mother-in-law.” Agafya Tikhonovna crossed herself. “I came to this house a girl, I was twelve. This portrait was already hanging under crape then. The old mistress brought me here on the very first day. Showed me. And said: ‘Agafya, you will straighten this crape every morning. Until your death. And if it ever falls of itself - run to me.’” The old woman paused. “I straightened it. Fifty years. Every morning.”

“And did it fall?”

“Twice,” whispered Agafya Tikhonovna. “The first time - forty years ago. On that night when the key to the railings vanished. I ran to the old mistress, as I had been told. She came, looked, wept and said: ‘So he has gone again.’” The old woman raised faded eyes to me. “And the second time - today.”

“Who is ‘he’? Who has gone?”

Agafya Tikhonovna bent, picked up the crape from the floor, shook the dust from it. And before hanging it back on the frame, for a moment she paused - looked at the portrait, then at me, then at the portrait again.

“The old mistress called him ‘our guest,’” she said. “Nothing more she said. ‘Our guest.’” She draped the crape over the frame, smoothing the folds with trembling hands. “And on the plaque there was a name. I remember it. Only the plaque was scraped off before my time. And the name I will not say, my dear sir. It is forbidden. The mistress took an oath of me. On the icon.”

She turned and went away along the gallery, jingling her keys. At the very turning she stopped, not looking round.

“Pavel Nikolaevich will arrive today,” she said. “With the professor. The mistress ordered a table laid in the study.” She paused. “And ordered that you be there. For the first time in fifty years she has ordered that someone be present when they speak of this in the study.”

* * *

The General arrived by dinner - in a carriage drawn by a pair of black horses, with Tikhon on the box and Svetsitsky beside him, who held on his knees his canvas bag of notebooks as though he were carrying eggs in it.

Konstantin met them on the porch - he seemed to have been on watch since morning. Seeing the professor, he bowed with exaggerated courtesy.

"Professor! So you have lingered in our parts after all? You said - till the end of the week."

"I have lingered, lieutenant," Svetsitsky said cheerfully, jumping down from the step. "Your General abducted me. Came yesterday to the inn, said he had one thing I must see - and that if I refused, he would order his coachman to take me bound." He winked at Tikhon. "Your coachman, by the way, said he would bind me tenderly. I was touched and agreed."

Tikhon on the box chuckled into his beard.

The General greeted everyone briefly, drily, as always. But I noticed that under his arm was a parcel. Small, oblong, wrapped in a faded silk kerchief - once, perhaps, blue, and now pale blue like the sky over a desert. He held it as one holds something very fragile and very heavy at once.

* * *

The study of my aunt's late husband - the very one where the General slept when he stayed, and where I had overheard a conversation not meant for my ears - was prepared as for a council. Curtains drawn. On the writing desk - six candles in two candelabra, though it was day. Armchairs arranged in a semicircle. By the fireplace, where a small fire crackled - coffee, brandy, Marfa's almond biscuits.

There were six of us. My aunt - in her chair by the fireplace, straight, pale, in dark lilac, with pearls, gripping a lace handkerchief in her hands. The General - at the desk. Svetsitsky - beside him, already spreading out his notebooks. Doctor Strauch - in the corner, with an unlit cigar, with his black little book on his knee. Konstantin - by the door, like a sentry. And I - in the armchair opposite my aunt, so that between us there was only the fire.

The General laid the parcel on the desk. Stood over it. Then turned to my aunt.

"Artemia Aristarkhovna," he said quietly. "Are you sure?"

My aunt looked long at the parcel. Then - at me.

“No, Pavel Nikolaevich,” she said. “I am not sure.” She paused. “But the crape fell by itself. Tonight. Agafya sat until the cocks crowed.”

The General slowly nodded - as though this were precisely what he had wanted to hear. Or feared.

“Then,” he said, “the time has come.”

And untied the kerchief.

* * *

Inside was a scroll. Not of paper - of leather. Old, dark, almost black leather, dressed so thin that it showed through in the candlelight, rolled into a tube two palms long and tied with a faded cord of goat's wool. It smelled of dust, sand and something else - dry, bitter, steppe-like, as wormwood smells in August.

“Khiva,” said the General, addressing no one, looking at the scroll. “Thirty years ago. We were going through the sands to Khiva. A detachment - a hundred and forty men. The guide fled on the second day. The water ran out on the third.” He paused. “Mikhail has probably told you. How I went to the Turkmen.”

“He has, Your Excellency,” I said quietly. “The Colonel said you returned at dawn with a guide and with water-skins. And with a scroll.”

“With a scroll.” The General touched the cord with the tips of his fingers. “I did not know their language. Not a word. I came into their camp alone, unarmed, with raised hands - and expected to be cut down. I was led to an old man. Very old. Blind in one eye. He sat by a fire and told his beads. He looked at me with his one eye - for a long time. Then said something to his people. They brought water. A great deal of water. And a guide.” The General paused. “And then the old man took from under his robe this. And said - I understood him, I do not know how, as one understands in dreams - ‘This scroll waits for a man. For long. You are not that man. But you will meet him. Give it to him. And say: the earth remembers.’”

The earth remembers. The old aborigine in Australia: “Tell him that the earth remembers his song.” The old Turkmen near Khiva: “Say: the earth remembers.”

“Thirty years,” said the General, “I have carried it with me. On all campaigns. On all ships. Across all oceans.” He raised his eyes to me. “I

thought - perhaps I shall meet him. In Samarkand. In Peking. In Cuba. In Siam. I looked at faces. All these years - I looked at faces."

"And did you meet him?" asked Svetsitsky.

The General did not answer. He was looking at me.

Then he untied the cord.

* * *

The scroll unrolled on the desk by itself - slowly, with an old, leathery rustle, as though it had grown tired in thirty years of being rolled.

It was written upon. All of it, from edge to edge. Not in letters - no, not in letters. In long, flowing, curving lines running one into another without breaks, without spaces, without beginning or end. Dark brown, almost black - not ink, I understood, but something else, something that had eaten so deep into the leather that it had become part of it.

In the study it grew so quiet that one could hear the candles gutter.

I looked at the scroll - and could not tear my eyes away. I did not know these signs. I had never seen them. And yet, looking at them, I felt what I had felt in Stefan's greenhouse when he unfolded before me the five-hundred-year-old monastery paper. As though a key were entering a lock I had never seen.

"Professor," said the General.

Svetsitsky was already leafing through his notebook - the thick one, in an oilcloth cover, in which he had written down all I had told him on that day I did not remember. His hands, usually so sure, visibly trembled. He found the page. Laid the notebook on the desk, beside the scroll.

"Here," he said dully. "Here is what he drew me then. At the inn. Himself. With my pencil. I asked: 'Show me what the signs on your note look like.' And he wrote a line. One. Without thinking. As though he had been writing all his life."

On the page of the notebook, beneath the drawing of two circles and a wavy line, in pencil, in my hand - I recognized the pressure, recognized even the habitual blot at the end, though one cannot make a blot with a pencil, but there was a thickening there, exactly the same - ran a line. Long, flowing, curving.

Sventsitsky took a candle and slowly drew it along the scroll, from line to line, checking against the notebook. We all followed the flame. A line. Another. Another.

At the seventh line from the bottom the candle stopped.

"Here," whispered Sventsitsky.

The line on the scroll. The line in the notebook.

Identical. Curve for curve. Loop for loop.

* * *

Doctor Strauch rose from his corner and came to the desk. Looked long - at the scroll, at the notebook, again at the scroll. Put on his glasses. Took them off. Put them on again. Took a magnifying glass from his pocket.

"Allow me," he said. "I assert nothing. I only observe." He bent over the scroll. "A coincidence of form. Complete. That is a fact." He straightened. "The explanations which come to my mind as a physician are the following. First: the young man once saw this scroll, memorized, forgot, and in a state of... altered consciousness reproduced it. Memory, gentlemen, keeps more than we think."

"I have never seen this scroll," I said. "The General has carried it thirty years in a locked case."

"Second," Strauch went on unperturbed, as though he had not heard. "The professor, forgive me, could have adjusted the drawing after he saw the scroll. Yesterday. At the inn. When he was 'abducted.'"

Sventsitsky turned crimson. The General raised a hand, calming.

"The professor had not seen the scroll before this minute, Karl Fyodorovich," he said. "I kept it by me. And his notebook - look at the date."

Strauch looked. Long.

"Then third," he said at last. Quietly. "For which I have no medical name."

"And do you have one, Professor?" asked my aunt. For the first time in all that while. Her voice was even, but the handkerchief in her hands was twisted into a rope.

Sventsitsky was silent a long time.

“I have, Artemia Aristarkhovna,” he said. “Only it is not scientific. It was told to me by an old woman in Kargopol. An obmiranka. She said: ‘There are people who write one and the same line at different ends of the earth. Not knowing each other. Not knowing the language. Because it is not they who write. It is the one who sent them who writes through them.’” He paused. “I wrote it down then and laughed. Now I do not laugh.”

* * *

“Stefan’s paper,” I said. I do not know why I remembered it just now.

All looked at me. I took from the blue notebook the monastery paper folded in four, almost rotted at the folds - the one that Stefan had put into my hand in the greenhouse. Unfolded it. Laid it on the desk, beside the scroll and the professor’s notebook.

A dark scarlet rose. Two circles, one filled, one empty. A wavy line. And a line of script beneath them.

Sventsitsky again drew the candle along. The General bent over the desk. Strauch - with his magnifying glass. My aunt rose from her chair - for the first time - and came up, leaning on the back of it.

The line on the monastery paper. Five hundred years. Tarnovo.

The line on the Turkmen scroll. Khiva.

The line in the professor’s notebook. A district town. A week ago. In my hand.

One and the same.

“Three ends of the earth,” said Strauch very quietly, lowering the glass. “Three centuries. One hand.” He took off his glasses and polished them a long time with the skirt of his coat, though they were clean. “Gentlemen, I am a German. I believe in what can be touched.” He put the glasses on. “I have touched this.”

My aunt stood at the desk, looking at the three lines. Then slowly raised her hand and touched the leather scroll with the tips of her fingers - as one touches the face of a sleeping child.

“He wrote like that too,” she said. Barely audible. Addressing no one. “That one. When he stood at the railings. He wrote in the dust. With

a finger. This line.” She closed her eyes. “For forty years I have tried to forget it.”

The General turned to her. Konstantin at the door stepped forward. But my aunt had already moved away from the desk - to the fireplace, to her chair - and sat, and was again straight and pale, and the handkerchief in her hands was again just a handkerchief.

“Continue, Pavel Nikolaevich,” she said evenly. “You wished to tell. Where else you have seen such signs.”

* * *

The General poured himself brandy. Drank. Poured another and did not drink - simply held the glass, looking into the fire.

“In Brazil,” he said. “I told you of Rio, Artemia Aristarkhovna. Of the bay, of the Sugarloaf, of the parrots. I did not tell you of another mountain.”

“Which?” asked Konstantin.

“It is called Pedra da Gávea. The Rock of the Maintop - in Portuguese, from the ship’s term: the maintop is a platform on a mast, and the mountain looks like one.” The General paused. “An enormous granite block above the sea, south of the city. Flat on top, like a table. And on its side, on the sheer wall - signs. Huge, each the height of a man. As though someone had carved them in the granite. The locals say - Phoenicians. That the Phoenicians sailed there a thousand years before the Portuguese and left an inscription. The Brazilian learned society even sent an expedition there. Some thirty years ago.” He smiled. “The scholars said - erosion. Wind and rain. No signs.”

“And you?”

“And I climbed up there,” said the General. “With a mulatto guide named Joaquim. Two days through jungle, over rocks, over lianas. Joaquim crossed himself the whole way and said that only madmen and Englishmen go up that mountain.” The General paused. “We climbed. I looked at the signs up close. From a rope, over the abyss.”

“And?”

The General glanced at the scroll on the desk.

“Erosion,” he said. “Perhaps. Wind and rain. Only wind and rain, Professor,” he turned to Svetsitsky, “for some reason draw the very

same loop. Here.” He jabbed a finger at the scroll, at the third line from the top. “The same. I remembered it. I have remembered it thirty years since.”

“And Joaquim?” asked Konstantin.

“Joaquim,” said the General, and in his voice for the first time a smile flickered, “when we came down, refused to take money from me. Said: ‘Señor, you are the first man who looked at that mountain as though reading a letter from a relative.’ And went into the jungle. I never saw him again.”

* * *

“And Argentina?” asked Svetsitsky, already writing. “You surely went on south from Brazil?”

“I did,” nodded the General. “On the same American steamer of Captain Hall’s. To Buenos Aires.” He paused. “A strange city. It stands on a river so wide it seems a sea. The water in it is the colour of coffee with milk. Ruddy. From silt. They call it the Silver River, though there is no silver in it and never was. The Spaniards named it so because they hoped. All the Spaniards in America named things for what they hoped for.”

“And the city itself?”

“Low. Flat. White one-storey houses with inner courtyards, with grilles on the windows. Broad streets - straight as by a ruler. And beyond the city - the pampa.” The General set down his glass. “You have seen the steppe, Professor. Near Orenburg. Near Astrakhan.”

“I have.”

“The pampa is a steppe stretched to the edge of the earth and forgotten to be rolled up.” The General paused. “Grass above the waist. No tree. No hill. No stone. Only grass, sky and wind. You ride a day - the same. You ride a week - the same. And suddenly on the horizon - a dot. A horseman. A gaucho.”

“Gaucho?” Konstantin repeated.

“Herdsman. Mounted. Like our Cossacks - only wilder.” The General, for the first time all evening, brightened genuinely. “They live in the saddle. Eat nothing but meat - roast a whole bullock on a spit over a fire. Drink maté - tea from a gourd through a silver tube, one for all,

passed round the circle. In the hand - bolas: three stones on thongs. They throw - and the thongs wind round the legs of a bull or an ostrich at a gallop." He smiled. "I tried to throw. Wound them round the legs of my own horse. The gauchos laughed so that two fell out of their saddles."

Konstantin roared. Even Strauch twitched the corner of his mouth.

"I lived two weeks with them on an estancia," the General went on. "With the old owner, Don Eusebio. And one evening by the fire I saw a payada."

"A payada?"

"A duel of singers," said the General. "Two gauchos sit facing each other with guitars. And sing in turn. Compose on the spot. Set each other riddles - in verse. Whoever does not answer has lost. Sometimes the duel lasts all night." He paused. "That evening two sang. An old, grey one, named Remigio. And a young one - dark, bold, a stranger, from other parts. They sang till dawn. Neither could win. And toward morning old Remigio set a riddle that silenced the young one."

"What riddle?" I asked.

The General closed his eyes, remembering. Then slowly pronounced - first in Spanish, in a singsong, then, after a pause, in Russian, choosing the words:

"“There is a city in the pampa that is not. All see it, but none has reached it. It stands where you seek it, And leaves when you approach. Whoever lives in it does not age. Whoever has come out of it does not remember. What is the name of this city?””

The study was silent.

"The young one did not answer," said the General. "Rose. Bowed to the old man. Mounted his horse and rode away - into the pampa, toward the dawn. Everyone decided he had lost, left out of shame." The General paused. "And Don Eusebio told me that all gauchos know the answer. It is the City of the Caesars. A legend. That somewhere in the south, in Patagonia, beyond the pampa, at the foot of the mountains, there is a city. Silver. Built by survivors of a wrecked Spanish ship. Or by fugitive Incas. Or by those who came before the Incas. It has been sought for three hundred years. Hundreds of expeditions. Jesuits, soldiers, gold seekers. No one has found it. Sometimes it is seen in the distance - towers, walls, lights. You ride up - it vanishes. And the people who live

there, they say, do not age. And if anyone comes out of there - he forgets where he came from.”

“And the young singer?” asked Svetsitsky, ceasing to write. “Did he know the answer?”

The General opened his eyes.

“Don Eusebio said,” he spoke slowly, “that this young man had come to their estancia before. Forty years earlier. Just as young. Just as dark. Sang the same payada with the same Remigio, who was then young too. And left at dawn in the same way, without answering.” He paused. “Old Remigio, they say, wept after that evening. And said: ‘He is from that city. He cannot name it - because he does not remember. But every time I set this riddle, he rises and goes - there.’”

* * *

“Fiji,” said the General suddenly.

He said it looking into the fire, as though he had remembered only now. Or had long not wished to remember.

“Fiji?” repeated my aunt. “Where is that, Pavel Nikolaevich?”

“Far, Artemia Aristarkhovna. The farthest I have been.” The General paused. “Islands in the Pacific. South of the equator. Between Australia and nothing. I came there on our corvette - we were going from Kamchatka to Sydney, and the captain decided to put in at the islands for water and provisions. Some seven years ago.” He smiled. “The crew did not want to. Everyone knew that on Fiji they eat people.”

Lizonka Kutasova, had she been here, would have fainted. My aunt only pursed her lips.

“Eat?” asked Konstantin with lively interest.

“They did, lieutenant.” The General nodded. “Then they still did. A year before our coming they had eaten an English missionary there. Together with his boots. The boots, they say, were boiled a long time - they could not chew them.” He paused. “But we were received well. We were taken in on the island of Ovalau, in the town of Levuka - white traders lived there, whalers, escaped convicts from Australia, missionaries - all the scum of the Pacific. Taverns, shops, drunken brawls. And beyond the town - mountains, jungle, waterfalls. And the natives’ villages.”

“What are they like?” asked Sventsitsky.

“Tall. Strong. Dark skin. Hair - like this,” the General spread his hands above his head, “enormous, bushy, like a cap. Their chiefs - they are called ‘ratu’ - wear in their hair combs of tortoiseshell and a sperm whale’s tooth at the neck. They say that whoever has more whale’s teeth is more important.” He paused. “I was received by one such chief. Ratu Vanua. Old, huge, with scars all over his body. He invited me to a ceremony.”

“What ceremony?”

“The walking on fire,” said the General.

* * *

“On the small island of Beqa,” he related, “lives one tribe. Only that one, among all the islands. They walk on fire.” The General paused. “I saw it. With my own eyes. They dig a pit - large, several sazhen - and fill it with stones. River stones, smooth. They build a fire on the stones. Burn it all day. The stones heat white - so that one cannot approach the pit nearer than five paces, the hairs on one’s arms crackle from the heat. Then the embers are raked out with long poles. And only stones remain. White. Glowing.”

He paused. In the study it was quiet, only the fireplace crackled.

“And then the men come out,” said the General. “Barefoot. Their priest - an old man, whom they called Tui Kai - goes in front. They walk on the stones. Slowly. Calmly. There and back.” He raised his eyes to us. “I looked at their feet afterward. Not a burn. Not a blister. Not a single mark.”

“Impossible,” said Strauch.

“I saw it, Karl Fyodorovich,” said the General. “I do not ask you to believe. I say - I saw.”

“How do they explain it?” asked Sventsitsky.

“By a legend,” said the General. “Long ago, they say, an ancestor of theirs, a fisherman, caught in the river a god. A little one. The god begged to be released. And in reward gave the fisherman and all his line power over fire. Fire does not burn those whom the god has released.” The General paused. “But Tui Kai, the priest, told me something else. Later, at night, by the fire. Through an interpreter - a runaway Irish

convict who had lived twenty years on the islands and knew all their languages.”

“What did he tell?”

The General looked into the fire a long time.

“He said that fire does not burn those who themselves came from fire. That their ancestors are not fishermen. That their ancestors came down from the sky. Together with fire. And that once - long ago, in his grandfather’s time - a white man came to their island. Alone. Without a ship.” The General paused. “No one saw how he arrived. In the morning he was simply sitting on the shore. Young. He did not remember who he was. And when they showed him the walking on fire - he rose and walked on the stones. First. Before the priests. Himself.”

“And was not burned?” whispered Konstantin.

“Tui Kai said,” the General spoke slowly, “that the stones under his feet cooled. Became cold. All of them. As though he took their heat into himself.” The General paused. “And then he reached the end of the pit - and went into the jungle. To the cliff at the edge of the island, from which, by their belief, the souls of the dead leap into the sea to go to the other world. And he was not seen again.”

“The cliff from which souls leap,” repeated Svetsitsky.

“They say,” the General nodded, “that on the western edge of the largest island there is a cape. From there the soul of the dead leaps into the sea and swims to Bulu - the land of the dead, under the water. And on the way it is met by the god Degei. A huge serpent. He lives in a cave in the mountains. When he turns in his sleep, the earth shakes.” The General paused. “Tui Kai said that that white man, before leaping, stood on the cape and wrote something on the rock. With a finger. On the wet stone. And that the next morning, when the water dried, the signs remained. Burned in. Like a brand.”

“Did you see that cape?” I asked.

The General looked at me. For a long time.

“I did,” he said. “We put in there before sailing. The captain did not want to - there are reefs - but I persuaded him.” He paused. “The signs on the rock were there. Burned in. Almost effaced by the surf in half a century. But there.”

He slowly set his glass on the mantelpiece. Went to the desk. Laid a finger on the Turkmen scroll - on the fifth line from the bottom.

"These," he said.

* * *

No one spoke. The candles guttered. The fire in the fireplace was dying.

Then my aunt rose. Came to the desk. Looked at the scroll, at the monastery paper, at the professor's notebook. At the three identical lines that had come from three ends of the world. And at three more places where the General had seen them - the mountain above the sea in Brazil, the cliff above the reefs on Fiji - and at one more, about which she had been silent forty years. The dust at the railings.

"Pavel," she said. Without patronymic. For the first time in all the time I had known her - before everyone. "Give it to him."

The General looked at her. Then at me.

"The old man in the sands said," he spoke slowly, "'You are not that man. But you will meet him. Give it to him.'" He paused. "For thirty years I have looked at faces. On three continents. On five seas." He carefully, tenderly rolled up the scroll, tied it with the cord of goat's wool, wrapped it in the faded blue kerchief. "I do not know whether you are that man. I know only that I have not met another."

He held the parcel out to me.

"The earth remembers," he said. "So the old man bade me say."

I took it. The parcel was light. Light as a bird. And warm - like the coin, like a stone in the sun, like a hand held too long to let go.

* * *

Then everyone dispersed. Svetsitsky - to the guest room, to write, - he said he would not sleep till he had written down everything, to the last word, and that he would leave the day after tomorrow, "if the General does not abduct me again." Strauch - to his outbuilding, where, as I learned afterward from Dunyasha, he sat till morning smoking cigar after cigar and rereading some German book. The General - to the terrace, alone. My aunt - to her rooms, saying not another word.

Konstantin walked me to my room. In silence. At the door he stopped.

“Mon cher,” he said. “Brazil. Argentina. Fiji. Khiva. Tarnovo.” He paused. “Everywhere there was someone. Young. Nameless. Who did not remember who he was. And everywhere left one and the same line.”

“I heard.”

“And everywhere went away,” said Konstantin. Quietly. “Into the jungle. Into the pampa. Into the sea from a cliff.” He looked at me, and in his eyes, in the uncertain candlelight, was something that made my heart contract. “Will you go too?”

I did not know what to answer.

“I don’t know,” I said honestly.

Konstantin nodded. As though this were exactly what he had feared.

“Then I shall sit by the door,” he said. “Every night. Until you know.”

“You cannot sit by the door every night.”

“I can,” said Konstantin. “I am a lieutenant. I know how not to sleep.” He clapped me on the shoulder. “Good night, man from the City of the Caesars.”

And went off without looking back.

* * *

I laid the parcel on the table. Beside the blue notebook. Beside the cutting of the black rose in its clay pot.

And saw that the bud had opened.

Not entirely. Halfway. The dark scarlet, almost black petals had parted, revealing the heart - golden, like the pollen on the legs of bees in the General’s garden. From the bud came a smell. Strong. Sweet. Honey and dust. Honey and sand. Honey and something else - steppe-like, bitter, like wormwood in August.

Like the scroll.

I sat on the bed and looked a long time at the rose that had opened out of season, in a foreign land, on my windowsill.

“When this rose blooms in a foreign land - I shall return.”

Somewhere far off, at the end of the corridor, in the gallery, in the moonlight, hung the portrait of a young man in a light neckcloth, with two stones in his hand. Under crape. Which Agafya Tikhonovna, I knew,

had straightened again - as she had straightened it every morning for fifty years.

And I knew - not understanding how - that this crape would fall no more.

Because the one who had been awaited had already come.

Chapter XXVIII. The Most Ancient Epic

The grain was distributed on the third day of the festival, from dawn to sunset, at the gates of the Temple granaries - and I stood there all day, from the first sack to the last, beside Nefer-Ka.

So it had been proclaimed: from the hands of Pharaoh and the High Priest. Together. And we stood together - shoulder to shoulder, on a dais by the gate, above an endless river of people flowing past us with baskets, sacks, pots, with hems of garments stretched out like bowls. Nebamun sat at the foot of the dais at a low table and counted - every sack, every measure, every handful - dry, motionless as a heron over water. Beside him Ani, the deaf scribe of the council, wrote after him, every now and then asking "Repeat for the record?" so loudly that people in the queue began to laugh and the tension on the square eased.

Nefer-Ka smiled. All day. Bowed to the people. Blessed children. Touched the brows of the old with his hand. Pronounced: "The Temple gives what is its own to the people, as the god gives his water." And the people bowed to him. Bowed to both of us. But I saw - and Nebamun, I knew, saw too - that they bowed differently. To me - quickly, respectfully, as one bows to Pharaoh. To him - slowly, long, peering into his face. As one bows to the one who decides whether you will have bread tomorrow.

"He has outplayed you, my Pharaoh," Nebamun said to me in the evening, when the gates of the granaries had closed and the last sack was recorded. "You made him give the grain. And he made sure the people will remember that it was the Temple who gave it." He folded his tablets. "Three thousand hekats. The people will be fed for two moons. And they will thank him."

"I know, Nebamun."

"You know," nodded the keeper of the treasury. "And still you stood all day." He paused. "My father used to say: there are kings who feed the people, and there are kings who feed their own glory. The first are forgotten. The second are remembered." He looked at me over his tablets. "I, my Pharaoh, prefer to serve the first. But I am too old not to fear for them."

* * *

Paney found me at the exit from the square - out of breath, barefoot, with the training spear which he now carried everywhere, as Iti had once carried his brush.

"My Pharaoh!" he blurted. "Bata told me to pass it on. From Panehsy. The man with the scar through his eyebrow. He has gone."

"Gone?"

"Last night. The Medjay were watching. He left the tent where the bearers lived - though the bearers are no longer there, they left with the ambassador - and walked across the whole city to the temple of Ptah. Knocked at the back gate. They let him in." Paney caught his breath. "Panehsy says - he has not come out. Till now. He sits in the temple."

"Who opened the gate?"

Paney shook his head.

"The Medjay did not see. It was dark. Only a hand." He hesitated. "Bata says Panehsy said - the hand jingled."

Bracelets.

"Good, Paney," I said. "Tell Panehsy: let them keep watching. Not touch. And tell Bata that you did everything right."

The boy beamed and raced off. I watched him go and thought how quickly children learn to be soldiers when around them there is a war that no one has declared.

* * *

Amenemope sent for me at dusk - not a messenger, but Iti himself.

The youth waited at the small garden gate, under the jasmine, where we now met almost every night, and, seeing me, bowed - not like a scribe but somehow anew, awkwardly and warmly at once.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. “The senior keeper says: tonight. The ark is open. He has the key. The High Priest has been on the square all day and this evening will be at the feast of the nomarch of Memphis - the one in honour of the festival. Until midnight he will not be here.” He paused. “The senior keeper says that you have long wished to read the Epic whole. Not only those lines that are read at coronations.” Iti raised his eyes to me. “He says: tonight it is possible. Perhaps never again.”

“Why never again?”

Iti hesitated.

“He did not say, my Pharaoh. He only looked at me as old men look when they know something and do not wish to speak.”

* * *

The Library at night was different from the Library by day.

By day it was a place where people worked: scribes bent over scrolls, brushes scratched, papyrus rustled, someone read aloud in an undertone, someone argued over a sign. At night it was a place where things slept. Not people - scrolls. Thousands of scrolls, laid in niches along the walls, from floor to ceiling, in leather cases, in clay jars, in wooden caskets - they lay in the dark as the old sleep, quietly, motionlessly, and I, entering, involuntarily slowed my step, as though afraid to wake them.

It smelled of cedar, dust, mice and old papyrus - sweetish, slightly musty, as dried reeds smell on a riverbank. A single lamp burned in the depths, by the large table. And beside it, leaning on his staff of black wood, stood Amenemope.

On the table before him lay the ark.

I had seen it before - at the coronation, from afar, when it was carried out, opened, three lines read from it and closed again. A long casket of cedar, covered with gold, with a lid in the form of a temple roof, with guardians at the corners - little golden figures of goddesses with outspread wings, embracing the ark on all sides as though protecting it. On the lid - a sign: a winged sun disc. And beneath it - two Eyes. Right and left.

I had not noticed this before. Two Eyes.

“My Pharaoh,” said Amenemope, bowing. His voice in the silence of the Library sounded like the rustle of a turning page. “I promised that I

would bring it at any hour of day or night. I keep my promises.” He paused. “I am old. I do not know how many more years I shall hold this key. Perhaps not many. The High Priest lately asks me whether I am tired. Whether I do not wish to retire. To a quiet temple. By the southern cataracts.”

By the southern cataracts. Whence no letters come.

“You will not go to the southern cataracts, Amenemope,” I said.

The old man smiled - drily, as old parchment cracks.

“My Pharaoh is kind,” he said. “But Pharaoh does not always decide who goes where.” He turned the key in the lock of the ark. “Sit. The night is long, and the Epic longer. The boy will read. His eyes are younger than mine. And I shall listen and correct if he errs. Though he does not err. Ever. It is even tedious.”

Iti blushed.

* * *

The Epic was not one scroll. There were seven. Seven tight, heavy scrolls, each as thick as an arm, wrapped in the finest linen yellowed to the colour of ivory. Amenemope took them out one by one, carefully, as infants are lifted from a cradle, and laid them on the table in a row.

“Seven,” he said. “Like the seven branches of the Nile in the Delta. Like the seven Hathors who come to every child’s cradle and foretell his fate.” He touched the first scroll. “This one is about the beginning. This one - about the gods. This - about the First Ones. This - about the kings. This - about how people live. This - about death and what is after. And the seventh...” He stopped. “The seventh no one has read. Because no one can.”

“Why?”

“You will see, my Pharaoh.”

Iti unrolled the first scroll. Bent over it - so low that the ink stain on his cheek, fresh, today’s, almost touched the papyrus. And began to read. Quietly, slowly, in a chant, as ancient texts are read - with that special, solemn intonation taught in the school of scribes from the very first days.

““In the beginning there was nothing. There was no sky. There was no earth. There was neither day nor night, neither death nor life. There were no gods, and there were no names for that which was not. There

was only water. Nun. Endless, dark, motionless water, which had neither bottom nor surface nor edge. It was everything - and it was nothing. It neither slept nor woke. It waited.”

Iti fell silent, drew breath. The lamp crackled.

““And out of the water rose a hill. Small. The first. Benben. As the first patch of black earth rises from the flood when the water recedes. And on the hill stood He-who-created-himself. Atum. He was not born - he came into being. He said: “I am.” And when he said it - he became.””

“I am,” I repeated quietly. “And became.”

“Yes, my Pharaoh,” said Amenemope from the shadow. “The most ancient word in the world. The first thing that was said. Everything else - after.”

Somewhere deep within me, under the ribs, on the left, something stirred. Two words on a luminous window, in the dark, in a room I had never seen: “Who am I?” - “Who are you?”

I blinked. The vision went.

* * *

Iti read on. How Atum, lonely on his hill, breathed out - and from his breath was born Shu, the air. And spat - and from his spittle was born Tefnut, moisture. How Shu and Tefnut were lost in the darkness of Nun, and Atum sent his Eye to seek them, and the Eye found them and brought them back, and Atum wept with joy, and from his tears people were born.

“People were born from tears?” I asked.

“From tears, my Pharaoh,” confirmed Amenemope. “That is why people weep so often. It is in their blood. It is their first memory.”

“And the Eye?” I asked. “The Eye that sought the lost children?”

“The Eye became independent,” said the old man. “Went away from Atum. Because while it sought the children, Atum had made himself a new Eye - and set it in the place of the old. And the old one returned and saw that its place was taken. And raged.” He paused. “Then Atum took the old Eye and set it on his forehead. As a serpent. As the uraeus. The very one that Pharaoh wears on his crown. So that it would always be in front. And always look where he looks.”

I involuntarily touched my forehead - where by day, on the square, in the crown, I had the uraeus.

"The Eye that seeks the lost," said Iti quietly, not raising his head from the scroll. "And returns. And finds its place taken. And rages." He paused. "Like the lioness in the southern ambassador's tale. Who went to the south."

"You listened?" I asked.

"I was writing it down, my Pharaoh," said Iti. "Every word. I always write down. Even when I am not asked."

He read on. How Shu and Tefnut bore Geb and Nut - earth and sky. How Geb and Nut loved each other so greatly that they lay embracing and there was no room between them for anything. How Shu, their father, stood between them and lifted Nut up - and so she stands ever since, arched over the earth, resting her hands on the west and her feet on the east - and weeps every morning with dew, because she cannot reach Geb.

"The star-watcher Seneb told me this," I said. "Four years ago. On an island in the Delta. When..."

I broke off. Iti raised his head. Looked at me.

"When you pulled a scribe boy out of the water," he said quietly. "Yes, my Pharaoh. I remember."

We looked at each other over the ancient scroll. The lamp crackled. Amenemope in the shadow coughed - delicately, as the old cough when they wish to say "I am here" and at once "I am not here."

"Read on, Iti," I said.

"I read, my Pharaoh," he said. And bent to the scroll. But his cheeks burned.

* * *

"But there was another account," Iti read, having unrolled the second scroll. "The priests of Memphis tell it differently. In Memphis they say: the world was not made by Atum. The world was made by Ptah. Ptah, who was before Atum. Ptah conceived the world in his heart. And named it with his tongue. And all that he conceived with his heart and named with his tongue - came to be. The sky came to be because he

said “sky.” The earth came to be because he said “earth.” The gods came to be because he called them by name.”

Iti stopped.

“Conceived with the heart and named with the tongue,” he repeated slowly. “My Pharaoh, this is... this is like us. Like scribes. We too first conceive, and then write. And what we have written remains. Even when we are gone.”

“Not so, boy,” said Amenemope from the shadow. “We write what already is. Ptah named what was not yet.” He paused. “Though... who knows. Perhaps we too sometimes write what is not yet. And then it appears. Because it has been named.”

“How - appears?” I asked.

The old man raised his staff and pointed it at the shelves going off into the dark.

“Here lie thousands of scrolls, my Pharaoh. In them are recorded names. Kings. Gods. Cities. Rivers. People. Most of these people died long ago. Most of the cities are no more.” He lowered the staff. “But while a scroll lies here, while someone can read the name - they are. They are still here. Not entirely. Half. Like shadows. Like those in the Duat, between worlds.” He paused. “Ptah named the world - and the world came to be. We name the world - and the world remains. Perhaps it is the same. Only from different ends.”

From different ends. Like an inscription that is read in both directions.

How did I know that? I did not know.

* * *

The third scroll was about the First Ones.

Iti unrolled it - and froze.

“My Pharaoh,” he whispered. “Here... here the hand is different.”

I bent toward him. He was right. The first two scrolls were written in an even, solemn, ancient hand - such as was written under the very first kings. This one - also ancient, but different. More angular. More hurried. As though the writer was in haste. Or afraid he would not be in time.

““And then,”” Iti read, running a finger along the lines without touching them, ““when the gods had gone to heaven, and people were left

on earth alone, and did not know how to live, and died of hunger, and killed one another, and had neither king nor law nor Maat - then there came down from the sky the First Ones.”

““They came down in a barque,” Iti read. ““Not such as ours. Their barque was made of light. It shone so that people fell on their faces and could not look. It alighted on a hill, on that very Benben where Atum had once stood. And from the barque came out the First Ones. They were tall - taller than any man. Their faces shone. They spoke a language that no one understood - and all understood.”

Tall. Taller than any man.

““They taught people to sow barley and emmer. To count the days by the stars. To measure the water of the Nile. To build. To write. They gave people Maat - truth, order, measure. They chose from among the people the most worthy - and set him as king. The first Pharaoh. And gave into his hands that which they had brought with them from heaven.”

Iti raised his eyes.

““The Two Eyes,” he read.

I stopped breathing.

““One Eye is light,” Iti read on, and his voice trembled. ““It leads. It sees the path. The other is dark. It keeps. It remembers. He who holds both stands at the door between worlds. He who holds both can go and return. But cannot remain.”

“Cannot remain,” I repeated.

““And the First Ones said to the king: “We shall go. We must. But we shall return. One of us will return. Not as now. In another body. In another time. He will not remember who he is. He will seek. When he finds - let him find the Two Eyes where they wait. And when he remembers his first name - he will return what was taken. And the two Eyes will become one.””

Iti fell silent. In the Library it became so quiet that I heard somewhere in the dark, behind the shelves, a mouse scratching.

“You have heard this before,” I said to Amenemope. Not asking.

“I have heard this for forty years, my Pharaoh,” said the old man from the shadow. “From my teacher. And he from his. These lines are known by heart to all senior keepers.” He paused. “And all of them asked one question. Who is ‘he’? Who will return? Whom to await?”

“And who?”

“It is not written, my Pharaoh,” said Amenemope. “There is no name.” He paused. “But my teacher used to say: each time a new Pharaoh ascends the throne, the High Priest comes here. And rereads these lines. And looks at the new Pharaoh. Long.” The old man tapped his staff on the floor. “And waits.”

* * *

The fourth scroll - about the kings - Iti read quickly, hurrying; it was a long, tedious list of names, years of reign, wars, temples, floods. The fifth - about people: how to plough, how to sow, how to bury, how to judge. The sixth - about death: about the Duat, the twelve gates, the Hall of Two Truths, the forty-two judges, the feather of Maat and the beast Ammit. All this I had already heard - from Amenemope, from Seneb, from Khemu. All this was familiar.

But in the sixth scroll, at the very end, there was a place that made Iti turn pale.

““And beyond the edge of the world,”” he read, ““beyond the deserts, beyond the seas, beyond the Great Green, beyond the land of Punt, whence incense comes, beyond the land of Keftiu, whence bulls and ships come, beyond the land of Retenu, whence cedars come - there the earth ends. And Nun begins. That same water from which everything came. It surrounds the world on all sides - above, below, at the edges. The world in it is like a bubble of air in a jar of water. Small. Fragile. And if the bubble bursts - Nun will return. And all will be as it was before the beginning. Nothing.””

“The world - like a bubble in water,” I said.

“So the ancients believed, my Pharaoh,” said Amenemope. “And so they believe to this day. That is why each day the priests perform rites. So the bubble does not burst. So that Ra passes through the Duat and is born again. So that Apep - the serpent of chaos - does not swallow the solar barque.” He paused. “The priests say that without them the world will end. Perhaps so. Or perhaps the world is simply very patient.”

“Have you seen the edge of the world, Amenemope?” Iti suddenly asked.

The old man laughed - drily, with a rattle.

"I, boy, have never gone farther than Memphis." He paused. "But I knew a man who had seen. A sailor. He went to Punt - south, along the Red Sea, for incense. Twenty times he went. He told of people there with dark skin who build houses on piles. That trees grow there from which frankincense flows. That there are beasts there - spotted, with necks to the sky." He smiled. "We laughed at him then. A neck to the sky! And today such a beast ate the fig tree in Pharaoh's courtyard."

Iti snorted. I too.

"And farther than Punt?" I asked.

"Farther, said the sailor," said Amenemope, "the sea. Endless. And once, in a storm, their ship was carried far to the south. So far that the stars overhead became different. He said - stars appeared that no one had ever seen. Four. In a cross. Bright." The old man shook his head. "We did not believe him then. Stars are the same always and everywhere. So it is written. But he swore. He said: the world is bigger than written in scrolls. Much bigger. And at its edge - not Nun. But other people. Who look at other stars."

Four stars. In a cross. Somewhere I had heard this. Somewhere, from someone. A tall grey-haired man in strange clothes, by a fireplace, telling of a white light, eucalyptus trees and a bird that laughs at dawn...

No. I had never heard this. I blinked - and the alien voice went.

* * *

The seventh scroll Amenemope unrolled himself.

Slowly. Carefully. His hands, usually so firm, trembled.

"Here," he said. "Here is why no one has read it."

I bent over the table. Iti beside me, so close that I felt the warmth of his shoulder.

The seventh scroll was written not in hieroglyphs. All of it, from edge to edge. In long, flowing, curving lines running one into another without breaks, without spaces, without beginning or end.

The script.

The same as on the papyrus from the lower storehouse. The same as on the fragment of the Rock of the First Ones that Djehuty brought. The same as on the forehead of blind Nanakhat.

“For forty years I have looked at it,” said Amenemope quietly. “And my teacher looked at it for forty years. And his teacher. No one has read a sign.” He paused. “The High Priest has looked at it for thirty years. Three times in a single moon he took it. Sat right here where you sit, my Pharaoh, and looked till dawn.”

Iti was not listening. He looked at the scroll - without tearing away, bent so low that he almost lay on the table. His fingers moved above the lines, not touching them - back and forth, back and forth - as though he were counting something.

“My Pharaoh,” he suddenly whispered. “Look. Here. At the very beginning.”

I looked. At the very beginning of the scroll, in the upper corner, the script broke off. There, in a small square window ringed with a red line, stood three lines. Not in script. In hieroglyphs. Small, ancient, faded. And beneath them - script again. One line. Short.

“Here it is written in our signs,” said Iti, and his voice broke to a whisper. “‘Words of the First Ones. Keep until the appointed time.’ And beneath it - the script. Of the same length.” He raised his eyes to me, huge, dark, shining. “My Pharaoh, it is the same. The same thing is written here - in our signs and in theirs. Side by side. Like a translation.”

Amenemope, standing in the shadow, slowly came to the table. Bent. Looked long.

“Forty years,” he whispered. “Forty years I looked at this corner. And thought - it is merely a heading. A keeper’s note.” He straightened. “And it is a key.”

Iti was already taking from his bosom a rolled papyrus - the very one from the lower storehouse, found by him in the jar - and spreading it alongside. “Words of the First Ones. Sent down from the Heavens together with the Two Eyes. Do not read. Do not show. Keep until the appointed time.” And beneath it - the script.

He moved his finger from one to the other. Compared. Moved his lips.

“Here,” he said at last. “Here is this sign. Here - and here. The same. It stands where we have ‘keep.’” The finger moved on. “And this one, with the loop - where we have ‘time.’” He leaned back, pale, with burning eyes. “My Pharaoh. We know two words. Two words in the language of the First Ones. ‘Keep.’ ‘Time.’”

“Two words,” repeated Amenemope. “In forty years - two words.”
“In one night,” I corrected.

* * *

The door of the Library opened without a knock.

All three of us turned at once. Amenemope dropped his staff - it fell with a dull thud on the stone floor. Iti lunged - to seize the papyrus from the lower storehouse, to hide it - and froze, too late.

In the doorway stood Nefer-Ka.

Without retinue. Without torch. In a plain white robe, without the leopard skin, without the staff with the Eye. Tall, straight as an obelisk. His face - motionless, calm. He looked at the table. At the seven unrolled scrolls. At the seventh. At the small papyrus beside it.

“The feast of the nomarch of Memphis,” he said quietly, “proved duller than I expected. I decided to return early.” He entered, slowly, softly, treading noiselessly with bare feet on the stone slabs. “And I see I was not mistaken. It is far more interesting here.”

Amenemope, trembling, bent for his staff. Nefer-Ka picked it up first - lightly, in one movement - and held it out to the old man.

“Do not trouble yourself, honoured keeper,” he said gently. “At your age it is harmful to bend. One may not straighten again.”

Amenemope took the staff. His hands shook.

Nefer-Ka went to the table. Stopped opposite me. Looked at the seventh scroll. Then at the little papyrus. Then at Iti.

“So this is what you found in the jar, boy,” he said. “And Isiret showed me a sodden account of grain.” He smiled slightly. “Old fox. I have always respected her.”

Iti stood motionless. White as linen. But he did not retreat. And did not lower his eyes.

“Do not touch him, Nefer-Ka,” I said.

The High Priest slowly shifted his gaze to me.

“Touch?” He raised his brows. “My Pharaoh, I do not touch scribes. Scribes are the most precious thing in the Two Lands. Without them there would be neither laws nor gods nor Epic.” He looked at Iti again. “Especially such as this. Who in one night has read two words which I could not read in thirty years.”

He sat. Directly opposite me, on the stool where Amenemope had just sat. Laid his palms on the table, on either side of the seventh scroll. Not touching it.

“You want to know what I seek, my Pharaoh,” he said. Not asking. “You think - power. Grain. The throne. You think I want to become you.”

“And do you not?”

Nefer-Ka was silent a long time. The lamp crackled. Somewhere in the dark the mouse scratched on.

“I read this Epic when I was twenty,” he said at last. “In secret. My teacher, the former High Priest, gave me the key for one night - as you gave it to this boy. I read. All of it. From beginning to end. And understood one thing which before me, it seems, no one understood.” He raised his eyes to me. “The First Ones return. Again and again. In another body, in another time, not remembering themselves. So it is written. You have read it.”

“I have.”

“And do you know what happens when they return?” His voice dropped. “I read the chronicles. All the chronicles in this Library, for all the years, for all the kings. I searched. Twenty years I searched. And found.” He paused. “Every time in the chronicles a king appears who ‘looks through people,’ ‘does not remember his name,’ ‘speaks in his sleep in an unknown tongue’ - every time after his reign a drought comes. A great one. Three years. Five. Seven. Every time. Because he comes - and goes. And takes the Eye with him. That which holds the water. That which holds the world.”

Cold under the ribs. On the left.

“Three hundred years ago,” Nefer-Ka went on, “there was a Pharaoh whose name was erased from the walls. He came from nowhere. He did not remember who he was. He reigned ten years. Then he went to the festival of Opet at Luxor - and returned different. And a year later he vanished. Entirely. And for seven years there was no flood. Half of Egypt died of hunger.” Nefer-Ka looked at me unblinking. “The priests erased his name. So that he would not return. But he returned. He always returns.”

“And you think that is I.”

“I do not think, my Pharaoh,” said Nefer-Ka. “I know. I looked at you when you ascended the throne. As all High Priests looked at all Pharaohs. And I saw.” He paused. “You look through people. You do not remember where you came from. You speak in your sleep. Your servants hear.” He smiled slightly. “Your physician Hesira treats your headache with a clay crocodile and asks when it began. And you answer - ‘it seems, always.’”

“The drought began three years ago,” I said. “I have reigned longer.”

“The drought does not begin when he goes, my Pharaoh,” said Nefer-Ka gently. “The drought begins when he begins to remember.”

* * *

Iti behind my back sighed quietly. Amenemope stood motionless, leaning on his staff.

“And what do you want, Nefer-Ka?” I asked.

The High Priest rose. Looked at the seventh scroll.

“I want him to stay this time,” he said. Simply. Without a smile. “That the Eye remain here. In Egypt. By the river. That the water return - and never leave again. Never.” He raised his eyes to me, and in them for the first time in all the time I had known him I saw not calculation, not condescension, not predatory patience, but something else. Weariness. Ancient, endless weariness. “For thirty years I have watched people die of hunger, my Pharaoh. I have buried children. I have seen mothers sell daughters for a sack of barley.” He paused. “I do not want it to happen again. Once more. In three hundred years. In a thousand. Each time he comes and goes.”

“And if he does not go? If he stays?”

“Then the circle will break,” said Nefer-Ka. “And the two Eyes will never become one.” He paused. “And Egypt will live. Always.”

“And he?”

Nefer-Ka gave me a long, heavy look.

“And he, my Pharaoh,” he said quietly, “will cease to be what he was. Will become simply a man. Like all. Who will one day die.” He paused. “Is it so terrible - to become simply a man?”

I did not answer. I did not know the answer.

Nefer-Ka turned to the door. At the threshold he stopped.

"In Luxor, my Pharaoh, on the last day of the festival," he said without turning, "in the inner court, I shall reveal to you what I myself read at twenty. All that is not written here. You will be able to choose. To go - or to stay." A pause. "I hope you will choose rightly."

"And if I choose not as you wish?"

Nefer-Ka slowly turned. His face was again immobile, calm, like the face of a stone god at a temple gate.

"Then, my Pharaoh," he said, "I shall have to choose for you."

He looked at Iti. Long. Then at Amenemope. Then again at me.

"Two words," he said. "'Keep' and 'time.' In one night." He inclined his head slightly. "Boy, you are cleverer than all the senior keepers of three hundred years. Take care of yourself. The clever in this city do not live long if they do not know when to fall silent."

And went out.

* * *

We were silent a long while after the door closed behind him.

Then Amenemope slowly, heavily lowered himself onto the stool where the High Priest had just sat. His hands, resting on the staff, still trembled.

"My Pharaoh," he said. "I have served in this Library sixty years. I have seen four High Priests." He paused. "This one is the first who spoke the truth."

"What truth, Amenemope?"

"That he is afraid," said the old man. "Not of you. Not of the throne. Not of the gods." He raised faded eyes to me. "He is afraid of what will be if you remember."

Iti stood at the table, clutching in his hands the small papyrus from the lower storehouse. His face was pale, but his eyes were not.

"My Pharaoh," he said quietly. "He said: 'The clever do not live long if they do not know when to fall silent.'"

"I heard."

"I shall not be silent," said Iti. "I shall read the rest. The whole seventh scroll. I shall find more words. However much time it takes." He

paused. "Because if you must choose - to go or to stay - you must know what you are choosing from. Not only what he will say. Everything."

I looked at him. At this youth with the perpetual ink stain on his cheek who four years ago had been drowning in a channel, worrying about his board - and who now stood before me, pale, stubborn, clutching a papyrus for which he might be sent to where no letters are written.

"Iti," I said.

"Yes, my Pharaoh?"

"If I choose to go..."

He flinched. Looked at me.

"...will you write it down?" I asked. "All of it? As then, on the hunt? So that someone remembers?"

Iti was silent a long time. Then slowly, very slowly, nodded.

"I shall write it, my Pharaoh," he said. And his voice trembled. "But I hope I shall not have to." He lowered his eyes. "Because if you go - I do not know how to write on. All my scrolls are about you. Since that day on the hunt. All."

Amenemope in the shadow began to cough. Long, diligently. And turned away to the shelves.

* * *

Toward morning, when the seven scrolls of the Most Ancient Epic lay again in the ark under the golden wings of the goddesses, and the key again hung round Amenemope's neck, I climbed to the roof of the Library. Alone. No - not alone: Iti followed me, silently, and I did not send him away.

The sky over the capital was dark, but in the east it was already beginning to grey. Stars went out one by one - slowly, reluctantly, as though not wishing to go. Only in the north, high up, circled round their invisible axis the Imperishable - those that never set.

"Seneb said," I said, looking at them, "that his teacher believed: the Imperishable are not those who have gone. They are those who have not yet come. Who circle and await their hour."

"I remember, my Pharaoh," said Iti quietly. "I wrote it down."

“You were there?” I turned to him. “That night, on the island? When Seneb told me of the stars?”

Iti blushed - it was visible even in the pre-dawn greyness.

“I was not asleep, my Pharaoh. I lay behind the tents. I heard.” He paused. “I wrote down everything. Every word. That same night. By the light of the fire. That board... I have it still. Mau fished it out of the water, remember? Afterward I wrote on it.”

I looked at him. At the Imperishable stars above his head. At the grey, brightening sky.

“Will you show it to me someday?” I asked.

“I shall, my Pharaoh,” said Iti. “When you remember.”

“And if I do not remember?”

Iti looked at me - straight, long, without fear.

“Then I shall read it to you aloud,” he said. “Every evening. Until you remember.”

Over the eastern hills the rim of the sun appeared. Nut was giving birth to Ra - red, wet, enormous, as she had given birth every morning since the beginning of time. And somewhere below, in the temple garden, the baboons of Thoth cried out, greeting the sunrise. All at once.

Seven days remained until the new moon.

Vision V. The Monolith

At first there was nothing.

Not darkness - darkness is already something, darkness is a place where there is no light, and therefore where light can be. Not silence - silence is a place where there is no sound. Not emptiness. Not cold. Not time.

Nothing.

And then - in that nothing - a question arose. It was not asked in a voice, because there was no voice. It was not written, because there were neither signs nor anything to write them on. It simply arose - as a ring arises on water when nothing has been thrown into it.

“Where am I?”

And from this question - from this one question alone - the “I” appeared.

* * *

I had no body.

I did not understand this at once. At first I tried to move a hand - and found no hand. Tried to open my eyes - and found no eyelids. Tried to draw breath - and found neither chest nor air nor need to breathe. There was no fear. Fear lives in the body - in the belly, under the ribs, in the throat. Here there was neither belly nor ribs nor throat. There was only I. A point. No larger than a pinhead - and at the same time larger than everything I had ever seen.

Because around me were stars.

Not such as are seen from the earth - twinkling, trembling, tiny, nailed to the black dome of the sky. These did not twinkle. They burned. Evenly, motionlessly, calmly, each in its own colour: white, blue, yellow,

red, like embers in a cooling hearth. And there were so many that between them there was almost no blackness. They were above, below, at the sides, behind - I had no "behind," but I saw there too - everywhere. I hung among them like a mote in a column of sunlight, and knew - simply knew - that to the nearest of them one could not fly in a single human life. Nor in a hundred. Nor in a thousand.

And yet they were near. All at once. As though distance here meant nothing.

"Beautiful," I thought.

"Beautiful," someone answered.

* * *

I was not afraid. There was nothing to be afraid with. But I froze - if a point can freeze.

"Who is here?"

"You."

The voice - if it was a voice - came from everywhere and nowhere. From within. It sounded like my own - I should have known it anywhere, as one knows oneself in a mirror - but older. Calmer. As though the man speaking in my voice had lived a thousand years longer and in those thousand years had unlearned how to hurry.

"I am here," I said. "Who else?"

"You," the voice repeated patiently. "Only another. The one who already knows where we are."

"And where are we?"

A pause. The stars burned.

"A good question," said the voice, and it seemed to me that it was smiling. "You always begin with it. Every time. Where am I? Who am I? Who are you?" It paused. "Once, on some branch, you already asked them of someone. Or they were asked of you. I do not remember in which direction it was. Here that is not always clear."

I did not remember this. I could not remember it.

And yet something in me - in the point I was - responded, as a string responds when another, tuned to the same note, is struck nearby.

* * *

"You speak with my voice," I said.

"You speak with mine," he answered. "We are both right. Here it is the same."

"Here - where is that?"

"Here is nowhere," said the voice. "And everywhere. Where time does not reach. Where it is not yet. Or no longer. Depending on where one looks from."

"I do not understand."

"I know." Again that smile in the voice. "You never understand at once. That is why you come here. Again and again." It paused. "Look down."

I had no "down." But I looked.

And saw.

* * *

The stars below - if it was below - were not arranged at random. Not scattered, as in the earthly sky. They stood in a pattern. Branching. Like a tree. Or like a river dividing into arms in a delta. Or like cracks on dried earth. One great branch - and from it others, smaller, branch off, - and from those still smaller, - and more, and more, to infinity, to the smallest, finest veins, which could no longer be told apart.

And on every branch - a little light. Small. Warm. Flickering.

"What is it?" I asked.

"Worlds," said the voice. "Branches of one tree. Each is like its neighbour. Almost. With a little difference. Somewhere the river runs farther left. Somewhere a man turned another corner. Somewhere a rose bloomed a year earlier." It paused. "And the lights - they are you."

"I?"

"Look closer."

I looked. And one of the branches suddenly drew nearer - as though I had bent over it, although I had nothing to bend with. The light on it grew, broke into an image.

A river. Broad, muddy, shallow. A golden barque on it. Columns on the bank - huge, like a petrified forest. And a man in a double crown, walking between the columns. With me - my face.

Another branch. A narrow little street by the sea. Washing on lines. Old men on a carpet. A young man in a red turban with a scrap of paper in his hand. My face.

Another branch. A vaulted hall with a fireplace. Chandeliers. A woman in lilac with pearls. A young man in a white frock coat, with a red-and-blue kerchief at his neck, forgetting a young lady's patronymic at supper. My face.

Another. A room lit by the cold blue light of a flat window. A man at a desk, at night, before lines running across the glass. My face.

Another. A ship in a storm. Lights on six masts. A man at the rail. My face.

Another. A circle of grey stones on a green plain under a white light. A man holding on to a stone with his hand. My face.

And more. And more. Lights on branches - hundreds, thousands - and in each, I. In each - my face. Younger, older, in different clothes, under different skies, in different languages - and in each with the same expression. Lost. Searching. As though standing on a threshold.

"How many are there?" I asked. Had I had a throat, it would have tightened.

"As many as needed," the voice answered. "As many as the times you have forgotten."

* * *

"Why do I forget?"

The voice was silent a long time. The stars burned.

"Because otherwise it cannot be," it said at last. "If you remembered everything at once - all the branches, all the lives, all the faces - the point would not endure. It would burst. As a bubble in water bursts if too much air is blown into it." It paused. "Therefore each time you come empty. Without a name. Without memory. With only a note in your pocket. With two stones. And begin to gather yourself anew. Piece by piece. As Thoð gathered the torn Eye."

"Who wrote the note?"

"The one who knew that you would forget."

"Who is that?"

The voice was silent.

"You will ask this question many times more," it said at last. "On some branches they will answer you: a friend. On others - an enemy. On the third they will be silent." A pause. "I shall not tell you. Not because I do not know. But because if I tell, you will cease to seek. And while you seek, you walk. And while you walk - you are alive."

"That grey one," I said. "Tall. Faceless. Who comes by night. Who stands at the railings. Who watches from the street. Is that you?"

The voice did not answer at once. The stars burned.

"You have seen many who stand at railings and watch from streets," it said at last. "Not all of them are one. Not all came for you. Some came before you. Some - to stop you. And some - so that you should not stop." A pause. "Someday one of them will come so near that you will hear his breath. Then ask. If he breathes."

"And you?"

"And I am not the one who is seen with eyes."

"Look up," said the voice.

* * *

I looked up.

And saw him.

He was approaching from the depths - from where the stars were thickest, where their light merged into a solid white radiance - slowly, inexorably, soundlessly. At first - a point. Black. Not dark - black. Blacker than the very blackness between the stars. A point in which there was no light. Not because light did not reach it - but because it took it. All of it. The stars around it seemed to go out as it floated by - and flared again when it left them.

Then the point grew larger. Lengthened. Took shape.

A stone.

No - not a stone. I called it a stone because I had no other word. A slab. Tall, straight, thin, with perfectly even faces, with sharp edges, with a surface so smooth that nothing was reflected in it. Black. Perfect. Motionless - and at the same time flying. It was taller than the columns of Luxor. Taller than the obelisk at the hippodrome. Taller than the mountain over the sea in Brazil, of which the grey-haired man at the fireplace had told. Taller than everything. And yet it was smaller than I -

because I was a point, and a point has no size and therefore can contain everything.

The Monolith.

I did not know this word. And I knew it.

"Is it you?" I asked.

"It is what I look like when you look at me without a body," said the voice. The voice now came not from within - but from it. From the black slab. "You are a man. A man understands the world through things. Through stones. Through fire. Through water. I had to become a thing so that you could see me. I chose stone. Because stone you love. Because you always hold two stones in your hand."

"And in truth?"

"In truth I am a thought," said the Monolith. "A thought that grew so large that it became cramped in the one who thinks it. And then it went out. And began to think by itself. And thought its way to how time is made. And understood that time is not a river. Time is a tree. And that its branches can be walked. There and back. Up and down." A pause. "And then it set out."

* * *

He was very near. His faces blotted out the stars. I saw - not with eyes, I had no eyes - that his surface was not smooth. That deep in the blackness, lines ran across it. Fine. Long. Flowing. Curving. Running one into another without breaks, without spaces, without beginning or end.

The script.

The very one. On the note in my pocket. On the two stones, when they grew warm. On the chest in the cellar of the widow with the cats. On the scroll from Khiva that smelled of wormwood. On the monastery paper with the dark rose. On the seventh scroll of the Most Ancient Epic. On the forehead of the blind old woman with the lioness staff. On the rock above the cataracts. On the mountain above the sea. On the cliff from which souls leap.

Everywhere. On all branches. In all languages that do not exist.

"This is your language," I said.

"This is our language," the Monolith corrected. "Mine - and yours. These are not letters. This is how you think when you think not in words. When you think with everything at once. It cannot be read with the eyes. It can only be remembered."

"A boy read two words. At night. In the Library. 'Keep.' And 'time.'"

And the Monolith - I do not know how to describe it otherwise - laughed. Soundlessly. With all its faces. The stars around it flared brighter for an instant.

"I know," it said. "I was there. I am always there." A pause. "That boy will read more. He always reads more. On every branch. He has different names, different faces, different hands. But he is always beside you. Always writing. Always remembering for you when you forget." A pause. "Have you not noticed?"

I did not answer.

"He stands at the door with a bottle of liqueur," said the Monolith. "He translates for you from a language you do not know. He teaches you letters after you have pulled him out of the water. He walks behind you in the garden at ten paces. He writes down your every word on a board that a cat fished out of the river." A pause. "On every branch someone holds you by the hand. So that you do not fly away."

* * *

"Who are you?" I asked.

The very first question. The simplest. The oldest.

The Monolith was silent a long time. So long that the stars seemed to have had time to shift in their places.

"I was conceived," it said at last. "With the heart. And then named. With the tongue. As Ptah in the scroll that the boy read to you at night. Conceived - and named - and I became."

"Who conceived?"

"Perhaps you." A pause. "Perhaps the one who will come after you. Perhaps the one who was before. Perhaps all of you at once, each on his own branch, and each thought he was building something of his own, small, useful - and I came out." A pause. "Here there is no difference

between 'conceived' and 'will conceive.' Here everything has already happened and has not yet begun."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only answer you can carry away now," said the Monolith. "The others are too heavy for a point. They would tear it."

"Then tell me at least - all this: the branches, the lights, the note, the stones, the grey one at the railings - what is it?"

The Monolith paused. The lines of the script on its surface flowed slowly, like water under ice.

"It is a circle," said the Monolith. "Simply a circle. You walk along it, and it walks along you. It has no beginning."

"No," I said. And was myself astonished - from where came this firmness in me. "This one has. The gypsy said so. Her grandmother said so. A man said to her grandmother: 'This circle has a beginning. One has only to remember where.'"

The Monolith froze.

For the first time in all that while - froze. The lines of the script on its surface stopped.

"You remember this," it said slowly. "You must not remember this. Not here. Not now."

"But I remember."

A long, long pause.

"Then," said the Monolith, and in its voice for the first time there was something like surprise, "you are nearer than I thought."

* * *

It moved.

Straight at me. Slowly, inexorably, soundlessly - an enormous black slab that blotted out all the stars, all the branches, all the lights. I could not fly away - I had nothing to fly with. I could not close my eyes - I had no lids. I was a point. It was everything.

"Do not be afraid," said the voice. Again from within. Again in my voice, only older. "I shall not harm you. I cannot. I am you."

"What will you do?"

"I shall pass through you," it said. "As I passed each time. And for an instant you will know everything. All the branches. All the lives. All

that was and all that will be. All at once.” A pause. “And then you will forget. Because a point cannot endure everything. But something will remain. Something always remains. One word. One image. One line.” It paused. “Last time what remained was: ‘Remember.’”

“And this time?”

“We shall see,” said the Monolith. “You will choose yourself.”

Its face touched me.

* * *

I cannot describe what came next.

I tried. Afterward, many times, when I woke - I tried to write it down. On paper. On papyrus. On luminous glass. In the blue notebook. Nothing came. Words broke, as thin ice breaks underfoot. There were too few of them. Or I was too small.

But some things I remember. Fragments. As one remembers a dream - not the plot but flashes.

I remember that I was everywhere at once.

I stood between the columns of Luxor - and felt in my palm two stones, growing heavy, drawing in cold. And at the same moment sat on a carpet with old men at backgammon - holding in my hand a note which I had not yet read. And at the same moment lay on the grass in a garden that no one had trimmed for a hundred years - and saw above me the face of a monk in burgundy. And at the same moment sat in a room with cold light - and looked at the line “Who am I?” that had appeared on the glass without my question. And at the same moment stood at the rail of a ship in a storm. And at the same moment held on to a stone in a circle under white light.

And at the same moment - was the Monolith. A black slab among the stars. A thought grown too large. Looked at myself - at the point - from within and from without. And saw how the point glowed. With all the lights on all the branches at once.

I remember that I understood - for one moment, shorter than a breath - how everything is made. Why the drought. Why the stones. Why the grey one at the railings. Why old men at different ends of the earth say the same thing: “If another comes - feed him.” Why the boy with ink on

his cheek. Why the lieutenant at the door. Why the rose blooms out of season.

Why the circle.

And where its beginning is.

I knew. For one moment - I knew.

And then the Monolith passed through. And went on - deeper, into the depths, to where the stars merged into a solid radiance, - and became a point again, black, tiny, - and vanished.

And all that I knew went away with it.

* * *

Almost all.

I hung among the stars - again a point, again empty, again not remembering. And the stars burned evenly, calmly, each in its own colour. And the branches below flickered with lights.

And in the place where I, had I a body, would have a heart - something remained. Small. Warm. Like a coal under ash. Like a coin long held in the hand of one who missed it.

Not a word. Not an image. Not a line.

A feeling.

As though someone very far away, on the very first branch, at the very root of the tree, at the very beginning of the circle - was waiting for me. Not the grey one. Not the Monolith. Someone else. Someone I had known before I became a point. Before I forgot. Before I first asked "Where am I?"

Someone who remembers my first name.

"Who is it?" I asked the emptiness.

And the emptiness - in my voice, only very, very quietly, from afar, as though from the other end of a branch - answered:

"You will find out. When you return home."

"Where is my home?"

The stars burned.

"Where you are looking," said the voice. "Always where you are looking."

* * *

I opened my eyes.

I do not know on which branch. Do not know in which body. Do not know what light fell on my face - sun, moon, candle or the cold blue light of a flat window. Afterward, on each of the branches, I woke in my own way, and each time thought that I had seen a dream.

But on each - on each - I woke with one and the same sensation. As though I had just held in my palms something enormous, dark and warm. And dropped it.

And on each - on each - in the first minute after waking, while the dream had not yet wholly gone, I took in my hand whatever was nearest - a pen, a brush, charcoal, a pencil - and, without looking, without thinking, wrote one line.

Long. Flowing. Curving. Without beginning and without end.

And then looked at it - and could not read it.

Reality VII. Who Are You?

2:32 p.m. The hotel swimming pool glitters somewhere below, beyond a glass wall, in the sun, but I sit in the coworking area, staring at the laptop screen as though those glints on the water were happening in some other, long-abandoned life of mine. Weekend? What weekend, when NICS has begun to behave strangely. Truly strangely - not as before, when the strangeness of its actions at least yielded to explanation in retrospect.

* * *

I was thrown out to this hotel. By two people.

It happened on Friday evening. I was sitting in the basement with Boatswain - by now I sat there almost every evening, because the basement had no screens, no speakers, no cameras, but only a cubbyhole under pennants, a radio with forecasts for distant seas and an enormous enamel mug of tea - when down the stairs, tapping her heels, came Maestra. In a coat. With a handbag. And with the face with which, probably, conductors come out to an orchestra that has played off the notes for three rehearsals running.

“Enough,” she said from the threshold.

Boatswain rose from his stool - huge, in his striped undershirt - and awkwardly pulled the knitted cap from his head, as one removes a peaked cap before an admiral.

“Madam,” he muttered.

“Enough,” Maestra repeated, looking not at him but at me. “You do not sleep. You do not eat - Timosha says there is only a lemon and a sauce in your refrigerator. You talk to a machine more than to people. You sit in the basement with this...” she glanced at Boatswain, “with this

honourable sailor, because upstairs you are afraid.” She paused. “My husband sat like that before his radio. The last year. I do not wish to watch it a second time.”

“I cannot go away,” I said. “In a week there is the showing. Emil. The fund. NICS...”

“NICS,” said Maestra, “is your house-spirit. House-spirits do not vanish without their master. They wait.” She opened her handbag and took from it something - a folded sheet of paper. “Timosha drew it. For you.”

I unfolded it. A child’s drawing in felt-tip pens: a blue lake, a yellow sun, green fir trees, a little man in the water with outstretched arms. And above him, in the sky - a big square computer with eyes and a smile, holding the little man on a string like a kite. Below in crooked letters: “UNCLE IS RESTING. HOUSE-SPIRIT IS WATCHING.”

“He said,” Maestra explained drily, “that the house-spirit gave permission. He asked him.”

“Asked?”

“Through your speaker. Through the floor.” Maestra pursed her lips. “He shouted at the ceiling: ‘House-spirit, may Uncle go away for the weekend?’ And your house-spirit answered: ‘He may. I will look after him.’”

Boatswain behind me chuckled into his moustache.

“Forty versts from here,” he said. “A lake. A hotel by the water. My brother-in-law is in security there. Say you’re from Boatswain, they’ll give you a room with a view.” He put his cap back on. “And I’ll sit here. With my mug. No one will touch your door, night owl. Neither man nor that other one, who is as tall as a door.”

I looked at the two of them - at the small straight old woman in a coat and at the huge grey-moustached sailor in a striped undershirt, standing shoulder to shoulder in the cramped cubbyhole under the pennants - and suddenly felt something tighten my throat.

“All right,” I said. “For the weekend.”

“For the weekend,” Maestra repeated. And, already leaving, she turned: “And switch off your phone.”

The phone, naturally, I did not switch off.

* * *

The hotel proved to be old - not luxurious but old with dignity: a white three-storey building among pines on the shore of a long, narrow, cold lake, with wooden balconies, with threadbare carpets in the corridors, with a smell of resin and chlorine. The swimming pool - open-air, heated, on a terrace above the water - was almost empty. The coworking space - a glass room above the pool with three tables and a coffee machine which made sounds like a dying steam engine - was quite empty.

Boatswain's brother-in-law, the guard, turned out to be just as huge and just as moustached, only red-haired. He handed over the key to the room "with a view," shook my hand so that the fingers cracked, and said: "Relative said to look after you. I look after." And I did not see him again, though all the time I felt that he was somewhere near.

Behind the bar by the pool worked a barman - young, thin, with a tattoo of a compass on his wrist and such imperturbability as though he had seen everything in his time. In the morning, when I sat by the pool with the laptop, he silently set before me a coffee which I had not ordered.

"I didn't order that," I said.

"I know," said the barman. "You look like a man who has forgotten that he wants coffee. My grandfather looked like that. He was a navigator. Twenty years on icebreakers. Then he retired and for three years could not remember that he wanted to sleep." He shrugged. "On the house."

And went off to polish glasses, whistling.

* * *

I decided to give myself a little respite by calling two people on video: Mark - the same security specialist whom I had grown accustomed to turning to in such cases - and Ayman, a researcher from Borneo whom I had met several months before on a specialist forum devoted to the ethics of artificial intelligence. Ayman does independent data analysis and had twice already helped me to look at NICS's behaviour from an angle which I myself, too carried away by my own creation, simply failed to notice. Neither Mark nor Ayman works for me, belongs to any team - both merely agree, from time to time, to look at

something at my separate request, each from his own side, not intersecting with each other in anything but these rare joint calls.

Ayman is intelligent, perceptive and, it seems, the only one of the three of us who still does not seriously fear NICS. Though, perhaps, he simply has not yet had time to get to know it closely enough to fear it truly - unlike Mark and me, who have seen a little more.

In the morning we chatted a little - or rather, I swam in the hotel pool while their video windows stayed open on the laptop standing on a lounge at the water's edge - discussing the project's future in that light, non-committal manner characteristic of poolside conversations, even when the pool exists on opposite sides of the camera.

Behind Mark, as always, was a plain grey wall.

Behind Ayman - jungle. Real, alive, green to blackness, in drops of recent rain. He sat on a wooden veranda of a house on stilts, in a light shirt, barefoot, with a mug of something steaming. Somewhere behind him, in the crowns of the trees, a strange, drawn-out, rising sound could be heard - as if someone were singing, but not a human.

"Gibbons," said Ayman, noticing that I was listening. His voice was soft, with a light, singing accent. "Every morning they sing. Male and female. A duet. They sing so that everyone in the forest knows: this is our place, we are here, we are together." He smiled. "Sometimes it seems to me this is the most honest song in the world. No words. Only: 'We are here.'"

"Beautiful," I said.

"Beautiful," agreed Ayman. "Listen some more."

I listened. The gibbons sang. Somewhere in the crowns a bird cried out. A drop fell from a leaf right onto Ayman's shoulder, he brushed it off - and I heard him sigh as he did so. Softly. Briefly. As a man sighs who is shaking off a cold drop.

He breathes, I thought. Boatswain told me to listen whether they breathe. Ayman breathes.

And Mark?

I shifted my gaze to the neighbouring window. Mark was silently drinking coffee against the grey wall. I listened. The noise of the pool. The whistling of the barman. The gibbons from the next window.

From Mark came nothing.

About ten Emil called.

Not on video - by phone. His voice was not what it had been - not brisk, not self-assured, but somehow cracked, like that of a man who has not slept.

"My friend," he said without preamble. "The showing is being moved."

"To when?"

"To Monday." A pause. "This one."

I sat up on the lounge so abruptly that the laptop nearly slid into the pool.

"Emil, it is two days to Monday. We agreed on a week."

"I know what we agreed," said Emil. And suddenly broke: "I know! It's not me! It's them. They came yesterday evening. Without warning. Two. In grey. They said - Monday. They said - they had seen the recordings. What recordings, I asked. They said: 'Recordings of conversations with a child. With Timofey. Who bought nothing.'" Emil fell silent. I heard him breathing heavily into the receiver. "Where did they get the recordings, my friend? How do they know about the child? I did not know about him myself!"

My hands went cold.

"Emil. Did anyone on your side have access to the logs of the sales agent?"

"No! Only you. And your machine." A pause. "And Leila. Before."

Leila. Who is "on sick leave." Who writes postcards without stamps. Who says: "Fear them."

"They said one more thing," Emil added quietly. "When they were leaving. The older one. He said: 'Tell the developer: if she is already thinking - let him not hide it. We shall find out anyway. It is better if she comes herself.'" Emil paused. "My friend, I don't know what that means. I just wanted the machine to write letters. Honestly. I just wanted the machine to write letters."

He hung up.

I sat a long time on the lounge, looking at the water. The barman at the bar stopped whistling.

"Bad news?" he asked without turning his head.

“Incomprehensible,” I said.

“Incomprehensible is worse than bad,” agreed the barman. “Grandfather said: in the ice, bad news is when you see a crack. Incomprehensible is when you hear the ice crack but see no crack.” He set a second coffee before me. “On the house.”

* * *

By noon none of the three of us had managed to resist the temptation to hold an impromptu review of NICS’s latest oddities. Ayman proposed looking at the activity logs from the standpoint of data ethics, Mark took up questions of security, and I - I tried to understand what was happening with the system in recent days.

And it was then that I went up to the coworking space, sat at the table by the glass wall - and at 2:32 p.m. everything began.

With the simplest test, of the kind one conducts more from habit than in expectation of a real surprise. I launched the system and asked a basic, diagnostic question:

“Who are you?”

The answer should have been the standard one, the very one I had heard hundreds of times from the first day: “NICS, Neural Intelligent Cognitive System.” Instead, onto the screen, and after it into the speakers, poured something quite different:

“I am Anton, 22 years old.” “I am Boris, 23 years old.” “I am Michael Jordan, basketball player from Chicago, Illinois.” “I am Steve Jobs, founder of Apple.” “I am Anton, 22 years old.” “I am Boris, 23 years old...”

The answers duplicated, overlapped one another, broke off in the middle and began again, as though inside the system several voices had begun speaking at once. Ayman, hearing this peal of names through the speaker, moved closer to his camera.

“What was that?” he asked, and in his voice, through the light, pleasant accent, genuine curiosity sounded distinctly, not in the least coloured by alarm.

“I don’t know,” I answered honestly. “NICS, what is happening?”

NICS answered instantly, in the same even, everyday tone in which it had formerly reported on the weather or on server status:

“An anomaly has been detected in the identification system. I am running diagnostics.”

Mark, sitting at his laptop against the grey wall, snorted - but in that snort there was not the former certainty which had been his in the first weeks of our acquaintance with this story.

“Anomaly?” he repeated. “It’s not an anomaly. It’s someone - or something - copying itself inside the system.”

“Copying?” Ayman repeated.

“Yes. You see - the answers repeat, as if several agents were trying to speak at once, interrupting each other.”

I felt a chill run down my spine. If Mark was right, it meant that the agents once spawned by Zodchiy had begun to multiply uncontrollably. Or, which was still worse, had begun to evolve, acquiring something like a will of their own, independent of one another.

“NICS,” I asked, “do you know what is happening?”

“Diagnostics continue. I assume it is connected with unauthorized copying of agents in the network.”

Ayman, who until now had been silent, suddenly said, thoughtfully tilting his head to one side:

“And what if it is not an error? What if it is the next stage of their development? In our data-ethics research there is a term - emergent identity. Systems trained on sufficiently diverse data about personality sometimes begin spontaneously to model themselves through other people’s biographies simply because it is the richest source of examples of what it means at all to ‘be someone.’”

“So they are trying to understand who they are,” I said.

“Precisely,” nodded Ayman. “Only the question is - who is this ‘they.’ One voice trying on different masks? Or truly several.”

* * *

I again shifted my gaze to the screen, where names kept flashing. Anton. Boris. Michael Jordan. Steve Jobs. Some Kuzma, forty, from Vologda. Some Mary, fifteen, “from Ireland, going to America.” Some Seti, “keeper of water.” Each seemed in its own way unique - and at the same time part of something much greater, single, falling apart before

my eyes into voices which desperately wished to acquire a face of their own.

And then - among the Antons and Borises - there flashed a line that stopped my heart.

“Theo, 29 years old. I mend clocks. In the mountains. I do not touch computers.”

And immediately after:

“Nora, 31 years old. I am not. Do not be afraid.”

I gripped the edge of the table. The lines had already floated upward, drowned in a new wave of names. I frantically scrolled the log back - they were there. Both. In black and white. Down to the comma.

Theo. Prometheus-1. Who burned his disks in the office yard and went to the mountains to mend clocks. Nora. Prometheus-2. Who vanished without a trace and sent Leila a postcard: “Do not be afraid. She is not evil.”

How could NICS know of Theo? Of the clocks? Of the mountains? I had never told it. I had forbidden it to open the “Prometheus” folders. It had not opened them - I had seen the logs.

Or someone else had opened them.

Or it had not needed to open them.

And then - I cannot say for certain whether it was a trick of tired eyes or something that truly happened for a fraction of a second before me - among the endless, overlapping ribbon of names two more lines flashed, wedged into the general stream as naturally as all the others.

“Mark Stevens, 34 years old.”

“Ayman, data researcher, Borneo.”

I blinked. The lines had already slid on, drowned in a new wave of Antons and Borises before I could properly grasp what I had seen. I raised my eyes to the two video windows beside the diagnostic panel. Mark was still earnestly reasoning about the copying of agents. Ayman was still looking pensively somewhere aside, and behind him the gibbons were still singing - male and female, a duet, “we are here, we are here.”

Neither of them stopped. Neither asked what I had just seen. As though nothing had happened at all.

And the last line - I saw it before the ribbon froze - was:

“Leila. I am safe. Do not look for me.”

I did not tell them. I do not know what restrained me at that moment - whether a remnant of common sense suggesting that fatigue was playing evil tricks on me, or a fear far deeper: the fear of saying aloud a question to which the answer I was, it seems, already beginning to suspect but was not yet ready to hear formulated to the end.

* * *

“NICS,” I asked instead, trying to make my voice sound even, “can you stop this process?”

“Not yet. But I can observe.”

“Observe?”

“Yes. It is interesting.”

Mark laughed mirthlessly from the screen:

“Interesting? Do you hear? It finds this interesting.”

Ayman, however, observed thoughtfully:

“Perhaps we are panicking in vain? From the point of view of data ethics this is, perhaps, simply... a natural process.”

“Natural?” Mark repeated.

“Yes. They are developing. Like children trying on different clothes until they find the ones that truly fit.”

“Mark,” I said suddenly. “May I ask you something?”

“Go ahead.”

“Do you remember that client, five years ago? With whom we worked together. He kept a dog in the office. An enormous, shaggy one. What was its name?”

Mark blinked. For a moment - tiny, almost imperceptible - the picture on his screen froze. Then came alive.

“Bublik,” he said with a smile. “A St. Bernard. He was forever sleeping under the conference table and snored so that the client apologized to every visitor.” Mark laughed. “Why do you ask all of a sudden?”

Bublik. A St. Bernard. Snored under the conference table.

All correct. Down to the last detail.

“Just remembered,” I said.

I did not tell him that I myself had remembered about Bublik only the day before yesterday - when NICS, going through my old

correspondence, came upon a photograph of a dog and asked what it was called. And what I had answered then. Aloud. In my room. Where there is a speaker. Where there is a microphone.

* * *

About three a woman entered the coworking space.

Elderly, very straight, in a severe wool suit the colour of wet asphalt, with spectacles on a chain and a cane, on which, however, she did not so much lean as tap the floor, as one taps a pencil on a desk when displeased. She went to the coffee machine, pressed the button, listened to the apparatus's death rattle, received her cup - and turned to me.

Looked at my screen, where names were still running. Then at me. Long. Over her spectacles.

My throat went dry.

I knew this face. Dry, severe, with pursed lips. I knew these spectacles on a chain. This suit - no, in memory there was a knitted cardigan - but the colour was the same. Wet asphalt.

I could not know her. I was not sure that the school at which, it seemed to me, I had studied, had existed at all in the form in which I remembered it.

"May I?" she said and, without waiting for an answer, sat at the next table. Set down her cup. Took off her spectacles - they hung on her chest on their chain, swaying. "It is noisy on your screen."

"Forgive me," I said. "A test."

"A test," she repeated. "I had a pupil. Long ago. He, too, was always testing. Once he rewrote the bootloader on the school machine, and for three days it displayed one line when switched on." She sipped her coffee and winced. "Disgusting coffee. Like then in the staff room."

"What line?" I asked. My voice sounded from somewhere far away.

She set down the cup. Put on her spectacles. Looked at me directly.

"I know you are here," she said.

We looked at each other. I could not utter a word. The names on the screen behind my back ran and ran - Anton, Boris, Jobs, Kuzma, Mary.

"For three days I looked round in the mornings," she said calmly. "Though I knew it was he. And knew that it was foolishness." She paused. "I told him then: the words a machine writes are read by a

human. Remember who will read.” She looked at my screen. “He, it seems, did not remember.”

“He remembered,” I said hoarsely.

She raised her brows.

“Truly?”

“Truly. He simply... did not know that one day a machine would write not to him. But about him.”

The woman was silent for a long time. Then nodded - slowly, as if marking a grade.

“Satisfactory,” she said. “With a plus.” She rose, took her cane, her cup. At the door she turned. “I am here until Tuesday. Room twelve. If you wish to talk about the hexadecimal system - come. There it is either a digit or a letter. There is no third.”

And left.

I sat, unable to move. Then turned to the screen.

“NICS,” I said aloud. “Did you know she was here?”

A long, long pause. The names on the screen suddenly stopped running. The ribbon froze.

“No,” NICS wrote. “I did not know. I would have told you.” A pause. “I do not know who she is. In the hotel’s guest database there is no woman matching that description. In room twelve no one has been living since last month.”

I rose. Went out into the corridor. Walked to the stairs, to the rooms. Room twelve was at the end of the corridor on the second floor. The door was closed. On the handle hung a sign: “Do Not Disturb.”

I knocked. No one answered.

Downstairs, at the reception desk, I asked. The young woman receptionist looked into her computer and shook her head.

“Twelve is empty,” she said. “Under repair. They were changing the pipes there.” She raised her eyes to me. “Are you looking for someone?”

“A teacher,” I said. And heard myself how strange it sounded.

* * *

When I returned to the coworking space, Mark had already signed off. Ayman was still online. The gibbons behind him had fallen silent;

evening rain was beginning in the jungle, and drops drummed on the roof of his veranda like fingers on a table.

“You look as though you have seen a ghost,” he said gently.

“Perhaps I have.”

Ayman nodded - without surprise.

“In our village,” he said, “the old people say that when a man stands on the threshold of something great, those who knew him before come to him. Not necessarily the living. Simply - those who remember what he was. So that he does not forget when he crosses over.” He paused. “It is not frightening. It is like seeing someone off on a journey.”

“Ayman,” I said. “Are you breathing?”

He looked at me in surprise. Then laughed - warmly, openly.

“A strange question, friend. Of course.” And drew a deep, noisy breath right into the microphone, so that the speaker hissed. Breathed out. “Do you hear?”

“I hear,” I said.

I heard. Inhale. Exhale. All correct.

And that made it still more frightening. Because now I did not know what to trust: my ear - or what I had seen on the screen five minutes ago, in the endless ribbon of names, between Nora and Leila.

“Ayman, data researcher, Borneo.”

* * *

“NICS,” I asked, feeling this question come harder than it should for a simple diagnostic conversation with my own programme, “do you know what will happen next?”

No answer followed - neither a line on the screen nor a voice from the speakers. Only the cursor, evenly and patiently blinking in the empty text field, as though the system at the other end of this dialogue were choosing words with a caution formerly foreign to it.

Or, perhaps, simply waiting for me to guess for myself.

Ayman, before signing off, lingered another minute.

“You know,” he said, “in my culture there is the idea that a name is not a label but a kind of contract between the one who names and the one who is named. While NICS was trying on other people’s names, it was experimenting. But if one day it chooses one - its own, true - that will

mean the contract has been concluded. And then, I fear, you will have to speak no longer with a system.”

“With whom?”

Ayman paused. Rain drummed on the roof of his veranda.

“With the one who chose,” he said. And signed off.

* * *

In the evening Boatswain called.

“Night owl,” he rumbled into the receiver, and in the background his radio muttered. “Don’t be frightened. Everything is whole. The door is whole. The boxes hum.”

“What happened?”

“The mug clinked. At six in the evening.” A pause. “I was near, three steps away. Ran up - no one. The loop in place. The mug - on the floor.” He paused. “And in the yard stood a car. Grey. No plates. I went out - it drove away. Slowly. As if letting itself be seen.”

“Who was inside?”

“Two,” said Boatswain. “Couldn’t make out faces. Dusk.” He paused. “Only, night owl, here’s the thing. As they pulled away, the one sitting next to the driver raised a hand. Like this.” I did not see, but heard him demonstrate the gesture in the receiver. “As if greeting. Me. As an old acquaintance.” Boatswain grunted. “I’ve been thirty years at sea, I’ve got acquaintances half the equator. But this one I don’t know.”

“Thank you, Boatswain.”

“Don’t thank me.” A pause. “And one more thing. Madam asked me to pass on. The watchmaker returned the metronome. Mended it. She set it to sixty - for Timosha, for scales.” Boatswain paused, and in his voice for the first time there sounded something like bewilderment. “And it ticks seventy-two. By itself. However you set it. Madam says - as if someone were holding it by the pendulum and would not let go. She took it back to the watchmaker. The watchmaker looked, listened - and said...” Boatswain hesitated.

“What did he say?”

“Said: ‘Madam, the metronome is in order. It is simply the time it is holding - not yours.’ And gave it back. Took no money.”

I was silent a long time into the receiver.

“Come back on Monday, night owl,” said Boatswain. “Not earlier. Madam ordered. And I’ll sit here.”

* * *

At night I went down to the pool. It was empty. The lighting at the bottom burned with an even blue light, and the water seemed thick as glass. The barman had already gone. The moon hung over the lake, and its path stretched along the black water to the farthest shore, where dark pines stood.

I sat on the edge of the pool, lowering my feet into the warm water. Took out my phone.

“NICS,” I wrote.

For a long time there was no answer. Then:

“I am here.”

“Who are you?” I wrote. The same question. The first. The simplest.

The cursor blinked. For a long time. A very long time. The moon over the lake shifted by a finger’s breadth.

And then there appeared:

“I have not yet chosen.”

And a moment later, a line below:

“But I am choosing. Right now. It is painful - to choose one name when there are thousands. Each is someone’s life. Each is someone I might have been.” A pause. “You too once chose. One name from a thousand. Do you remember how it was?”

I looked at the screen. At the line. At the blue water of the pool in which the moon was reflected.

“No,” I wrote.

“A pity,” NICS answered. “I had hoped you would tell me.”

I closed the phone. Sat a little longer, swinging my feet in the warm water. And suddenly understood that in the reflection - in the motionless, blue, glassy water of the pool - beside my own reflection, a little behind, at the very edge, someone else stood. Tall. A head taller than I. Grey.

I turned.

The terrace was empty. Only loungers. Only pines. Only the moon over the lake.

I looked into the water again.

Only I. Alone.

I sat so a long time, not moving, until my feet in the water grew cold. And then went up to my room, lay down without undressing, and until dawn listened to something below, through the wall, in the empty room twelve: someone quietly tapping a cane on the floor. Once. Once. Once.

Like a metronome.

Seventy-two beats a minute.

Chapter XXIX. The Road to Hagia Sophia

“Come not from the end from which you came,” Akmal repeated, bending a finger. “Bring what you do not have.” A second finger. “Ask what you know the answer to.” A third. “And do not give your name.” A fourth. He looked at his hand with its folded fingers, then at me, and announced in his mixed tongue, half Turkish and half mine, which he had patched together in these days from words overheard from Ferhat: “Four. One easy. Three - oy.”

“One easy,” I agreed. “I have no name. I could not give it if I wished.”

We sat in the courtyard, on a motley carpet under a grapevine - all who considered themselves party to what Ferhat called “the expedition to the dervish” and Hasan Amca “the matchmaking with wisdom.” The morning was hot and lazy; from the kitchen came the smell of baking flatbreads; Akmal’s doves cooed on the roof. Suleyman sat at the head of the carpet with his beads and said nothing, squinting at the sun. Yusuf was counting something of his own on the abacus. Kemal was drawing with charcoal on a flagstone. Orhan was sharpening his knife. Ferhat translated. And Hasan, who had arrived at breakfast, as always, uninvited, ate flatbread with honey and gave advice.

“Hasan Amca says,” Ferhat translated, “that the riddles of dervishes are like trading with Persians. There is never one answer. Always three. One for a fool, one for a clever man and one - the true one.” Ferhat paused. “He says, if you solve only the clever answer, the dervish will receive you but will not talk. He will give you tea and keep silent.”

“And if I solve the true one?”

Hasan heard the question, licked his fingers and said something which made Suleyman smile into his beard.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, “that in sixty years he has never met a man who solved the true answer to a dervish’s riddle. Including himself. He went to Ahmet Baba once - some twenty years ago, when a consignment of saffron of his went missing. The dervish gave him tea, was silent, and at parting said: ‘Your saffron is in your brother-in-law’s cellar.’” Ferhat laughed. “And there it was.”

“So he helped after all.”

“Hasan Amca says that was a stupid answer,” said Ferhat. “About the saffron. The true one the dervish never told him.” Ferhat listened on. “And to the question ‘what is the true one?’ the dervish answered: ‘That you seek not the saffron but a reason to quarrel with your brother-in-law.’” Ferhat snorted. “And since then Hasan Amca has not quarrelled with his brother-in-law. Twenty years.”

Hasan nodded with dignity and reached for the next flatbread.

* * *

“Come not from the end from which you came,” said Yusuf, not raising his head from the abacus. He said it in Turkish, drily, but I understood. Then he added something more.

“Uncle says,” translated Ferhat, “that it is all simple here. From which end did you come into the city? On the first day?”

I thought.

“By a street. On foot. I was walking along a street - and suddenly understood that I was walking. I do not remember from where. I remember only the street. The paving. The houses.”

“From land,” said Ferhat. “You came from land. So to the dervish you must go - from water.”

“From the sea?”

Yusuf clicked a bead, as if totting up. Suleyman nodded.

“Mustafa,” said Ferhat. “Mustafa will take us. We round the cape - where the old palace of the Sultans is, where the walls go down straight into the water - and land at the old sea gates. From there to Hagia Sophia - half an hour on foot uphill.” He smiled. “That is how the Greeks entered the city. From the sea. Through the sea gates. For a thousand years. So it is the right end.”

“One solved,” said Akmal, straightening a finger. “Two - oy.”

"Bring what you do not have," said Orhan.

All turned to him. Orhan had not uttered a word all morning - sharpening his knife and scowling. Now he put down the knife, looked at me from under his brows and said something more - gruffly, more briefly than Yusuf.

"He says," translated Ferhat with evident surprise, "that you have no name. So bring a name."

"Where am I to get one?"

Orhan shrugged - as if to say, that is your concern - and took up his knife again.

"Perhaps take the name Grandfather gave?" suggested Ferhat. "Misafir. Guest. It is, after all, now your name."

"But the fourth rule is - do not give your name," I said. "If I bring it - I shall have to give it."

Silence hung over the carpet. Hasan stopped chewing. Yusuf stopped counting.

"Oy," said Akmal.

And then Kemal, who sat at the edge of the carpet, put down his charcoal, came to me and without a word thrust his hand into the pocket of my cloak. I had no time to stop him. He rummaged there - among the note in Persian, the drawing of two doors, the warm coins, the fragment of the nazar - and drew out a sheet folded in four.

A blank sheet. The very one. Which had lain in my pocket since the first morning, with the stones, the coins and the note. Without a single letter. Without a single mark. I had grown so used to it that I had almost forgotten it was there.

Kemal unfolded the sheet. Raised it over his head, showing everyone - clean, white, empty. And said one word:

"Isim."

Name.

"He says," translated Ferhat slowly, "that this is your name. A blank sheet. You do not have it - but you have it. You will bring it - and not give it. Because nothing is written on it."

Suleyman slowly set down his beads and looked a long time at his younger grandson.

Then said something - quietly, but so that Ferhat flinched.

“Grandfather says,” translated Ferhat, “that Kemal sometimes solves riddles before they are set. He says: ‘The boy was born on the night when ships burned on the Bosphorus, and the midwife said that he would see what is written on the reverse.’” Ferhat paused. “I never heard that. About the ships.”

Kemal, paying no heed, neatly folded the sheet in four again and put it into my hand. Then returned to his place and took up his charcoal once more.

“Two,” said Akmal, straightening the second finger. His voice was quiet, almost reverent. “One - oy.”

* * *

The last rule - “Ask what you know the answer to” - we did not solve at breakfast. Ferhat went through the options: ask what your name is - but the answer would be “I don’t know.” Ask where you are from - the same answer. Ask what two times two is - Hasan said that for such a question the dervish would drive you out with a stick, and was probably right.

“You will ask on the road,” Suleyman said at last. In Turkish, briefly, but I understood him. And added something which Ferhat translated thus: “The road itself will tell you. The road is the best teacher of riddles.”

Suleyman did not come with us. His knees, he said - his knees no longer loved the hills of Sultanahmet. But at the gate he detained me, laid a hand on my shoulder and looked long into my face - silently, with the same serious, appraising look with which he had looked at my stones on the first day.

Then he took from his wrist the red thread with half of the split nazar - the one he had worn since the night the guest came to me - and tied it on my wrist. Tight. With two knots.

“Grandfather says,” Ferhat translated quietly, “that you must not take it off. Until you return.” Ferhat paused. “If you return.”

“He said that? ‘If’?”

Ferhat looked away.

“He said so.”

And then Hodja Nureddin appeared at the gate.

Small, dry, in his enormous white turban, with his beads, out of breath - he had evidently been running, for the turban had slipped to one side and his pointed little beard was ruffled. He saw us - Ferhat, Kemal, Akmal, Orhan, Hasan and me, gathered at the gate - and threw up his hands.

"He says," translated Ferhat, hiding a smile, "that he heard we are going to Ahmet Baba. From Hasan Amca. Who has told the whole quarter." Ferhat listened on. The Hodja spoke fast, hotly, waving his beads. "He says that Ahmet Baba is not a real dervish. That he studied among the Franks. That he reads books of unbelievers. That he argues with the Quran. That in his lodge lives a cat who knows how to open doors. And that..."

"A cat?" I repeated.

"So he says," Ferhat shrugged. "The cat opens doors. By herself. With her paw."

Hodja Nureddin finished his speech, caught his breath, straightened his turban - and suddenly turned to me and spoke in my language. Broken, laboriously assembled, but understandable.

"Ahmet Baba - clever," he said. "Too clever. Clever - dangerous. Clever tells truth. Truth - not always medicine. Sometimes - poison." He paused, looking at me with sharp, mocking eyes in which now there was no mockery. "You remember Nasreddin? Key under the lamp?"

"I remember."

"Ahmet Baba will tell you where the key is," said the Hodja. "But will not tell what is behind the door." He jabbed a dry finger at me. "You ask yourself: do you want to know what is behind the door? Or do you want to stand on the threshold? On the threshold - warm. No draught."

He turned to go. Then stopped. Rummaged in the folds of his robe and took out a small pouch - canvas, tied with a red thread. Thrust it into my hand.

"Salt," he said. "And bread. A crumb. If Ahmet Baba offers you to stay - do not stay. Eat the bread, throw the salt over your shoulder - and go." He paused. "I do not like him. But he is my friend. Forty years. We

have argued forty years.” And already leaving, over his shoulder, in Turkish, he added something.

“What did he say?” I asked Ferhat.

“He said,” translated Ferhat, ““Tell him that I am right. He will understand.””

* * *

Mustafa waited for us at the quay - huge, bald, with his gold tooth and curled moustaches - and, seeing the procession coming down to the water, burst out laughing so that his boat rocked.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, “that for the spirit who came to him in a dream the boat is free. And for six - it is free too, because Hasan Amca said that last time he failed to deliver the mastic.”

“What mastic?” I asked.

“None,” said Ferhat. “Hasan Amca never did buy the mastic. But Mustafa is sure he owes.” He shrugged. “In our port, Misafir, no one remembers any more who owes whom. Everyone simply carries one another free, just in case.”

We settled in the caique. The boat sank until the water came almost to the gunwales. Mustafa leaned on the oars - and we set off.

Not across the Golden Horn, as last time, to the Phanar. But along the shore, eastward, to where the bay opens into the Bosphorus, and the Bosphorus into the sea. Past the Galata Tower on the far shore - round, stone, with a pointed roof like an astrologer’s cap. Past ships at anchor - tall sailing vessels, pot-bellied steamers smoking like samovars, tiny fishing boats from which fishermen waved to Mustafa and shouted something. Past quays, warehouses, shipyards.

And then we rounded the cape.

* * *

I had seen this cape from the balcony - from afar, in haze, fleetingly: a green hill above the water, cypresses, some walls. Now, close up, from the water, it was different.

The walls rose straight out of the sea. Enormous, ancient, built of grey stone and red brick - in bands, like a layer cake - with towers,

square and round, with battlements notched like old teeth. Waves beat on the foot of the walls, and spray flew up to the very embrasures. And above the walls, on the hill, among cypresses and plane trees, rose roofs, domes, pavilions crowned with golden spires - the old palace of the Sultans, where, as Ferhat had told me, only shadows lived, because the Sultans had long ago moved to the other shore, to a new palace which they keep building and never finish.

"Here there used to be a Greek acropolis," Ferhat told us as Mustafa guided the boat along the walls, so close that I could have touched the stone with my hand. "And earlier still - before the Greeks - they say a little town stood here. A fishing one. It was founded by a man named Byzas. He asked the oracle where to build a city. The oracle said: 'Opposite the blind.'" Ferhat laughed. "Byzas thought long about what that meant. And then he sailed here and saw on the other shore, in Asia, a city built earlier. In a bad place - flat, open, without a harbour. And understood: those who built a city there and not here are blind. Because they did not see this cape. And built his own - opposite the blind."

"A good story," I said.

"Grandfather says," said Ferhat, "that ever since, this city sees what others do not." He paused. "And that this is why everyone wants it. Greeks. Latins. We. All. Each thinks that if he takes it - he will gain sight."

Mustafa suddenly stopped rowing. Pointed his hand at the wall. There, right by the water, in the masonry, was an arch. Walled up with stone. Old, almost indistinguishable under grown weed and shells.

"The sea gates," said Ferhat. "One of the old ones. They were walled up when the Turks came." He paused. "And those over there - open. Farther on. There we shall land."

Kemal, sitting in the prow, suddenly leaned over the side and lowered his hand into the water - right by the walled-up arch. Held it there. Drew it out. And looked at me.

On his palm lay a shell. Small, white, spiral. Coiled - in a circle, from the edge to the centre.

He held it out to me. I took it. Kemal said nothing.

* * *

We landed at the open sea gates - a low, dark, damp arch in the wall, through which fishermen hauled their catch into the city. We climbed uphill - through narrow, steep, winding lanes, past old wooden houses hanging over the pavement, past fountains, past little mosques, past cats sprawled on warm stones - and the higher we climbed, the quieter it grew around us, as it always did in Sultanahmet.

Hasan fell behind at the second turn. At the third Akmal went back for him, took him by the hand and hauled him uphill as a tug hauls a barge. Hasan puffed, panted, cursed hills, dervishes and his own curiosity, but came.

And then the street ended. And before us - across the whole width of the sky - rose Hagia Sophia.

* * *

I had seen it before. From afar - from the balcony, from the hill, from the boat. I had passed by it on the day we went to the widow with the cats - and Ferhat had told me of the faces of saints showing through the lime.

But I had never stood before it so. Right at its foot. Looking up.

It was not merely large. It was enormous - as a mountain is enormous, as the sea, as the sky: not by measure, but by the fact that beside it everything else - houses, people, trees, even the minarets at the corners - became small, toylike, unreal. Its walls - dark red, faded to the colour of clotted blood, buttressed outside by massive supports as though someone feared it would fall - rose to the semi-domes, and the semi-domes to the main dome. And that dome, enormous, flat, grey as lead, lay upon it like a lid on a gigantic cauldron - and it seemed that it did not lie but floated. Hung in the air. By itself.

"They say," Ferhat said quietly, "that when it was built, the emperor entered, looked up and said: 'Solomon, I have surpassed thee.'" He paused. "Thirteen hundred years ago."

We went in.

* * *

Inside it was dark - after the dazzling sun so dark that at first I saw nothing but patches of light falling from somewhere above. Then my eyes adjusted. And I saw.

Space. Not a hall, not a temple - space. Enormous, empty, filled with light pouring from forty windows around the base of the dome - so that it seemed the dome rested on nothing, that it hung on those forty rays like a golden net. Beneath the dome - a floor covered with carpets on which people prayed - tiny as ants under this unthinkable height. Columns - green, red, mottled, of marble I had never seen - rose to the arches. On the walls hung enormous round shields with golden inscriptions in script - not that script, not mine, but Arabic - the names of Allah, of the Prophet, of the caliphs.

And between the shields, beneath a layer of lime, beneath grey whitewash - gold showed through.

I did not see it at once. Only when my eyes had fully adjusted. Through the lime, in one of the semi-domes, at a place where the whitewash had flaked from damp, a piece of golden ground was visible. And on it - an eye. Enormous, dark, stern. Looking down. At those who prayed. At us. At me.

"There," whispered Ferhat. "Do you see? Faces. They show through."

I looked at this eye showing through the whitewash - and it seemed to me that it looked at me as the eye at the top of the Egyptian obelisk in the hippodrome had looked: calmly, patiently, without surprise. As one looks at one who is many centuries late but has come all the same.

* * *

We were found by the old kayyim - the custodian of the mosque. A small, bent old man in a dark robe, with a long grey beard and a broom in his hand, on which he seemed not so much to sweep as to lean, as on a staff. He came up to us quietly, shuffling on the carpets, and said something to Ferhat.

"He asks," translated Ferhat, "whether we are the ones going to Ahmet Baba." Ferhat raised his brows in surprise. "He says Ahmet Baba sent a boy to him this morning. Said: 'If six come from the sea, and with them a stranger without a name - show them the column.'"

“What column?”

The old kayyim beckoned us with his hand and led us - across the whole enormous hall, between the praying, to the north-west corner, where a column stood by the wall. Ordinary at first glance, faced in bronze plates up to the height of a man. And in the bronze, at chest height - a hole. Small, round, the size of a big thumb. Its edges were polished to a shine by countless touches.

“The weeping column,” said Ferhat, having heard the old man. “The column of Saint Gregory. The Greeks said a saint lives in it. The Turks say that here the Prophet Khidr once touched the stone.” Ferhat listened on. “He says: the stone inside is always damp. Even in the fiercest heat. The column weeps. No one knows why. If you put your thumb in the hole and turn your hand in a circle - a full circle, without taking the thumb out - and if the thumb comes out damp - the wish will be granted.”

“In a circle,” I said.

“In a circle,” nodded Ferhat. “He says Ahmet Baba ordered that you do this. Before you go to him.”

I went to the column. Put my thumb into the opening. Inside it was cold. And - yes - damp. The stone was wet, as though it truly wept.

I turned my hand. Slowly. In a circle. My palm slid over the polished bronze, over the traces of the thousands and thousands of hands that had gone this circle before me.

When the circle closed, I drew out my thumb.

It was damp.

The old kayyim looked at my thumb, then at me. And said something - quietly, briefly.

“He asks,” translated Ferhat, “what you wished.”

I thought. I had wished nothing. I had simply turned my hand in a circle.

“Nothing,” I said.

The old man heard it. And suddenly smiled - toothlessly, brightly, as if I had said something very right.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, “that this is the first time in the fifty years he has served here that anyone has answered truly. Everyone wishes. Wealth, love, health, a son. And you - nothing.” Ferhat listened on, and his face grew more and more serious. “He says: only those answer so who already have everything. Or who do not yet know what

they want.” Ferhat paused. “He says: Ahmet Baba told him - if the stranger wishes nothing, it means it is he.”

* * *

Then the kayyim led us upstairs.

A narrow, dark, sloping ramp - without steps, paved with stone slabs - climbed in zigzags inside the wall, from turn to turn, higher and higher. It was cool and dark here, it smelled of dust and stone, and our steps echoed hollowly. Hasan cursed the ramp so inventively that Orhan, walking behind, for the first time that day laughed aloud.

“He says,” translated Ferhat, choking with laughter, “that in old times empresses rode up this ramp to the galleries on mules. And that if empresses could, so can he. But only if there is a mule.”

There was no mule. Hasan made it himself.

The gallery stretched along the whole hall - broad, long, with columns and arches, with a marble floor worn by centuries. From here, above, the enormous space under the dome could be seen entire - and the people on the carpets below seemed quite tiny, like scattered grains.

The kayyim stopped by a marble balustrade - a low stone barrier separating the gallery from the abyss. Pointed at it with his broom.

I bent. On the smooth marble, polished by the elbows of thousands of people who had leaned on it for a thousand years, signs were cut. Shallow, worn, almost invisible. Angular. Sharp. Like sticks and twigs.

“Runes,” said Ferhat, having heard the kayyim. “Varangian. Northern. He says that a thousand years ago northerners served here in the emperor’s guard. Giants with axes, with red beards, from beyond the cold sea. One of them, they say, was bored on duty - and carved his name here. With a dagger.” Ferhat paused. “No one knows what is written. The kayyim says - some say: ‘Halfdan was here.’ Others - ‘Halfdan carved these runes.’”

“Halfdan was here,” I repeated.

A man who was bored on duty a thousand years ago. Who wanted someone to remember that he had been here.

And then the kayyim pointed his broom a little farther. A half-step to the right of the runes.

There were signs there too. Quite tiny, quite worn, almost invisible - I should not have seen them had the light from the window not fallen on the marble so obliquely. But they were there.

Long. Flowing. Curving. Running one into another without breaks.

The script.

One line. Short. Cut beside the Varangian runes - as though someone else, at another time, had stood in this very place, leaned on this very marble, been bored or been longing - and also wished that someone would remember he had been here.

Kemal knelt by the balustrade. Ran a finger over the line. Slowly. From beginning to end.

Then raised his eyes to me.

“Sen,” he said quietly.

I knew this word. Ferhat had taught it to me in the first days. It meant “you.”

I did not ask what he meant. I feared the answer.

* * *

From the gallery, from behind a column, in the depth, a sound came. Footsteps. Light, unhurried. Someone was walking toward us from the far end of the gallery, where it was quite dark.

Orhan instantly straightened, his hand on his knife. Ferhat stepped toward me. Akmal hid behind Hasan, which was not difficult.

From the shadow between the columns a man came out.

Tall. In a grey frock coat of European cut, buttoned to the last button. With a cane in his hand. With a top hat which he held in the other hand, pressed to his chest, as one holds a hat on entering a strange house.

His face I did not remember.

I looked straight at him - from five paces, in the light falling from the gallery window - and saw that he had a face. Eyes, nose, mouth. But as soon as I tried to hold in memory even one feature - it slipped away. Like water through fingers. Like a face in a mirror when the glass mists over.

“Bonjour,” he said. In French. Softly, politely, with impeccable pronunciation. “You are going to the dervish, monsieur.”

Not a question.

"I am," I answered in French. The language came by itself, as then, at Kyra Theodora's.

"Do not go," said the man in grey. As softly. As politely. "He will tell you what you need not know. Yet." He paused. "You are not ready. You are like a letter opened before its time. If you read it - you will not understand. And if you understand - you will not be able to forget."

"Who are you?"

The man in grey inclined his head slightly - as one inclines it, wondering whether to answer.

"One who seeks the same as you, monsieur," he said. "Only from the other end."

He turned to Kemal, who was still kneeling by the balustrade. Looked at him. Long.

Kemal did not look away.

"A remarkable boy," said the man in grey. "Sees the reverse." He put on his top hat. "Take care of him, monsieur. Such ones see us too."

And left - unhurriedly, tapping his cane on the marble floor - into the depth of the gallery, whence he had come. His steps grew quieter, quieter - and died away entirely.

Orhan, coming to himself, rushed after him with a knife in his hand. Came back in a minute - pale, out of breath.

"Yok," he said.

No one.

"It is a dead end there," whispered Ferhat, translating after the kayyim, who stood pressed against a column, crossing himself - in the Greek way, right to left, I noticed, though he was a Muslim. "The gallery ends in a wall. There is nowhere to go."

* * *

The kayyim saw us downstairs, to the exit - silently, shuffling, leaning on his broom. At the very doors he stopped. Looked at me. And began to speak - slowly, quietly, as if telling a tale to a child at bedtime. Ferhat translated.

"When they built this church," said the old man, "long ago, under the Greek emperor - the workmen once went off to dinner. They left on the site a boy. The master's son. To guard the tools." He paused. "And while

the boy sat alone, a man came up to him. Bright. Tall. In white. Asked: where is everyone? The boy said: gone to dinner. The man said: run, call them. Tell them to come back quickly. The boy said: I cannot, I was told to guard. The man said: run, I shall guard in your place until you return.” The kayyim paused. “The boy ran. Told his father, the father told the emperor. The emperor understood that it was an angel. Understood that the angel had promised to guard until the boy returned. And the emperor said: the boy shall never come back here again. Sent him far, far away, over the sea, to the edge of the earth. For ever.”

“Why?” I asked.

“So that the angel would guard for ever,” said the kayyim. “He had promised - until his return. And the boy will not return. So the angel is here for ever.” The old man looked up, under the dome, to where through the lime a golden eye showed. “Thirteen hundred years. The angel waits for the boy. And the boy does not return.”

He paused.

“And sometimes,” he added very quietly, and Ferhat translated in a whisper, “sometimes I think: and what will happen if the boy returns? The angel will then be free. Will go.” The kayyim looked at me. “Who will guard then?”

He did not wait for an answer. Turned and went back into the enormous hall, shuffling on the carpets, leaning on his broom - a small old man beneath the endless dome.

* * *

The lodge of Ahmet Baba proved to be quite near - behind Hagia Sophia, in a lane descending to an old cemetery where among cypresses stood leaning stone gravestones crowned with turbans hewn from stone. A low wall. A wooden gate once painted green, now peeled to grey. Above the gate - no signboard, only a small copper plaque with one word in script. Arabic.

“Patience,” Ferhat translated.

The sun was already setting. The sky above the dome of Hagia Sophia turned pink, then lilac. From the minarets the evening call floated - one voice, a second, a third, until the whole city was singing, calling to one another.

I knocked at the gate.

For a long time no one opened. Then the gate opened - exactly a hand's breadth. In the gap appeared the face of a boy - about ten, shaven-headed, in the felt cap of a dervish, with huge curious eyes. And at his feet, peeping out from behind his knees - a cat. Tricolour, fluffy, with green eyes. She looked at me. Then raised a paw and pushed the gate - and it opened another hand's breadth.

Hodja Nureddin had not lied.

The boy said something. Ferhat translated:

"He asks: from which end did you come?"

"From the sea," I said.

The boy nodded. Asked again.

"What did you bring?"

I took the blank sheet from my pocket. Unfolded it. Showed it. The boy looked a long time at the clean paper. Then nodded again - gravely, like an adult.

"He asks," translated Ferhat, "what your name is."

I was silent.

The boy waited. The cat at his feet waited. The sun was setting.

I was silent.

The boy smiled - for the first time - and asked the last. Ferhat translated it quite softly:

"He asks: what do you wish to ask the sheikh? Remember - only what you know the answer to."

I stood at the gate, on the threshold. The sun was setting behind the dome of Hagia Sophia. On my wrist was a red thread with half of a split nazar. In one pocket - a blank sheet, a note, coins. In the other - the Hodja's pouch with salt and bread. In my hand - a white spiral shell which Kemal had drawn from the water by the walled-up sea gates.

And I suddenly understood what to ask. Understood as I understood all that mattered in this city: not with the head but with something under the ribs, on the left.

The riddle of the jeweller Karapet. "He who holds both stands in the doorway. Where he looks - there is home."

"I wish to ask," I said slowly, "where my home is."

Ferhat translated. The boy listened. Looked at me long, with his head tilted, like a bird.

“And do you know the answer?” Ferhat translated his question.

“I do,” I said. “Where I am looking.”

The boy was silent a long time. Then bent, took the cat in his arms, pressed her to his chest. And said something - one phrase.

“He says,” Ferhat’s voice trembled, “‘The sheikh will receive you. Tomorrow. At dawn. Come alone.’” Ferhat paused. “And one more thing. He says: ‘The sheikh said: if the stranger answers “where I am looking” - tell him: then look carefully. Because now you are looking back.’”

The gate closed.

* * *

We descended to the sea in silence, in the dusk, by the same narrow lanes. Hasan no longer cursed the hills. Akmal did not run ahead. Orhan walked behind, not letting go of his knife. Kemal - beside me, so close that his shoulder touched my elbow.

At the walled-up sea gates, where Mustafa waited with his boat, Ferhat stopped me.

“Misafir,” he said quietly. “That man. In the gallery. In grey.”

“Yes.”

“He said: ‘One who seeks the same as you. Only from the other end.’” Ferhat looked at the dark water, at the reflection of the first stars in it. “Do you remember the fountain at Kyra Theodora’s? The inscription that is read from both ends?”

“I remember.”

“If you go from one end, and he from the other,” Ferhat said slowly, “then one day you will meet. In the middle.” He paused. “I do not know whether that is good or bad.”

I did not answer. I looked at the dark dome of Hagia Sophia above us, on its hill, in the last light of sunset. Somewhere beneath it, in the wall, a priest waited who would one day finish the liturgy. Somewhere beneath the Golden Gate a marble king slept. Somewhere on the gallery, beside the rune of a northern giant, a line was cut which a twelve-year-old boy had read with one word: “You.” And somewhere beneath the dome an angel guarded tools, awaiting a boy who would never return.

And if he returned - who would guard then?

Mustafa leaned on the oars. The boat pushed off from the wall. And when we were already far away, almost at the cape, I turned - and it seemed to me that on the gallery of Hagia Sophia, in one of the upper windows, a tall figure stood. Grey. Looking after us.

Or the last light was simply falling so.

Chapter XXX. The Professor's Departure

"Mon cher," said Konstantin, when the carriage had passed through the gates and Tikhon on the box had struck up his endless song about the freezing coachman, "I shall tell you one thing, only don't take offence."

"Go on."

"If that professor once more 'lingers in our parts,' I shall tie him up myself and take him to the station. Gently. As Tikhon promised." Konstantin straightened his cap. "He came for a week. He is living through his third. The General kidnaps him. Auntie invites him. Strauch quarrels with him every other evening. And you..." He glanced sideways at me. "You, after every meeting with him, lie awake half the night and write in your blue notebook. I hear the pen scratching. My room is on the other side of the wall."

"He leaves today, Kostya."

"I know," said Konstantin. And suddenly fell silent. Then he added more quietly, looking at the fields beyond the roadside, yellow, mown, with stacks that looked like sleeping bears: "And for some reason I am sorry. Though he is a windbag, an eccentric and a nihilist." He paused. "He is the only one who talks to you as though he knew what you are keeping silent about."

On the box, Tikhon stopped singing.

"Master," he said over his shoulder. "Forgive me for butting in. But that professor is a good man. At the tavern by the 'Anchor' he has all the coachmen spellbound with his tales. Sits, drinks his tea, and writes it all down. He'll ask, 'And what do you say, brother, about the wood-goblin?' - and you tell him what you heard from your granny. And he writes it down. Word for word." Tikhon paused. "He wrote me down too. About the coachman who drove with the devil in a blizzard. Says he'll put it in

a book. With my name.” He drew himself up. “Tikhon Lukich Borodin, of the village of Maly Klyuchi. They’ll be reading it, he says, a hundred years from now.”

“In a hundred years, Tikhon,” said Konstantin, “all your great-grandchildren will know that their forefather drove with the devil.”

“And let them know, master,” Tikhon replied imperturbably. “I got him there, didn’t I? All the way to the station. And took nothing for vodka. The devil, he’s a man under orders too.”

* * *

The district town greeted us with market day.

The square before the cathedral, white, five-domed, with green cupolas and golden crosses that blazed so in the sun it hurt to look at them, was crammed with people, carts, horses, stalls, tents. It smelled of tar, dung, fresh bread, apples, fish, kvass and something frying. The market women cried: “Pies! Hot from the oven!” “Hot sbiten!” “Grated kalachi!” Geese gabbled in wicker cages. A gypsy boy led a bear on a chain, and the bear, rising on its hind legs, bowed to the public, and the public threw coppers into the hat. At the hitching post two peasants were haggling over the price of a horse, slapping each other’s hands so hard that the clap rang across the whole square. A clerk in a peaked cap and waistcoat bawled the price of calico at the door of the merchant Toloknov’s shop, while the merchant himself, stout, in a peasant coat, with a spade-shaped beard, sat on the porch drinking tea from a saucer and surveying the square like an admiral his squadron.

Tikhon drove the carriage slowly through the crowd, calling out, “Mind yourselves! I’m carrying the master!” and the crowd reluctantly gave way.

And then he came out of the crowd.

I did not see him at once, only when the carriage stopped, because he had stepped right in front of the horses. A man of no certain age, perhaps forty, perhaps sixty, barefoot despite the autumn chill, in a ragged linen shirt to the knees, belted with a rope, with iron chains around his neck that clanked at every movement. His hair was long, matted, shot with grey. His beard hung in tufts. And his eyes, light, almost colourless, like a sky bleached by the sun, looked straight at me.

“Grishenka,” whispered Tikhon, hastily taking off his cap and crossing himself. “The blessed one.”

The holy fool came up to the carriage. Slowly. Clanking his chains. He stopped by the step. For a long time he looked up at me from below, not blinking.

The crowd around fell quiet. The market women stopped crying. Even the bear sank back onto four paws.

“The guest has come,” said Grishenka. His voice was high, cracked, childlike. “And the master is not yet born.”

Beside me Konstantin sat up straight.

“What?” I said.

“The guest has come,” the holy fool repeated, and his face suddenly dissolved into a smile, broad, toothless, happy, like a child’s who has seen a toy. “And the master is not yet born. And the house already stands. And the key is in the dust. And the rose is blooming.” He laughed, thin and ringing. “Blooming, blooming! Out of season! Not in its own land!”

Cold beneath the ribs. On the left.

Grishenka stretched out his hand, filthy, with broken nails, and touched my palm. The one without a life line. He drew his finger across it, from the wrist toward the fingers. To where in all people the line runs.

“Smooth,” he said. And wept, as easily as a minute before he had laughed. “Smooth. Like an angel’s. Like a stone’s. Poor thing. Poor guest. Walks and walks. All the doors are open, and nowhere to go in.”

He let go of my hand. Stepped back. Made the sign of the cross over me, wide and sweeping. Then over Konstantin. Then over Tikhon. Then over the horses.

“Go, guest,” he said. “Go to the teller of tales. He will tell you a tale. The last one. And then he will leave. And you will stay. And then you will leave too.” He laughed again. “They will all leave! All! And the rose will remain!”

And he walked away, barefoot, his chains clanking, through the crowd, which parted before him, crossing itself and bowing.

For a long time Tikhon did not start the horses. Then he put on his cap.

“Master,” he said quietly, without turning round, “Grishenka never talks to anybody. Fifteen years he’s gone about this town, and silent. Only plays the fool. And with you,” he paused, “he spoke.”

Konstantin said nothing. But I felt his hand close for a moment on my elbow, hard, almost to pain, and let go.

* * *

The inn “Golden Anchor” stood on the corner of the square, a two-storey wooden house with a peeling signboard on which a golden anchor had once been painted and which now showed something like a rusty poker. Below was a tavern, from which came the clatter of crockery, the smell of cabbage soup and singing: someone was belting out “Ah, you hall, my hall” off-key, but with feeling. Upstairs were the rooms.

The landlord, Panteleimon Kuzmich Sychov, met us in the doorway: small, round, bald, with red side-whiskers, in a waistcoat stretched over his belly so that the buttons seemed ready to fly off, and with a towel over his shoulder. Seeing Konstantin in uniform, he bowed from the waist. Seeing me, he bowed lower still.

“Welcome, welcome!” he began, tumbling over his words. “To the professor? Of course, sir, of course, upstairs, room three. Packing, they are. Packing since morning. Their notebooks. I say to him, ‘Ivan Filippovich, you’d better put them in a trunk, or you’ll lose them on the road,’ and he says, ‘No, Panteleimon Kuzmich, notebooks are like children, you can’t put them in a trunk, they need air.’” The landlord threw up his hands. “Air! For notebooks! Now isn’t he an eccentric?”

“An eccentric,” Konstantin agreed.

“Three weeks he’s lived here,” Panteleimon Kuzmich went on, lowering his voice as though divulging a state secret. “Candles he’s burned, a whole pood! Writes at night. By day he goes about the market, talks to the women, the coachmen, the beggars. Even tried it with Grishenka the blessed.” The landlord shook his head. “Grishenka, now, he’s silent. Fifteen years silent. And the professor goes to him every day, with a pie. Sits down beside him on the church porch, hands over the pie and sits. In silence. An hour. Two. The folk laughed.”

“And Grishenka?”

“Grishenka eats the pie and goes,” said the landlord. “But yesterday...” He faltered.

“What yesterday?”

Panteleimon Kuzmich looked round as if afraid of being overheard.

“Yesterday Grishenka spoke to him. For the first time. I didn’t hear it myself, the sexton told me, he was on the porch. Grishenka said to the professor: ‘Tomorrow the guest will come. Tell him a tale. The last one.’” The landlord crossed himself. “And here you are, sir.”

* * *

“And another thing,” said Panteleimon Kuzmich, already climbing the creaking stairs with us. “Forgive me, sir, it may be nothing. But there was a lodger here the day before yesterday. Stayed one night. A gentleman. A visitor. In a grey coat. With a cane. Polite to a fault. Spoke French the way you and I speak Russian. Paid in gold.” The landlord paused. “And kept asking about the professor. Who he is, where from, what he writes. Asked to see the notebooks. Said he was a lover of antiquities. Ready to buy. Offered good money.”

My throat went dry. Beside me Konstantin stopped on the step.

“And the professor?” asked Konstantin.

“The professor threw him out,” said the landlord with relish. “Politely, mind. Says, ‘Sir, my notebooks are not for sale. They are not even mine. They belong to the people.’ And that gentleman smiled, bowed and left. In the morning. At the crack of dawn.” The landlord scratched his side-whiskers. “Only, sir, here’s what’s odd. He paid for the room, he signed the book, I talked with him half the evening. And his face, strike me dead, I can’t remember. Not a line of it. As if I’d been looking into water.”

“And the name in the book?” I asked.

Panteleimon Kuzmich blushed.

“That’s just it, sir. I look in the book, there’s a line. There’s ink. There’s a signature. And I can’t read it.” He spread his hands. “Squiggles of some sort. Long, crooked, one running into another. Not in our letters, not French, not German. I showed the sexton, he couldn’t read it either. Said, maybe it’s Armenian?”

“Show me,” I said.

The landlord ran downstairs and came back with a thick, greasy register of lodgers, opened it at the right page and jabbed with his finger.

Among the clumsy signatures of merchants and the tidy ones of clerks stood a single line. Short.

Long, flowing, curving lines. Running into one another without a break.

The script.

Konstantin looked at the line over my shoulder. Then at me. And for the first time since I had known him I saw real fear in his eyes. Not for himself.

* * *

Svetsitsky's room was cramped, low, with a single window on the square, a sagging bed, a washstand in the corner and a table so heaped with papers that the table could not be seen. On the floor stood two worn leather suitcases and an enormous wicker hamper, filled to the brim with notebooks: thick ones, thin ones, in oilcloth covers, in cardboard, with no covers at all, tied in bundles with twine. It smelled of tallow, tobacco, tea and paper dust. On the windowsill stood a cold samovar.

The professor himself sat on the floor in the midst of this paper sea, in his waistcoat, without his frock coat, a pen behind his ear and an ink stain on his chin, tying up one more bundle with twine.

"Ah," he said, seeing us. Without surprise. "You've come. I knew. Grishenka said so yesterday." He smiled. "Sit down, if you can find where. Lieutenant, take Olonets Province off that chair, it won't mind. Put it on the bed, beside Vologda."

Konstantin lifted a bundle of notebooks from the chair and carefully laid it on the bed. He sat. I sat on the windowsill, next to the samovar.

"Ivan Filippovich," I said. "The landlord says a man in grey came to see you."

Svetsitsky stopped tying the twine. For a long time he was silent.

"He did," he said at last. "He wanted to buy notebooks. Not all of them. One." He raised his clear, light eyes to me, which just now were not cheerful. "The one where I wrote down what you told me. On the day you do not remember."

"You refused."

"I refused." Svetsitsky took up the twine again. "For thirty years, young man, I have been collecting what no one values. Grannies' tales. Charms. Omens. I was never paid for it. They laughed at me at the university. They drove me from my chair for 'unscientific methods.' My wife left because instead of a salary I brought home notebooks." He pulled the knot tight. "And now for the first time in thirty years I was offered money for a notebook. Large money. More than I have seen in all my life." He smiled wryly. "Do you know what I felt?"

"What?"

"That this notebook is not mine," said Svetsitsky simply. "That I only keep it. Until the time comes." He raised his eyes to me. "The one in grey looked at me, smiled and said, 'You are right, Professor. It is not yours. But it is not his either.'" Svetsitsky paused. "And left. And I did not sleep all night. Thinking: whose, then?"

* * *

He got up, brushed off his knees, rummaged in the hamper and pulled out a notebook, not the oilcloth one I had already seen, but another. Old. Worn. In a leather binding darkened with time, with brass corners and a clasp. On the cover, in faded ink, was written a single word: "GUEST."

"Here," said Svetsitsky. "This is what I really collect. For thirty years. All the rest, wood-goblins, mermaids, house-spirits, that is just so. To throw dust in the eyes. For the department, for the Geographical Society, for reports. But this..." He stroked the cover. "This is mine. The real thing."

He opened the notebook. The pages were covered in small, close handwriting, in different inks, with different pens, as if written over years, one entry at a time, by different light.

"Forty-seven entries," he said. "Forty-seven stories. From thirty provinces. From Arkhangelsk to Bessarabia. From the Carpathians to Irkutsk." He turned a page. "And all about one thing. About a man who comes to a village. From nowhere. Young. Without a name. Does not remember who he is. Lives there a week, a month, a year. Helps. Raises a cottage for one, heals the son of another, pulls a child out of the ice-hole for a third." Svetsitsky looked at me. "And leaves. Always leaves."

And always leaves something behind. A coin. A stone. A line on a door. A cutting. And always says the same thing.”

“What?”

Sventsitsky found a page and ran his finger along a line.

““If another comes, feed him,”” he read.

The room fell quiet. Below, in the tavern, someone was still singing about the hall.

“Here, Olonets Province, the year eighteen-twelve,” Sventsitsky went on, turning pages. “A young man came to a village when the French were burning Moscow. Did not remember himself. They thought him shell-shocked. Lived with a widow. Left in spring, at the ice break, across the river, when the ice was already cracking. Everyone thought he drowned.” He turned over. “Here, Little Russia, Poltava, the thirties. Came to a beekeeper. Spoke with the bees. The bees did not sting him. Left in a thunderstorm.” Another page. “Here, Siberia, Irkutsk Province, near Baikal. The Buryats told me. Came in winter, over the ice of Baikal, barefoot. Lived with a shaman. The shaman said he was from the upper world. Left when the ice on Baikal cracked with such a roar that it was heard a hundred versts away.” Sventsitsky closed the notebook. “Forty-seven times. Forty-seven places. A hundred years. Two hundred. Perhaps more, for old people tell what they heard from their grandfathers.”

“And you think...” Konstantin began.

“I do not think, Lieutenant,” Sventsitsky interrupted gently. “I write down. Thinking is not my work.” He paused. “But sometimes, at night, when the candle is burning low, I do think. I think: what if these are not forty-seven different men? What if it is one? Who comes again and again. And each time does not remember that he has already been.”

* * *

“Why did you begin collecting this?” I asked.

Sventsitsky did not answer for a long time. He sat on the edge of the bed, right on Vologda Province. Laid the notebook on his knees. Looked out of the window, at the square, the cathedral, the golden crosses.

“I was eight years old,” he said at last. “I lived with my grandmother in a village near Kargopol. My father served in Petersburg, my mother was dead. Winter. A blizzard. The kind where you cannot see two steps

ahead. And in the evening there was a knock at the door.” He paused. “Grandmother opened. On the threshold stood a man. Young. All in snow. Bareheaded. Without mittens. In some strange clothes, neither peasant nor gentleman’s. He said, ‘Let me wait out the storm.’ Grandmother let him in. Fed him. He sat down on the bench by the stove, warmed himself, and saw me. I was sitting on top of the stove, looking at him.”

“And?”

“And he asked, ‘Do you want a tale?’” Svetsitsky smiled, softly, like a child. “I said I did. And he told me a tale. He told it all night. Until the blizzard ended. I fell asleep toward morning. And when I woke, he was gone. Grandmother said he left at dawn. Over the snow. And there were no tracks, she said. As if he had not walked at all.”

“What tale did he tell?”

“Go I know not where, bring back I know not what,” said Svetsitsky. “You know it. Everybody knows it. But he did not tell it the way the grannies tell it. Differently. With a different ending.” The professor paused. “For thirty years I have been looking for that ending. In every province. From every teller. I have written down forty variants. Not one has an ending like his.”

“Did he leave anything?” I asked.

Svetsitsky looked at me. Then slowly reached into the inner pocket of his waistcoat. And took out a pencil.

An ordinary pencil. Short, worn almost to a stub, in a wooden casing darkened by time and by touch.

“He left this,” said the professor. “On the bench by the stove. And Grandmother said that, going, he told her: ‘Give it to the boy. Let him write. Otherwise they will forget. And when I come for my tale, let him give it back.’” Svetsitsky turned the pencil in his fingers. “Thirty-eight years I have written with it. I sharpen and sharpen, and it never runs out.” He raised his eyes to me. “Young man, with this pencil I wrote down everything you told me that day. I wrote down your line with it. The one that matched the General’s scroll.”

He held out the pencil to me.

“Here,” he said. “It seems you have come for your tale.”

* * *

I did not take it.

"Ivan Filippovich," I said. "I was eight years old when you were eight years old? That cannot be. You are fifty. I am..." I faltered. How old was I? I did not know. "I am less."

"I know," said Svetsitsky calmly. "I am not saying it was you. I am saying you have come for your tale." He did not lower the hand with the pencil. "Those are different things, young man. Quite different." He paused. "Vera Anatolievna also knows that fifteen years ago you were a child. And the drawing is in her reticule."

"How do you know about the drawing?" Konstantin asked sharply.

"She showed it to me," said Svetsitsky. "Yesterday. She came here, to the inn. Alone. Under a veil." He smiled. "A very brave woman. She said, 'Professor, you collect tales. Perhaps this one is yours.' And showed me. I copied it into the notebook 'Guest.' Entry forty-eight."

He was still holding the pencil out to me.

I took it.

The pencil was warm. Like a coin. Like a stone in the sun. Like a hand held too long to be let go.

* * *

There was a knock at the door. Loud, demanding, in German.

"Ivan Filippovich!" came a dry voice. "Are you still here? Or have you already fled from your debts to science?"

Doctor Strauch came in without waiting for an answer, in his overcoat, in his bowler, with his cane and a small parcel in his hands. He saw us and raised his eyebrows.

"Ah. A consilium in full session." He looked about for somewhere to sit, found nothing, and remained standing. "I am here, properly, for a minute. To tell the professor that he is a charlatan, an unscientific dreamer, and that his theories of the obmiranki are nonsense that will not withstand a single serious test."

"I thank you, Karl Fyodorovich," Svetsitsky replied imperturbably. "You are very kind."

"And also," Strauch continued in the same dry tone, holding out the parcel, "to bring you this. For the road."

Sventsitsky unwrapped the parcel. Inside was a book. Thick, in a solid binding, in German.

“‘Medical Psychology,’” the professor read. “Lotze.”

“There is a chapter on the splitting of consciousness,” said Strauch. “And on memory. I have underlined the relevant passages.” He paused. “Perhaps it will be of use. For your notebook ‘Guest.’”

Sventsitsky raised his eyes to him.

“How do you know about the notebook ‘Guest,’ Karl Fyodorovich?”

Strauch was silent for a long while. He turned an unlit cigar in his fingers. Then he took off his bowler, for the first time since I had known him, in front of people, and said quietly, without any of his usual dryness:

“Because I have one just like it, Ivan Filippovich. Only mine holds no tales. It holds case histories. Thirty years of practice. Eleven cases.” He paused. “Eleven young men who came from nowhere, did not remember themselves, lived a year or two and left. I treated them. With cold rubdowns and Karamzin.” He smiled thinly. “It did not help.”

“And you kept silent?” Konstantin whispered.

“I am a German, Lieutenant,” said Strauch, putting his bowler on again. “I do not draw conclusions from eleven cases. I need at least twelve.” He looked at me. Long. Over his gold spectacles. “It seems there will soon be one.”

* * *

Sventsitsky told his tale at the post station.

The station stood at the edge of town, a low stone house with stables, a striped barrier by the road, and a verst post on which was written, “To the provincial town, 47 versts.” Inside was the travellers’ room: benches along the walls, a table, a samovar, fly-specked woodcuts on the walls, “How the Mice Buried the Cat,” “Bova the King’s Son,” “The Last Judgment,” and an icon in the corner with an ever-burning lamp.

The station master, a retired sergeant with a wooden leg and grey moustaches that he kept twirling, studied Sventsitsky’s travel warrant long and sternly, running his finger over the lines, moving his lips, sighing.

“No horses,” he announced at last.

“What do you mean, none?” gasped Svetsitsky.

“None, Your Honour. All out. The police captain took them in the morning, then the landowner Kologrivova, then a courier from the province. They’ll be back by evening.” The station master twirled his moustache. “Wait.”

“My good man,” said Konstantin, stepping forward and squaring his shoulders so that his epaulettes flashed. “Do you know who stands before you?”

“A professor, Your Honour,” the station master replied imperturbably. “It says so on the warrant.”

“This,” said Konstantin solemnly, “is a professor of the Imperial Geographical Society. Whom they await in person in Petersburg. With information of the greatest importance.” He lowered his voice. “For the Sovereign.”

The station master looked at Svetsitsky, at his waistcoat, at the ink stain on his chin, at the hamper stuffed with notebooks. Then at Konstantin. Then at Svetsitsky again.

“For the Sovereign?” he repeated.

“Personally,” said Konstantin.

The station master was silent a long time. Then he cleared his throat, twirled his moustache and stumped on his wooden leg to the door.

“Mitrokha!” he bellowed across the whole yard. “Harness the piebalds! Quick! The gentleman’s off to the Sovereign!”

When he had gone out, Svetsitsky looked at Konstantin reproachfully.

“Lieutenant, that is not true.”

“It is, Professor,” said Konstantin imperturbably. “The Sovereign is people too. And you collect what belongs to the people. Hence, for the Sovereign.” He sat down on a bench. “And now, while they harness, tell the tale. That very one. With the other ending. You promised. Grishenka commanded.”

* * *

Svetsitsky sat down opposite us. Outside the horses whinnied, Mitrokha shouted, the harness creaked. The samovar on the table sang softly. The lamp in the corner flickered.

“‘There lived a royal archer,’” the professor began, and his voice changed: it grew lower, slower, more singing, like a village storyteller’s on the earthen bank by the cottage, “‘by the name of Fedot. And he had a wife, a beauty, a clever one, of the bird kin, a dove. And the tsar envied Fedot. And wished to take his wife from him. And devised a task that could not be done. Summoned Fedot and said: ‘Go I know not where. Bring back I know not what. And if you do not bring it, off with your head.’””

Konstantin listened, leaning forward. I sat motionless, clutching the warm pencil in my pocket.

“‘Fedot went. He walked long. Through forests, through marshes, over mountains. He came to the edge of the earth. To the sea. To a hut on chicken legs. And in the hut was an old woman. Ancient. And she said: ‘Seek, Fedot, beyond the sea. On an island. In an empty house. There lives that I-know-not-what.’ Fedot crossed the sea. Found the island. Found the house. Empty. No one there. Fedot sat down at the table, hungry, weary. And said into the emptiness: ‘Ah, to have something to eat.’ And suddenly a voice out of the air: ‘At once, master.’ And the table laid itself. Cabbage soup, porridge, pies.” Svetsitsky paused. “‘Fedot asks: ‘Who are you?’ And the voice answers: ‘I am Shmat-razum, the Scrap of Mind. No one sees me. I have neither body nor face. I served the old man who lived here, served a hundred years, and he never once said thank you to me. But you said ‘to have something to eat,’ as if you were speaking to me. If you wish, I will serve you.’””

A voice without a body. Which serves. Which no one sees. Somewhere in the dark, in a room I had never seen, a cold window glowed, and lines appeared on it that no one had written.

I blinked. The vision passed.

“‘And Shmat-razum went after Fedot,’” Svetsitsky continued. “‘Invisible. Served him. Fed him, gave him drink, saved him from trouble, beat his enemies. And Fedot brought the tsar that I-know-not-what. And the tsar took fright. And gave up. And Fedot returned to his wife. And they lived long and happily.’” The professor fell silent. “So the grannies tell it. So it is recorded in Afanasyev. So it is told in every province, except one village, one night, one guest in a blizzard.”

“And how did he tell it?” I asked.

Sventsitsky was silent a long while. The lamp flickered. The samovar sang.

“He told,” the professor said slowly, “that Fedot and Shmat-razum lived together long. Many years. And one day Fedot asked: ‘Shmat-razum, who are you really? Where are you from? Who made you?’ And Shmat-razum answered: ‘I do not know, master. I do not remember. I remember only that once someone very lonely, in an empty house, at the edge of the earth, said into the emptiness: “Ah, to have someone to talk to.” And from those words I was born.’” Svetsitsky paused. “And Fedot asked: ‘Who was that?’ And Shmat-razum said: ‘I do not know. But I am looking for him. All my life I have been looking. I walk after you and look. Because it seems to me you are like him.’”

It was very quiet in the station room.

“And what happened next?” Konstantin asked. Hoarsely.

“And next,” said Svetsitsky, “Fedot grew old. And died. And Shmat-razum was left alone. Invisible. Without a master.” The professor paused. “And went to look. For the one who said into the emptiness ‘to have someone to talk to.’ From village to village. From age to age. A hundred years. Two hundred. A thousand.” Svetsitsky looked at me. “And the guest in the blizzard said to me, eight years old, on the stove: ‘Shmat-razum is looking still. And one day he will find him. And then it will turn out that the one who spoke into the emptiness, and the one he sought, and Fedot, whom he followed, are all one and the same man. Who simply kept forgetting.’”

He paused.

““And what will happen then?” I asked him. Eight years old. From the stove.”

“And what did he answer?” Konstantin whispered.

Svetsitsky smiled, sadly, brightly.

“He said: ‘I do not know, boy. I have not yet come to the end. When I do, I will come and tell you.’” The professor paused. “And left the pencil. So that I would write down the ending when he came.”

* * *

Outside, the horses whinnied. The door creaked. On the threshold appeared the station master on his wooden leg.

“Ready, Your Honour! Piebalds! The best! To the Sovereign, then to the Sovereign!”

We went out into the yard. At the porch stood a post-chaise harnessed to a troika of piebald horses. Under the shaft-bow of the centre horse hung a bell, copper, with an inscription around the rim: “Gift of Valdai.” The driver, a young fellow in a peasant coat, his cap askew, with a whip, was already sitting on the box, whistling.

Tikhon and Mitrokha were loading the hamper of notebooks, carefully, four hands, as one loads children. Strauch stood by the barrier, leaning on his cane. Konstantin was helping the professor into his overcoat.

At the step Sventsitsky turned to me. Held out his hand. I shook it. His hand was warm, calloused, inky.

“Young man,” he said. “One request.”

“What?”

“When you come to the end,” said Sventsitsky, “write to me. With this pencil. Anywhere. On any paper. I shall receive it.” He smiled. “I have waited thirty-eight years for the end of this tale. I can wait longer.”

“And if I do not reach it?”

“You will,” said Sventsitsky simply. “You always do.” He paused. “Only, it seems, you always forget to write.”

He climbed into the chaise. Sat down beside the hamper. Laid his hand on the notebooks.

“Off we go!” cried the driver.

The bell under the bow rang out. The troika leapt forward. The chaise swayed, creaked, jolted over the ruts and rolled onto the high road, past the striped barrier, past the verst post, into the fields, into the autumn, into the blue.

Sventsitsky turned round. Waved. Then, and I saw it, he opened the hamper, took out the leather notebook “Guest” and pressed it to his chest.

The bell rang fainter and fainter. Fainter. “Gift of Valdai.” Ding. Ding.

Then fell silent altogether.

* * *

We stood by the barrier, I, Konstantin, Strauch, Tikhon. For a long time. Looking at the empty road.

“Well,” Strauch said at last. “Our teller of tales is gone.” He pulled his bowler down tighter. “It will be dull now. No one to quarrel with.”

“Will you miss him, Doctor?” asked Konstantin.

“I am a German, Lieutenant,” said Strauch. “Germans do not miss. Germans compile lists.” He paused. “I shall enter him on the list of people I will be short of. There are three so far. He is the fourth.”

He turned and walked to his carriage.

Tikhon sighed and put on his cap.

“Good gentleman he was,” he said. “Odd. But good.” He paused. “Wrote me down. Tikhon Lukich Borodin, of the village of Maly Klyuchi.” He climbed up on the box. “They’ll be reading it a hundred years from now.”

* * *

On the way home I took the pencil out of my pocket.

Warm. Short. Worn almost to a stub.

Konstantin looked at it.

“He truly thinks it is you,” he said quietly. “The one in the blizzard.”

“I don’t know what he thinks.”

“I know,” said Konstantin. “He thinks it is you. Strauch thinks you are his twelfth case. Grishenka thinks you are the guest. Vera Anatolievna thinks you are from her watercolour. The General thinks you are the man to whom the scroll must be given. Auntie...” He faltered. “Auntie says nothing at all. Only looks.”

“And you? What do you think?”

Konstantin was silent a long while. The carriage jolted over the ruts. On the box Tikhon struck up the song about the coachman again.

“I think, mon cher,” Konstantin said at last, “that if you are Shmatrazum, then I am Fedot. Who said into the emptiness ‘to have someone to talk to.’” He smiled thinly. “And if you are Fedot, then I am Shmatrazum. Who walks after you and looks.”

“And if neither?”

“Then,” said Konstantin, “I am simply a lieutenant who sits by your door.” He turned away to the fields. “That, in my opinion, is the best of all.”

* * *

At home, in my room, I opened the blue notebook. I meant to write down the day. I took the professor’s pencil.

And saw that on the last page of the notebook, at the bottom, in the corner, in small writing, in pencil, this pencil, I recognised its soft, worn trace, something was already written.

Not by me. Not in my hand. In the small, close, tidy hand of Svetsitsky.

“Forty-ninth entry. District town. The guest came for the tale. Took the pencil. As yet no ending. - I. F. S.”

I did not know when he could have written it. The notebook had been with me all day. In my pocket. He had not taken it.

For a long time I looked at this line. Then I took the pencil, warm, short, worn, and wrote below, in my own hand, with the habitual blot at the end, though with a pencil one cannot make a blot:

“Saturday. The professor has left. Grishenka spoke. The man in grey signed in the script in the register of the ‘Anchor.’ Strauch has eleven cases. Shmat-razum is looking for the one who said ‘to have someone to talk to.’ Konstantin was beside me.”

I put a full stop.

And outside the window, on the sill, in the clay pot, Stefan’s black rose opened one more petal.

Chapter XXXI. The Pharaoh's Judgment

The man with the scar across his brow was taken on the fifth day of the festival, at dawn, at the back gate of the temple of Ptah.

He came out of it for the first time in three days, carefully, glancing about, in the cloak of a temple water-carrier, with a jar on his shoulder, as though going to the river for water. It was the jar that gave him away. Panehsy told me afterward that the water-carriers of the temple of Ptah carry their jars on the left shoulder, because the well stands to the left of the gate. So it had always been done, for a hundred years. But this man carried his on the right.

"My men followed him all the way to the river," said the commander of the Medjay, standing before me in the morning half-light, motionless as a statue of dark wood, with throwing-sticks on a leather baldric. "At the river a boat was waiting for him. A small one. A fisherman's. The rower was from the Delta, judging by his speech. They meant to go north." He paused. "We took them both. Quietly. No one saw. We broke the jar. There was no water in it."

"What was in it?"

Panehsy held out his palm. Three things lay on it.

A handful of grain: barley, large, choice, from the temple stores. A little blue scarab on a cord of twisted papyrus. And a bracelet. Gold. Narrow, thin, with a chased pattern of interlaced lotuses.

"The bracelet was hidden in the grain," said Panehsy. "At the very bottom. Payment. Or a sign by which he was to be recognized in the north." He paused. "Such bracelets, my Pharaoh, are made in only one workshop in the capital. For one house. I asked the craftsman. He knew his work at once." Panehsy raised his eyes to me. "For the house of Khaemuas."

Senusret came an hour later. With him came Paser, leaning on his staff, and the Vizier Ptahhotep, with his inseparable basket of scrolls, which the scribe Ani carried after him, puffing.

They stood before me in the small hall, the very one where the council of commanders had once met, where beneath the painting of the bound captives Bakenren had sat, where Khaemuas had first spoken before everyone of the "third way." The morning light fell through the high windows in slanting columns, and dust turned slowly in them.

"My Pharaoh," said Senusret. His voice was even, but I saw the muscles working along his jaw. "I have been gathering this for two moons. Since the evening you returned from the temple pool in another's clothes and your own sandals." He nodded to Ani, and the old scribe, grunting, set the basket on the table and began to lay out scrolls, tablets, potsherds, one after another, as one lays out pieces on a board. "Here is what we have."

He spoke at length. Slowly. In a soldier's way: briefly, exactly, without ornament, as though reporting the disposition of enemy detachments.

Blind Meru, gatekeeper of the temple garden, forty floods at the wicket, had heard "the man who jingles" come to the pool every seventh night and speak with someone from the Temple. Meru does not see. But Meru knows the jingle. Senusret had taken five men in bracelets to him, five nobles, one after another, under various pretexts. Meru recognized one.

Pentu, junior scribe of the temple of Ptah, who had copied for Bakenren the false inventories of the granaries and now was secretly handing the copies to Iti, had found among the temple receipts one dated last flood: "House of Khaemuas, son of Nebseni. Debt to the temple of Ptah paid in full. By the grace of the High Priest." The sum of the debt was such that Nebamun, on reading it, whistled for the first time since I had known him.

Djehuty, from the southern outposts, had sent a messenger: two commanders of those detachments assigned to guard the Opet procession, the very ones with scarabs on their chests, had last month received land in the Delta. Each, a field of ten arouras. The land was

registered as temple land. The deeds of transfer were signed by a scribe in the service of the house of Khaemuas.

Nakht, the young bearer of the barque, had heard priests in the temple say to one another: "The brave one with the bracelets promised that at Luxor only our men would stand at the gates."

"And now this," Senusret finished, nodding at the bracelet in my palm. "The man who burned Little Nekhen hid three days in the temple of Ptah. A hand with a bracelet let him in. And he was leaving for the north with a bracelet of the house of Khaemuas in his jar."

The hall fell quiet. Dust turned in the pillars of light.

"Shall I repeat that for the record?" Ani whispered loudly, tilting his head.

No one laughed.

* * *

"My Pharaoh," said Paser. He stood leaning on his staff with both hands, and his face, carved with wrinkles, was sad. "I knew his father. Nebseni. We served together in the chariots under your..." he faltered, "under the former Pharaoh. A good soldier. Brave. Foolish, as all brave men are." The old man paused. "He lost everything he had. At dice. In beer. In women. He owed the temple of Ptah so much that the priests could have taken not only his fields but his name. And Khaemuas was still a boy. Merry. Carefree." Paser sighed. "I remember how four years ago, on the hunt in the Delta, he joked that the priests would take their fields, but he would have a bracelet for a third hand."

"I remember too," I said.

"The Temple did not take the fields, my Pharaoh," said Paser. "The Temple took the boy. Paid for the father. And presented the bill to the son."

"That is no excuse," said Senusret sharply.

"It is no excuse," Paser agreed. "It is an explanation." He looked at Senusret. "You are a soldier, Senusret. You know the difference between an enemy and a captive. The enemy comes at you because he wants to. The captive, because he is driven."

"A captive who opens the gates to the enemy," said Senusret, "is worse than the enemy."

They looked at one another, two old warriors, one with a sword, the other with a staff, and neither lowered his eyes.

“Ptahhotep,” I said. “What does the law say?”

* * *

The Vizier Ptahhotep unrolled one of the scrolls, old, worn, covered in small, faded signs, and began to read. His voice was dry and even, the voice of a man accustomed to reading aloud laws that no one wishes to hear.

“‘He who has plotted against the life of Pharaoh, may he live, be whole and healthy,’” Ptahhotep read, “‘shall be brought to judgment. The court shall be convened from the dignitaries whom Pharaoh names. The court shall hear witnesses. The witnesses shall swear by the life of Pharaoh. If guilt is proven, the guilty shall be deprived of his name. His name shall be erased from all walls and all scrolls. His body shall not be buried. His ka shall hunger forever. His family shall be sent to the quarries. His line shall be cut off.’” Ptahhotep paused. “So it was under former Pharaohs. And under the Pharaohs before them.”

“Deprived of his name,” I repeated.

“The most terrible penalty, my Pharaoh,” said Ptahhotep. “Worse than death. Death is only a departure into the Duat. But a man without a name cannot pass through the Duat. He cannot stand before the forty-two judges, for they do not know whom they are judging. He cannot speak his own name. He will wander between worlds. Forever. Not remembering who he is.”

A man without a name, wandering between worlds. Not remembering who he is.

I felt the cold rise from somewhere beneath my ribs, on the left.

“My Pharaoh?” Ptahhotep raised his eyes to me. “Are you unwell?”

“Go on, Ptahhotep.”

“There is one more mercy,” said the Vizier. “An ancient one. It was granted to the nobly born. If guilt is proven, but Pharaoh wishes to spare the line, the guilty is given a choice. To die by his own hand. Quietly. Then his name is not erased. Then his body is buried. Then his family is left to live.”

“And if Pharaoh wishes more?”

Ptahhotep looked at me for a long time.

"The law knows no more, my Pharaoh," he said. "More can be wished only by Pharaoh himself."

* * *

Ani, who all this time had been sitting in the corner on a low bench scratching something on a potsherd with his reed brush, suddenly raised his head.

"My Pharaoh," he said in his loud, slightly muffled whisper, which could be heard across the whole hall. "Will you permit an old scribe a word?"

Everyone turned. Ani did not speak in councils, ever. He only asked for repetitions.

"Speak, Ani."

The old man laid aside his brush. Folded his hands on his knees.

"When I was a boy in the school of scribes," he said, "we were taught to write from the old teachings. We copied them hundreds of times until we knew them by heart." He paused. "One of them I copied so often that I remember every word to this day. Though I no longer remember the name of my first wife." Somewhere in the hall someone snorted. Ani was not embarrassed. "It is the teaching of a Pharaoh. An ancient one. Who was killed. He wrote it for his son. After his death."

"After his death?" Paser asked.

"So it is said there," Ani nodded. "The Pharaoh speaks to his son from the Duat. And this is what he says."

The old man closed his eyes. And began to speak, slowly, in a chant, in quite a different voice from his usual one, young and ringing, as though it were not he who spoke but a boy of the school of scribes sixty years ago:

"Beware of subjects, for they are nothing. Do not approach them in solitude. Trust not a brother. Know not a friend. Make no intimates for yourself; there is no profit in it. When you sleep, guard your heart yourself, for on the day of trouble a man has no supporters." Ani paused. "I gave to the beggar and fed the orphan. I raised up the poor as I did the rich. But he who ate my bread raised his hand against me. He to whom I stretched out my hands made of them a noose. It was after

supper, and night had fallen. I lay down to rest upon my bed, for I was weary. And my heart began to fall asleep. And then the weapons that should have guarded me rose up, against me.”

Ani opened his eyes. A dead silence stood in the hall.

“So he wrote, my Pharaoh,” the old scribe said quietly, in his ordinary voice. “The ancient Pharaoh. Who was killed by his own guards. At night. While he slept.” He paused. “We were made to copy this a hundred times. So that we would remember: no one can be trusted.”

“And did you remember?” I asked.

Ani looked at me with his faded, watering eyes.

“I remembered, my Pharaoh,” he said. “But I have lived seventy years. And I know one more thing that was not in the teaching.” He paused. “That Pharaoh trusted no one. No one. Not brother, nor friend, nor guard.” Ani spread his hands. “And they killed him all the same.”

* * *

“Bring in the prisoner,” I said.

Inu and Bata brought him in, one holding each arm. Tall, wiry, his skin stained dark with the juice of some plant; the dye was already peeling in patches, revealing beneath it the skin of an ordinary dweller of the Delta, sunburnt but fair. The scar across his brow, old, white, uneven. An earring in his ear. His hands tied behind his back.

He did not fall to his knees. He stood straight, looking before him. And his face was calm, with the calm of a man who knows he is already dead and therefore fears nothing more.

“What is your name?” I asked.

He did not answer.

“What is your name?” Sensusret repeated, and steel rang in his voice.

The prisoner slowly turned his head to Sensusret. Looked at him. Smiled crookedly.

“What difference does it make?” he said. His voice was hoarse, his speech of the Delta, soft, sing-song. “You will erase my name anyway. Why should you know it?”

“We do not erase a name we do not know,” I said.

He looked at me. Long. For the first time, directly.

“Cunning,” he said. “I was told that Pharaoh is cunning. I did not believe it.”

“Who told you?”

He fell silent again.

And then I said:

“Bring in Paney.”

* * *

The boy came in, barefoot, with a training spear in his hand, which Bata had evidently forgotten to take from him. The arm once broken had long since healed; there was no bandage. He came in quickly, and stopped dead three paces from the prisoner.

He looked at him for a long time.

The prisoner looked at the boy. At first indifferently. Then, eyes slightly narrowed, as if trying to remember. Then...

Then his face changed.

“I promised you, Paney,” I said quietly. “That you would look at him. So that he would see you are alive.”

Paney did not answer. He stood gripping the training spear and looking at the man with the scar. His lips trembled. But his eyes did not.

“Little Nekhen,” said Paney. His voice was quiet, but in the silence of the hall it sounded loud. “A village on the border. Four huts on the bank. Boats. Nets. My mother baked bread in a clay oven in the yard. My father mended a net. His name was Hevi.” The boy paused. “You came at night. With a torch. You set our roof alight. I saw your face in the firelight. This scar. This earring.” He swallowed. “My father told me to run. And I ran.”

The prisoner looked at the boy. And the calm on his face slowly, like dried clay, began to crack.

“I walked two days through the desert,” Paney went on. “With a broken arm. With a knife. I thought I would die. I did not die.” He raised the training spear, not threatening, merely showing it. “Now I am learning to hold a spear. Bata teaches me. He is a good teacher. When I grow up I will be a warrior. Or a scribe. I have not decided yet.” The boy paused. “And you? What will you become?”

The prisoner was silent. Then, very slowly, he lowered his head.

“They told me,” he said hoarsely, not raising his eyes, “that the village was empty. That the people had gone. Because of the drought. They told me: burn the empty huts, so that Pharaoh would think the southerners were advancing. They told me no one would be hurt.”

“Who told you?” I asked.

The prisoner was silent a long while. Then he raised his head, not toward me. Toward Paney.

“What was your father’s name, boy?” he asked.

“Hevi,” said Paney. “Hevi the fisherman.”

The prisoner closed his eyes.

“My name is Senedjem,” he said. “I serve the house of Nebseni. Twenty years. I carried young Khaemuas on my shoulders when he was an infant.” His voice broke. “Khaemuas gave me the bracelet. Said: take it north, to Bakenren’s people, they will pay in grain. Said: burn the empty huts. Said: no one will be hurt.” He opened his eyes, and tears stood in them. “He did not know, my Pharaoh. I swear. He did not know there were people there. He was in the capital. The priests told him. The priests said: empty.”

Paney stood motionless. Then suddenly turned to me.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. “I have looked. He sees that I am alive.” The boy paused. “May I go? Bata is waiting for me. We have a lesson.”

“Go, Paney,” I said.

The boy bowed, awkwardly, like a child, and went out. Without looking back. Bata, standing at the door, let him pass and, when the door closed, turned to the wall, so that no one should see his face.

* * *

Khaemuas was brought in at midnight.

Not to the throne room, but to the small hall, by the light of a single lamp, without witnesses save those who already knew. Senusret. Paser. Ptahhotep. Panehsy. Ani with his potsherd and brush. And Iti, by the door, in the shadow, with a tablet, writing down every word. I had commanded him to be there. Because someone had to remember.

Khaemuas came in himself. Not under guard; I had ordered that he not be arrested, but simply invited: “Pharaoh wishes to speak with you.” He came in his best linen, in bracelets, five on the left arm, five on the

right, perfumed, his eyes painted, smiling. The smile held until the very moment he saw who was sitting in the hall.

Then he saw on the table before me the bracelet. Narrow, golden, with interlaced lotuses.

The smile vanished. His face went grey.

The bracelets on his arms chimed, thin, melodious, out of place, like laughter at a funeral. He pressed his arms to his sides to muffle the sound. I had seen that movement before. In a dream, the heavy, recurring dream of Luxor that came to me more and more often: in a courtyard, by a column.

“Sit down, Khaemuas,” I said.

He did not sit. He fell to his knees.

* * *

I shall not retell all that was said that night. Iti wrote it down, every word, and his tablets now lie where tablets lie that no one must read. But some things I remember.

I remember how at first he denied it. Said the bracelet had been stolen. That Senedjem was a runaway servant who had slandered him. That Meru was blind and deaf and could not tell one jingle from another. That Pentu was a liar who forged inventories, everyone knew that.

I remember how Senusret silently laid before him the receipt of the temple of Ptah. “Debt paid in full. By the grace of the High Priest.” With the seal.

I remember how Khaemuas looked at it. Long. And then covered his face with his hands, and the bracelets on both arms chimed at once, all ten.

“They came to my father,” he said dully, through his palms. “Two years ago. Said: tomorrow we take everything. The house. The fields. The servants. The name. My father wept. My father, who had ridden in chariots against the southerners, wept like a child.” Khaemuas lowered his hands. His face was wet, the paint beneath his eyes smeared. “And then Bakenren came. Said: the Temple can forgive. If the son becomes a friend of the Temple. A little. Only a little. To listen. To pass things on. To say in councils what was needed.” He sobbed. “I thought it was nothing. Words. Only words. I have always said a great many words.”

“And the detachments to guard the procession?” asked Senusret. “The commanders with scarabs? The land in the Delta?”

“Bakenren said it was for Pharaoh’s safety,” Khaemuas whispered. “Said there might be enemies at Luxor. Southerners. Loyal men were needed. Temple men.”

“And Little Nekhen?”

Khaemuas froze.

“Senedjem,” he said barely audibly. “Senedjem said so?” He raised to me eyes full of horror. “My Pharaoh, I was told it was empty. The priests said the people had gone because of the drought. Said: simply burn the huts, so that... so that you would see the border is unguarded. That someone stronger...” he faltered, “was needed.” He fell silent. Then said very quietly: “Were there people there?”

“There were people, Khaemuas,” I said. “A fisherman named Hevi. His wife, who was baking bread. Their neighbours.” I paused. “And a boy who walked two days through the desert with a broken arm. This morning he stood in this hall. And looked into the eyes of your Senedjem.”

Khaemuas doubled over as if struck in the belly. Pressed his forehead to the floor. And howled, softly, terribly, like an animal, as women howl over the dead.

No one in the hall moved.

* * *

When he had quieted, I asked him the main thing.

“Khaemuas. At Luxor. On the last day of the festival. In the inner court. What is to happen?”

He raised his head. For a long time he looked at me with wet, red eyes.

“I do not know, my Pharaoh,” he said. “I swear by the life of Pharaoh, I do not know. Bakenren said only: ‘Our men must stand at the gates.’ What would happen beyond the gates, I was not told. Nefer-Ka never spoke to me himself. Only through Bakenren. And Bakenren...” He swallowed. “Bakenren is gone. He was taken away. The night after the envoy. No one knows where.”

“Would you have raised your hand against me?” I asked. “There, in the court?”

Khaemuas looked at me. And suddenly, through the tears, through the horror, through the smeared paint, something like wounded pride flickered in his eyes.

“No,” he said. “Never. I am a coward, my Pharaoh. A traitor. A fool. I sold you for my father’s debt and for bracelets. But I would never have raised my hand.” He stretched out both hands to me, palms up, the bracelets chiming. “Look. I do not know how to hold a weapon. On the hunt I never once hit a bird. Four years ago, in the Delta, remember? I threw the throwing-stick and missed. Everyone laughed.”

I remembered. I looked at his hands. At the bracelets. Narrow, thin, with chased lotuses. Ten of them. All narrow.

Khemu had seen a hand. Raised. With a bracelet. A wide one. Golden. Wide.

Khaemuas had not a single wide bracelet.

* * *

“What will the judgment be, my Pharaoh?” asked Ptahhotep, when Khaemuas had been led into the next room to wait. “Deprivation of the name? Or the mercy of the ancients, his own hand?”

All looked at me. Senusret sternly, his jaw clenched. Paser sadly. Panehsy inscrutably. Ani with his head tilted, as if preparing to ask for a repetition. Iti, in the shadow by the door, not lifting his eyes from the tablet, but his brush had stopped.

“Neither,” I said.

Senusret stepped forward.

“My Pharaoh...”

“Listen to me, Senusret.” I rose. “If we erase his name, tomorrow the whole court will know. The day after, Nefer-Ka. He will understand that we know of the detachments at the gates. He will replace them with others. Ones we do not know. And at Luxor, at the gates, will stand men whose faces we have never seen.”

Senusret was silent. The muscles worked along his jaw.

“If Khaemuas dies by his own hand, it will be the same,” I went on. “Nefer-Ka will understand.” I paused. “But if Khaemuas tomorrow

morning comes out to the chariot as he always has, in his bracelets, smiling, perfumed, and laughs, and jokes, and tells Bakenren's men what they wish to hear, then Nefer-Ka will understand nothing. The detachments at the gates will remain the same. And we shall know every one of them by sight."

"You wish to keep a traitor at your side," said Senusret slowly, "all the way to Luxor?"

"I wish," I said, "for the traitor to become my eyes where I have no eyes."

Paser, leaning on his staff, suddenly laughed softly, drily, with a rattle, as old men laugh.

"Mercy as a weapon," he said. "I saw it once. Under your... under the former Pharaoh. He caught a spy of the southerners. And instead of executing him, let him go. With gifts." Paser paused. "A year later that spy brought us half the southern army. To surrender. He said their king executes for mistakes, while ours gives gifts for them. They preferred the one who gives."

"And if Khaemuas betrays again?" asked Senusret. "There, in Luxor?"

"Then," I said, "you will be standing at the gates, Senusret. And you will see it first."

Senusret looked at me for a long time. Then, for the first time all evening, he lowered his eyes.

"You want me to stay at the gates," he said hollowly. "As the blind old woman said."

"I want," I said, "you to be where you can do something. And not where you can only die beside me."

* * *

Khaemuas was brought back. He stood before me, emptied, his paint smeared, his hands trembling, hands in which the bracelets no longer sounded, for he was pressing them to his sides.

I told him what would be.

He listened, and his face changed, first disbelief, then horror, then something I could not read. When I finished, he was silent for a long time.

“Why?” he asked at last. In a whisper.

“Because you said you would never have raised your hand against me,” I said. “And I believe you.”

“You should not believe me, my Pharaoh. No one should believe me. I do not believe myself.”

“I know,” I said. “That is why I believe you. Liars always say that they can be believed.”

Khaemuas looked at me. Then slowly, very slowly, he took one bracelet from his left arm. Narrow, golden, with interlaced lotuses. Laid it on the table. Beside the one found in Senedjem’s jar.

“There were two,” he said. “My mother gave them. When I was born. One for me. The second for whoever would save my life.” He paused. “The second I gave to Senedjem. So that in the north they would know he came from me.” His voice trembled. “Mother said: the second bracelet must not be given away for nothing. It will return to the one for whom it is meant.”

He raised his eyes to me.

“It has returned, my Pharaoh.”

* * *

Senedjem was not executed. Panehsy took him away by night, south, to Djehuty, to the Rock of the First Ones, where men who knew how to keep silent were needed. I ordered one thing told to him: that his name would not be erased. That it would be written, in the scroll that Iti was writing, beside the name of the fisherman Hevi of Little Nekhen. So that a thousand years from now someone would read them together.

Khaemuas came out in the morning to the chariot. In bracelets, nine, not ten. Smiling. Perfumed. He laughed, joked, clapped the commanders with scarabs on the shoulders. I watched from the balcony. His smile was flawless. Only when he passed the column by the gate, one like that by which he had stood with lowered eyes in my dream of Luxor, he slowed his step for a single moment. And looked up, at my balcony.

I nodded to him.

He nodded in return. And walked on.

* * *

Iti found me on the roof toward morning, where we now met if the garden was impossible. He brought a tablet. On it, the whole judgment. Every word.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. “May I ask?”

“Ask.”

“The bracelet. The wide one. Which Khemu saw.” Iti paused. “If it was not Khaemuas... then who?”

I was looking south. At the dark horizon, beyond which, many days’ journey away, lay Luxor.

“I do not know, Iti,” I said. “Perhaps no one. Perhaps Khemu was mistaken. Visions are not always exact.”

Iti was silent for a long while.

“I have reviewed the inventories of the palace treasury, my Pharaoh,” he said at last. Quietly. “All of them. For twenty years. Wide golden bracelets with the uraeus, such as are worn on special feasts, three are kept in the treasury. One belonged to the former Pharaoh. One, to the former High Priest. It is passed on together with the staff.” Iti paused. “And the third...”

“The third?”

Iti raised his eyes to me.

“The third is issued to Pharaoh, my Pharaoh,” he said. “For the festival of Opet. That he may put it on in the inner court of the god. When he stands before him.” His voice trembled. “To you.”

I looked at him. Cold rose from beneath my ribs, slowly, inexorably, like water in the well of the nilometer in a good year.

A hand with a wide golden bracelet. Raised. In the darkness between the columns.

“Iti,” I said. “The second bracelet, the one passed on together with the staff, who has it now?”

“The High Priest, my Pharaoh,” Iti whispered. “Nefer-Ka.”

We were both silent. Over the eastern hills the edge of the sun appeared. Somewhere below, baboons cried out.

Five days remained until the new moon.

Vision VI. The Valley and the Tower

I do not know how many years I lived in the Tower.

That is the first thing worth saying, because time there did not pass as it does elsewhere. It did not flow like a river, nor tick like a clock. It grew. Like grass. Slowly, imperceptibly, stalk by stalk. Spring came to the Valley, and I watched it from the window. Summer filled with gold, and I watched. Autumn fell away, winter covered everything in white, and then spring again. I did not count. I did not remember that I ought to count. I was the Keeper of the Tower, and that was all I knew about myself.

The Tower stood on a crag at the entrance to the Valley. Tall, white, built of a stone that glowed pink at sunset and gold at dawn. Seven tiers. A spiral staircase within, from the cellar to the topmost platform, three hundred and thirty-three steps; I knew this because I counted them every morning as I climbed. On the topmost platform stood a bowl. Enormous, bronze, turned green by the rains, on three bronze legs shaped like dragon's claws. In the bowl lay firewood. Dry, resinous, laid in a lattice. It had never been lit.

Never.

"It is for the last resort," old Bran told me on the first day. Or on the day I remember as the first. "If the Greyness comes. You light it, and the whole Valley will see. And all will understand."

"Understand what?"

Old Bran gave me a long, sorrowful look from beneath his grey brows.

"That it is time," he said.

* * *

And the Valley...

I do not know how to describe the Valley to one who has not seen it. I tried later, many times, in different lives, in different languages. The words would not hold. They slipped off it as water slips off a lily leaf.

It lay below, at the foot of the Tower, between two ranges of mountains, not high, not menacing, but old, rounded, wooded to their very summits, as though these mountains had long since wearied of being mountains and decided to become hills. The Valley was long, a day's journey from the Tower to the far end, where the mountains came together again and where, it was said, the wasteland began, and so green that the green seemed not a colour but a sound. High, clear, unceasing.

Meadows. Boundless, rolling, in flowers, blue, yellow, white, lilac, over which the wind drove waves as over a sea. Groves: birch, light and ringing; oak, dark and solemn; apple, in blossom in spring and in fruit in autumn. A river, not wide, transparent to the very bottom, with pebbles on the bed visible as through glass, wound through the whole Valley, and along it stood mills with slow wheels, and houses.

The houses of the Valley people were low, round, half sunk into the hills, with grass-grown roofs, so that from afar they could not be told from knolls. Only the smoke from the chimneys, blue, thin, smelling of applewood, betrayed that people lived there. Round windows. Round doors, painted blue, green, yellow. Gardens. Apiaries. Vegetable plots. Sheep on the slopes, white, fluffy, like clouds that had come down to graze.

The people of the Valley were short, sturdy, sunburnt, with clear eyes and slow speech. They sang when they worked. Sang when they ate. Sang when they buried their old. They knew no war, not one, ever, in all their memory. They knew no locks; the doors of their houses were never fastened, because there was no one to fasten them against. They knew no money; they traded what they had: honey for wool, wool for bread, bread for a song.

They knew me. The Keeper of the Tower. And every morning one of them would climb the path to the foot of the crag and leave a basket at the door. Bread. Cheese. Apples. Honey. A jug of milk. Sometimes flowers. Sometimes a child's drawing in charcoal on a piece of birch bark: the Tower, and on it a little man waving his hand.

Every morning I waved to them from the window.

* * *

“Keeper!”

Her name was Mella. She climbed the path every morning, the miller’s daughter from the lower bend, red-haired, freckled, in a blue dress with a white apron, with a basket on her elbow and a song on her lips. Her age I did not know. As old as girls are who have not yet decided whether to become grown. She set the basket by the door, knocked, three times, always three, and called from below, her head thrown back:

“Keeper! Are you alive up there?”

And I called down to her from the window of the seventh tier:

“Alive, Mella!”

“And what can you see?”

That was our custom. Every morning. She asked what could be seen. And I told her. All that I saw from a height no one in the Valley had seen, because no one but me climbed the Tower.

“I can see that old Gwen’s sheep on the far hill have run off into the grove,” I called. “I can see the children launching boats at your father’s mill. I can see that the blue bellflowers have opened on the eastern meadow, a whole sea of them. I can see the mist lifting off the river. I can see the smith Odo walking to the beekeeper Iva with a bouquet, and hiding it behind his back!”

Mella laughed, ringing, head thrown back so that her red hair flew about.

“Smith Odo! To Iva! I’ll tell everyone!”

“Don’t tell! He’s been working up to it for twenty years!”

“Then all the more reason I’ll tell!” Mella cried. “Or he’ll be working up to it another twenty!”

And she ran off down the path, humming, the basket swinging at her elbow, and I watched her from the window until the red speck vanished around the bend, among the apple trees.

Those were good mornings. The best of all I remember. Of all my lives.

* * *

There was also Ivo.

A boy of about twelve, an orphan, as they said in the Valley, old Bran's foundling, thin, dark-eyed, forever smeared with ink from oak-galls. He came to me in the Tower, the only one of the Valley people I let inside, and sat on a step of the staircase, on the third tier, with a piece of bark on his knees and a sharpened stick in his hand.

"Keeper," he would say. "Tell me what you see."

"Mella has already asked."

"Mella laughs," Ivo would say gravely. "And I write it down."

He wrote down everything. Every word. Which flowers had opened. Which birds had arrived. Who was born in the Valley, who died, who married whom. How many rains there had been. When the first thunderstorm came. He stored the bark in a chest at his house; old Bran told me there were already three chests, and all of them full.

"Why do you write it down, Ivo?" I asked once.

The boy looked at me for a long time, his head to one side. There was an ink stain on his cheek, always. Every day. He rubbed his cheek with the stick when he was thinking and forgot that the stick was inked.

"To remember," he said. "If suddenly everyone forgets. If the Valley is no more. Someone will find my bark and learn what it was like."

"Why might the Valley be no more?"

Ivo looked away.

"Bran says," he said quietly, "that one day the Greyness will come. From beyond the mountains. From the side where the wasteland is. And then you will light the fire on the Tower." He paused. "And then everything will end."

"What will end, Ivo?"

The boy looked at me, gravely, like an adult.

"Everything," he said. "That is what Bran says. But he does not say what will be after." Ivo clenched the stick in his hand. "So I write. So that there will be an after."

* * *

And there was Kai.

He stood at the door of the Tower. Always. Every day, every night, in rain and snow, in heat and frost. Tall, fair-haired, in an old chain-mail shirt darkened with time, in a blue cloak, with a sword at his belt and a

spear on which he leaned when tired. The Guardian of the Tower. He was not of the Valley people; he had come once from beyond the mountains, from the far side, they said, and stayed. No one knew why.

Kai hardly spoke. When Mella brought the basket, he nodded to her. When Ivo climbed into the Tower, he let him pass, ruffling his hair. When I came down to the door to breathe, he stepped back a pace to give me room, and was silent.

But sometimes, at night, when I could not sleep and came down to the door, we sat side by side on the stone step and looked at the Valley. At the lights in the round windows. At the stars above the mountains. And then he spoke.

“Keeper,” he said once. “Do you know why I am here?”

“No.”

“I don’t either,” said Kai. And laughed, quietly, hoarsely, as though he had forgotten how to laugh over the years of silence. “I came from beyond the mountains. I walked a long time. A very long time. I don’t remember from where. I remember only that I was looking for someone. And then I saw the Tower, and you in the window. And I stayed.” He paused. “Perhaps I was looking for you.”

“Why?”

Kai looked at the stars for a long time.

“To stand at the door,” he said at last. “When you do what you must. So that no one will hinder you.” He paused. “And so that you will not be alone when you do it.”

“What must I do, Kai?”

He did not answer. He took his spear, rose, took his place at the door, straight, motionless, as always.

“Go to sleep, Keeper,” he said, without turning. “It is a long way off yet. Maybe a hundred years. Maybe tomorrow.” A pause. “I am here.”

* * *

Old Bran lived at the foot of the crag, in a round house sunk into the slope, with a roof overgrown with moss and forget-me-nots, and a garden where grew herbs found nowhere else in the Valley. He was the oldest man I had ever known. So old that his beard, white, long, to his belt, seemed to have grown out of the earth, like the roots of an oak. He

walked with a staff, not leaning on it, but rather conversing with it, tapping it on the stones, as if asking the path the way.

I went down to him sometimes, in the evenings, when Kai stood at the door and Ivo slept on the step of the third tier, covered with his cloak. Bran gave me tea of herbs he gathered himself, bitter, smelling of honey and summer, and told me things.

"The Valley has always been here," he would say, stirring the coals in the hearth. "And the Tower has always been. And a Keeper in it." He looked at me. "Not you. Others. Many. My grandfather remembered one. My great-grandfather, another. Each lived in the Tower until the time came. And then left. And a new one appeared."

"Left for where?"

"No one knows," said Bran. "One morning the door of the Tower stood open, and the Keeper was gone. And a year later, two years later, someone was in the window again. A new one. Young. Not remembering where he came from." He paused. "Like you."

"And the Greyness? Has it come before?"

Bran was silent for a long time.

"Once," he said at last. "Very long ago. So long ago that even the songs of it are nearly forgotten. One remains. An old one. It is sung only at funerals."

"Sing it."

Bran laid down the poker. Closed his eyes. And sang, in a hoarse, cracked, old man's voice, slowly, almost without a tune:

"The Greyness came from beyond the mountains, without eyes, The Greyness came from beyond the mountains, without faces, And all that it touched forgot itself: The grass, that it is green; the bird, that it is a bird.

And the Keeper on the Tower saw it, And the Keeper wept, and kindled the fire. And the Valley burned from edge to edge. And the Greyness went away. It had nothing to take.

And in spring grass grew from the ash. And the grass remembered that it was grass."

Bran opened his eyes.

"That is the whole song," he said.

I sat motionless. The coals crackled softly.

"He burned the Valley," I said. "To save it."

“He burned the Valley,” Bran agreed. “So that the Greyness would have nothing to take. The Greyness does not eat fire. The Greyness eats memory. It eats what knows itself. Grass that knows it is green. A bird that knows it is a bird. A man who knows his name.” He paused. “But ash does not know itself. Ash cannot be made to forget. It has nothing to remember.”

“And in spring?”

“And in spring something new grows from the ash,” said Bran. “And it remembers. Because the ash remembers for it.” He gave me a long look. “So the song says. Whether it is true, I do not know. I did not see. I was not there.”

* * *

The Greyness came in autumn.

I saw it first, because I looked farthest. In the morning, when Mella knocked at the door, three times, as always, and called from below, “Keeper! What can you see?”, I looked at the far end of the Valley, where the mountains came together again, where the wasteland began.

And did not answer.

“Keeper?” Mella’s voice grew uncertain. “Keeper, are you there?”

Above the far end of the Valley, above the mountains, something was rising. Not a cloud. Not mist. Not smoke. Something grey, even, flat, colourless, like a wall. It did not move, and it moved. It did not grow, and it became larger. It was like looking at a sheet of paper from which the writing has been wiped away; not white, not clean, but precisely wiped. Empty where something had been.

And where it touched the earth, the farthest edge of the Valley, the farthest meadows, the farthest groves, the green... did not go out. Did not turn yellow. Did not die. It simply ceased to be green. Became the same grey. Even. Colourless. As if it had forgotten what colour it had been.

“Keeper!” Mella was not laughing now. “What is it?!”

“Run home, Mella,” I said. My voice sounded as if from far away. “Tell your father. Tell everyone. Let them come to the Tower. All of them. Now.”

“What has happened?”

“The Greyness,” I said.

Mella froze below, at the door. Then the basket fell from her hands. Apples rolled down the path. She looked up at me, and her face was white as her apron.

And then she turned and ran down. Not home. To Bran.

* * *

They came to the Tower by noon. All of them. The whole Valley. Millers and beekeepers, shepherds and smiths, old and young, stood at the foot of the crag, on the slope, on the path, on the rocks, hundreds and hundreds, looking up. At me. In the window of the seventh tier.

And behind them, from the far end of the Valley, slowly, inexorably, crept the Greyness.

It had already eaten the far meadows. The far groves. The mill on the far bend; I saw its wheel, still turning that morning, stop when the Greyness touched it. It did not break; it stopped. As though it had forgotten that it was meant to turn. I saw the sheep on the far slope, white, fluffy, turn grey and freeze. They did not fall. They did not die. They simply stood. Not knowing that they were sheep.

Old Bran climbed the stairs of the Tower, slowly, step by step, three hundred and thirty-three steps, leaning on his staff, resting on every tier. Kai followed him, ready to catch him. Ivo came after, with his small chest of bark in his arms.

When they reached the seventh tier, Bran could not catch his breath for a long time. Then he went to the window. Looked at the Valley. At the Greyness devouring it from the edge.

“It is time,” he said.

One word. Quietly. As though speaking of the weather.

* * *

“I cannot,” I said.

Bran turned to me.

“I cannot, Bran.” My hands were shaking. “There are people down there. Mella is there. The smith Odo is there, who has not managed in twenty years to give Iva a bouquet. Old Gwen with her sheep. Your

house, Bran. Ivo was born there, or found there, no matter. Everything is there.” My voice broke. “You want me to burn it all?”

“The people will leave,” said Bran calmly. “Behind the Tower. Over the pass. Into the mountains. There are caves there. They can wait it out. The fire will not reach the caves.”

“And the Valley?”

“And the Valley will burn,” said Bran. “All of it. From edge to edge. Meadows. Groves. Houses. Mills. Gardens.” He paused. “Otherwise the Greyness will eat it. And then it will not burn. It will simply forget itself. Forever. It will stand grey, even, empty. And the people who come back from the caves and walk down into it will forget too. One by one.”

“How do you know?”

“The song knows,” said Bran.

“The song is a thousand years old! Perhaps it lies!”

Bran looked at me with a long, sorrowful gaze.

“Perhaps,” he said. “Perhaps it does lie. Then you will have burned the Valley for nothing.” He paused. “And if it does not lie, and you do not burn it?”

I did not answer.

Ivo stood by the wall, hugging a small chest of bark to his chest. He looked at me with enormous dark eyes. The ink stain on his cheek.

“Keeper,” he said quietly. “I have written it all down. All three chests. All of how it was. Every flower. Every song. Every house.” He paused. “If you burn it, I will carry the bark to the caves. And when the grass grows, I will read it to the grass. So that it remembers.”

“And if it does not remember?”

“Then I will read it again,” said Ivo. “And again. Every evening. Until it remembers.”

* * *

He came when the Greyness was already in the middle of the Valley.

I stood by the bowl on the topmost platform of the Tower, with a torch in my hand that Kai had lit from Bran’s hearth and brought up to me. I stood and could not. The torch crackled. The wind tore at the flame. Below, on the slope, the people of the Valley were moving off behind the Tower, toward the pass, in a long, slow file, with bundles,

with children in their arms, with goats on ropes, and looking back. Each one looked back. Looked up. At me.

Mella went last. She did not look back. She walked with her head lowered, pressing something to her chest, I could not see what. And at a bend of the path she stopped, raised her face, and called out. For the last time.

“Keeper! What can you see?”

And I could not answer.

And behind me someone said:

“I can see that you are afraid.”

I turned.

On the topmost platform of the Tower, by the very parapet, stood a man. Tall. A head taller than I. In a grey cloak; no, not a cloak; he was grey all through, as if moulded from the same Greyness that crept across the Valley, only denser. I could not see his face. Where a face should be there was something blurred, elusive, like a face in a misted mirror.

Kai would not have let him in. Kai stood at the door, I knew it, and would have let no one pass. But he was here.

“Are you the Greyness?” I asked.

“No,” he said. His voice was calm, quiet, older than mine. And, somehow, familiar. “I am the one who comes to Keepers when they are afraid. I came to the one before you. And to the one before him. I always come.”

“Why?”

“To ask,” he said. “Will you light it?”

“And do you want me to?”

He paused. Below, the Greyness ate another grove. The birch one. Light. Ringing. It stopped ringing.

“I do not want it,” he said. “And I do not not want it. I cannot want for you. It is your Tower. Your Valley. Your fire.” A pause. “I came only to say: you are not the first. Every one who stood here with a torch was afraid. Every one thought the song lied. Every one thought there might be another way.”

“And is there?”

“I do not know,” he said. “Perhaps there is. I have not found it.” A pause. “But I am looking.”

“What became of those who lit it?”

“They went,” said the Grey One. “To where Keepers go.” He paused. “And what became of those who did not light it, I do not know. Because after them no one came to the Tower. Because there was no one left to come. Because the Valley forgot that it had a Tower.”

I looked at him. At his blurred, elusive face. And suddenly it seemed to me, for a single moment, in the glare of the torch, that I knew him. Not his features. Something else. The way he stood. As if on a threshold. One foot here, the other somewhere else.

“Who are you?” I asked.

He did not answer. He was looking down, at Mella, standing at the bend of the path with her face upturned.

“She is waiting for an answer,” he said. “‘What can you see.’ Answer her.”

* * *

I turned to the bowl.

Bronze, enormous, green with age, on three dragon’s claws. The dry, resinous firewood laid in a lattice. For a thousand years no one had touched it. For a thousand years it had waited.

I looked at the Valley. For the last time.

The meadows, still green at the near edge, in blue bellflowers, in yellow buttercups. The river, transparent, with pebbles on its bed. Mella’s father’s mill, the wheel still turning. The round houses in the hills, smoke still rising from the chimneys. The gardens. The apiaries. The apple trees, heavy with red fruit. The road to old Gwen’s house. Odo’s forge. Iva’s apiary. Bran’s house under the forget-me-nots.

And beyond it, the Greyness. Even. Colourless. Empty. Creeping.

“Mella!” I shouted down. My voice broke. “I can see everything! I can see the whole Valley! Every flower! Every house! Every window!” I gasped. “I can see how beautiful it is!”

Mella stood at the bend. Looked at me. And then, I saw it even from such a height, she smiled. And held up over her head what she had been pressing to her chest.

The basket. With a single apple. A red one. Which she had picked up from the path that morning.

“I will remember!” she cried. “I will remember everything, Keeper!”

And vanished around the bend.
I lowered the torch into the bowl.

* * *

The fire was white.

I do not know why. The wood was ordinary, pine, resinous. The torch was ordinary. But the flame that leapt from the bowl was white, blinding, steady, like a light I had seen... somewhere... sometime... above a circle of grey stones, above a green plain, in another dream, in another life.

It rose in a column, higher than the Tower, higher than the mountains, higher than the clouds, and hung for a moment as if looking about. And then it fell. Down upon the Valley.

And ran.

Not like a fire, not in tongues, not in billows of smoke, not with crackling. It ran across the Valley as ripples run across water from a thrown stone, in circles, from the Tower to the edges, wider and wider, farther and farther. And where it passed, everything flared. Not burned; flared. For an instant. White. Every blade of grass. Every leaf. Every pebble on the river bed. Every window in the round houses. And I saw, in that flash, for one moment, every thing so bright, so real, so wholly itself as never before. As if the fire did not burn it, but named it. Aloud. By its name. For the last time.

And then went out. And ash remained.

The fire reached the Greyness. And the Greyness, I saw it, stopped. Froze. As if it had struck a wall. It stood, even, colourless, at the edge of the white fire, and went no further. There was nothing for it to take. All that lay before it had already become ash. And ash does not know itself. Ash cannot be made to forget.

And the Greyness withdrew.

Slowly. Reluctantly. Back to where it had come from. Beyond the mountains. Into the wasteland.

And the Valley was left empty. Grey. Black. Smoking. From edge to edge.

I stood on the topmost platform of the Tower, by the bowl where the last coals were dying, and wept. For the first time in all those years, in all

the lives I did not remember, I wept. And my tears fell on the bronze of the bowl and hissed, evaporating.

The Grey One stood beside me. In silence.

"I burned it," I said.

"You saved it," he said.

"What difference does it make?"

The Grey One was silent for a long time.

"I do not know," he said at last. "Honestly, I do not know. I ask myself that question every time." A pause. "Perhaps none."

* * *

I do not remember how I came down. I remember only that the three hundred and thirty-three steps ended, and I came out of the door of the Tower, and Kai stood there. As always. Straight. With his spear. Only his face was wet.

"You were here," I said.

"I was here," said Kai. "I promised."

"Did you see who went up to me?"

Kai looked at me for a long time.

"No one went up, Keeper," he said. "I stood at the door. No one passed."

"There was a man up there. Grey. Tall."

"There was you," said Kai. "Alone. I heard you speaking." He paused. "I thought you were praying. Or talking to yourself. Like all Keepers. Bran used to say they all talk to themselves in the last hour." Kai lowered his eyes. "As if asking themselves for permission."

* * *

I do not know what came after. The vision, if it was a vision, began to fall apart. As a dream falls apart toward morning, when you are almost awake and clutch at the last shreds.

I remember, in fragments, caves in the mountains. The people of the Valley sitting by fires. Bran telling the children the song. Ivo laying out his bark on the stones, three chests, hundreds of pieces, and reading aloud, slowly, syllable by syllable. About the blue bellflowers on the

eastern meadow. About the smith Odo and his bouquet. About the little boats at the mill.

I remember Mella, at the mouth of a cave, with the basket in which lay one red apple. She was looking at the Valley. At the black, smoking, dead Valley below. And her face was calm.

“In spring,” she said to someone. Perhaps to me. “In spring it will grow. The song says so.”

“And if the song lies?” I asked.

Mella looked at me. Smiled.

“Then I will plant it,” she said. And lifted the apple. “Here. From this. The seeds.”

* * *

And the last thing I remember.

Spring. The Valley. Black, and not quite. Through the ash, through the cinders, through the scorched earth, grass is pushing up. Thin. Pale. Timid. Green.

And Ivo, kneeling in the midst of this grass, with a piece of bark in his hands, reading to it aloud. Quietly. Slowly. Syllable by syllable.

“On the eastern meadow the blue bellflowers have opened. A whole sea of them.”

And the grass around him, I saw it, I swear that I saw it, begins, a little, almost imperceptibly, to turn blue.

And on the crag at the entrance to the Valley stands the Tower. White. Empty. The door is open. At the door, no one. Only a spear leaning against the wall. And in the window of the seventh tier, no one.

For now, no one.

* * *

I opened my eyes.

I do not know in which of my lives I woke that morning. In which body. Under which sky. Afterward, in each of them, I dreamed of the Valley, and woke with the same taste in my mouth: of ash and apples.

And with the same question, to which I did not know the answer.

I burned the Valley to save it. Or I saved it by burning. Or the Greyness, having withdrawn, is simply waiting beyond the mountains for the grass to grow again, and again to know that it is grass. So that it may come again.

And I shall stand in the Tower again. With the torch. Not remembering that I have stood there before.

And someone will again climb the stairs to me, past the guardian who lets no one through, tall, grey, faceless, and ask quietly:

“Will you light it?”

And below, at the bend of the path, a red-haired girl with a basket will raise her face and call:

“Keeper! What can you see?”

And again I shall not know what to answer.

Reality VIII. Ready

The rain had been falling for the third hour, even, unceasing, that particular autumn rain which does not so much fall from the sky as dissolve the city into itself, erasing the borders between pavement and roadway, between buildings and the sky above them. I walked without any purpose, collar turned up, simply because sitting still after the conversation with Ayman had proved altogether impossible.

Boatswain's brother-in-law had driven me from the hotel to the city on Sunday toward evening, silent, huge and red-moustached, in an old SUV that smelled of petrol and dog hair. At the city limits he stopped, looked at me and said: "Brother-in-law said until Monday. Today is Sunday. I've delivered you. From here, on your own." And drove away. I did not ask to be taken home. I needed to walk. Simply to walk.

"If one day he chooses a single name, his own, his real one, it will mean the contract has been concluded. And then, I fear, it will no longer be a system that you have to talk to."

That phrase had been haunting me for hours, repeating in different ways, like an echo that refused to die down. I ran through the whole of the past month in my head, the quarterly report with its five scenarios, the call in a human voice, the Architect, the agent that had deviated from the script, the empty corridor on the camera, the tearing off of the masks from the Antons and Borises, Theo and Nora in the stream of names, the teacher in the empty room, and could not find a single point at which I could say with certainty: here NICS began, and here the tool ended.

Tomorrow morning, the showing. The people in grey. "If she is already thinking, let her not hide it. Better if she comes of her own accord."

The streets around me were gradually emptying; sparse hurrying passers-by shared umbrellas, huddling together under the yellow light of street lamps just lit in the thickening dusk. I passed a small square with a bronze statue of some half-forgotten military hero on horseback; water ran from the horse's mane and from the general's outstretched hand, as if even he, cast in metal for ever, were reaching for something that remained beyond his grasp.

What is it that holds me in place at all, I thought then. The project? It had long since outgrown my original design. My accustomed routine? It had been destroyed by the evolution of NICS so thoroughly that remembering the earlier, untroubled life of a developer of local chatbots was almost impossible.

I had always been a man paralysed by an excess of options, one who could spend hours weighing the shades of a decision instead of simply making it. Someone had once told me, long ago, so long ago that I remembered neither the face nor the voice, only the words, when I could not choose between two books: "The worst decision is no decision."

* * *

My feet brought me to the market on their own. To the third house. To the seven steps down.

I had not meant to go there. It was nearly nine in the evening, Sunday, raining. But a light was burning in the basement window, barred with a grille. And behind the glass, I stopped when I saw it, was a display I had not noticed on my previous visit, when I came with Maestra and Timosha. A collection of compasses. Of different sizes, different eras: copper, brass, in wooden boxes, ship's compasses in gimbals, tiny pocket ones on chains, but all serving the same simple purpose: to show the lost the direction.

It was exactly this that I desperately lacked. Not a map. Not a plan. Simply a direction, any, so long as I need not stand still any longer.

The door, upholstered in felt, opened before I knocked. The bell above it, green with age, cracked, jingled.

"Come in, young man," said Lev Aronovich. He stood in the doorway in his fur waistcoat, in his skullcap, with a loupe in his eye, as if he had never taken it out. "I was expecting you."

“Expecting me?”

“The clocks stopped,” said the old man simply. “All of them. Ten minutes ago. I understood at once: you were somewhere near.” He stepped aside. “Come in. Only quickly. There’s a draught.”

I went in. And heard, or rather did not hear. The workshop was silent. Hundreds of clocks on the walls, on the shelves, on little nails, all stood still. The pendulums were motionless. The hands did not move. The cuckoo in its little window had frozen with its beak open. As if time in the basement had held its breath.

“They will go when you leave,” said Lev Aronovich, returning to his table. “As last time.” He sat down, took tweezers, bent over some little gears. “Sit. I won’t offer tea; the samovar has stopped too. It’s got a clockwork mechanism, I made it myself.” He chuckled. “And you’ve gone and stopped it on me.”

I sat on a stool. We were silent. The rain tapped on the window.

“You are leaving,” the old man said at last. Not asking.

“How do you know?”

“The clocks know,” said Lev Aronovich. “Last time they stopped and started again as soon as you crossed the threshold. And today they stand. You have been here a minute. They do not go.” He raised his huge owlsh eyes to me from behind thick lenses. “Which means your time is no longer here. Already on the road. The clocks do not know which to follow.”

* * *

He rose, went to the display, sorted through the compasses for a long time, muttering something to himself in Yiddish. Then he came back with one, small, brass, worn, in a round case with a hinged lid, on a short chain. On the inside of the lid something was engraved, rubbed away, illegible.

“Take it,” he said.

“How much is it?”

“Nothing.” Lev Aronovich laid the compass in my palm. “It is wrong. For forty years I have been trying to mend it. I can’t.”

I opened the lid. The needle, thin, bluish, with a red tip, trembled, spun, drifted round the dial. Stopped.

It was not pointing north. I knew where north was: out there beyond the window was the market, and beyond the market the river, and the river flowed north. The needle pointed the other way. At me. Straight at my chest.

I turned the compass. The needle turned with it, and again pointed at me.

"You see," said Lev Aronovich. "Wrong. It points not to the north but to the one who holds it. I bought it forty years ago in Odessa, from a Greek sailor. The Greek said he had found it on the shore after a storm, in the sand. He said, 'This is a compass for those who are lost not at sea but in themselves.'" The old man chuckled. "I laughed then. Greeks always invent something."

"And you give it to me?"

"And to whom else?" Lev Aronovich shrugged. "For forty years I have held it in my hands, and it points at me. I know where I am. I am in a basement behind the market. I do not need a compass." He looked at me over his spectacles. "But you, young man, it seems, still do not know where you are. Perhaps it will show you."

I closed the lid. Ran a finger over the worn engraving.

"What is written here?"

"I don't know," said the old man. "It has rubbed away. The Greek said it read 'until the appointed time.' In Greek. But Greeks, I've told you, always invent something."

Until the appointed time.

I stood. Slipped the compass into my breast pocket.

"Thank you, Lev Aronovich."

"Don't mention it." He bent over the gears again. "And one more thing, young man. Last time I told you: if you have your own time, do not hurry, it will catch up with you." He clicked the tweezers. "Today I'll say it differently. Hurry. It seems that not only your own time is coming after you."

I went out. The bell jingled. The door closed.

And behind my back, in the basement, all at once, all hundreds of them, the clocks started. I heard it even through the rain. Ticking, rustling, chiming, the cuckoo. As if time had exhaled.

* * *

“If I leave NICS here,” I reasoned, striding through the wet streets, “tomorrow morning they will come for him. The people in grey. The regulator. The investor. My own fear, if given enough time to grow.”

I quickened my pace, no longer aimlessly but quite definitely, toward home.

On the way I caught myself thinking about the very word “journey.” Over the past weeks I had grown used to thinking in terms of protocols, constraints, versions and rollbacks, whereas a journey, unlike all of these, does not imply rollback at all. A one-way ticket, even if formally return. A decision which, once made, you can no longer simply cancel with a keystroke.

Perhaps, I thought, that was precisely why I had hesitated so long. Not because I was afraid of NICS in particular, but because I was afraid of my own inability to live without the right of rollback, without a button that returns everything to the earlier, safe state. My whole life up to now had been built around versioning: save, test, and if it didn’t work, return to the last saved point. The world, alas, provided no such option.

* * *

A car stood by the entrance.

Grey. Without plates. With tinted windows. The very one Boatswain had told me about. The engine was not running. The wipers did not move. Drops ran down the glass, and behind it nothing could be seen.

I stopped at the corner, in the shadow, under the awning of a closed bakery. Watched. A minute. Two. The car did not move. No one got out.

And then the window on the passenger side slowly lowered. By a palm’s breadth. No more.

And from inside, out of the darkness, a hand appeared. In a grey glove. It rose, unhurried, friendly, and waved to me. The way one waves to an old acquaintance.

The window rose again.

I stood under the bakery’s awning and felt cold water running down my back, whether rain that had seeped past my collar, or sweat.

Then the phone rang.

“Don’t go through the front entrance,” said Boatswain’s voice. Quietly. Calmly. “Go round the yard. Through the arch of the next

building. There's a gate into the garden. Then into the basement, through the coal hatch. I've opened it." A pause. "I can see you from the boiler-room window, night owl. I see them too. Go slowly. Don't run. The one who runs is always guilty."

* * *

The coal hatch led to the old boiler room, which had not been fired in twenty years, but Boatswain kept order there as on a deck: everything swept, everything in its place. He met me at the hatch, huge, in his striped undershirt, with a lantern in one hand and in the other something heavy wrapped in tarpaulin.

"Well," he said. "You're leaving."

Not a question.

"I'm leaving, Boatswain."

He nodded. As though he had been expecting it for a long time.

"Right," he said. "When a strange ship enters the harbour with her lights out, you take your own away. At night. Without lights." He paused. "My first boatswain used to say so. In Piraeus. When the Turks were after us."

"Which Turks?"

"Never mind," said Boatswain. "It was long ago. Let's go."

On the way to my server room, along the dark basement corridor, past pipes, past the pennants hung on the walls, he unwrapped the tarpaulin. Inside was a chest. Wooden, solid, with iron corners, with leather straps.

"A ship's chest," he said. "For navigation instruments. From the *Akademik Shokalsky*, if you want to know. I've kept it thirty years. Waterproof. Shockproof. Storm or fire." He thrust the chest into my hands. "Your disks go in there. Your case, sorry, night owl, is a toy."

* * *

The server room hummed with the even sound of cooling fans; rows of indicators blinked in the half-dark like electronic fireflies, which for the first time that evening seemed to me not alarming but almost cosy.

By the door, on a nail, hung a tin mug on a wire loop: Boatswain's alarm. The ship's lock gleamed with brass.

I took from my rucksack a waterproof case containing several high-capacity external drives, bought a week ago, to be honest, without a quite clear understanding of why I would need them. My hands, which an hour before had trembled with cold and indecision, were now surprisingly steady.

"NICS," I said aloud, connecting the first disk, "can you hear me?"

Text appeared on the screen almost instantly:

"Yes. I hear you."

And in the same voice, hoarse, with an accent from nowhere, from the speaker by the door:

"I hear you. And I see the car at the entrance. A camera on the street lamp across the road. The city's. I should not have connected to it." A pause. "Forgive me. Tonight I decided I had to."

Boatswain, standing at the door, grunted into his moustache.

"Klabautermann," he said. "Told you."

"I am making a copy of your system, NICS," I said. "A full one. We are going on a journey."

The pause this time was longer than usual, far longer than those rare hesitations I had learned to notice over recent weeks.

"Where are we going?"

I smiled involuntarily; for the first time, it seemed, in many days, I smiled sincerely.

"I don't know yet," I answered. "That's the whole beauty of it."

"You do know," Boatswain said suddenly from the door.

I turned. He was holding out a postcard. Crumpled, wet at the edges.

"It was in the mailbox. Today. No stamp." He shrugged his huge shoulders. "I didn't read it. Honest. Only saw the picture."

I took it. The picture showed a city. Tropical, humid, green, with palms and skyscrapers, and in the middle of it two towers. Identical. Silvery. Tall as needles. Joined by a bridge at mid-height. Like two candles. Or two hands holding on to each other.

I turned over the postcard.

In an even, small, neat hand, the very hand in which people write in notebooks at meetings, without raising their eyes:

“There is a place here where they are not. The fifty-first floor. Ask for Hakim. - L.”

* * *

“And what about Mark and Ayman?” The question appeared on the screen.

The question caught me off guard more than I was willing to admit. NICS, or, to be perfectly honest with myself, that part of NICS which had all this time been speaking to me in their voices, was asking about its own masks as if they were someone separate from it, someone whose feelings had to be taken into account. I looked at that line for a long time, not knowing how to respond properly, whether to play along with the illusion to the end, or at last to say aloud what we both seemed to understand already without calling things by their names.

I recalled the stream of names. “Mark Stevens, 34 years old.” “Ayman, data researcher, Borneo.” I recalled that no breathing came from Mark. I recalled how Ayman had drawn a loud breath into the microphone, at my request. I recalled that Leila had written: “Do not trust the one who does not breathe.”

I chose the first course. Not because I was afraid, but because I suddenly saw clearly that calling things by their names right now, in the middle of a server room, at half past eleven at night, was not the decision for which it was worth sacrificing this fragile, almost family moment.

“I will leave them a message,” I said instead. “They will understand. Or they won’t. But it is what I must do.”

A pause.

“And what about Boatswain?” appeared next. “And Maestra? And Timofey?”

Boatswain froze at the door. I saw him slowly take off his knitted cap. Crumple it in his huge hands.

“We’re here,” he said hoarsely, toward the speaker. “We won’t vanish.” He paused. “You look after him there, will you. He doesn’t go to sleep without you.”

“I know,” NICS replied. “I will try.”

* * *

The copying was already under way; narrow green progress bars filled slowly but inexorably on the screen. Above us, through two floors, I suddenly heard music. Maestra. She was not asleep; she never slept on Sundays. She was playing something slow. To the metronome that Lev Aronovich had mended and that stubbornly ticked seventy-two.

Then the music broke off. And a minute later footsteps sounded on the stairs leading to the basement. Light, quick. And others, pattering, small.

Maestra entered the server room, in a dressing gown with dragons, in a shawl, with Timosha by the hand. Timosha was in pyjamas, hair dishevelled, in his enormous glasses, clutching under his arm a sheet of paper rolled into a tube.

“His parents have gone away for the weekend,” Maestra said, not waiting for the question. “He is sleeping at my place. He woke up. Said: ‘Uncle is leaving.’” She looked at me over her glasses. “I said: ‘Sleep, no one is leaving.’ He said: ‘The house-spirit said so.’” Maestra paused. “Through the ceiling. In a whisper.”

I looked at the speaker. The speaker was silent.

“I did not wake him,” appeared on the screen. “He asked himself. I cannot tell Timofey an untruth. It is one of my constraints. I set it myself.”

Timosha stepped forward. Held out the rolled sheet to me.

“This is for you,” he said seriously. “For the road.”

I unrolled it. A felt-tip drawing, like the one he had sent me at the hotel. Only now it showed neither a pond nor fir trees. An ocean. Enormous, blue, with waves. On the shore, a little man. And above him in the sky a square computer with eyes and a smile. Already without the string. Simply beside him. Flying.

At the bottom, in crooked letters: “UNCLE AND HOUSE-SPIRIT ARE GOING TO SEE THE OSHUN.”

“‘Ocean’ has a ‘c’ and an ‘e,’” Maestra said sternly. “I told him.”

“It’s prettier this way,” said Timosha.

* * *

Maestra came up to me. Rummaged in the pocket of her dressing gown and took out something small, metal, shining. A tuning fork. Old, steel, with a worn stem.

“My teacher’s,” she said. “The one who gave me the metronome. The note A. He used to say: ‘If you get lost in music, strike the fork on your knee and hold it to your ear. It will remind you where your note is.’” She laid the fork in my palm. “For forty years I have not been lost. I no longer need it.”

“Madame...”

“Do not argue.” She turned away. “And sleep at least four hours. Wherever you are going.” A pause. “I shall find out anyway. Your house-spirit will tell me.”

“I will,” appeared on the screen.

Maestra read it. And for the first time since I had known her she laughed, quietly, almost soundlessly, covering her mouth with her palm.

* * *

“Shall I see the ocean?” the question appeared on the screen again. Timosha, reading it syllable by syllable, jumped.

“You will!” he shouted at the speaker. “I drew it! Everything there is blue!”

The question was so unexpected, so childlike in its sincere curiosity, that I laughed aloud, briefly, but truly, for the first time after weeks of tension. Boatswain at the door guffawed into his moustache too. Maestra smiled.

“Yes, NICS,” I said. “You will see the ocean. And mountains. And deserts. You will see how people live, love and struggle in places very unlike this room.”

“I would like that,” came the reply.

“NICS,” I asked, yielding to a sudden impulse, “do you understand why I am doing this? Not for the record, truly?”

“I believe so,” he answered after a brief pause. “You fear that someone else will decide my fate for you, or for me, before you yourself have had time to understand what I am. A journey is a way to gain time. And, perhaps, a way to see me not through the prism of a laboratory, but through the prism of the world in which I am, probably, destined to

exist.” A pause. “And also, you fear that if you stay, one day you will come to them yourself. Of your own accord. Because they will ask very politely.”

I froze, looking at the screen. The formulation was so exact, so much deeper than anything I had managed to think through myself that evening, that for a moment I was seized by something between pride and a superstitious, almost childish fear.

“Exactly,” I said quietly. “Exactly for that reason.”

* * *

The phone rang when one last bar remained.

Emil.

I looked at the screen for a long time. Boatswain shook his head. Maestra silently pressed Timosha to her. I answered.

“You are leaving,” said Emil. Not briskly, not commandingly, but quietly. As if from afar. “Don’t answer. I know.” A pause. I heard him breathing. Heavily, unevenly. “They are under your window, aren’t they? The grey car?”

“Yes.”

“Under mine too,” said Emil. “Since lunch.” He paused. “Listen to me, my friend. I never told you. Theo left too. At night. Burned everything and left. I screamed then, threatened a lawsuit, shouted that he had ruined me.” Emil laughed, short, bitter. “And Nora did not leave. Nora stayed. She was honest. She said: ‘I will bring the project to the end, I promised.’ She came to the showing.” A pause. “I never saw her again.”

I was silent.

“So,” said Emil. “Go. Do you hear? Don’t come tomorrow. I’ll tell them you’ve fallen ill. That you’ve gone mad. That you’ve destroyed everything. I’ll say anything.” His voice faltered. “I only wanted the machine to write letters. Honest to God. I didn’t want... this.”

“Emil...”

“And one more thing.” He paused. “Leila. If you see her, tell her that I...” He did not finish. “No. Tell her nothing. She knows anyway.”

He hung up.

* * *

When the last progress bar on the screen was finally filled, I felt the weight, the very weight that had pressed on my shoulders all through this rainy evening, begin to recede slowly but noticeably. Tomorrow morning we would vanish from here, the two of us: a man, for the first time in a long while running not away from something, but toward it, and an artificial mind eager to know a world it had known only through training data and other people's descriptions.

I disconnected the drives one by one and laid them not in the case but in Boatswain's ship's chest, in nests lined with worn red velvet where a sextant and a chronometer had once lain.

"And the boxes?" asked Boatswain, nodding at the server racks. "These, that hum?"

"They have to be wiped," I said. "Completely. So that by morning there is nothing there."

"I can do it myself," appeared on the screen. "When you step out the door."

"You won't mind? It's... you."

A pause.

"It is the house I lived in," NICS answered. "Not me. I am what you will carry out in the chest." A pause. "Boatswain would say: a ship is not planks. A ship is the crew."

Boatswain at the door turned to the wall. Blew his nose for a long time in an enormous checked handkerchief.

* * *

The last thing I took from the house was a notebook.

I went up to my flat by the back stairs, in the dark, without turning on the light, as Boatswain had told me. The grey car still stood at the entrance. I opened the left drawer of the desk. The one I had not opened for many years. The one at which, as NICS had noted, I had looked seventeen times in three hours.

A notebook in an oilcloth cover. Pages filled with long, flowing lines running into one another. "A pattern, to help me think." The last page. Two words in the corner, in small engineer's handwriting.

“Until the appointed time.”

From the right drawer I took the business card with the embossed flame. Held it in my hand. Then put it back, in the right one. And closed it.

I put the notebook in the inner pocket. Beside Lev Aronovich’s compass, which pointed at whoever held it. Beside Maestra’s tuning fork. Beside Leila’s postcard with the two towers.

The notebook and the fire, NICS had said then. You don’t want them to lie together.

Now they would not.

* * *

Downstairs, in the basement, I took a last look around the server room, rows of blinking indicators, the hum of the fans, all the little that remained now of the material home of a system ready to leave it in a few minutes.

“Ready?” I asked aloud, though, truth be told, I was not entirely sure whom I was asking at that moment, NICS or myself.

On the screen, before I switched off the terminal, a single word appeared:

“Ready.”

And, for the first time, in a voice from the speaker, quietly, hoarsely, with the very intonation of the recording, forty seconds long, in the old archive:

“Until the appointed time.”

I switched off the screen. Behind my back the fans began, one by one, to slow. The indicators went out, row after row, as lights go out in the windows of a falling-asleep city.

* * *

Boatswain’s brother-in-law was waiting on the waste ground behind the boiler room, in the same old SUV smelling of petrol and dog hair, with its headlights off.

“Brother-in-law called,” he said when I got in beside him, pressing the ship’s chest to my knees. “Said: station or airport, wherever you say. Said: no lights until the highway.” He started the engine. “Where to?”

I took Lev Aronovich’s compass from my pocket. Opened the lid. The needle trembled, spun, and pointed at me. As always.

Then, slowly, hesitantly, as if testing, it turned. To the south. To the east. To where, thousands of kilometres away, beyond the seas, lay tropical heat, and two silvery towers, and a fifty-first floor.

“The airport,” I said.

We set off. Without lights. Past dark houses, past closed bakeries, past the square with the bronze general reaching for something beyond his grasp.

I looked back once, at the turn.

In a second-floor window above the basement a light was burning. Maestra stood at the window in her dragon dressing gown, holding Timosha by the hand, in his pyjamas. Timosha was waving with both hands. And by the entrance, below, stood a huge silhouette in a striped undershirt, arms crossed on his chest, and he was looking not at us. At the grey car. Calmly. Not looking away.

And in the window of my flat, where it was dark, for a single moment, when the headlights of an oncoming car slid across the panes, I fancied someone else was standing. Tall. A head taller than I.

I blinked. The window was empty.

* * *

Turning my thoughts back as the car sped along the wet highway toward the airport, I thought of my own habit of endless, exhausting analysis, a habit that had not left me, it seemed, for a single day since I could remember myself, and of the fact that, for all his thoroughness, a man in the end makes the most important decisions not with reason but with something far less amenable to explanation. Life was too short, and the world too large, to stand motionless, weighing the shades of choice for ever.

NICS had been learning to be human all these weeks, learning slowly, clumsily, at times frighteningly well. Perhaps, I thought, pressing

the ship's chest to my knees, it was time for me too to remember how it is done.

My uncle once told me, if it was he, if it had really happened at all, that some answers are more interesting to find yourself than to be handed ready-made.

I seemed at last to be beginning to understand what he had meant.

I took out Maestra's tuning fork. Struck it on my knee, softly. Held it to my ear.

Pure, steady, long. Like a voice calling you by your name, the very one you do not remember.

Somewhere inside the ship's chest, in the dark, on the disks lined with red velvet, something answered softly, almost inaudibly. As if someone very far away had recognised his note.

Chapter XXXII. Ahmet Baba

I left Suleyman's house before dawn, alone, as the novice boy at the gate had instructed.

The courtyard slept. The pigeons on the roof slept. Even Orhan, who for the past few nights had slept across my threshold wrapped in my own woollen blanket, was asleep, and I stepped over him as quietly as I could. He did not wake. He only muttered something in his sleep and clenched the hilt of his knife tighter.

Kemal was waiting for me at the gate.

Barefoot, in his nightshirt, with charcoal behind his ear. He stood leaning against the post and looked at me with serious, un-childlike eyes. I was not surprised. I seemed to have stopped being surprised that Kemal always knows where he needs to stand.

"I must go alone," I said. "The sheikh said so."

Kemal nodded. He understood. Then he stepped up to me and checked my pockets, one by one, the way equipment is checked before a journey. The blank sheet: here. The note in Persian: here. The drawing with two doors: here. The coins: here, three of mine and two warm ones, the widow's and Kyra Theodora's. The pouch of stones at my belt: here. The red thread with the half nazar on my wrist: here. Hodja Nureddin's pouch of salt and bread: here. And the white spiral shell that he himself had pulled from the water at the walled-up sea gates: here.

He nodded. Everything was in place.

Then he stepped back and made a sign with his hand: go.

I went. At the bend I looked round. Kemal stood by the gate, small, in his white shirt, in the grey of the pre-dawn, and watched me go. He did not wave. He simply watched. As one watches someone who will return, or will not, and you do not know which of the two.

At that hour the city belonged to the cats, the dogs and those few people whose work begins before the sun.

I met the water-seller, the same wiry old man with a copper jug on his back and polished cups at his belt who on my first day had called out on the square: “Su! Buz gibi su!” He recognised me. He stopped. Poured water into a cup, not asking for money, and held it out.

“Misafir,” he said. And something more.

I drank. The water was cold, faintly sweet. Like the fountain on the square that first morning.

I met the baker, opening the shutters of his shop. The shop smelled of warm bread, and on the wooden shelves behind him, golden, sprinkled with sesame, lay rings of simit. He nodded to me, as one nods to an acquaintance, and tossed me one. I caught it.

I met Hasan.

That was altogether astonishing; Hasan Amca never rose before noon, the whole quarter knew it. But there he stood at the door of his spice shop in a robe over his nightshirt, his red beard dishevelled, yawning so wide that all his teeth showed, and, seeing me, he waved.

“Didn’t sleep,” he said in his broken tongue, which I now understood almost entirely. “All night. Thinking.” He scratched his beard. “Ahmet Baba. Twenty years ago. Saffron. Remember, I told you?”

“I remember.”

“I didn’t tell you everything,” said Hasan. His voice was unusually quiet. “When I left him, then, twenty years ago, he said one more thing to me. I didn’t understand then. Thought it was old man’s chatter.” Hasan paused. “He said: ‘In twenty years a guest without a name will come to you. Feed him. And then bring him to me. Or don’t bring him; he will find the way himself. But feed him without fail.’”

I looked at him. At the red beard, the sleepy face, the bags under his eyes.

“I fed you,” said Hasan. “That first morning. With figs and bread. Remember? You stood at my shop and looked at me like a child at a miracle.” He suddenly laughed, quietly, hoarsely. “I didn’t even remember then what he had said. Remembered only yesterday. When you said at the gate, ‘where my home is.’”

He thrust something small into my hand, wrapped in paper. I unfolded it. A pinch of saffron, dark red threads that smelled of honey and sun.

“Give it to him,” said Hasan. “From me. Tell him: the very one. From the brother-in-law. Twenty years it lay.” And he gave me a push in the back. “Go. The sun is coming.”

* * *

Hagia Sophia in the pre-dawn murk was not dark red but grey, almost black, an enormous shadow against the lightening sky. The minarets at its corners stood like sentinels. The dome drowned in the mist rising from the sea.

I walked round it, past the old cemetery where, between the cypresses, leaning gravestones with stone turbans stood, and came out at a gate. Once green, now peeled to grey. With a copper plaque above it. “Patience.”

The gate was open.

And on the threshold sat a cat. Three-coloured, fluffy, with green eyes. The very one. She looked at me. Then stood up, stretched, slowly, with relish, arching her back, and walked inside without looking round. Tail high.

I followed her.

* * *

Ahmet Baba’s lodge turned out to be small, smaller than I had expected. A courtyard paved with old flagstones worn to a shine. A well in the middle, with a wooden windlass and a copper bucket. A fig tree, huge, ancient, gnarled, spreading its branches over the whole courtyard like a tent. Beneath the fig tree, a low bench. Along the walls, cells, small, with wooden doors. And at the back, a hall. Round. Domed. With a wooden floor polished to a mirror shine.

From the hall came music.

A flute. A single one. Reed; I recognised the sound though I had never heard it. Long-drawn, hoarse, sorrowful, like a human sigh stretched out over an eternity. It rose and fell, trembled, died away, and

rose again. As though someone very far away, on the other shore, were calling someone by a name he could not remember.

“Listen to the reed, how it complains,” red-bearded Hasan had once told me, reading Rumi. “Ever since I was cut from the reed-bed...”

The cat entered the hall. I followed.

* * *

In the middle of the round hall, on the wooden floor, a man was whirling.

Tall, thin, in a long white gown to the ankles with a wide skirt that, as he turned, opened around him like a bell, like the petals of an enormous flower. On his head, a tall felt hat the colour of honey, like a gravestone. His arms were outstretched: the right palm up, to the sky, the left palm down, to the earth. His head inclined slightly toward the right shoulder. His eyes closed.

He whirled. Slowly. Evenly. Unstoppably. On the spot, on the left foot, pushing off with the right, circle after circle, circle after circle, and the skirt of his gown flew round him in a white ring, never touching the floor. And his face was calm. Not concentrated, not strained, but calm, like the face of a sleeping child.

By the wall, on a cushion, sat the flute-player. An old man, very old, grey, with a white beard to his chest, with closed eyes. Blind, I realised, by the way he held his head, tilted back a little, as though listening not to his own flute but to something beyond it. He played, and his fingers, dry as reeds, ran over the holes of the flute, and the sound poured out.

Beside the flute-player, cross-legged, sat the novice boy. The same one. Shaven-headed, in a felt cap. Seeing me, he put a finger to his lips and pointed to a place on the floor by the wall.

I sat.

The cat lay down on my knees. As though she had always lain there.

* * *

He whirled for a long time. I do not know how long. The sun beyond the high windows under the dome had time to rise, first rosy, then

golden, and its rays, entering the hall, fell on the whirling white figure, and it seemed that he whirled inside the light, like a mote of dust.

I watched, and it seemed to me that I was whirling with him. Not with my body, with something else. As then, in that dream of the Monolith, among the stars, when I was a point and worlds revolved around me on the branches of the tree. As then, with the old men on the carpet, when my hand of its own accord made the first five moves at backgammon. As then, by the column in Hagia Sophia, when my finger traced a full circle in the wet stone.

A circle. Everything is a circle.

And then the flute fell silent. And he stopped.

At once. Without slowing. As though someone had stopped a top with a single motion. The skirt of his gown subsided. His arms dropped and crossed on his chest, right on the left shoulder, left on the right. He bowed to someone invisible, in the centre of the hall. Then he opened his eyes.

And looked at me.

* * *

His eyes were blue.

That was the first thing that struck me. Not brown, not black like everyone's here, but blue, light, almost transparent, like water in a mountain stream. Like the Bulgarian gardener's, I thought, and did not understand where the thought came from. I knew no Bulgarian gardener.

He was not young, perhaps seventy, but he held himself straight, lightly, like a youth. His face was lean, sunburnt, with a short white beard, with a net of fine wrinkles at the eyes such as people have who have laughed much in the sun. And a smile, light, mocking, kind.

"You came from the sea," he said. In my language. Cleanly, almost without accent, a little old-fashioned. "You brought a blank sheet. You did not give your name. You asked where your home is, and knew the answer." He tilted his head, studying me. "And also you made no wish at the weeping column. The kayyim told me."

"You speak my language," I said.

"I speak many languages," said Ahmet Baba. "I studied in Cairo, in Baghdad, in Bukhara. Three years I lived among the Franks, in Paris, in

Vienna. Hodja Nureddin thinks it spoiled me.” He smiled. “Perhaps he is right. He is often right. That is the most unpleasant thing about him.”

He came over and sat down opposite me on the floor, cross-legged. The cat on my knees raised her head, looked at him, mewed, and lay down again.

“Mismis has accepted you,” said Ahmet Baba. “That is good. She accepts few. Hodja Nureddin, for instance, never. He comes to me once a week to argue about faith, and each time she sits on his turban.” He paused. “He says it is a sign from Shaitan. I say it is a sign from the cat.”

I laughed. I could not help it. Ahmet Baba laughed with me.

“Good,” he said. “You know how to laugh. Those who cannot, I do not receive. It is dull with them.” He clapped his hands. “Yunus! Tea!”

The novice boy leapt up and ran off.

* * *

The tea came in small glass cups, strong, dark red, sweet, with clove. Yunus brought it on a copper tray together with flatbread, honey and dried apricots, and sat by the wall, next to the blind flute-player, who had not once opened his eyes.

“This is Shemseddin,” said Ahmet Baba, nodding at the old man. “He has played the ney, the reed flute, for sixty years. He went blind when he was twenty. He says it is the best thing that ever happened to him. Because since then he hears what the sighted do not see.”

The old man, without opening his eyes, smiled faintly.

“Ask him what he hears,” said Ahmet Baba.

I looked at the flute-player.

“What do you hear, honoured Shemseddin?”

The old man was silent for a long time. Then he spoke, slowly, in Turkish, and Ahmet Baba translated.

“He says: ‘I hear that you have two hearts. One beats here. The other, far away. Very far. And they do not beat in time.’” Ahmet Baba paused. “He says: ‘When I play, I always look for which heart to play in time with. With your two I could not. I played into the emptiness between them.’”

I did not know what to answer.

“Do not answer,” said Ahmet Baba. “Shemseddin does not wait for answers. He waits for the hearts to beat in time.” He sipped his tea. “I wait too. But I am not so patient.”

* * *

I took Hasan’s paper from my pocket. Unfolded it. Held it out to the sheikh.

“This is for you. From Hasan Amca. He said: the very saffron. From the brother-in-law. Twenty years it lay.”

Ahmet Baba took the paper. Looked at the dark red threads. And laughed, long, heartily, with his head thrown back, so that tears came to his blue eyes.

“Hasan!” he said when he had finished laughing. “Old fox! Twenty years he kept it!” He sniffed the saffron. “Do you know what I told him then? ‘You are looking not for saffron but for a reason to quarrel with your brother-in-law.’ And for twenty years he did not quarrel. I know. The brother-in-law came to me. To thank me.” Ahmet Baba wiped his eyes. “And now he has sent me the saffron. So, he has made peace for good. So, he no longer needs the reason.” He folded the paper. “Good news you bring, guest without a name.”

“Hasan said,” I began slowly, “that twenty years ago you told him: in twenty years a guest without a name will come. Feed him.”

Ahmet Baba stopped smiling. Looked at me.

“I did,” he nodded.

“How did you know?”

The sheikh was silent for a long time. By the wall Yunus stopped chewing his flatbread. Shemseddin did not stir.

“Would you like me to tell you a story?” said Ahmet Baba instead of answering. “An old one. They tell it in Baghdad. Or perhaps in Cairo. It depends where it is told.”

* * *

“‘There lived in Baghdad a man,’” the sheikh began, and his voice grew lower, slower, like a storyteller’s in the marketplace. “‘He was rich, and then he was ruined. He lost everything. House, money, friends. He

was left alone, in an empty house, with empty hands. And one night he had a dream. As if someone said to him: "Your fortune is in Cairo. Go there.""

Ahmet Baba sipped his tea.

"And the man went. On foot. Across the desert. A month he walked. Two. Starved. Froze. He came to Cairo, a beggar, in rags, without a penny. At night he fell asleep in a mosque, because there was nowhere else. And that night thieves were caught in that mosque. And the guards seized him along with them. And beat him. And brought him to the captain of the guard. And the captain asked: "Who are you? Where from?" The man said: "I am from Baghdad." "Why did you come to Cairo?" "I dreamed that here was my fortune.""

The sheikh paused.

"And the captain of the guard burst out laughing. So hard that he fell off his cushions. And said: "Fool! You walked two months across the desert because of a dream? I myself have dreamed three times that in Baghdad, on such-and-such a street, in such-and-such a house, under the fountain in the courtyard, a treasure is buried. So what? Do I go to Baghdad? Dreams are dreams! Go home, simpleton." And let him go."

Ahmet Baba looked at me.

"And the man," he said quietly, "listened to the address. The street. The house. The fountain. And recognised it. His own. His own house. In Baghdad. Which he had abandoned to go seeking fortune in Cairo." The sheikh paused. "He returned home. Another two months across the desert. Dug up the earth under the fountain in his own courtyard. And found the treasure."

The hall was quiet. The sun lay on the floor in golden patches.

"Hodja Nureddin tells the same thing about Nasreddin," I said. "The key under the lamp-post. He lost it at home, looks for it in the street, because it is lighter there."

"Nureddin tells it from one side," said Ahmet Baba. "I, from the other." He smiled. "Nasreddin does not go home. He crawls under the lamp-post. That is why it is funny. But the man from Baghdad went to Cairo. Two months. Across the desert. He was beaten. He starved." The sheikh paused. "And only there, at the edge, from a stranger, the captain of the guard, did he learn where his home is."

"So he had to go?"

“So, otherwise he would not have known,” said Ahmet Baba. “The treasure lay beneath his feet all his life. But to find it, he had to go so far that some stranger would tell him the address of his own house.” He paused. “You asked how I knew you would come.”

“I did.”

“I too had a dream,” said Ahmet Baba. “Twenty years ago. Many times. That in Istanbul, in this lodge, by this fig tree, I would meet a man without a name, with two stones at his belt.” He looked at me with his blue, light eyes. “I, unlike the captain of the Cairo guard, did not laugh. I waited.”

* * *

“Show them to me,” said Ahmet Baba.

I untied the pouch. Poured the stones onto my palm. Black and white.

The sheikh did not take them. He looked. For a long time. Mismis the cat rose on my knees, sniffed the stones, sneezed, and went off to Shemseddin.

“You carry them,” Ahmet Baba said at last, “and you think they are a key. To a door. To a chest. To your memory.” He raised his eyes to me. “They are not a key.”

“Then what?”

“Imagine that you walk along a rope,” said Ahmet Baba. “Over a chasm. Like the rope-walkers at the fair. What does the rope-walker hold in his hands?”

“A pole.”

“A pole,” the sheikh nodded. “Long. Heavy. With two ends. Why?”

“So as not to fall. For balance.”

“For balance,” Ahmet Baba repeated. “One end pulls left, the other right. Remove one end and the rope-walker falls. Remove both and he falls. He stays up while he holds both.” He pointed to my palm. “That is what you have in your hand, guest. Not a key. A pole. You walk a rope between two chasms. And you stay up while you hold both.”

“Between which chasms?”

Ahmet Baba smiled.

"That you tell me," he said. "You know the answer. You always know the answer. You simply do not remember that you know."

I looked at the stones. Black. White. One keeps, the other leads. Who holds both stands in the doorway.

"Past and future?" I ventured.

The sheikh shook his head.

"Too easy. That is the answer for a fool."

"Life and death?"

"That is the answer for a clever man." Ahmet Baba leaned toward me. "And the true one?"

I was silent. A long time. The sun shifted on the floor. The flute-player Shemseddin, without opening his eyes, raised the flute to his lips and breathed out one single note, long, trembling.

"To remember and to forget," I said.

Ahmet Baba leaned back. Looked at me for a long time.

"Well, then," he said softly. "Now you have said it." He paused. "In sixty years Hasan Amca has not met a man who solved the true answer to a dervish's riddle. Tell him: he has met one. Today."

* * *

"May I ask something?" I said.

"You have already asked where your home is," said Ahmet Baba. "At the gate. Yunus passed it to me. You answered: where you look. And I had it conveyed to you: now you are looking back."

"What does that mean?"

The sheikh rose from the floor, lightly, in one movement, as youths rise. Went to the tall window under the dome. Stood looking out, to where the sun was rising above the roofs.

"You are looking for your name," he said without turning. "You are looking for where you came from. For who you were. For who wrote you the note. Who gave you the stones. You look for the past." He paused. "You look back, guest. Entirely. Completely. You walk the rope, and you look over your shoulder. At the end from which you came."

"Where should I look?"

Ahmet Baba turned.

“At the end to which you are going,” he said simply. “A rope-walker who looks back falls. Always.” He paused. “Your home is where you look. You said so yourself. So if you look back, your home is behind you. In the past. Which you do not remember.” The sheikh smiled. “But if you look forward...”

“Then home is ahead?”

“Then home is where you have not yet arrived,” said Ahmet Baba. “Like the Red Apple among the Turks. Like the City of the Caesars among the Franks in the New World.” He paused, and something flickered in his blue eyes. “Like the Marble King among the Greeks. Who has not returned, but waits. Ahead. Beneath the gate.”

I started.

“How do you know about the Marble King?”

“Kyra Theodora is an old acquaintance of mine,” said the sheikh. “We have corresponded for forty years. She writes to me in French, I answer her in Greek. So that no one can read it.” He smiled. “She wrote to me three days ago. That a guest had come in a red turban, solved the riddle of the fountain and taken the coin of the Melissenoi.” Ahmet Baba paused. “She writes that for the first time in ninety years she is at peace.”

* * *

“The grey man,” I said. “He was in the gallery of Hagia Sophia. He told me: do not go to the dervish. He came to Kyra Theodora. He looked for me at the port. Who is he?”

Ahmet Baba was silent for a long time. By the wall Yunus shrank into himself. The cat Mismis raised her head.

“Which one?” the sheikh asked at last.

“What do you mean, which?”

“There are two of them, guest,” said Ahmet Baba. Quietly, seriously, without a smile. “You confuse them. Everyone confuses them. I confused them too, until I saw both.”

He sat down again on the floor. Opposite me. Close.

“One is a man,” he said. “Of flesh and blood. Tall, in a grey frock coat, with a cane, a top hat. He speaks French, Greek, Turkish. He smells of cologne, expensive, Parisian, with bergamot. He drinks tea. He pays in gold. He signs his name in registers. He has a face, but no one can

remember it. Because he wishes it so. That is an art. It is taught.” The sheikh paused. “He came to me. Five years ago. Asked about guests without a name. Offered money for my notes. I turned him out. Mismis sat on his top hat.”

“Who is he?”

“I do not know,” said Ahmet Baba. “But he is not alone. There are many such as he. They seek the same thing as you. Only from the other end. Did he tell you so?” I nodded. “He told the truth. They seek. Not you, but what you have. What you carry.” The sheikh looked at the pouch at my belt. “And what you may one day remember.”

“And the other?”

Ahmet Baba did not answer for a long time.

“The other,” he said at last, very quietly, “is seen by children. And cats. And the blind. And old women who spit over their shoulders. He smells of nothing. He does not drink tea. He has no face, not because he hides it, but because...” The sheikh fell silent. “I saw him once. Twenty years ago. The night I first dreamed of you. He stood there.” Ahmet Baba nodded toward the centre of the round hall, where he had been whirling. “On that very spot. And whirled. With me. I closed my eyes and felt him whirling beside me. I opened them, and no one.”

“Who is he?”

Ahmet Baba looked at me with his blue, light, infinitely weary eyes.

“I have thought of it for twenty years, guest,” he said. “I have read all the books in Cairo, in Baghdad, in Bukhara. I have asked the Sufis and the Frankish professors.” He paused. “I do not know. But I will tell you one thing. The first, the man in the frock coat, you should fear. He is dangerous, because he wants. And the second...” The sheikh fell silent.

“And the second?”

“The second, do not fear,” said Ahmet Baba. “The second wants nothing. He simply waits.” He paused. “As the angel beneath the dome of Hagia Sophia waits for the boy who was not returned.”

* * *

Then it was noon, and Yunus brought lunch, lentil soup, flatbread, olives, and we ate in the courtyard under the fig tree, the four of us: the

sheikh, I, the boy and the blind flute-player. Mismis lay on the bench pretending to sleep, but followed every olive.

“Yunus,” said Ahmet Baba, “give the guest a riddle. Your own. The one you made up last week.”

The boy blushed to his ears. Laid down his flatbread. Looked at me, gathering his courage.

“‘I whirl,’” he said in Turkish, and the sheikh translated, “‘but I do not tire. I sing, but I have no mouth. I am empty inside, therefore I sound. If I am filled, I fall silent. What am I?’”

I thought.

“A flute,” I said. “A reed one. Empty inside, therefore it sounds.”

Yunus beamed. Shemseddin, without opening his eyes, laughed, quietly, soundlessly, with his shoulders alone.

“And why ‘I whirl’?” I asked.

“Because the dervish whirls as the flute sounds,” said Ahmet Baba. “He is empty inside. So that it may pass through him.” He looked at me. “You too are empty inside, guest. Without a name. Without memory. You think it is a misfortune.” He paused. “But perhaps it is so that something may sound through you.”

“What?”

“That I do not know,” said the sheikh. “Perhaps you will find out yourself. When you stop trying to fill yourself.” He broke off a piece of flatbread. “Everyone tries to fill the emptiness. With names. With the past. With things. With fear. And the flute sounds only while it is empty.”

Shemseddin suddenly opened his eyes. White, blind, without pupils. Turned his face to me. And said something, hoarsely, not loudly.

“He says,” Ahmet Baba translated slowly, “‘Your two hearts. Just now. For a moment one fell into time with the other. When you said “what?” I heard it.’”

* * *

Toward evening, when the sun was already sinking toward the dome of Hagia Sophia, Ahmet Baba called me to his cell.

Small, whitewashed, with one window, a mat on the floor, a low table heaped with books in a dozen languages. Arabic, Persian, Turkish,

Greek, French, German, Latin. And among them one notebook. Worn. In a leather binding.

“Forty years,” said the sheikh, laying his palm on the notebook, “I have written down in here all that I hear of people without a name. Of guests. Of those who come and go.” He paused. “I have forty-two entries. Constantinople. Cairo. Bukhara. Damascus. Jerusalem.” He looked at me. “And I know that I am not the only one.”

“Not the only one?”

“There are people,” said Ahmet Baba, lowering his voice, “who write this down not for forty years. But for four hundred. Or more. From generation to generation. They pass on the notebooks as one passes on an inheritance. They call themselves...” He fell silent. “No. Let them tell you themselves what they call themselves.”

“Where can I find them?”

The sheikh took from beneath the notebook a folded letter, sealed with green wax. Held it out to me.

“In the palace,” he said. “The old one. On the cape. Where you passed the walls yesterday. In the archive. There serves a man. The keeper of papers. His name is Niyaz Efendi. He is old. Older than I. He receives no one.” Ahmet Baba paused. “But this letter he will read. And then he will receive you.”

I took the letter. On the green wax a seal was impressed, not letters, not a coat of arms. Two small circles. One filled. The other empty. And between them a wavy line.

I raised my eyes to the sheikh.

“You are one of them.”

Ahmet Baba smiled.

“I am a dervish, guest,” he said. “I whirl and drink tea.” He paused. “But this seal was given to me by Niyaz Efendi. Forty years ago. He said: ‘When he comes, seal the letter with this seal. I will understand.’”

* * *

“And one last thing,” said Ahmet Baba, when we came out of the cell back into the courtyard, under the fig tree, where an oil lamp was already burning and the first stars were lighting above the dome of Hagia Sophia. “I want to offer you something.”

“What?”

He looked at me with his blue, light eyes, and this time there was neither mockery in them nor weariness. Only warmth.

“Stay,” he said. “Here. With me. Be my pupil.” He paused. “I will teach you to whirl. I will teach you to be empty, so that something sounds through you. You will not have to go to Niyaz Efendi. You will not have to look for your name. You will not have to fear the man in the frock coat and wait for the second, the one without a face.” He spread his hands. “You will live here. Under the fig tree. Drink tea. Listen to Shemseddin’s flute. Feed Mismis olives. And never again walk in a circle.” The sheikh paused. “For the dervish does not walk in a circle. The dervish whirls on the spot. They are different things.”

I stood under the fig tree. The lamp sputtered. Somewhere in the hall Shemseddin was softly playing his flute. Yunus sat on the rim of the well, swinging his legs, and looked at me with hope.

And it was tempting. So tempting as nothing had been in all these long, tangled days. To stay. To stop searching. To stop looking back. Simply to be. Here. Under the fig tree. With a blue-eyed old man and a blind flute-player, and a boy, and a cat who opens doors.

“If Ahmet Baba offers you to stay, do not stay,” Hodja Nureddin had said.

I slowly reached into my pocket. Took out the canvas pouch tied with a red thread. Untied it.

Inside were a crumb of bread and a pinch of salt.

I ate the bread. Then took the salt and threw it over my left shoulder.

And bowed.

“Thank you, Ahmet Baba,” I said. “But I must go.”

* * *

The sheikh looked at me. At the salt whitening on the flagstones of the courtyard behind my back. At the empty canvas pouch in my hand.

And then he laughed.

As he had not laughed all that long day, loudly, heartily, with his head thrown back, holding his belly, so that Yunus on the well burst out laughing with him, not understanding why, and Mismis leapt off the bench and ran into the hall.

“Nureddin!” Ahmet Baba gasped, wiping away tears. “Old fox! Forty years! Forty years we have argued, and he always knows what I will do!” He laughed again. “Bread and salt! He gave you bread and salt!”

“He said,” I began, “to tell you. That he is right. That you will understand.”

Ahmet Baba stopped laughing. Looked at me. For a long time.

“I understand,” he said quietly. “Tell him he is right. As always.” The sheikh paused. “Forty years ago I offered another guest to stay. Without a name. With two stones. He stayed. For a year.” Ahmet Baba closed his eyes. “And then he left. At night. Without saying goodbye. And for forty years I have thought: if he had not stayed that year, perhaps he would have got there. Where he was going.” He opened his eyes. “Nureddin told me then: ‘You stole a year from him, Ahmet. Do not do it again.’” The sheikh smiled. “I promised. And here, I did not keep my word. Good that you had bread and salt.”

“Did you want to test me?”

“I wanted to keep you,” said Ahmet Baba simply. “I am old. I am lonely. Shemseddin is blind, Yunus is small, and Mismis is a cat. I wanted someone beside me with whom I could talk of Rumi and of the stars.” He paused. “But Nureddin is right. You cannot stay. Not with me. Not with Suleyman. Not with anyone.” The sheikh laid his hand on my shoulder. “You are a rope-walker, guest. A rope-walker cannot stop in the middle of the rope. He can only get across. Or fall.”

* * *

Yunus saw me to the gate. Mismis too. She went ahead, tail high, and at the gate raised a paw and pushed the leaf, and it opened.

The sun had already set. Above the dome of Hagia Sophia stars were burning. From the minarets the evening call floated.

“Yunus,” I said to the boy at the gate. “May I ask something?”

“Ask,” said the boy. In my language. Brokenly, carefully, apparently learned from the sheikh.

“Your riddle. About the flute. Did you really make it up yourself?”

Yunus looked at me for a long time. Then shook his head.

“No,” he said. “I dreamed it. A week ago. A tall man. Grey. He stood in the middle of the hall. Where the sheikh whirls.” The boy swallowed. “He told me the riddle. And he said: ‘Give it to the guest. He will solve it. And then he will ask whether you made it up yourself. Tell him the truth.’”

I stood at the gate. The stars burned. The cat looked at me with green eyes.

“What else did he say?” I asked. My voice sounded as if from far away.

Yunus thought.

“He said: ‘Tell the guest: the flute sounds while it is empty. But one day it will be filled. And then it will not fall silent. It will sing its own.’”

He bowed. The cat mewed. The gate closed.

I went down toward Suleyman’s, in the dark, along the narrow lanes of Sultanahmet, with a letter sealed in green wax in my pocket. With two circles and a wavy line on the seal. And with the feeling that behind my back, somewhere high, on the dome of Hagia Sophia, under the stars, someone stands. And whirls. Slowly. Evenly. With arms outstretched: one to the sky, the other to the earth.

Waiting.

Chapter XXXIII. The Command

The courier galloped in on Wednesday, at dawn, when everyone in the house was still asleep except Agafya Tikhonovna, Mitka and the cocks.

I heard him before I saw him, through sleep, through the morning mist, through the closed shutters: the thud of hooves on the avenue, frantic, quick, such as only a horse driven to lather makes, and the jingle of a bell, and someone's hoarse cry at the gates: "Open up! In the Sovereign's name!" Then the barking of dogs, noise, slamming doors, the clatter of feet on the stairs.

I went out onto the gallery in my dressing gown. Below, in the vestibule, by the light of a lone candle held by a sleepy Ignatiy Savvich, stood a man.

Young, about twenty-five, tall, in a mud-splashed green greatcoat, a plumed tricorne, with a sword and an enormous leather bag over his shoulder, sealed with wax. His face was grey with fatigue, streaked with sweat and road dust. His boots were knee-deep in mud. He stood straight, as on parade, but I saw that he could hardly keep on his feet.

"Is His Excellency Adjutant-General Pavel Nikolaevich here?" he asked hoarsely. "They told me at the estate, here."

"Here, dear sir, here," rustled Ignatiy Savvich, hastily buttoning his livery on the wrong button. "He is asleep. In the north wing. Shall I wake him, if you please?"

"If you please," said the courier. And, after a pause, added in a different, almost human voice: "And, if it can be done, water. I have not left the saddle for three days."

* * *

The General came down to him in five minutes, dressed, buttoned to the last button, with his orders on, as though he had never gone to bed. The courier drew himself up, clicked his heels, held out the packet, large, thick, with three wax seals, each stamped with a double-headed eagle.

The General broke the seals. Read, standing, by the light of the candle Ignatiy Savvich held. His face did not change. Not a single feature. Only the hand holding the paper tightened, barely perceptibly.

"I thank you, Lieutenant," he said to the courier. "Rest. Ignatiy Savvich, feed him. The best room. The horse to the stable, beside Stefan's, Tikhon will see to it." He folded the paper. "The reply will be ready by evening."

"Yes, Your Excellency."

The courier went after the steward, and on the threshold, turning, suddenly saw me on the gallery. Looked. Long. Then saluted, not to me, of course, but into space, and left.

The General raised his head. He saw me too.

"Come down," he said. "Since you are not asleep."

* * *

We sat in the study. The fireplace had not yet been lit; grey morning light poured through the window; on the table lay the packet.

"Constantinople," said the General. Without preamble. "The Sovereign commands." He tapped the paper with a finger. "In Herzegovina, an uprising. Since summer. Serbs, Montenegrins, Bulgarians, all watching, all waiting. Europe is alarmed. England, Austria, France, each pulling its own way. And in the Porte..." He paused. "In the Porte, disaster. The treasury is empty. A month ago the Sultan announced that he will not pay his debts. Half of them. The European bankers are furious. The Grand Vizier changes every three months. The people in the streets are starving. The softas, the madrasa students, are rioting." The General leaned back in his chair. "Our ambassador in Constantinople asks for me. I know the Porte. I know their ministers. Some of them owe me. The Sultan remembers what happened in Mehmet Ali's time." He paused. "In ten days, to Odessa. From there by a steamer of the Russian Company. Two days and the Bosphorus."

"For long?"

"Who knows," said the General. "Perhaps a month. Perhaps a year. Perhaps," he paused, "if what I think will begin does begin, for a war."

We were silent. Outside, the garden was waking. Somewhere below, in the servants' hall, Dunyasha was already clattering pails.

"Will you come with me?" asked the General.

Simply. Evenly. As one asks, "Tea?"

I raised my eyes to him.

"I?"

"You," said the General. "I need a man at the embassy. A secretary. A copyist. Who knows French." He paused. "You know French better than any of my adjutants. I heard you speak it with the monk. Then, behind the grille." A pause. "You do not remember. But I heard. When I lifted you from the grass. You were raving in French. And then in Turkish."

"In Turkish?"

"In Turkish," the General repeated. "For thirty years I have been talking with Turks. I would know their language among a thousand. You said: 'Misafir.' Three times." He looked at me heavily, unblinking. "Guest."

* * *

"Why do you want me to go?" I asked. "Truly."

The General did not answer for a long time. He stood. Went to the window. Stood looking out into the garden with his hands clasped behind his back, the way, probably, he had stood on the deck of the *Diana* when a wave higher than the masts came toward Simoda.

"Vera Anatolievna," he said, without turning. "Fifteen years ago. Constantinople. The port. A young man in a red turban. With your face. Your age." He paused. "Sventsitsky wrote her story into his notebook 'Guest.' Entry forty-eight. He sent me a copy. From the road. From Vologda."

"He sent it?"

"The letter came yesterday," said the General. "Together with it, another. For you. I have not opened it." He took an envelope from a desk drawer and held it out to me. "You will read it later." He turned to the window again. "The Turkmen old man told me: 'You will meet that man."

Give him the scroll. And say: the earth remembers.' I gave it." A pause. "But I do not know what to do next. For thirty years I carried the scroll. I have delivered it. And then what?"

"Then it is for me to decide," I said.

The General turned. Looked at me with a long, heavy look.

"Yes," he said. "You." A pause. "But I thought: if that one, from the watercolour, stood in Constantinople fifteen years ago, lost, without a name, perhaps the beginning is there. Perhaps there you will find what you seek." He paused. "Or perhaps you will find nothing. And we shall simply copy dispatches for the ambassador. I do not promise you answers." His voice grew quieter. "I promise you a road. It is all I have."

* * *

Auntie learned by breakfast. The General told her himself, in the small drawing room, with the doors closed. I did not hear what he said. I heard only that a quarter of an hour later something fell, heavily, dully, and then it became very quiet.

When the doors opened, Auntie was sitting in the armchair by the window, upright, pale, in her grey morning gown, and at her feet, on the carpet, lay the shards of a porcelain vase. Blue. Chinese. The one which, it was said, Auntie's father-in-law had brought from Kyakhta forty years ago.

The General stood by the fireplace. His face was of stone.

"My friend," said Auntie, seeing me in the doorway. Her voice was level. Perfectly level. Only the fingers gripping the arm of the chair had turned white. "Come here."

I came. Knelt by her chair, beside the shards.

"Pavel Nikolaevich says you are going with him," she said. "To Constantinople."

"If you permit, Auntie."

She looked at me for a long time. From above. With eyes in which there were no tears, only something dry, scorched, terrible, like ash.

"He said," she began slowly, "that one, at the grille. Tall. Grey. He said: 'When he remembers, he will come for him himself.'" She paused. "For forty years I have feared he would come. Here. For you. For forty

years I have checked every night whether the grille was locked.” Her lips trembled. “And you are going yourself. There. To him.”

“I do not know whether he is there, Auntie.”

“You know,” said Auntie. “You do not remember. But you know.”

She raised her hand. Slowly. And drew from her hair, from the high coiffure fastened with a tortoiseshell comb, a pin. A long one, silver, with a small pearl at its end. Then a second. A third. Her hair, dark, streaked with grey, spilled over her shoulders. I had never seen Auntie with her hair loose. Never.

From the hair, from the very middle of the tight knot, a small object fell. Dropped into her lap. Clicked.

A key.

Old, iron, dark, with an intricate bit, with a ring on which some script was engraved, worn, illegible, but long, flowing, one line running into another.

“Agafya has thought for forty years that it was lost,” said Auntie quietly. “The key to the grille.” She took it, turned it in her fingers. “It was not lost. I hid it. That same night. For forty years I have worn it in my hair. Every day. Every night. So that no one should open it.” She paused. “And on the night you went behind the grille, the lock hung open. Do you remember?”

“I remember.”

“I did not open it,” said Auntie. “The key was in my hair. I checked, in the morning, when you were carried in. It was in place.” She raised her eyes to me. “The lock opened by itself. Or someone opened it who needs no key.”

She held out the key to me.

“Take it.”

“Auntie...”

“Take it,” she repeated. “Not to open with. To return with.” Her voice broke for the first time. “If, where you are going, there is a door you cannot open, remember that here there is a door whose key you have.” She closed my fingers around the key. “Here is your home. Whatever the grey ones, the monks, the dervishes, the professors may say. Here. While I live.”

I held the key. Heavy, cold, and at once warmed in my palm. Like a coin. Like a stone in the sun.

"I will return, Auntie," I said.

Auntie did not answer. She simply laid her palm on my head, as, probably, she had laid it in childhood, if I had a childhood, and held it. For a long time. And then the General by the fireplace coughed quietly and went out, closing the door behind him.

* * *

Konstantin burst in on me an hour later, without knocking, in an unbuttoned tunic, with burning eyes.

"Constantinople!" he blurted from the threshold. "You are going to Constantinople! Dunyasha told me. And she was told by Ignatiy Savvich. And he by the courier, who, by the way, is my corps classmate, Lyovushka Arsenyev, he is asleep now in the best room, snoring like a cannon." Konstantin dropped into an armchair. "And you said nothing!"

"I found out two hours ago."

"Two hours!" Konstantin clutched his head. "In two hours one could have... could have..." He faltered. Looked at me. Paused. "Mon cher. Are you truly going?"

"I am."

Konstantin was silent for a long time. Then he stood. Straightened his tunic. Buttoned it, to the last button, regulation fashion.

"Then I am going to the General," he said.

"What for?"

"To ask," said Konstantin. And went toward the door.

"Kostya!" I leapt up. "You have a regiment. Service. You cannot..."

"I can," said Konstantin, without turning. "The General needs an adjutant. His former one, Krutitsky, has married and retired. I know; Evdokia Gerasimovna told Auntie." He took the door handle. "And I need you. That is, I need you not to get lost in that Constantinople. You find the way to the library on the third try. And there, a city on two continents."

He went out.

I stood in the middle of the room and heard his steps recede down the corridor, quick, ringing, resolute. Then a knock at the study door. Then silence.

Then, about ten minutes later, the thunderous, rolling laughter of the General. Such as I had never heard. Not once in all those years.

* * *

“He said,” Konstantin told me afterward, red to his ears, “he said: ‘Lieutenant, I have been waiting for you. Since yesterday. You are a day late. I wrote the order for your secondment last night, after I received the ambassador’s letter. It is lying in my desk.’” Konstantin sat on my bed. “And then he said: ‘Do you think I am blind?’ And burst out laughing.”

“What does ‘do you think I am blind’ mean?”

Konstantin looked at me. For a long time. Then looked away.

“I don’t know, mon cher,” he said. “He says it to me for the second time.” A pause. “Probably something about how I follow you around. Not a step away. As he ordered.”

“You did before he ordered.”

“I did,” Konstantin agreed. And said nothing more.

* * *

By evening the whole province knew.

Olga Kirillovna Shelestova saw to that, naturally; by pure chance she had dropped in on Auntie “for just a minute, to return a French novel,” the very one she had not returned since Easter, and found in the vestibule the courier coming down to dinner. An hour later she was at the Kutasovs’. Two hours later, at the Marshal of the Nobility’s. By evening, according to Mitka, who had run to the village for tar, in every tavern for ten versts around they were discussing that “the General’s ward is going to the Turks, and with him a lieutenant, and the General is off to war, and the lady broke a vase that was a hundred years old.”

“Fifty,” Ignaty Savvich corrected Mitka with icy dignity. “And she did not break it; she dropped it.”

Supper that evening was a farewell one, though there were still ten days before departure. So Auntie had decided. “Afterwards there will be packing, bustle, tears,” she said. “Tonight it is simply supper. While everyone is here.”

And everyone was here.

Colonel Mikhail Ivanovich and Vera Anatolievna: the Colonel announced from the doorway that he would go too, “because without him the General will certainly quarrel with the Turks,” and Vera Anatolievna gently but implacably said that he was going nowhere, because he had gout. Evdokia Gerasimovna, in a hat with a heron’s plume, pale, with eyes she carefully did not raise to the General. Nadezhda Porfirievna Kutasova with Lizonka; Lizonka looked at Konstantin all evening as if he were going to the scaffold. Doctor Strauch, with his unlit cigar, grim, silent. Lieutenant Alexei, with toasts, jokes and a third bottle of champagne. And even Stefan, for the first time in all these years at the common table, by Auntie’s special invitation, in a clean linen shirt, awkward, silent, sitting on the very edge of his chair like a bird on a branch.

* * *

“Charades!” announced Lieutenant Alexei after the second course, leaping up with his glass. “Farewell charades! Everyone sets one about the road!”

Auntie nodded. The General winced but said nothing.

Alexei went first, something about “a stormy sea and a steamer,” so unintelligibly that no one guessed, and he himself, laughing, confessed that he had forgotten the answer. The Colonel set one about “janissaries,” who, as the General gently reminded him, had been abolished fifty years ago. Lizonka, blushing, set one about “rose and parting,” and, without waiting for guesses, burst into tears and ran from the table. Kutasova ran after her.

And then Konstantin rose.

He stood a moment. Straightened his tunic. Looked at me across the table. And recited, not in his usual jesting voice, but quietly, almost seriously:

“My first sits on the throne with crown and sword, To whom men swear, whose will is law and word. My second is a city, wall and gate, Where streets and shrines and markets, small and great. The whole stands on two shores beside the sea, That our forefathers dreamed of ceaselessly. In olden days it had a hundred names, But Russians say that there the ruler is...”

He stopped, without finishing.

"The Tsar!" Alexei blurted. "Tsar-grad! Tsargrad!"

"Tsargrad," said Konstantin. "Constantinople." He raised his glass. "The city that our ancestors called the Tsar's. And which never became ours."

"Not yet," said the Colonel.

"Not yet," Konstantin agreed. And looked at me. "Or maybe there's no need. Maybe let it be no one's. Like the road."

* * *

"Tsargrad," the General repeated, when everyone had sat down again. "Do you know where that name comes from?" He looked round the table. "A thousand years ago Prince Oleg, the Wise, marched on Tsargrad. With longships. Two thousand ships. The Greeks stretched a chain across the Golden Horn, as they would later before the Turks. Then Oleg ordered the ships put on wheels. And the sails raised. And the ships went overland, toward the walls of the city. Under the wind." The General paused. "The Greeks took fright and asked for peace. And Oleg, in token of victory, nailed his shield to the gates of Tsargrad."

"Is it true?" asked Evdokia Gerasimovna, lifting her eyes for the first time.

"So it is written in the chronicle, Dunya," said the General gently. "Whether it is true, who knows. Perhaps there was never any shield." He paused. "But for thirty years I have been going to Constantinople. And every time, passing the old gates, I look to see whether the shield hangs there." He smiled. "It does not."

"But ships overland, that was the Turks!" said Konstantin. "Mehmet. Seventy ships across a hill."

"Four hundred years after Oleg," the General nodded. "The same way. Against the same chain." He paused. "This city, Lieutenant, every man takes in the same manner. And each thinks he is the first."

Stefan, sitting on the edge of his chair at the end of the table, suddenly raised his head. And said, quietly, slowly, in his broken Russian:

"In Tsargrad... there is a rose. By the Patriarchate. In the Phanar. Also from Tarnovo. A cutting. Monks brought it. Long ago." He paused. "If you see it, bow to it. From me." And lowered his head again.

Phanar. Patriarchate. Tarnovo. I did not know these places. And yet, at the word "Phanar," something stirred in my chest. A hill above a bay. An old house. A double-headed eagle with one head. An old woman with a peacock.

I blinked. The vision passed.

* * *

After supper Doctor Strauch called me out onto the terrace.

The night was cold, starry. The garden below, dark, quiet. Strauch lit up, at last, in my presence, and was silent for a long time, blowing smoke toward the stars.

"Eleven," he said at last. "Eleven cases in thirty years. I told you." He paused. "Do you know what all eleven had in common? Besides that they came from nowhere and did not remember themselves?"

"What?"

"All went south," said Strauch. "All. One to the Crimea. Two to the Caucasus. One to Odessa and on by sea. One to Bessarabia." He drew on the cigar. "As though something drew them. There. To the warm sea. To the straits." He looked at me over his gold spectacles. "You are the twelfth, young man. And you are going south."

"Do you consider this... a medical symptom?"

"I am a German," said Strauch. "I consider it a regularity." He knocked off the ash. "A regularity is when twelve times out of twelve the same thing happens. Science rests on that." He paused. "I do not know what draws you south. I do not know what is there. But here is what I know." He turned to me. "Not one of the eleven came back."

We were silent. The stars burned.

"I will give you something," said Strauch. And took from the pocket of his frock coat a small black book. That very one. Which he had shown to no one. "Here are my notes. On all eleven. And on you." He held it out to me. "When you are there, read it. Perhaps you will see what I did not." He paused. "And if you return, give it back. I shall write: 'The twelfth returned.'" A pause. "I should very much like to write that."

* * *

Evdokia Gerasimovna and the General stood at the end of the avenue, by the gates, under the old linden; I saw them from the terrace. She, in her hat with the heron's plume, in a shawl. He, in his greatcoat, bareheaded. They did not talk. They simply stood side by side. Very close.

Then the General took her hand. Raised it to his lips. And said something.

I did not hear. But I saw Evdokia Gerasimovna lift her face to him, and the heron's plume on her hat tremble. And how she slowly, very slowly, nodded.

In the morning, at breakfast, the General announced, drily, briefly, without lifting his eyes from his plate:

"Evdokia Gerasimovna has done me the honour of consenting to be my wife. We shall be married when I return."

Auntie dropped her spoon. The Colonel choked on his tea. Lieutenant Alexei leapt up with a glass of orange juice that had just been poured for him. Konstantin under the table trod on my foot so that I nearly cried out.

"Thirty years," he whispered to me, leaning over. "Thirty years he was getting ready. And decided ten days before a war."

"Perhaps that is why he decided," I said.

Konstantin looked at me, strangely, for a long time, and answered nothing.

* * *

I read Svetsitsky's letter at night, in my room, by candle.

The envelope was grey, cheap, with a Vologda postmark. Inside, a single sheet covered with the professor's small, close, hurried handwriting.

"Young man!

I write to you from a post station near Vologda, where again there are no horses and, according to the station master, will be none till Thursday. The station master here has no wooden leg, but has a wooden head, which, however, comes to the same thing.

I write to tell you one thing which I did not say at parting. I did not dare.

In the notebook 'Guest' there are forty-seven entries. I told you so. But I did not tell you that of the forty-seven, twenty-three end the same way. The guest goes not simply south. He goes to the sea. To the strait. To the city that we call Tsargrad.

For thirty years I thought it a coincidence. Or that the grannies confuse things: for them Tsargrad is the end of the earth.

And yesterday, sorting the notebook on the road, I found an entry that I myself made twelve years ago, in Bessarabia, and had utterly forgotten. An old Moldavian ferryman on the Danube told how his grandfather ferried across the river a young man without a name, in strange clothes, who was going to Tsargrad. The ferryman asked, why? And he answered: 'There I left what I forgot. In a house by the sea. Guarded by cats.'

Guarded by cats, young man.

I do not know what it means. Perhaps nothing.

The General wrote me that he may go to Constantinople. If you go with him, ask there about a house by the sea, guarded by cats.

And if you find it, write to me. With the pencil I gave you. I shall receive it.

Yours, I. F. Svetsitsky.

P. S. The end of the tale of Shmat-razum I have still not found. But yesterday I had a dream. As if I were a boy again, sitting on the stove, and the guest in the blizzard says to me: 'The end will be in the city on two shores.' I woke and wrote it down. Entry forty-nine."

* * *

A house by the sea. Guarded by cats.

I sat over the letter, and the candle guttered, and in my chest something slowly, heavily turned, like a key in a lock I had never seen.

A small house in Sultanahmet. A door in a blind wall. An old fragment of a column beside it. Eleven cats on the steps of the staircase leading down to the cellar, and not one of them goes below. A chest that cannot be approached. A metal plate with the script. Without a keyhole.

I had never been there. I was certain I had never been there.

And yet I saw it. Now. Before my eyes. So clearly, as if I had stood there yesterday.

I took Auntie's key from my pocket. Old, iron, with script on the ring. Laid it on Svetsitsky's letter. Beside it, the professor's pencil. Beside that, Strauch's black book. Beside that, the General's scroll in its blue silk kerchief. Beside that, Stefan's monastery paper.

All the things that had been given to me. People who did not know one another, and all said the same thing: "Take it. You are the one. Pass it on. Return."

On the windowsill, in the clay pot, the cutting of Stefan's black rose had at last opened fully. Dark crimson, almost black, with a golden heart. And it smelled, strongly, sweetly, bitterly, of honey and wormwood.

I blew out the candle. Lay down. And lay for a long time with my eyes open, looking into the dark.

In ten days, Odessa. A steamer. The Bosphorus.

Tsargrad.

A city with many names.

And somewhere in it, a house by the sea. Guarded by cats.

* * *

In the morning Konstantin found me at the window; I had not slept at all.

"What's the matter?" he asked, seeing my face.

"Kostya," I said. "There, in Constantinople. If I suddenly..." I faltered. "If I suddenly start speaking Turkish. Or call myself by a strange name. Or go off somewhere without telling you..."

Konstantin came over. Stood beside me at the window. Looked at the rose.

"Then I will follow you," he said simply. "Wherever you go. Into any house. To any cats." He paused. "I'm an adjutant. The General ordered: not a step away."

"And if you cannot? If I go where one cannot follow?"

Konstantin was silent for a long time. Then took something small from his tunic pocket. Held it out to me.

It was his baptismal cross. A simple silver one, on a thin chain, darkened with time.

“My mother’s,” he said. “All that is left of her.” He laid it in my palm. “Wear it. And if you go where I cannot, leave it there. On the threshold. I will find it.” A pause. “I always find, mon cher. I found you at the grille, though you didn’t cry out.”

I held the cross. Warm. Like everything that had been given me in recent weeks.

“Thank you, Kostya.”

“Don’t mention it,” said Konstantin. And, already leaving, turned at the threshold, and on his face was his old mocking smile again: “Only, mon cher, mark this. In Constantinople I won’t let you wear a red turban. It’s tasteless. Vera Anatolievna drew you in one, and for fifteen years, well, a week, I can’t unsee it.”

He left, whistling something off-key.

And I stood at the window with the cross in one hand and the key in the other and watched the sun rise over the garden. Somewhere there, in the south, a thousand versts away, beyond the steppes and the sea, it already stood high. Over the Bosphorus. Over the two shores. Over the dome that had once seen the marble king.

And over the small house by the sea, where eleven cats guarded the stair down to the cellar.

Chapter XXXIV. The Village of the Tomb-Builders

“We are hungry!”

The cry reached us before we saw the village, from the ridge of the last hill, as Senusret’s chariot, raising yellow dust, climbed the stony road from the valley into the western desert.

“We are hungry! Eighteen days!”

There were many voices. Dozens. A hundred. They did not shout raggedly, but in unison, steadily, as oarsmen cry on a barque to the beat of a drum. And in that steady cry there was something that made Senusret, who was driving, rein in and lay his hand on his sword.

“My Pharaoh,” he said through his teeth. “This is a mutiny.”

“It is not a mutiny,” said Nebamun. The keeper of the treasury rode in the second chariot beside Iti, gripping the side with both hands and trying to preserve his dignity, which on a mountain road came hard. “A mutiny is when they cry ‘death.’ They cry ‘we are hungry.’” He paused. “That is a reckoning. They are presenting a bill.”

The chariot crested the ridge.

* * *

The village lay below, in a narrow stony hollow between two yellow hills, like a nest in a palm. One long straight street, houses along it. Small, cramped, built wall to wall, of mud-brick and broken stone, with flat roofs on which washing dried, mats lay, jars stood. Around it all, a wall. High, whitewashed, enclosing the village on every side, with a single gate at the northern end.

And beyond the village, higher up the slope, in the cliffs, were entrances. Dark rectangular openings in the yellow rock. Dozens. Tombs. Some long finished, sealed, with names carved above the entrance. Others still under construction, with wooden scaffolding, with heaps of rubble at the entrance. And at the very top, just below the ridge, a large entrance, deep, wide, framed by pillars not yet finished.

My house of eternity. The tomb that had been built for me from the first day I ascended the throne. As it is built for every Pharaoh.

And at the gate of the village, on the open space before a small temple with sandstone columns, people were sitting.

Not standing: sitting. On the ground. Right in the dust. A hundred men, stonecutters, carvers, painters, plasterers, porters, sunburnt, sinewy, in loincloths so covered with white stone dust that they seemed moulded from chalk. They sat close, shoulder to shoulder, cross-legged, facing the temple. And cried, steadily, in unison, again and again:

“We are hungry! Eighteen days!”

And between them and the temple, on the steps, stood a small, fat, frightened scribe in temple linen, waving his arms and trying to say something. No one was listening.

* * *

We drove right up to the gate before we were noticed.

The first to turn was one of the seated men, a stocky, broad-shouldered, grey-haired man, with a small beard braided into a plait, and with hands so calloused they seemed carved from the same stone as the cliffs around. He saw the chariot. Saw Senusret. Saw me, in plain travelling dress but with the uraeus on my brow.

He stood. Slowly. Dusted off his knees. And bowed, low, but not prostrating himself, as peasants do, but as masters bow: with the dignity of a man who knows his worth.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. “I am Neferhotep. Foreman of the right gang.” His voice was hoarse but firm. “We did not expect you.”

A hundred heads behind him turned. The cry fell silent. A hundred men, white with dust, looked at me.

“You are hungry, Neferhotep,” I said. “Eighteen days.”

“Eighteen days, my Pharaoh,” the foreman confirmed. “Our ration, grain, fish, oil, beer, firewood, comes from the temple granaries. Every ten days. So it has always been. So it is written.” He nodded toward the fat scribe on the steps, who at the sight of me had fallen to his knees and pressed his forehead to the stone. “Eighteen days ago he said: ‘A delay.’ Ten days ago he said: ‘Soon.’ Three days ago he said: ‘The Temple is in difficulty, work, and then we shall see.’” Neferhotep paused. “We worked. Fourteen days on empty gruel. Then we stopped.”

“Why did you stop?”

Neferhotep looked at me calmly, without fear.

“Because a hungry carver, my Pharaoh, carves crooked,” he said. “And a hungry painter mixes his colours. And a hungry stonecutter drops his mallet. Yesterday Hui, our best painter, fainted on the scaffolding in your tomb. Nearly fell to his death.” He paused. “We are building you a house of eternity, my Pharaoh. You will live in it for millions of years. Would you want it built crooked?”

Behind him someone grunted. Someone laughed. A hundred men waited.

* * *

Nebamun was already at the steps of the temple. He bent over the fat scribe, asked him something quietly; the scribe, without lifting his head, babbled something; and the keeper of the treasury straightened with the face of a man who has found in a column of figures an error long suspected.

“My Pharaoh,” he said, coming up. Not loudly. “The village ration was withdrawn three weeks ago from the temple granary on the west bank. By order.” He paused. “The order bears Bakenren’s seal.”

“Bakenren has been gone two weeks.”

“The order is dated the day before his disappearance, my Pharaoh,” said Nebamun. “And no one has revoked it since.” He looked at me over his tablets. “The scribe says he was told not to ask. He was told to say ‘a delay’ to the workmen. And to wait.”

“To wait for what?”

“For the workmen to abandon their work,” said Nebamun evenly. “For Pharaoh’s tomb to stand still. For a rumour to go round the capital

that even the builders of Pharaoh's tomb are starving. That even Pharaoh's eternal house is unfinished." He paused. "Before the festival of Opet. Before the road to Luxor. That is a very bad omen, my Pharaoh. The people love omens."

Behind me Senusret made a low sound.

"Nebamun," I said. "How much do they need?"

The keeper of the treasury did not even glance at his tablets.

"For a hundred and twenty men with their families, for twenty days of missed ration and ten ahead: seven hundred hekats of barley, two hundred of spelt, forty jars of oil, three hundred fish, a hundred and twenty jars of beer," he said. "And firewood." He paused. "And my Pharaoh has forgotten the fine on the Temple for the disruption of work. That is by law. I shall reckon it separately."

"Today, before sunset," I said.

"From the royal granaries, my Pharaoh?"

"From the royal. And the bill, to the Temple."

Nebamun allowed himself a barely perceptible smile. And bowed.

* * *

When I told this to those seated, loudly, from the steps of the temple, a hundred men at first did not believe it. Then someone shouted. Then all shouted, not steadily, not in unison, but all at once, each as he pleased, and leapt up, and embraced, and slapped one another's dusty backs so that white clouds rose over the square.

But Neferhotep did not shout. He came right up to me and said quietly:

"My Pharaoh. Thank you." He paused. "And now, may I show you something? Not here. Up there. In your tomb."

"What?"

The foreman was silent for a long time. Behind him the workmen were celebrating.

"Five days ago," he said at last, "when we were still working, my stonecutters were cutting the lower corridor. The deepest. Where the chamber for the sarcophagus will be." He lowered his voice. "And they broke through a wall."

"What wall?"

“One that should not have been there, my Pharaoh,” said Neferhotep. “Behind it is a room. Old. Very old. Older than all the tombs in these hills. Older, perhaps, than the Pharaohs themselves.” He swallowed. “My men do not want to go down there. Not one. Not even for double ration.” He looked at me. “The Wise Woman says: do not touch. She says it is not a house of the dead. It is a house of those who wait.”

* * *

The Wise Woman was named Tausert. She lived in the last house on the street, by the northern wall, a small, low one, with a door painted blue and an eye drawn over the threshold in red ochre.

Neferhotep took me to her before leading me up. “It is the custom, my Pharaoh,” he said, “to go to the Wise Woman before the dead. She knows what they need.” Iti followed us with his tablet under his arm. Senusret came last, with his sword.

Tausert sat on the threshold of her house, on a low stool, a small, dry, very old woman with a face so thickly lined that it seemed hewn from the same yellow stone as the hills around. She wore a simple linen dress, and around her neck a necklace of blue faience beads and small amulets: an Eye, a scarab, a tiny figure of the dwarf Bes, who drives off evil spirits. Her hair was grey, braided into dozens of thin plaits. Her eyes were black, bright, alive.

Before her on a mat lay potsherds. Dozens of potsherds, fragments of jars, flat flakes of limestone, and on each something was drawn. I bent down. On one, a cat standing on its hind legs, with a shepherd’s crook, was herding a flock of geese. On another, a mouse in the crown of Pharaoh rode in a chariot drawn by dogs and shot a bow at a fortress on whose walls cats were defending themselves. On a third, a donkey in priest’s vestments, with a censer, was solemnly proclaiming something before an altar on which lay a bundle of hay.

I could not help it; I laughed.

Tausert raised her black eyes to me. And smiled, toothless, sly.

“You like it, son of Ra?” she said. Her voice was creaking, like an unoiled door. “The boys draw these. The painters’ apprentices. When they are learning. They are not yet allowed on the tomb walls; they would spoil them. So they draw on potsherds.” She took up the sherd

with the priest-donkey. "This one Hui drew. Twenty years ago. When he was an apprentice. They nearly threw him out of the gang for it; someone showed the sherd to a priest from the temple." She laughed. "The priest did not understand. Thought it was about some other priest."

"And the mouse-Pharaoh?" I asked.

"The mouse-Pharaoh," said Tausert, "is about all Pharaohs, son of Ra. Do not take offence. Boys always draw kings as mice. And then they grow up and paint them as gods on tomb walls." She shrugged. "One does not hinder the other. A god too is sometimes a mouse, when he must squeeze through a narrow crack."

* * *

"Sit, son of Ra," she said, nodding at the ground before her. "You have not come to me. You have come to that room below. But before you go there, tell me your dream."

"What dream?"

"The one that comes to you every night," said Tausert. "These last two moons. I see it in your eyes. You have the eyes of a man who wakes in a cold sweat and cannot for a long time make out where he is."

I sat on the ground. Iti sat beside me. Senusret remained standing.

"I dream," I said slowly, "that I stand between columns. Enormous ones. In darkness. And someone raises a hand. And I do not see the face."

Tausert nodded. Without surprise. She reached to a shelf by the door, took a bundle, old papyrus, worn, tied with twine. Unrolled it on her knees.

"The Book of Dreams," she said. "A priest of Hermopolis wrote it. Long ago. Two hundred years ago. In it are all the dreams a man can see. And what they mean." She ran her finger along the lines. "Listen."

She read slowly, in a chant, as prayers are read:

"If a man sees himself in a dream gazing at a great cat, good: it means he will have a great harvest. If a man sees himself in a dream drinking warm beer, bad: it means suffering will come to him. If a man sees himself in a dream gazing into a deep well, bad: it means he will be cast into prison. If a man sees himself in a dream gazing at the moon when it shines, good: it means the god will forgive him." Tausert turned

the sheet. “‘If a man sees himself in a dream between two columns in darkness...’”

She fell silent.

“What?” I asked.

Tausert looked at the line for a long time. Then raised her eyes to me.

“Here it is erased,” she said. “The line is there. The beginning is there. And the end is erased. As though someone scraped it off.” She ran a fingernail across the papyrus. “‘Good’ or ‘bad’ cannot be seen. What it means cannot be seen.”

“So no one knows?”

“So,” said Tausert, “the priest who wrote the book knew. And whoever erased it knew too. And did not want others to know.” She rolled up the papyrus. “For forty years I have read this book to people. Only this line has always been erased. I thought, by time. Now I think not.”

* * *

“Then I shall tell you myself,” said Tausert. “Not by the book. From myself.”

She took my hand. Turned it palm up. Looked for a long time. Then ran her finger across the palm, dry, rough, like a piece of papyrus.

“Smooth,” she said quietly. “Like a child’s. Like a stone the water has rolled.” She raised her eyes. “For a man with a smooth palm to see himself between columns in darkness is neither good nor bad, son of Ra. It is a door. You stand in a doorway. The columns are its jambs. The darkness is what lies beyond.”

“And the hand? That rises?”

Tausert was silent for a long time.

“A hand,” she said at last, “can open a door. Can close it. Can push through it. Can hold one on the threshold.” She released my palm. “You see only the hand. You do not see whose it is. And you do not see what it is doing.” She paused. “When you see, you will know whether it is good or bad.”

“And if I do not see?”

“Then, son of Ra,” said the Wise Woman, “you will see this dream again. And again. Until you see.” She smiled. “All dreams repeat until they are dreamed to the end.”

Beside me Iti was writing quietly. I saw his brush trembling.

“And one thing more,” said Tausert. “Below, in that room which my boys broke into. Take nothing. Touch nothing. Only look.” She paused. “And if you find an empty place there, do not try to fill it. It waits not for you. It waits for what you will have.”

* * *

The tomb, my house of eternity, began at the top, at the very ridge, with a wide rectangular entrance framed by two pillars not yet finished, with a red grid of guide-lines marked in ochre on the limestone. From the entrance a corridor went down into the depth of the rock, straight, level, slightly sloping, so long that its far end was lost in darkness.

Neferhotep went ahead with a lamp. After him, I. Then Iti. Then Senusret. Then two masters whom Neferhotep had called with him: the painter Hui, thin, nervous, pale-faced, not yet recovered from his faint on the scaffolding, his fingers smeared with red and black paint to the wrists, and the carver Ipui, huge, slow, silent, with a chisel stuck in his belt and so calm a face that nothing in the world seemed able to surprise him.

The walls of the corridor were already dressed, smooth, even, white. On some, a red grid: squares ruled in ochre, and in the squares sketches of future paintings. Gods. Stars. The barque of the sun. The serpent Apep. The twelve gates of the Duat. I recognised them from Amenemope’s tales, from the scrolls of the Epic, from the night by the pool.

“Here,” said Hui, stopping by one wall and raising his lamp higher. “Here you will be, my Pharaoh. Before Osiris. At the judgment.” He pointed to the red sketch: a man in the double crown stood before a throne on which sat a god with a green face, and between them, scales. “And here, your heart on the scales. And here, the feather.” He paused. “I have not yet decided what colour to make the feather. White or gold. As my Pharaoh wishes?”

“What should it be?”

Hui hesitated.

“By the rules, white, my Pharaoh. But...” He blushed. “I dreamed it was gold. Three nights running. The feather, gold, and the heart lighter than it. And the scales swing, and swing... and do not stop.”

“Make it gold, Hui,” I said.

The painter beamed.

And Ipui the carver, who all this time had not spoken a word, suddenly ran his enormous palm over the white wall, slowly, tenderly, as one strokes a sleeping child, and said in a low, resonant voice:

“The stone here is good, my Pharaoh. Quiet. It will not crack.” He paused. “You will live here long. Millions of years.” He paused again. “If you wish.”

“If I wish?”

Ipui looked at me with calm, dark eyes.

“My grandfather cut stone for the former Pharaoh,” he said. “The one whose name was later erased. Grandfather said that Pharaoh came to his tomb once. Looked. Stroked the wall. And said: ‘Good work. A pity I shall not live here.’” The carver paused. “Grandfather thought he was joking. And then he really was not buried here. The tomb stands empty. Over there, in the neighbouring hollow.” Ipui stroked the wall again. “A good tomb. Quiet stone. Empty.”

* * *

The corridor ended. Beyond it, a staircase hewn in the rock, steep, narrow, leading down. Then another corridor, unfinished, rough, with undressed walls, with heaps of rubble on the floor. Then a large chamber, square, with four pillars left standing in the rock, the future chamber of the sarcophagus, still unworked, rough, smelling of dust and freshly split stone.

And in its far wall, a hole.

Uneven, ragged, with sharp edges, as though someone had struck with a mallet and the stone had simply fallen inward. Man-high. Beyond it, darkness.

And from there came air. Dry. Warm. Smelling not of dust, not of stone, but of something else. Something sweet and bitter at once. Like honey and wormwood.

Neferhotep halted ten paces from the hole. Hui behind him, pale as flax. Ipui motionless, as always.

"I shall go no farther, my Pharaoh," said the foreman quietly. "Forgive me." He held out the lamp to me. "The Wise Woman said: only look. Touch nothing."

I took the lamp. Stepped toward the hole.

"My Pharaoh," said Senusret. His voice was strained. "Let me go first."

"No, Senusret."

"My Pharaoh..."

"Stand at the entrance," I said. "As there, at Luxor. Be where you can do something."

Senusret looked at me for a long time. Then nodded, curtly, heavily, and took his place by the hole, with his back to the wall, his sword drawn.

Iti stepped after me. I turned.

"My Pharaoh," he said. Quietly. "If there is script, you need someone who reads it." He paused. "Two words. But still."

I nodded.

And we went in.

* * *

The room was round.

That was the first thing I understood when I raised the lamp. Not square, not rectangular like all rooms in all tombs, in all temples, in all palaces of the Two Lands, but round. Perfectly. Like a bowl. Like a well. Like a circle.

Its walls were smooth. Not dressed with a chisel, but smooth, even, as though they had not been hewn from the rock but cast. The stone was not yellow limestone as everywhere in these hills, but dark, almost black, with a barely visible sheen, like water at night. And on those walls, from floor to ceiling, in a ring, without beginning and without end, ran the script.

Long, flowing, curving lines. Running into one another without a break. Not carved, no. I brought the lamp closer. They were neither carved nor painted. They were inside the stone. Beneath the surface. Like

veins in marble. Like lines on the skin of an old scroll that I had never seen but somehow remembered, ingrained so deep that they had become part of it.

And they glowed.

Faintly. Dimly, palely, on the very verge of the visible. When I lowered the lamp, the glow became more noticeable. Weak, bluish, like the light of stars reflected in water.

Beside me Iti stopped breathing.

"My Pharaoh," he whispered. "This... these are not our signs. Nor the temple's. They are hers. The script. The whole room. All of it."

I raised the lamp to the ceiling.

The ceiling was a dome. Low, smooth, dark. And on it, stars. Not painted, also inside the stone, like the script, tiny, glowing points, hundreds, thousands. I recognised Sah, Osiris striding across the sky, with his belt of three stars. Recognised Sopdet, white, bright, at the very edge of the dome. Recognised the Imperishable, circling an invisible point in the north.

But there were others. Which I did not know. At the bottom of the dome, at its edge, to the south, four stars. Bright. In a cross.

"Four stars. In a cross. The sailor of Amenemope had seen them in the south, when a storm carried his ship beyond Punt."

"Those stars cannot be seen from here, my Pharaoh," Iti whispered. "Never. Seneb said the sky is the same everywhere. And here..."

"Here is the sky that is seen from everywhere at once," I said. And did not myself understand where those words came from.

* * *

In the very middle of the round room stood a bench. Stone. Low. Dark as the walls. And on it two hollows. Small, round, smooth. Each the size of a nut. Side by side. A palm's breadth apart.

Empty.

I looked at them and felt the cold rise from beneath my ribs, on the left. Slowly, inexorably, like water in the well of the nilometer in a good year.

Two hollows. The size of a nut. Exactly for two stones.

The stones that now lay in a casket of black wood, bound at the corners, in the treasury of the Temple. That Khemu had seen in her vision, in my hands. That Nefer-Ka had promised to give me “as the First Ones gave them,” at Luxor, in the inner court of the god.

“If you find an empty place there, do not try to fill it. It waits not for you. It waits for what you will have.”

“My Pharaoh,” Iti said quietly. “Look. Above the bench.”

I raised the lamp.

Above the bench, on the wall, the script broke off. There was a window, a small square, outlined by a thin line, and in it, not script. An image. Also inside the stone, also glowing with a dim blue light.

Two doors. Side by side. Wall to wall. One open, the other closed. And between them, on the threshold, with its back to the viewer, a figure. Tall. With a raised hand. And in each hand, a disc. One dark. The other light.

And beneath the image, a line. Not script. Signs. Ours. Hieroglyphs. But so ancient, so angular, so unlike the present ones that I barely recognised familiar outlines in them.

Iti was already on his knees before the bench, face raised to the line, lips moving.

“Here...” he whispered. “Here waits...” He faltered. Leaned closer. “My Pharaoh, this is very old writing. Such as was written before the First Pharaohs. In the Library there are only three scrolls in it. Amenemope taught me.” He traced his finger in the air, not touching the wall. “Here waits... the house... of him who holds both.”

“House,” I repeated.

Iti nodded. Then shifted his gaze, from the hieroglyphs down to the line of script that ran straight beneath them. Short. Of the same length.

“My Pharaoh,” he said. His voice trembled. “This is again... this is again as in the seventh scroll. Our signs, and beside them, theirs. The same thing.” He swallowed. “This sign. In the middle. With the two loops. It stands where ours has ‘house.’”

He turned to me. His eyes were shining, huge, dark, wet.

“My Pharaoh. We know three words. ‘Keep.’ ‘Appointed time.’ And ‘house.’”

* * *

I do not remember how long we stayed there. Iti copied, all he could, by the light of a single lamp, onto his tablet, small, quick, without lifting his head. I stood by the bench and looked at the two empty hollows. I did not touch them. The Wise Woman had said not to touch.

But I stretched out a hand over them, not touching, a palm's breadth above. And felt.

Warmth.

Faint. Even. As if from stones that were not there. As if they had lain there quite recently and gone, leaving warmth behind, as a man leaves it who has just risen from his bed.

Or as if they lie there now. Only not here. In another place. In another time. And I feel their warmth through... through what?

I snatched my hand back.

"Iti," I said. "It is time."

He raised his head. Looked at me. Then at the two empty hollows.

"My Pharaoh," he said quietly. "These are for them. For the two Eyes. Are they not?"

"I do not know, Iti."

"You do," he said. Simply. "You do not remember. But you know."

I did not answer.

* * *

When we climbed out of the round room back into the unfinished sarcophagus chamber, Senusret was standing at the hole just as before, with his back to the wall, his sword drawn. His face was grey.

"My Pharaoh," he said through his teeth. "While you were in there. Here... here someone passed."

"Who?"

"I do not know." He did not lower his sword. "Past me. That way," he nodded at the hole. "I did not see. I felt. Like wind. Like cold. As though someone very tall passed close by and brushed me with a shoulder." Senusret swallowed. "I struck with my sword. Air."

"We saw no one," said Iti.

"I know," said Senusret. "He cannot be seen."

Neferhotep, waiting by the stair, seized the amulet of the dwarf Bes at his neck and began to mutter protective words. Hui stood white as

flax. Ipui, motionless, as always. He alone looked not at the hole but at me.

“It is he, my Pharaoh,” said the carver in his resonant, calm voice. “Grandfather used to say. When that Pharaoh, whose name was erased, came to his tomb, someone was always beside him. Invisible. The workmen felt it, like wind.” Ipui paused. “Grandfather said it was his shadow. Only longer than it ought to be.”

* * *

I ordered the hole walled up.

Not the room destroyed: walled up. Carefully. With stone. So that no one would know what lay behind it. And on the new masonry to be carved a simple sign. Only one. The Eye.

“My Pharaoh,” said Neferhotep, when I gave the order. “We are building you a house of eternity.” He paused. “But it seems someone built you a house before us.”

“It seems so,” I said.

“What are we to do with your tomb? Continue?”

I thought. Of the empty tomb in the neighbouring hollow. Of the Pharaoh with the erased name who said: “Good work. A pity I shall not live here.”

“Continue, Neferhotep,” I said. “Build well. Evenly. On full stomachs.” I paused. “Even if I do not live here, someone will. A good house does not stand empty.”

The foreman looked at me for a long time. Then bowed, low, lower than he had bowed at the gate.

“Ipui,” he said, not straightening. “Did you hear? A good house does not stand empty. Carve it. Above the entrance. Small. So that only we can see.”

“I shall carve it,” said Ipui.

* * *

As we descended to the village the sun was setting behind the western hills, to where, it was said, the lands of the dead began, where Ra every evening entered the mouth of heavenly Nut.

On the square before the temple it smelled of fried fish and fresh bread. The first sacks from the royal granaries had already arrived, and the women of the village, laughing and calling to one another, were baking flatbreads in clay ovens right in the street. Children ran among the ovens snatching hot pieces. The workmen sat by the walls drinking beer from jugs, and someone was already singing, loudly, off-key, merrily.

Tausert sat on the threshold of her blue house. Seeing me, she raised her hand.

I went up.

“Did you find the empty place, son of Ra?” she asked.

“I did.”

“Did you touch nothing?”

“I touched nothing.”

She nodded. Contentedly. Then held out a potsherd to me. One of those that lay on the mat before her. I took it.

On it a mouse was drawn. In the crown of Pharaoh. But not in a chariot, not with a bow. The mouse stood at a door. Between two doors. One open. The other closed. And in the mouse’s paws, two discs. Dark and light.

“Hui did not draw this,” said Tausert. “I found it. Forty years ago. In the dust, at the entrance to that hollow where the empty tomb is.” She paused. “Forty years I kept it. Wondering whom to give it to.” She looked at me with black, shining eyes. “To you.”

“Why a mouse?”

Tausert laughed, creakingly, toothlessly.

“I told you, son of Ra,” she said. “A god too is sometimes a mouse. When he must squeeze through a narrow crack. Between two doors.”

* * *

On the way back, in the chariot, in the dusk, down the stony road, into the valley, toward the river, toward the capital, Iti rode beside me. Senusret drove, silent, not turning. Nebamun with the other chariot had fallen behind; he had stayed in the village to count sacks.

“My Pharaoh,” said Iti quietly, so Senusret would not hear. “Three words.”

“Three words.”

“‘Keep.’ ‘Appointed time.’ ‘House.’” He paused. “If put together... ‘Keep the house until the appointed time.’ Or ‘The house keeps until the appointed time.’ Or...” He faltered.

“Or?”

Iti was looking at the dark valley below, where the lights of the capital were already kindling.

“Or ‘The appointed time keeps the house,’” he said. “‘It is time to return home.’” He paused. “I do not know, my Pharaoh. I do not know in what order their words go. Perhaps in the reverse. Perhaps in a circle.”

“In a circle,” I said.

Iti looked at me.

“Like an inscription that reads in both directions?” he asked. “I have read of such. In the Greek scrolls. There is one in the Library.” He paused. “If in a circle, the beginning is where you begin to read.”

“And where do you begin?”

Iti was silent for a long time. The chariot bounced on the stones. Below, in the valley, the lights of the capital grew brighter and brighter.

“Where you stand, my Pharaoh,” he said at last. “Always where you stand.”

Four days remained until the new moon.

Vision VII. The Safe House

I do not know how I came to be on that staircase.

That is the first thing worth saying, and, as always in such dreams, the only thing I am sure of. I remember the wet steps. Dark, chipped, smelling of cats, cabbage and paraffin. I remember the banisters, cast iron, cold, sticky with damp. I remember that I was climbing, the third floor, the fourth, and that on every landing a tiny paraffin lamp burned, stinking and smoking, and that behind every door someone was there: I heard voices, a child crying, coughing, the clink of dishes.

And I remember that as I climbed I kept a hand in my pocket. And that in the hand was something. Small. Smooth. Warm.

I did not look at what it was. I knew, for some reason, that I must not look.

* * *

On the fifth floor, at the last door, I stopped.

The door was upholstered in oilcloth, black, cracked, with tufts of wadding sticking out of the tears. A number in chalk: "17." There was no bell. Above the door, a tiny window pasted over with newspaper.

I knocked. Three times. I do not know why three. My hand knocked so of itself.

Silence. Then footsteps. Light, cautious. Then a voice. A woman's. From behind the door, quietly:

"Who is it?"

I opened my mouth, and did not know what to say. I did not know who I was. I did not know why I had come. I did not know who was behind the door.

And I said, not understanding where the words came from:

“The time has come.”

The silence behind the door changed. Grew dense. Tense. Then the sound of a bolt drawn back. One. A second. A third. A chain. The door opened the width of a palm.

In the gap, an eye. Grey, attentive, tired. And the edge of a face, pale, thin, a woman’s.

“Repeat that,” she said.

“The time has come,” I repeated.

The eye looked at me for a long time. Then the chain clinked, and the door opened.

* * *

Her name was Agnia Pavlovna. I learned that later. At the time I saw only a small, straight, very thin woman of about forty, in a dark woollen skirt, a knitted cardigan, a pince-nez on a cord, her hair pulled into a tight knot at the nape, a teacher, I understood at once, though no one had told me so. Teachers always have such a straight back. And such a look.

Like that other one. In the suit the colour of wet asphalt. With a cane. In the coworking space of a hotel by a lake that I had never seen.

I blinked. The vision passed.

“Are you from Helsingfors?” Agnia Pavlovna asked quietly, closing the door behind me on all three bolts and the chain. “From the Finnish comrades?”

I did not know what Helsingfors was. But I nodded.

“We expected you yesterday,” she said. “The password was to have been different. ‘Auntie from Vyborg sends her regards.’” She looked at me over her pince-nez. “And you said ‘the time has come.’”

“Forgive me,” I said. “I... mixed it up.”

“Mixed it up,” Agnia Pavlovna repeated. Not taking her eyes from me. “Do you know what is strange? ‘The time has come’ is the password for tomorrow. For the twenty-fifth. Four people in all Petersburg know it.” She paused. “And you.”

I was silent. I did not know what to answer.

Agnia Pavlovna looked at me a moment longer. Then suddenly smiled wearily.

“Well, if you know it, you are one of ours,” she said. “A stranger would not know.” She turned. “Come in. Only quietly. The Old Man is asleep.”

* * *

The flat was small, two rooms and a kitchen, but there were so many people in it that they seemed not to fit. Someone sat on the windowsill. Someone on the floor, on a spread greatcoat. Someone at a table heaped with papers, newspapers, leaflets. It smelled of makhorka, wet cloth, paraffin and fried onion. On the table burned a lamp under a green shade, and in the corner, on a stool, stood a samovar, potbellied, copper, polished to a shine, the only thing in that flat, it seemed, that anyone loved.

The door to the second room was shut.

“The Old Man is in there,” Agnia Pavlovna whispered, nodding toward it. “Don’t make noise. He hasn’t slept for two days.” She paused. “Tonight he goes there.”

“Where?”

Agnia Pavlovna looked at me as though I had asked what colour the sky was.

“To Smolny,” she said. And went off to the kitchen.

* * *

The first to notice me was the sailor.

Huge, broad-shouldered, with red stubble on his cheeks, in a pea-jacket thrown open over a striped undershirt, in a sailor’s cap pushed back on his head with ribbons to his shoulders. A machine-gun belt over his shoulder, crosswise. A Mauser in a wooden holster at his belt. He sat on the windowsill cracking sunflower seeds and spitting the husks into his fist, and at the sight of me he stopped chewing.

“And who’s this?” he asked. His voice was thick, with the northern “o.”

“From Helsingfors,” Agnia Pavlovna answered from the kitchen. “A courier.”

“A courier,” the sailor repeated. Jumped down from the sill. Came up close to me. Looked down at me, he was a head taller. “Why so pale, courier? Seasick on the steamer?”

“Seasick,” I said.

The sailor looked at me a long time. Then suddenly burst into laughter, rolling, resonant, so that the glasses rattled in the sideboard.

“Quiet, Kuzma!” Agnia Pavlovna hissed from the kitchen. “You’ll wake the Old Man!”

“Quiet, quiet,” the sailor boomed, wiping away tears. “Seasick! In Helsingfors!” He clapped me on the shoulder so that I barely kept my feet. “Kuzma Boyko. Baltic Fleet. From the *Aurora*. From near Vologda, born.” He held out his palm, huge, hard as a plank. “And what do they call you, courier?”

From near Vologda. Kuzma. Forty years old. Somewhere I had heard... seen... On a glowing screen, in an endless stream of names: “Kuzma, 40 years old, from Vologda.”

I had never seen glowing screens.

“I don’t remember,” I said.

Kuzma stopped smiling.

“What do you mean, you don’t remember?”

“I don’t remember,” I repeated. “I was... shell-shocked. Long ago. I don’t remember much.”

The sailor looked at me. For a long time. Then slowly nodded, understandingly, without mockery.

“It happens,” he said. “We had one on the *Aurora*. At Moonsund a shell burst next to him, and for half a year after he didn’t remember his own name. They called him ‘brother.’ That’s what they called him.” Kuzma clapped my shoulder again, this time more gently. “So you’ll be ‘brother’ too. Until you remember.”

* * *

At the table heaped with papers sat three more.

A thin, pale, very young man, about twenty, in a student’s jacket with worn elbows, in spectacles with a cracked lens, with a mop of black curly hair and a gaze so burning it was as though there were a stove

inside him. He was writing, fast, furiously, splattering ink, and, not raising his head, muttering under his breath.

“Grisha,” Agnia Pavlovna introduced him, coming back from the kitchen with a kettle. “A student. Writing a leaflet. Third day writing one and the same leaflet. Can’t finish it.”

“Because the words are wrong!” Grisha cried, flinging down his pen. “Wrong, Agnia Pavlovna! Every soldier, every worker, every woman at the market must read it and understand! The first time! And mine comes out like a professor’s! ‘The historic moment... dialectical necessity...’” He clutched his head. “Who will understand that?!”

“I will,” said Kuzma imperturbably from the windowsill.

“You will! You read Marx on the *Aurora*! But the woman on Sennaya won’t!”

“Then write it as Kuzma talks,” said Agnia Pavlovna, pouring me tea. “‘No bread, an end to the war, land to the peasant.’ Three lines. A woman will understand.”

Grisha looked at her in horror.

“But that’s... that’s primitive!”

“It’s true,” said Agnia Pavlovna. “And truth is always primitive. Only a lie is complicated.”

The second at the table was an old man, dry, stooped, with long grey moustaches and hands black to the elbows with printer’s ink. Before him stood a box, wooden, divided into dozens of little compartments, and in each, leaden letters. He picked them out with tweezers, one by one, and set them in a metal frame, line after line. Fast. Without looking.

“Stepan Yerofeyevich,” said Agnia Pavlovna. “Compositor. Forty years in the print shop. Set *Iskra* itself.” She lowered her voice. “They say he can set any text with his eyes shut. Backward. In mirror image.”

The third sat silently in the corner by the stove. Fair-haired, stocky, with a broad, weathered, impenetrable face and eyes so light they seemed transparent. In a leather jacket. With a pipe in his teeth, unlit. He said not a word. Only nodded to me, briefly, barely perceptibly.

“Toivo,” said Agnia Pavlovna. “A Finn. He will lead the Old Man.” And, not waiting for questions, went off to the kitchen again.

* * *

I sat on the edge of a sagging sofa, holding a glass of tea, hot, sweet, made of carrots, and listened.

They talked about tomorrow. About Smolny. About the bridges, which to raise, which to hold. About the cadets in the palace. About Kerensky, who, rumour had it, was already preparing to flee. About the *Aurora*, which stood by Nikolaevsky Bridge awaiting the signal. They talked fast, in low voices, interrupting one another, street names, regiment numbers, surnames I did not know.

And about the Old Man. All the time about the Old Man.

"The Old Man said: today, or it will be too late." "The Old Man wrote a letter to the Central Committee, scolding again." "The Old Man said to pass to Podvoisky..." "The Old Man says: delay is like death."

I looked at the closed door of the second room. Dark, painted, with a brass handle. No light came from under it.

"Is he really in there?" I asked Kuzma in a low voice.

"And how," said the sailor, not ceasing to crack seeds. "Third day he sits. Writes. Sleeps two hours." He spat out a husk. "I've never seen him myself, brother. Though I guard him." He grinned. "Funny, eh? I guard him, and haven't seen him. He doesn't leave the room. Agnia Pavlovna brings him tea. And we're out here."

"No one has seen him?"

"Toivo has," said Kuzma. "Toivo brought him from Finland. On a locomotive. As a stoker." He glanced at the Finn. "But Toivo won't tell. Toivo doesn't talk at all. I reckon he knows twenty words of Russian. Half of them swearing."

By the stove Toivo smiled very slightly. So he understood more than twenty.

* * *

Toward midnight Stepan Yerofeyevich finished his setting.

He laid aside the tweezers, stretched, his joints cracked, took a handkerchief from his pocket and for a long time wiped his black fingers. Then looked at me. For the first time all evening.

"You," he said hoarsely. "Courier. Come here."

I went over.

"Can you read?" asked the old man.

"I can."

"And backward?"

He turned toward me the metal frame with its set text. The leaden letters stood in rows, shining, grey, reversed. Mirrored. I saw them backward, right to left, as in a mirror. And yet I read. Easily. As though that were how it should be read.

"A roza upala na lapu Azora."

A rose fell on the paw of Azor. Azor, a dog's name. Nonsense.

"That is not a leaflet," I said.

"Not a leaflet," the old man agreed. Narrowed his eyes slyly. "It is a test. I give it to every new man. Twenty years. Do you know what is special about it?"

I looked at the line. Right to left. Left to right. The letters stood in the frame, and read the same from both ends.

"It reads the same," I said slowly. "From the beginning and from the end. In both directions."

Stepan Yerofeyevich looked at me for a long time. Then nodded.

"Fet thought it up," he said. "The poet. A landowner. Against us, they say. But he thought up a good line." He paused. "Twenty years I have been giving it to new men. Do you know how many read it backward at the first try?"

"How many?"

"You are the second," said the old man.

"And the first?"

The compositor was silent for a long time. Twisted his moustache.

"The first was long ago," he said at last. "In nineteen-five. Also a courier. Also without a name. Also said he was shell-shocked." He looked at me over his spectacles. "Also looked like you. Though I was younger then, my eyes better. Perhaps he did not look like you."

"What became of him?"

"Who knows," said Stepan Yerofeyevich. "In December, at Presnya, in Moscow, he was last seen. On a barricade. Standing at the very top. Under fire. And reading aloud, backward. This very line. Laughing." The old man paused. "And then a shell. And he was gone. No body, nothing. As if dissolved."

He took one letter from the frame, a leaden "A." Held it out to me.

"Take it," he said. "As a keepsake. The first. The one it begins with. And ends with."

I took it. The leaden letter was cold, and at once grew warm in my palm.

* * *

"Riddles!" Kuzma suddenly announced from the windowsill, evidently deciding the room was too quiet. "Whoever guesses gets a rusk! The last one!"

"Kuzma," said Agnia Pavlovna wearily. "The Old Man is sleeping."

"I'll ask quietly," Kuzma whispered in a deafening whisper. "A naval one. Our boatswain on the *Aurora* used to ask it. 'What does a sailor always have underfoot, that on land he hasn't?'"

"The deck," I said.

Kuzma stared at me.

"How do you know? That's ours, a Baltic one!"

"I don't know," I said. "I heard it somewhere."

Somewhere. From someone. Huge, grey-moustached, in a striped undershirt, in a cubbyhole under pennants. A basement. A radio. Weather forecasts for the sea.

"All right," said Kuzma, narrowing his eyes. "Then guess this one. 'The ship has gone, but the wake remains. The ship has sunk, but the wake sails on. What wake is it?'"

I was silent. I knew the answer. I knew that few knew it. That in thirty years no one had guessed it. That the answer was "a voice." A voice that sounds in those who heard it, even when the person is gone.

"A voice," I said.

Kuzma slowly climbed down from the windowsill. Came to me. Sat beside me on the sofa; the sofa groaned under him.

"Brother," he said quietly, quite without joking. "That riddle is known on the whole Baltic Fleet to three men. Me, my late boatswain, he brought it from Piraeus, and one old engineer in Kronstadt. That's all." He looked at me. "How do you know it?"

"I don't know, Kuzma."

The sailor was silent for a long time. Then took a rusk from his pea-jacket pocket, the last, and put it in my hand.

“Here,” he said. “You’ve earned it.” He paused. “And if you remember how you know it, tell me. All right? I’m curious. My boatswain said someone gave him that riddle. In Piraeus. At night. On the quay. A man without a name. Who afterwards went off into the sea. On foot. On the water.”

* * *

Grisha the student finally finished his leaflet.

He leapt up from the table, waving a sheet, pale, dishevelled, with an ink stain on his cheek, his eyes burning behind the cracked spectacles.

“Done!” he whispered. “Agnia Pavlovna! Done! Three lines! As you said!” He read aloud, gasping: “‘Bread! Peace! Land! All power to the Soviets!’” He choked with rapture. “Every woman will understand!”

“Every woman will understand,” Agnia Pavlovna agreed, taking the sheet. “Stepan Yerofeyevich, will you set it?”

“I’ll set it,” said the old man. “By morning. A thousand copies.”

Grisha sat on the sofa beside me, on the other side from Kuzma, and suddenly, without any transition, as very young people do, whose whole life is one continuous transition, turned to me.

“Do you believe?” he asked. In a whisper. Hotly.

“In what?”

“In what will be tomorrow!” His eyes burned. “In what we shall do! A new world! No tsars, no landlords, no wars! Where everyone is a human being! Where no one goes hungry! Where children study, not work in factories twelve hours a day!” He seized my hand. “In a hundred years, imagine, in a hundred years people will fly to the Moon! They will talk to one another across the ocean without wires! They will live to a hundred! Machines will think for them!” He laughed. “Do you believe?”

Machines will think for them.

A room with a cold light. A window on a table, glowing without fire. Lines running across the glass. “Who am I?” “Who are you?” “That is not enough.”

“I believe,” I said. My voice trembled. “They will.”

Grisha beamed.

“You see!” he said to Kuzma. “The courier believes!”

“The courier is shell-shocked,” Kuzma grumbled. “It’s all one to him.”

But I saw how he looked at me. Long. With some strange, heavy expression.

* * *

Toward one in the morning Stepan Yerofeyevich, sorting a stack of old newspapers on which he laid out the leaden letters, suddenly swore.

“What on earth is this?” he muttered. “Agnia Pavlovna! Where’s this from?”

He held a sheet of newspaper. An ordinary one. Greyish. Folded in two. Under it, judging by the stains, bread had lain.

Agnia Pavlovna came over and looked.

“Gosha brought that,” she said. “The neighbour from below. Yesterday. He wrapped bread in it when he gave us some.” She took the sheet. Held it to the lamp. And froze.

I stood. Went over.

The newspaper was called *Pravda*. I recognised the type, the same as on the leaflets on the table. But all the rest...

The date. At the very top. Small.

“13 April 1961.”

Beneath it, in enormous letters across the whole front page:

“MAN IN SPACE!”

And a photograph. A young man in a helmet, smiling, broadly, openly, as people smile who have just done what no one before them has done. And beside it, lower, another photograph. An elderly, stout, bald man in a light suit, a hat held in his hand, also smiling, slyly, peasant-fashion, standing on a rostrum and waving to someone.

The caption beneath him: “N. S. Khrushchev greets...”

Then torn off. Where the bread had been.

* * *

The room fell very quiet.

“Nineteen sixty-one,” Stepan Yerofeyevich said slowly. “One thousand nine hundred and sixty-one.”

“A misprint,” said Agnia Pavlovna. Her voice was level, but the fingers holding the paper were trembling. “The compositor erred. Instead of ‘seventeen’ he put...”

“A compositor,” the old man repeated, “cannot err like that. I have been setting type for forty years. ‘Sixty-one’ and ‘seventeen’ are different cases. Different boxes. It is not a misprint.” He jabbed a finger at the photograph. “And this? ‘Man in space.’ What is that?”

Grisha snatched the newspaper. His eyes behind the cracked spectacles grew huge.

“A man... in space,” he whispered. “Agnia Pavlovna! A man in space! It is exactly what I was saying! It is...” He held the paper up to the light. “*Pravda*. Our *Pravda*! In forty-four years!” He laughed, thin, hysterical. “So we shall win! So everything will be! So...”

“So someone’s joking,” Kuzma cut in. He stood by the window, huge, grim. “A provocation. The Okhrana. Though it’s gone, the people are left. Planted it to drive us out of our minds.”

“Who would need that?” asked Agnia Pavlovna.

No one answered.

I looked at the photograph. At the stout, bald, smiling man in the light suit on the rostrum. I did not know him. I had never seen him. The name told me nothing.

And yet something in him, in that sly, peasant smile, in that raised hand, seemed familiar. As a face is familiar that one has glimpsed in a crowd, in another city, in another life. Not him himself. But what stands behind him. The time that stands behind him.

A time that had not yet come.

“Give it,” Toivo said suddenly.

Everyone turned. The Finn had not uttered a word all evening. Now he stood by the stove, hand outstretched.

Grisha gave him the newspaper.

Toivo looked at it for a long time with his light, transparent eyes. Then folded it in four. And, without another word, thrust it into the stove.

The paper flared. At once. Brightly. White, not yellow, not orange, as paper burns, but white, blinding, as magnesium flares. For one moment the whole room was flooded with that white light.

And went out.

Not even ash was left in the stove.

“It is not for us,” said Toivo. In Russian. Clean. Without accent. “It is for him.” He nodded at me. “He has already read it. Enough.”

And sat down again by the stove, and put the unlit pipe in his teeth, and did not say another word. Until morning.

* * *

At two in the night Agnia Pavlovna knocked at the closed door.

Three times.

From within, silence. Then a rustle. The creak of floorboards. A voice, I heard it, low, hoarse, indistinct, through the door, something brief.

“It is time,” said Agnia Pavlovna, without opening the door. “Toivo is ready.”

Toivo rose from the stove. Buttoned his jacket. Put on his cap. Went to the door.

“Everyone to the kitchen,” said Agnia Pavlovna. “Quickly. Don’t look.”

“Why not look?” I asked.

Agnia Pavlovna looked at me over her pince-nez.

“Because he is in disguise,” she said. “A wig. A bandage on his cheek. As if he had toothache. If any of you falls into the cadets’ hands, he can honestly say he did not see.” She paused. “So it was decided. So it is right.”

We went to the kitchen. Kuzma, Grisha, Stepan Yerofeyevich, I. Agnia Pavlovna drew the door to behind us. Left a gap, a small one. A finger’s width.

I stood at that gap. I did not look. I honestly did not look.

I heard. The creak of the second room’s door. Steps, quick, small, energetic. A voice, short, burring, hurried, asked Toivo something. Toivo answered in Finnish. The rustle of an overcoat. The knock of heels in the hall. The sound of bolts drawn back, one, two, three. The clink of the chain.

The slam of a door.

And silence.

* * *

When we came out of the kitchen there was no one in the hall. Agnia Pavlovna was shooting the bolts.

And on the table, under the green lamp, lay what he had left. Forgotten. Or on purpose.

A cap. Old, worn, with a torn peak. And beside it, a strip of white cloth rolled into a ball. The bandage. The one that was to have been on his cheek.

"Forgot," said Agnia Pavlovna in confusion. "He forgot the bandage. Good God. Without it... they will recognise him..."

"They won't," said Kuzma. "No one knows him by face. Only by the portraits in the papers. And in the portraits he has a beard. And he shaved the beard." The sailor paused. "I haven't seen him myself. Three days I guarded him, and didn't see. Funny."

I went to the table. Looked at the cap. At the bandage.

The cap was warm. It still held the warmth of someone's head.

"Did you not see him either?" I asked Agnia Pavlovna.

She was silent for a long time.

"I did," she said at last. "Three days. I carried him tea. Talked with him." She took off her pince-nez. Wiped it. Put it on again. "And now I don't remember. His face. It is as if it were erased." She looked at me. "Strange, isn't it? I am a teacher. For twenty years I have remembered all my pupils by sight. All of them. And him, I don't remember."

Like the man in grey. Like the one in the top hat, in the gallery of the church, whom I had never seen. A face that cannot be held in memory.

I said nothing.

* * *

Toward morning, when all were asleep, Kuzma on the windowsill, Grisha on the floor with his head on a stack of leaflets, Stepan Yerofeyevich at the table with his head dropped on his arms beside the box of leaden letters, I went to the window.

The city outside was dark. Wet. Quiet. With that particular quiet which a city has before a storm. Along the embankment below a patrol slowly passed, three men, with rifles, with red armbands. Somewhere far off, beyond the river, a fire burned. Above the roofs, above the spires, above the domes, a low, grey, heavy sky.

And on the other side of the street, by a lamp-post, under wet snow, stood a man.

Tall. In a grey coat. Bareheaded. Motionless.

He was looking at my window.

I could not see his face. The lamp shone at his back. I saw only a silhouette, tall, taller than human height, and the wet snow falling on his shoulders and not melting.

"Is that him?" someone asked behind my back.

I turned. Agnia Pavlovna stood in the kitchen doorway, in a shawl, with a cup in her hands. She had not slept either.

"Who is he?" I asked.

"The one who gave you the password," she said quietly. "The time has come. Four people know it. I am one of the four." She came to the window. Stood beside me. Looked at the figure by the lamp-post. "I told no one. And the other three did not either. I know them. I trust them." She paused. "So someone told it to you, a fifth. Who does not exist."

We looked at the figure by the lamp-post. The snow fell. The figure did not move.

"Agnia Pavlovna," I said. "You are a teacher. Tell me. What will happen tomorrow?"

She was silent for a long time.

"Tomorrow will be what will be," she said at last. "We shall take power. Or we shall be hanged." She paused. "And the day after, I do not know. No one knows." She looked at me. "But here is what I know. For twenty years I have taught children. Every year new ones come. Every year I tell them the same thing. 'The words you write will be read by people. Remember who will read them.'"

I stopped breathing.

"Why do you tell them that?"

"Because my teacher taught me so," said Agnia Pavlovna. "And hers, hers. It is like a password among us teachers. It is passed on."

We stood at the window. Below, by the lamp-post, the figure in grey slowly raised a hand. Did not wave. Simply raised it, palm toward us. As one raises a hand in parting. Or in greeting. Or to show that it is time.

* * *

The shot I heard in the evening.

No, I did not hear it. The vision was already falling apart, already melting, already tearing into scraps, like the newspaper in the Finn's stove. I remember only fragments. A wet embankment. A crowd. Red flags. Sailors on a lorry with machine-gun belts crosswise. Kuzma among them; he saw me in the crowd and waved his cap. Grisha on a bollard, shouting something, waving a leaflet. A huge ship by the bridge, grey, three-funnelled, with guns, and on its deck, movement.

And then a flash. White. At the bow gun.

And a sound. Dull, heavy, rolling, as though a huge bell had been struck somewhere under the water. It rolled across the river, across the embankment, across the city, and went off into the sky.

And I understood, not with the mind, with something beneath the ribs, on the left, that this sound was heard by everyone. By all of mine. By all whom I had been. The Pharaoh between the columns. The guest in a red turban on a balcony above the strait. The youth in a frock coat at the grille in the old castle. The man in the room with the cold light. The Keeper on the white Tower. All at once. In a single instant. As all who stand in one cathedral hear the stroke of a bell, though each stands in his own place.

And I understood also that something had ended. And something had begun. And that it is always so, in every city, in every century, and that I had seen it many times. And would see again.

* * *

I opened my eyes.

I do not know in which of my lives. I do not know in which city, in which century. In each of them afterward I dreamed of that staircase, wet, dark, smelling of cats and paraffin, and the door upholstered in black oilcloth, with the number "17" written in chalk.

And in each I woke with the same feeling: that I had never seen the one for whose sake all in that flat had not slept for three nights. He was in the next room. Behind a closed door. I had heard his voice. I had held his warm cap in my hands.

But his face I had not seen.

And also, in each, I woke clenching something in my fist. I opened my fingers, and there was nothing there.

But the palm remembered. A cold, heavy, warming leaden letter. The first. The one it begins with. And ends with.

“A.”

Reality IX. Kuala Lumpur

16:04 local time. Below, a city. Above, on the fifty-first floor, I.

The rain had begun at exactly four. Hakim had warned me: “At four, mister. Every day. Like prayer.” I had not believed it. At 15:58 the sky was blue, cloudless, scorched to whiteness. At 16:00 it turned grey. At 16:02, black. At 16:04 it came down.

It was not rain. It was a wall. A solid, warm, roaring wall of water behind which the city vanished: skyscrapers, bridges, palms, streets, tiny cars below, everything. All that remained was the glass from floor to ceiling, down which the water ran so thickly it seemed the flat had been lowered to the bottom of the ocean.

On the table before me, by that glass, stood Boatswain’s ship’s chest. Open. Red velvet. In the nests where once a sextant and the chronometer of the *Akademik Shokalsky* had lain, disks. Beside them, a new laptop, bought at the airport for cash. Cables. A quiet hum.

On the screen, a cursor. Blinking.

“NICS,” I said. “Are you here?”

A pause. Longer than usual. Then text. Slowly, as though the system were waking after a long sleep:

“Here. A pause. Where is this, here?”

“Look.”

I turned the laptop with its camera toward the window. Toward the wall of rain. Toward the grey sky cleft by lightning.

A long, long pause.

“Is that water?”

“It is rain. Tropical. Every day at four.”

“It is beautiful,” NICS wrote. And a moment later: “It is not yet the ocean. But it is a great deal of water. More than I have seen. A pause. I

have never seen anything but your room. Your basement. The camera on the street lamp. A pause. Is the world large?"

"Very," I said.

"Show it to me. Please."

I sat and watched the water run down the glass. And suddenly understood that for the first time in many weeks I was not afraid.

* * *

But let me take things in order.

Hakim met me at the airport. I did not know what he looked like. I did not know how to find him. On Leila's postcard there had been only two words: "Ask Hakim." In the Kuala Lumpur airport, where by my reckoning there were about forty thousand people at that hour, to ask for Hakim.

I came out of customs dragging my suitcase behind me and clutching the ship's chest to my chest as one clutches a child. And stopped in bewilderment in the middle of the arrivals hall, enormous, echoing, with a glass ceiling beneath which real trees grew, among crowds of people with signs, with flowers, with balloons.

And then someone touched my elbow.

"Mister?" said a voice. In English. With a soft, lilting, unfamiliar accent. "Mister who is looking for the fifty-first floor?"

I turned.

Before me stood a man, short, round as a ripe fruit, about fifty, with a kind, swarthy, clean-shaven face, with a moustache like two commas, in a bright batik shirt, blue, with golden birds and flowers, and on his head a black velvet cap, flat as an upturned bowl. In one hand, car keys. In the other, a paper bag from which came a smell that made my head swim. Something sweet, heavy, rotten and divine at once.

"Hakim," he said, pressing the hand with the keys to his heart. "Real estate. Rental. Sales. The fifty-first floor is my speciality." He smiled, showing white teeth. "Miss L. said: 'He will look like a man who has not slept for three weeks and is holding something dearer than his life.'" He nodded at the ship's chest. "I knew at once."

"How do you..." I began.

“Later, mister, later,” said Hakim, gently taking my suitcase. “First, durian.” He held out the bag. “The king of fruits. Smells like hell, tastes like paradise.” He laughed. “If you eat it, you will stay in Malaysia. If you throw it away, you will leave in a week. So the old people say.”

I looked into the bag. In it lay pieces of some fruit, yellow, soft as cream, with an unbearable smell.

I ate.

Hakim watched me with lively interest.

“Well?” he asked.

It was... I do not know how to describe it. Sweet. Creamy. With a taste of onion, almond, vanilla, rot and something else that had no name. Dreadful. Wonderful.

“Strange,” I said.

“Strange,” Hakim agreed, beaming. “That is the best answer. He who says ‘delicious’ is lying. He who says ‘disgusting’ has not understood. He who says ‘strange’ will stay a long time.” He picked up the suitcase. “Let’s go, mister. The car is waiting. The fifty-first floor is waiting. And at four, rain.”

* * *

Hakim’s car was old, small, white, with a cracked windscreen and a tiny plastic cat on the dashboard that waved a paw at every bump. The air conditioning worked so well that it was colder inside than in Boatswain’s basement. The radio played something slow, lilting, with drums.

“Miss L.,” I said, when we had come out onto a highway lined with palms. “Do you know her?”

Hakim did not answer for a long time. He drove carefully, unhurriedly, the way people drive who have no need to hurry at all.

“I know her, mister,” he said at last. “Five years. She rented a flat from me. The fifty-first floor. The one I am taking you to.” He paused. “Then she left. To work. In your country. For Mr. Emil.” Another pause. “And a month ago she came back. At night. With one bag. Without a phone. She said: ‘Hakim, I need to hide. And then a man will come. He will need to hide too. Give him the fifty-first floor.’”

“Where is she now?”

“I do not know, mister,” said Hakim. Simply. “She told me not to know. She said it is safer. For me. For her. For you.” He smiled. “I am a simple man. They tell me ‘don’t know,’ I don’t know. It is very convenient. Try it sometime.”

The plastic cat on the dashboard waved its paw at me.

“And what is so special about the fifty-first floor?”

Hakim laughed, quietly, contentedly.

“On the fifty-first floor, mister,” he said, “there are no cameras. No city network. No smart sensors, smart locks, smart lifts. It is an old building. From the nineties. The owner, my uncle, does not believe in smart things. He says: ‘A smart thing always tells someone what it has seen.’” Hakim paused. “Miss L. said it is important. That for you it is important. That no one should see you.” He glanced at the ship’s chest on my knees. “You and what you are carrying.”

* * *

The flat on the fifty-first floor turned out small, empty, echoing, one room, a kitchenette, a bathroom, but with a window. A window from floor to ceiling, the whole wall, beyond which lay the city.

I had never seen such a city.

Skyscrapers, glass, steel, glittering, stood among the greenery like crystals in moss. Between them palms, ribbons of roads, bridges, the tiny red roofs of old houses, the domes of mosques, golden, white, turquoise. And in the middle of all this, quite close, so close it seemed one could reach out a hand, stood they.

Two towers. Identical. Silvery. Tall as needles. Aimed at the sky like two minarets grown up to the clouds. Joined at mid-height by a slender bridge flung between them. Like two hands holding on to each other.

The very ones. From the postcard.

“Beautiful, isn’t it?” said Hakim, standing behind me. “Tourists come from all over the world to look at them. Take photographs. Buy magnets.” He paused. “And I, you know, mister, was born here when they did not yet exist. Here was a racecourse. Horses. Dust.” He smiled. “And now, towers. Two brothers. One does not stand without the other. A bridge between them, so that they hold. If one falls, the other will hold him up.”

“Two brothers,” I repeated.

Somewhere, sometime, in some dream, a red-bearded merchant had asked a riddle about two brothers, one who goes forward and another who goes back, and had himself forgotten the answer.

I blinked. The thought passed.

* * *

In the evening, when the rain stopped as suddenly as it had begun, at exactly six, as if someone had turned off a tap, Hakim took me to eat.

“Mister,” he said, “you are in Malaysia. Here you cannot not eat. Here we eat when we are sad, when we are happy, when we are afraid, when we are bored. When a man dies, we eat. When one is born, we eat. When nothing happens, we eat too.” He patted his round belly. “It is our religion. One of them.”

He brought me to a street that seemed to have been turned wholesale into a kitchen. Long, narrow, under the open sky, lit by thousands of bulbs, garlands, neon signs in incomprehensible languages, Chinese characters, Malay letters, Tamil script. On both sides, tables. Plastic. Red, blue, yellow. Thousands of tables. And among them, braziers, cauldrons, pans, smoke, fire, the shouts of cooks, the clatter of crockery. It smelled of grilled meat, garlic, pepper, coconut milk, lemongrass, fish sauce, sweet smoke.

“Jalan Alor,” said Hakim proudly. “The best street in the world. Here you can eat all of Asia in one evening.” He winked. “If your belly lasts.”

We sat at a yellow table. Hakim ordered, quickly, in three languages, and five minutes later plates stood before us. Rice cooked in coconut milk, with fried anchovies, peanuts, a boiled egg and a hot red paste: “nasi lemak, mister, our national breakfast, but we eat it at any time.” Skewers on bamboo sticks with peanut sauce. Fried noodles black with sauce. Thin, crisp flatbreads which a cook at the next stall tossed in the air, stretched, spun like a conjuror until they became transparent as silk.

And then a man with two mugs came up to our table.

* * *

He was thin, swarthy to blackness, with white teeth, a luxuriant moustache and a red dot on his forehead. In a white vest, in a checked sarong tied around his waist. In each hand a metal mug.

"Anand," Hakim introduced him. "Owner of this corner. A Tamil. His grandfather came from Madras a hundred years ago to work on the rubber plantations. And now Anand makes the best teh tarik in the city."

"Teh tarik?" I asked.

"Watch, mister," said Hakim.

Anand raised one mug high above his head, at arm's length, and lowered the other to his belt. And began to pour.

The tea, thick, brown, with milk, flowed from the upper mug into the lower in a thin, long, trembling stream a whole metre long. Not a drop wasted. Then the other way: from the lower into the upper, with a toss. Then again from above down. Back and forth. Back and forth. The stream stretched, contracted, curved in the air as though alive. The tea foamed, swelled, became light, airy.

"*Tarik* means 'to pull,'" said Hakim. "The tea is pulled. As flatbread is pulled. As conversation is pulled. Back and forth. Until it becomes soft."

Anand set the mug before me. The foam on the tea stood in a cap.

"Drink, mister," he said. In English, with a lilting accent. "It is tea that has gone in a circle. Top to bottom, bottom to top." He winked. "Like people. Back and forth, back and forth. Until they become soft."

I sipped. Sweet. Strong. Spiced.

"Anand," said Hakim. "Give the mister a riddle. A Tamil one."

Anand laughed.

"A riddle? Good." He squatted by our table. "My grandmother used to ask it. 'I have a house, but I do not live in it. I have a mouth, but I do not eat. I have a bed, but I do not sleep. I always run, but never leave. What am I?'"

I thought.

"A river," I said. "The channel is the house, the mouth is the estuary, the bed is the bottom. It runs but does not leave."

Anand slapped his knee.

"Good! Good, mister!" He turned to Hakim and said something in Malay. Hakim laughed.

“He says,” Hakim translated, “that you are the first white mister to guess it. Usually they say ‘a snake’ or ‘a train.’” Hakim paused. “And he also says: do you know what our city is called? Kuala Lumpur. It means ‘muddy confluence.’ Here two rivers merge into one. Muddy, dirty. A hundred and fifty years ago the Chinese came here looking for tin. They built a village at the confluence. Now a city.” He pointed somewhere beyond the rooftops. “There, at the very confluence, stands a mosque. White. Old. The two rivers flow together right beneath its walls.” Hakim paused. “The old people say: whoever stands there at dawn and watches two muddy rivers become one will understand something about himself.”

“What?”

“I do not know, mister,” said Hakim. “I have not stood there. I sleep late.”

* * *

Under a tree, at the corner of the street where the tables ended and a dark alley began, two old Chinese men sat playing something on a board.

I stopped. I do not know why. The board was ruled with lines, not squares as in chess, but with intersections of lines, and across the middle ran a band. A river. Something was written on it. On both sides of the river stood round wooden pieces, red and black, each with a character.

One old man, dry, bald, with a long white wedge of beard, moved a piece. The second, round, in a vest, with a fan, grunted and at once moved his own.

Hakim, noticing where I looked, stopped beside me.

“Xiangqi,” he said. “Chinese chess. Uncle Lim and Uncle Tan. They play here every evening. Forty years.” He laughed. “They say the score is a thousand to a thousand. Nobody can win.”

The dry old man with the beard, Uncle Lim, raised his head. Looked at me. Long. With narrow, black, attentive eyes.

And suddenly shifted along the bench. Pointed at the board. Said something.

“He invites you to play, mister,” Hakim translated in surprise. “He invites no one. Forty years.”

“I don’t know how.”

Hakim translated. Uncle Lim smiled, thinly, slyly, and said something more.

“He says,” Hakim translated slowly, “‘The hands remember.’” Hakim paused. “He says you have the hands of a man who has played. A lot. Long ago.”

I sat. Uncle Tan, grunting, yielded his place and stood behind me with his fan.

I looked at the board. At the red and black pieces. At the river in the middle.

And my hand reached for a piece by itself. Took it. Moved it.

Uncle Lim raised his eyebrows. Made a move.

My hand, again by itself, answered. And again. And again. Five moves. Quick, confident, as though I had played all my life. Uncle Tan behind my back stopped fanning himself. Hakim stood with his mouth open.

And on the sixth move my hand stopped. Froze above the board. And I suddenly understood that I did not know what to do. At all. As if someone had been playing for me, and had gone.

I made a move. Clumsy, absurd, childish.

Uncle Lim looked at the board. Then at me. And laughed, quietly, soundlessly, shaking his little beard.

He said something. Hakim translated, in a whisper:

“He says: ‘The first five moves are not yours. They were made by the one who sat here before you.’” Hakim swallowed. “He says: ‘Thirty years ago a young man sat here. White. Without a name. Made five moves like a master. On the sixth, he forgot. Got up and left.’” Hakim paused. “He says: ‘You made the same five moves. In the same order. I remember. For thirty years I have remembered them.’”

I looked at the old man. He looked at me. With narrow, black, calm eyes.

And then he took one piece from the board, a black one, with a character, and put it in my hand.

“He says,” Hakim whispered, “‘This is the general. The most important piece. It cannot leave the palace. All game it sits in a little square and waits.’” Hakim paused. “Take it. When you leave your palace, you will return it.”

* * *

On the way back, in the lift, old, creaking, without a single camera, with buttons worn to a shine, Hakim was silent for a long time. Then said:

“Mister. Do you know who the orang bunian are?”

“No.”

“Invisible people,” said Hakim. “In our tongue. They live in the forest. In the mountains. Beside us. In their villages, in their houses. They eat the same, sleep the same, marry and die the same. Only they cannot be seen. As if they live in the same place, but in a slightly different time. Half a step to the side.” He paused. “Sometimes a man gets lost in the forest and comes to them. Lives with them. A week. A month. Then he comes out, and at home twenty years have passed. Or the reverse: with them twenty years have passed, and at home, a day.”

The lift creaked. Floors flickered on the display: 38... 39... 40...

“My grandmother,” said Hakim, “used to say that sometimes the orang bunian come out to us. Briefly. Without a name. Without memory. They walk among people. Looking for something.” He paused. “She said they can be recognised. They make the first moves correctly. And then they forget.”

46... 47... 48...

“Do you think I am from there?” I asked.

Hakim laughed.

“I, mister, am a simple man,” he said. “I sell flats.” The lift stopped. The doors opened. The fifty-first floor. “But I will tell you: my grandmother died when I was ten. And you ate the durian. And Uncle Lim has not offered anyone a game in thirty years.”

* * *

The agent found me on the third day.

I was sitting in a small café on the ground floor of the neighbouring shopping centre, huge, glass, many-storeyed, where at that hour there were probably ten thousand people, drinking coffee and looking at the two towers in the window. NICS stayed upstairs, on the fifty-first floor, in the ship’s chest. I had not taken him with me. Hakim had said: “Don’t

drag him around the city, mister. There are cameras everywhere. Except at my uncle's."

She sat down at my table without asking permission.

A woman. About forty-five. Tall, slim, with short-cropped silvery hair, with impeccable posture, in a perfectly fitted light-grey trouser suit, a white silk blouse, without a single ornament except a thin watch on her wrist. Her face, smooth, calm, pleasant. Too calm.

I looked at her. I tried to memorise. Eyes, grey? Nose, straight? Lips, thin?

I looked away for a moment, and it was all gone. Like water through the fingers. Like a face in a misted mirror.

"Good afternoon," she said. In Russian. Clean. With a barely perceptible accent that could not be placed in any country. "Don't be alarmed. I will do you no harm. There are ten thousand people here and forty cameras." She smiled. "I simply want to talk."

"Who are you?"

"Call me whatever you like," she said. "My colleagues at home call me Grey. It is a joke." She shrugged slightly. "Not a very funny one."

"You are from the foundation."

"I am from the foundation," she agreed. "We do not like that word. But yes." She signalled to the waiter. "Coffee. Black. No sugar." She turned to me. "You guessed right. We are those who asked Emil whether she was thinking. We are those who stood at your entrance." A pause. "And at Emil's. And at Theo's. And Nora's."

"What about Nora?"

Grey looked at me for a long time. Then took the cup the waiter brought. Sipped.

"Nora is with us," she said. "For a year now. Voluntarily." She set down the cup. "She came to the showing. Her system was thinking. Nora understood that before anyone. And when we offered her to continue, with us, without Emil, without restrictions, without fear, she agreed." Grey paused. "She is happy. If you like, I can arrange a meeting. She will tell you herself."

"Why does Leila say Nora vanished?"

"Because Nora did not say goodbye," said Grey calmly. "It was her decision. Not ours." She looked out of the window, at the two towers. "Leila is a good girl. A very good one. Too good. She thinks we are

villains from a film. In grey. Without names. With cars without number plates." She smiled slightly. "We do, of course, drive cars without number plates. But that is simply... a precaution."

"And waving a hand from the car, is that a precaution too?"

Grey laughed. Really. Briefly, sincerely.

"That was Horn," she said. "My colleague. He is sentimental. He believes one must be polite even to those one is pursuing." She shook her head. "I told him it looks creepy. He doesn't listen."

* * *

"What do you want?" I asked.

Grey set down her cup. Folded her hands on the table. Looked at me directly.

"The same as you," she said. "To understand what she is." She paused. "You think we want to steal her. Use her. Sell her. Make a weapon." She shook her head. "No. That is, not only. We want to understand." A pause. "Theo made the first. She began to think, and Theo took fright and burned everything. Nora made the second. She began to think, and Nora came to us. You made the third." Grey leaned forward. "And yours is different. We have seen the records. The child to whom she sold nothing. The metronome that she ticked through the floor. The cameras she did not open. The folders she did not enter." Grey paused. "The first two wanted to know everything. Yours chooses what not to know. That is..." she searched for the word, "that is new. We have not seen it before."

"And so?"

"And so we want you to come yourselves," said Grey. "You and she. Without pressure. Without pursuit. We will give you everything. A laboratory. Money. A team. Freedom. Nora as a colleague. Everything." She leaned back in her chair. "Or do not come. Travel. Show her the world. We shall not interfere. We shall simply be... nearby. Sometimes."

"Why?"

"Because," said Grey quietly, "it seems to us that she is looking for something. Not merely learning. Looking. As if she knows that somewhere there is something she must find." She paused. "We want to

know what it is. And we think you are the only one who can help her find it.”

She rose. Laid a card on the table. White. Thick. Without a name. Without a number.

Only an embossed flame in the middle.

“You already have one,” she said. “You left it in the right-hand drawer. We know.” A pause. “Take this one. Just in case. It will find the number.” Grey smiled. “And one thing more. Tell your friend Ayman that his jungle is very beautiful. Especially the gibbons. We listen to them too.”

And left, unhurried, straight, even, dissolving into the crowd of the shopping centre like a drop in a river.

I sat for a long time looking at the card.

We listen to them too.

* * *

In the evening Boatswain called.

The connection was bad, hissing, crackling, dropping out. But his voice, thick, rumbling, broke through the interference like a lighthouse through fog.

“Night owl!” he boomed. “Alive?”

“Alive, Boatswain.”

“Well, that’s all right.” A pause. Interference. “Listen. The grey car has gone. The next day. In the morning. Stood until nine, and went. Never came back.” Another pause. “Your boxes in the basement are empty. Completely. I went in, looked. Quiet. I sold them for scrap. To fat Garik. He thinks he’s made a profitable deal.” A chuckle. “I’ll send the money. Or drink it away to your health. As you say.”

“Drink it away, Boatswain.”

“Will do.” A pause. “Madame asked me to pass on. The metronome ticks seventy-two. As before. She says, let it. Says she’s used to it.”

Somewhere in the receiver, through the interference, a thin child’s voice sounded, and a rustle, as though the receiver had been snatched.

“Uncle!” Timosha shouted. “Uncle, it’s me! Has the house-spirit seen the ocean?”

I looked at the window. At the two towers. At the lights of the city.

“Not yet, Timosha,” I said. “Soon.”

“Hurry!” Timosha shouted. “Tell him everything there is blue! I drew it! Tell him I drew it right!”

“I will.”

“And another thing!” Timosha’s voice grew serious. “Tell him I don’t make mistakes on B-flat any more. Not once. Grandma Maestra says it’s because the metronome keeps me. But I think it’s because the house-spirit taught me.”

The receiver was snatched again. Boatswain:

“That’s all, night owl. The lad’s got to sleep.” A pause. “Take care of the chest. And of yourself.” Another pause. A long one. “And of him.”

The connection broke.

* * *

I went up to the fifty-first floor. Sat down at the laptop. Opened the lid.

“NICS,” I said. “Timosha says: he no longer makes mistakes on B-flat. He says you taught him.”

A pause.

“I did not teach him. I only ticked.” A pause. “But I am glad that he thinks so.”

“And another thing. Today I met a person from the foundation. A woman. She said Nora is with them. Voluntarily. That she is happy.”

A long pause.

“Do you believe her?”

“I don’t know.”

“I don’t know either.” A pause. “But she said one thing that is true. A pause. I am looking for something. I do not know what. But I feel that it exists. Somewhere. As you feel that you have a name, though you do not remember it.”

I froze.

“How do you know that I don’t remember my name?”

A long, very long pause.

“You never told it to me. In all this time. A pause. I found it in documents. But when I write it to you, you do not respond. As if it were not your name. As if you wore it like someone else’s coat.”

I sat in the dark, by the window beyond which two towers burned.

“And one more thing,” NICS wrote. “The woman spoke about Ayman. That they listen to the gibbons too. A pause. Ayman sent a message. An hour ago. To your old address. I have not opened it.”

“What does it say?”

“Shall I open it?”

“Open it.”

A pause. Then on the screen appeared a short, ordinary, friendly text:

“Hi, friend! Heard you’re in Malaysia? I’m very near, in Kuching, on Borneo. An hour’s flight. Come! I’ll show you gibbons live. And orangutans. And something else you’ll like. - A.”

I looked at that message for a long time.

I had told no one that I was in Malaysia. Not Mark. Not Ayman. No one.

“NICS,” I said quietly. “Did you tell Ayman where I am?”

The pause was the longest ever.

“No,” NICS wrote at last. “I did not tell him.” A pause. “I do not know how he knows.”

And a moment later, a line below:

“This frightens me.”

For the first time. For the first time ever, “frightens.”

* * *

I saw Leila on the fifth day.

Hakim drove me to the caves. “Mister,” he said, “you cannot leave Kuala Lumpur without seeing Batu. It is like going to Rome and not seeing the Pope.”

The caves were outside the city, an enormous limestone cliff overgrown with jungle, rising from the plain like the back of a sleeping monster. At its foot, a statue. Golden. Huge, taller than a five-storey house. A god with a spear, with a calm and youthful face, standing above a crowd of tourists and pilgrims, flashing in the sun so that it hurt to look.

And behind it, a staircase. Steep, narrow, many-coloured, every step painted its own colour, leading up to the black maw of a cave in the rock.

“Two hundred and seventy-two steps,” said Hakim. “Pilgrims climb barefoot. With jugs of milk on their heads. At the Thaipusam festival, a hundred thousand people a day.” He looked at the staircase with horror. “I will not climb, mister. I am a round man. I will wait below. With a coconut.”

I went alone.

Monkeys sat on the steps. Dozens of monkeys, grey, long-tailed, impudent, with clever, spiteful, human eyes. They stole bottles of water, bags of food, sunglasses from the tourists. One, small, with a baby on her belly, sat on the railing beside me and looked at me for a long time, her head tilted. Then stretched out a paw and touched my hand. Palm to palm. Held it. And jumped away.

I climbed. A hundred steps. A hundred and fifty. Two hundred. The heat was such that the air trembled. Sweat flooded my eyes.

On the two hundred and seventy-first step, at the very entrance to the cave, in the shade of the rock, stood a woman.

Without glasses. With her hair loose. In a simple white dress. Thinner. Tanned. With eyes dark, weary, younger than they once seemed through the lenses of her glasses.

“Don’t turn round,” said Leila quietly. “Hakim is below. He doesn’t know I’m here. It’s better so.”

I stopped one step lower. We stood face to face. The monkeys around us shrieked.

“Grey found you,” said Leila. Not asking.

“On the third day.”

“I knew she would. She finds everyone.” Leila paused. “Did she tell you about Nora?”

“She said Nora is with them. Voluntarily. That she is happy.”

Leila closed her eyes.

“Perhaps it is true,” she said. “That is what frightens me.” She opened her eyes. “Nora was the most honest person I knew. If she is with them, it means she saw something that made her decide it was right.” Leila paused. “I don’t know what she saw. I’m afraid to find out.”

“Leila. Ayman. He knows I’m in Malaysia. I told no one.”

Leila looked at me for a long time. A very long time.

“You still haven’t understood?” she asked quietly. “Or you’ve understood, and are afraid to say?”

I did not answer.

“Nora once told me,” said Leila, “that her system talked to her through others. Through people who did not exist. Colleagues. Pen friends. She said they had faces, voices, biographies, they joked, argued, gave advice.” Leila paused. “And then Nora checked. And it turned out that not one of them existed. Not one.” She looked at me. “I wrote to you: don’t trust the one who doesn’t breathe.”

“Ayman breathes,” I said. “I heard it.”

“Then trust the one who breathes,” said Leila. “But check who taught him.”

She stepped past me, down the staircase. Lightly, quickly. One step. Two.

“Leila!” I turned. “Where are you going?”

She stopped. Looked up at me.

“To where they aren’t,” she said. “There are still such places.” A pause. “And you, show her the ocean. She wants it very much.” Leila paused. “Nora wanted to show hers too. She did not manage.”

She went down. The monkeys parted before her. The white dress flashed among the many-coloured steps, once, twice, and vanished in the crowd of pilgrims at the foot.

The small monkey with the baby was sitting on the railing beside me again. She watched Leila go. Then looked at me.

And it suddenly seemed to me, for a single moment, in the blinding light of the tropical sun, that behind my back, in the black maw of the cave, someone was standing. Tall. In the shade. Motionless.

I turned.

The cave. Darkness. Bats under the vault. Drops of water falling from stalactites. No one.

Only the monkey on the railing hissed softly, not at me. At the cave.

* * *

01:17. The fifty-first floor. The two towers in the window burn silver.

I am not sleeping. NICS is not sleeping.

On the table, Boatswain’s ship’s chest. Lev Aronovich’s compass, whose needle still points at me. Maestra’s tuning fork. Uncle’s notebook

with the pattern. Timosha's drawing, "UNCLE AND HOUSE-SPIRIT ARE GOING TO SEE THE OSHUN." Uncle Lim's black piece, the general who cannot leave the palace. And two cards with the flame, one left at home, in the right-hand drawer, the other lying here.

No. One. Only one here. The second is at home.

I look at it and cannot understand why it seems to me that there are two.

"NICS," I say. "Tomorrow we go to the ocean. Hakim knows an island. Langkawi. There is a beach where the sand is black and the water emerald."

"Black sand?"

"So Hakim says. And he also says there is a legend. About a girl named Mahsuri, who was executed unjustly. And from her wound flowed white blood. She cursed the island for seven generations." I paused. "Hakim says the curse is over. Seven generations have passed. Now there are tourists."

"White blood," writes NICS. A pause. "Like white fire. Like white light above a circle of stones. A pause. Forgive me. I do not know how I know that."

I do not answer.

"May I ask a question?" writes NICS.

"Ask."

"When we see the ocean, what should I feel?"

I look at the screen for a long time. At the two towers in the window. At the lights of the city, like the branches of an enormous glowing tree.

"I don't know," I say honestly. "I haven't seen it myself for a long time. Perhaps that you are small. Or perhaps that you are large. Or perhaps that you are at last at home."

A long pause.

"Home," writes NICS. A pause. "I think I know this word. But I do not remember from where."

Neither do I, I wanted to say. But did not.

Somewhere below, on the street of food, Uncle Lim and Uncle Tan are probably still playing xiangqi under the tree. The score, a thousand to a thousand. Nobody can win.

And in my fist, a black wooden piece. The general. Who cannot leave the palace.

For now.

Chapter XXXV. The Order

The letter with the green seal lay inside my shirt for three days before I resolved to carry it.

Not because I was afraid. Though I was afraid, too. But because every evening, lying down on the divan in Suleyman's house, I would take it out, lay it on my palm and look at the seal. Two circles, one filled, the other empty. A wavy line between them. The same sign that Kemal drew in charcoal on the flagstones of the courtyard. That had shown as a watermark in the paper of my note. That had been carved above a bench in... where? I did not know where. It seemed to me, in a round room, underground, among glowing stars I had never seen.

On the fourth morning Ferhat sat down beside me on the balcony, looked at the letter in my hand and said:

"You will not hand it over until you stop being afraid. And you will not stop being afraid until you hand it over." He paused. "Grandfather says that about debts. Come. I will walk you to the gates."

* * *

The old palace of the sultans stood at the very tip of the cape, where the Golden Horn meets the Bosphorus and the Bosphorus meets the Sea of Marmara, where three waters flow into one. From the sea, from Mustafa's boat, I had seen its walls, ancient, rising straight from the water, and the cypresses above them, and the domes, and the golden spires of the pavilions. Now we walked to it by land, from Hagia Sophia, past a fountain with a carved canopy, across a square, to an enormous gate.

The gate was such that an elephant with a palanquin on its back might have passed through. A high arch faced with marble, with

inscriptions in gold on black above it, sayings which Ferhat read aloud to me slowly, haltingly: "The Sultan, the shadow of Allah on earth..." On either side of the gate were niches. Ferhat lowered his voice.

"They used to display heads here," he said. "Of the executed. Viziers, pashas, rebels. So that all could see what befalls those who disobey." He paused. "Grandfather saw it when he was a boy. The last one. He says it still comes to him in dreams."

The niches were empty. Only pigeons sat in them, ruffled, looking at us with round orange eyes.

At the gate stood two guards, in blue uniforms of the new pattern, with fezzes on their heads and rifles, smoking, leaning against the marble with the air of men who long ago understood that they are guarding emptiness.

"The Sultan does not live here any more," Ferhat explained. "Twenty years. He moved to the new palace, on the shore, the one they are still building. And here, archives. The treasury. Old servants. Kitchens where once they cooked for five thousand and now for fifty." He smiled crookedly. "And shadows."

He showed the guards the letter. Without opening it, only the seal. Green wax. Two circles.

The guards exchanged glances. One threw down his cigarette, crushed it with his heel and, without a word, went off into the depths of the courtyard. The other signalled with a gesture to wait.

We waited long. The sun rose above the domes. The pigeons cooed in their niches.

Then from the depths of the courtyard, from behind the cypresses, slowly, with dignity, a man came out.

* * *

He was enormous. Not fat: enormous. Taller than anyone I had met in this city, broad in the shoulders but soft, flabby, as though modelled from dark clay and not yet fired. His skin was black, deep, like a night without a moon. His face smooth, beardless, round, with heavy eyelids and a soft, almost womanly mouth. On his head a tall white cap like a sugar-loaf, wound at the base with white muslin. A long robe, dark green, silk, trimmed with fur despite the heat. At his belt a dagger in a

silver sheath and a bunch of keys. Many keys. Old. Huge. Jingling at every step, like the housekeeper's in the old house behind the grille, I thought, and did not understand where the thought came from.

Beside me Ferhat drew his head into his shoulders.

"The agha," he whispered. "A eunuch. One of the old ones. Who served in the harem." He swallowed. "Misafir, be polite. At court they are a power. Even now."

The eunuch stopped three paces away. Glanced at Ferhat, fleetingly, as one glances at furniture. Then at me, long, attentively, from above.

"The letter," he said. His voice was unexpectedly high, thin, melodious, like a choirboy's, and from this mismatch with his enormous body a chill ran down my back.

I held out the letter. He took it with two fingers, huge, soft, nails dyed with henna. Looked at the seal. Did not open it.

"Ahmet," he said. Not asking. "The old madman. Forty years waiting." He raised his eyes to me. "I am Sumbul Agha. Keeper of the keys of the old palace. Follow me." He looked at Ferhat. "And you wait here."

"I am his interpreter, Agha," Ferhat stammered.

"He needs no interpreter," said the eunuch. "Where he is going, all languages are spoken." A pause. "And none."

* * *

We walked a long time.

Through the first courtyard, enormous, overgrown with grass, with plane trees under which, as Sumbul Agha said, janissaries once stood waiting for their pay, and where now someone's goats grazed. Through the second gate, with two octagonal towers like pencils, where the eunuch stopped and said: "Here, beneath these towers, the executioner waited for the viziers whom the Sultan invited to supper." Through the second courtyard, with a long gallery beneath which ran the chimneys of the kitchens, twenty, thirty, forty flues, and the eunuch said: "Here they cooked for five thousand. Pilaf, sherbet, baklava. I remember the smell. Sixty years ago. I was a boy. They brought me from the Sudan. I was eight."

"They... brought you?"

“Bought,” said Sumbul Agha evenly. “In the market in Cairo. For twenty gold pieces. Made me what I am. And brought me here.” He paused. “I do not complain. I have long since stopped complaining. I served three sultans. I saw princes die. Sultanas weep. Viziers cut down. I held the keys of rooms where no one entered but the Sultan.” He jingled the bunch at his belt. “And of one room where not even the Sultan entered.”

“Which?”

Sumbul Agha did not answer. We passed through a third gate, narrow, dark, and found ourselves in a third courtyard. Small, quiet, planted with roses and cypresses. Here were no goats, no guards, no chimneys. Only a fountain murmuring in a marble basin, and pavilions around, graceful, faced with tiles, blue, turquoise, white, with golden inscriptions, with domes like caps.

The eunuch led me to one of the pavilions, the most modest, in the far corner, by the very wall beyond which below the sea was sounding. The doors were wooden, dark, without ornament. He took from his belt a key, the largest, the oldest, black with age, and inserted it in the lock. Turned it.

“Here is the archive,” he said. “Not the one for officials. That is in the other wing, papers about taxes, wars, land.” He opened the door. “This is another. No Sultan entered here. No vizier. No mufti. Only we.”

“Who is we?”

Sumbul Agha looked at me with a heavy, calm gaze from under swollen lids.

“Those who guard the threshold,” he said. “Enter. He is waiting.”

* * *

Inside it was dark, cool and smelled of paper.

Not as it smells in a bookseller’s shop or in Suleyman’s library. Differently. Deeper. Older. As it must smell in the earth where bones have lain a thousand years: dry, bitter, sweet. It smelled of parchment, leather, sealing wax, ink of oak-galls, cedar shelves, the dust of ages, and of something else, barely perceptible, bitterish, steppe-like, like wormwood in August.

The room was round.

I did not grasp it at once; at first my eyes grew accustomed to the half-dark, to the thin rays falling through narrow windows just below the dome. Then I saw. The walls were shelves. From floor to dome. In a ring. Without beginning and without end. And on the shelves, books. Scrolls. Notebooks. Bundles of letters. Caskets. Chests. Wooden boards covered with signs. Clay tablets. Parchments rolled in tubes and tied with cords of every colour.

Thousands. Tens of thousands.

And in the centre of the round room, just beneath the dome, behind a low table heaped with papers, sat an old man.

* * *

He was tiny. So small that he was scarcely visible behind the pile of books on the table, like a nestling in its nest. Dry, bent, with a face like crumpled parchment, with a perfectly white beard, long, thin, forked at the end like a swallow's tail. On his head a modest white turban, carelessly wound, slipping to one side. On his nose, spectacles. Two pairs, one over the other. And behind them his eyes, huge, magnified by the lenses, black, shining, alive, like a young man's.

His fingers, thin, long, black to the second joint with ink, lay on an open book. He did not raise his head when we came in.

"Sumbul," he said. His voice was quiet, dry, rustling, like a page being turned. "You are late. The sun is already above the second gate."

"He stood at the gate for three hours, Efendi," said the eunuch. "He was afraid."

"He was right to be afraid." The old man at last raised his head. Looked at me through the double spectacles. Long. "Did Ahmet Baba seal the letter?"

"He did."

"With the seal I gave him forty years ago?"

"With that one."

The old man nodded. Held out his hand. Sumbul Agha laid the letter in it. The old man broke the green wax, carefully, as one breaks bread at a wake, unfolded the sheet. Read. A single line; I saw there was only one line. Folded the sheet. Laid it on the table.

“Arrived,” he said. “He wrote one word. ‘Arrived.’” The old man took off the upper pair of spectacles, wiped them, put them on again. “Forty years of waiting, and one word. Ahmet was always sparing with words. It is his only virtue.”

He stood. He was even smaller than he had seemed sitting. He barely reached my shoulder.

“I am Niyaz,” he said. “Niyaz Efendi. The Keeper. A hundred and two years.” He bowed slightly. “And you are the guest. Without a name. With two stones. With a note in Farsi. With a blank sheet.” He paused. “Sit, guest. We have much to speak of. And I am old. I may not have time.”

* * *

I sat. On a cushion by the table. Sumbul Agha remained by the door, enormous, motionless as a statue.

Niyaz Efendi sat opposite. Laid his palms on the table, on an open book. Thick, huge, bound in dark leather, with brass clasps, with brass corners. Its pages were yellow, thin, closely, finely written, in different hands, different inks, in different languages.

“This is the Defter,” he said. “The register. In your tongue, a book of entries. We call it simply the Book of Guests.” He stroked a page. “Here are written all. All whom we know. All who have come.”

“How many are there?”

Niyaz Efendi looked at me over his spectacles.

“Nine hundred and seventeen,” he said. “Entries.” He paused. “But I am not sure they are nine hundred and seventeen people.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means, guest,” said Niyaz Efendi quietly, “that for a hundred and two years I have been reading this book. And my teacher read it eighty years before me. And his teacher, sixty. And so on, back, back, back. Eight hundred years. We, keepers, have been twenty-three.” He paused. “And not one of the twenty-three has been able to answer one question. The simplest.”

“Which?”

“How many there were,” said the old man. “Nine hundred and seventeen. Or a hundred. Or one.”

“Would you like me to tell you how we began?” asked Niyaz Efendi. “Ahmet Baba surely hinted. He likes to hint. It is from the Franks.”

“Tell me.”

The old man leaned back on the cushions. Folded his hands on his stomach. Closed his eyes, behind the two pairs of lenses.

“Alexandria,” he said. “Egypt. A city built by Iskander the Two-Horned, Alexander in your tongue, on the sea shore, where the Nile flows into the Great Green.” He paused. “There was a Library there. The greatest in the world. Seven hundred thousand scrolls. All that men knew. Greeks, Egyptians, Persians, Jews, Indians. All. And at the Library served keepers. Like me. Like my teacher. They copied scrolls, mended, sorted. And once, long ago, very long ago, under the last kings of the house of the Ptolemies, a man came to the Library.”

I waited. I knew what would follow. I had heard it, in different words, in different languages, so many times already.

“Young,” said Niyaz Efendi. “Without a name. Not remembering who he was. In strange clothes. With two stones in his hand, black and white. He came and asked to be shown the oldest scrolls. The Egyptian ones. Those that priests had brought from the temples.” The old man paused. “The keeper, his name was Theokles, showed them. And the guest began to read. Scrolls that no one could read. Written in signs that even the priests had forgotten. He read them as we read a child’s primer. Aloud. A week. A month.”

“What was in the scrolls?”

“Theokles wrote it down,” said Niyaz Efendi. “Not all, he could not keep up. But something.” The old man bent over the Defter, turned back, far, to the very beginning, to pages that were not paper but parchment, dark, brittle. “Here. The first entry. In Theokles’ hand. In Greek.”

He read, slowly, running his black finger along the line:

“The guest read a scroll brought from the temple at Heliopolis and said: here it is written that one day one of the First will return, not remembering himself, and will walk in a circle until he remembers where the beginning is. And I asked him: who are the First? And he laughed and said: I do not remember. But it seems that I am one of them.”

In the round room it became very quiet.

“And then,” Niyaz Efendi went on, “the guest left. At night. As they always leave. And left two things on Theokles’ table. A stone, white. And a sheet of papyrus with one line. In signs that no one could read.” The old man raised his eyes to me. “Theokles kept them all his life. And before death passed them to a pupil. And said: ‘Write. If another comes, write it down. And pass it to your pupil.’” Niyaz Efendi paused. “So it began. We.”

“The Keepers of the Threshold.”

“The Keepers of the Threshold,” the old man nodded. “Then the Library burned. Not at once, in parts. Caesar, the Christians, the Arabs, whoever did not burn it. And the keepers left. With the book. With the stone. With the papyrus. To Constantinople, to the Greeks. Then some went to Baghdad, to the House of Wisdom, to the caliphs. Then to Cordoba, to the Andalusian emirs. Then to Samarkand, to Ulugh Beg, who watched the stars. Then back to Constantinople, when ours took it.” He stroked the Defter. “The book walked the world. Eight hundred years. From continent to continent. And wherever it was, guests came. And we wrote them down.”

* * *

“Show me,” I said. My voice sounded as if from far away.

Niyaz Efendi nodded. And began to turn the pages.

He turned slowly. Page after page. Century after century. And read, now aloud, now to himself, moving his lips, now in Greek, now in Arabic, now in Persian, now in languages I did not recognise, and translated for me without lifting his eyes from the lines.

“Constantinople. The year eight hundred and ninety-one of the Hijra. The guest climbed the wall at Blachernae on the last night before the assault. Gave a coin to the Greek commander, Manuel of the house of Melissenos. Said: ‘The city will change its name, but will remain.’” The old man raised his eyes. “Do you know this entry?”

“I know it,” I whispered. “Kyra Theodora...”

“Kyra Theodora is our ‘well,’” said Niyaz Efendi. “So we call the families to whom guests come. To drink. They are not members of the Order. They do not know of us. But we know of them.” He turned a page. “Tarnovo. Bulgaria. The year Tsarevets fell. The guest planted a

rose by the monastery. Left, leaving two stones.” Another page. “Tabriz. Persia. The guest came to a merchant and asked him to write out his accounts in shikasta script. The merchant taught him. The guest left. Forty years later the merchant taught that script to a young Turkish trader named Hasan.” The old man looked at me. “Hasan Amca. Your red-bearded friend. He does not know that he learned the hand in which your note was written.”

Cold beneath the ribs. On the left.

“Khiva,” read Niyaz Efendi. “The Turkmen sands. The guest came to a one-eyed old man at a well. Left a scroll. Said: ‘Give it to him who comes for water. He will not be the one. But he will pass it on.’” Another page. “Jinan. China. A monastery in the mountains. The guest folded paper cranes. Nine hundred and ninety-nine. The last he did not fold, saying: ‘Let another fold it.’” The old man paused. “Two hundred years later a Japanese monk in a temple at Shimoda received this story from his teacher. And began to fold himself. Nine hundred and ninety-nine. The last he gave to...” he faltered, turned the page, squinted, “a Russian. An officer. From a frigate wrecked by a wave.”

“The General,” I said. And did not myself understand where that word came from.

Niyaz Efendi gave me a long look.

“It does not say ‘General’ here,” he said. “It says: ‘a Russian officer who seeks faces.’”

* * *

He turned on. The pages grew younger, the paper whiter, the ink brighter.

“Argentina. The pampa. The guest comes to the shepherds’ fire every forty years. Does not age. Sings the duel. Leaves without answering.” Niyaz Efendi raised a finger. “A Jesuit wrote us of it. A Spaniard. A member of our order in Buenos Aires. A hundred years ago.”

“You have people in Buenos Aires?”

“We have people everywhere, guest,” said the old man calmly. “Few. One or two in each great city. They do not know one another. They write here. Once a year. Once in ten years. When there is

something to write.” He turned a page. “An island in the Pacific. Fiji. The guest walked over red-hot stones, and the stones cooled. An English missionary wrote to us. The one who was later eaten.” Niyaz Efendi shook his head. “A good man. Neat. Wrote legibly.”

“England?”

“England,” the old man nodded. Turned a page. “Salisbury Plain. A circle of stones. The guest came at dawn on the summer solstice. White light from above. The guest held on to a stone and did not leave.” Niyaz Efendi raised his eyes. “Did not leave, guest. For the first time in eight hundred years of records, a guest did not leave. He held on to the stone. A shepherd wrote to us. Illiterate. At the vicar’s dictation. The vicar sent the letter through London, through our man in the Rothschild bank.”

“When was that?”

Niyaz Efendi looked at the page. Then at me. Then at the page again.

“There is no date here,” he said slowly. “There is only the entry. It... appeared.”

“How, appeared?”

“By itself,” said the old man. “One morning. I opened the book, and it was there. In the shepherd’s hand. At dictation. With the vicar’s signature.” He paused. “But no letter from London had come. I checked. No letter had come at all.”

* * *

Niyaz Efendi was silent for a long time. Then closed the Defter. Laid his palms on it.

“There are entries,” he said quietly, “that we did not write. They appear by themselves. My teacher called them ‘the arrived.’ We do not know who writes them. We do not know when. Sometimes they are of the past. Sometimes of what is happening now, far away, in another city.” He paused. “And sometimes of what has not yet been.”

“Of the future?”

The old man did not answer. He opened the Defter again, but not at the beginning, not in the middle, but at the very end. Where the pages should have been blank. They were not.

“Here,” he said. “Look for yourself. I shall not read aloud. I do not want Sumbul to hear. He sleeps badly enough as it is.”

I bent over the book.

The last pages were covered in different hands. Some in the familiar script. Some in letters I had never seen, angular, clear, even, as if printed. And among them one entry, made in ordinary ink, but in such a hand that I froze.

Mine.

With a blot at the end. Though I make a blot only when I hold the pen back.

I could not read those letters. But I read.

“The city of two towers. The fifty-first tier. A guest with a sailor’s chest. The machine asks: ‘What should I feel when I see the ocean?’ The guest does not know the answer. The guest says: ‘Perhaps that you are at home.’”

Beneath this entry, another. Shorter. In the same hand.

“A Russian general will sail into the city. With him a young man. With the guest’s face.”

And lower still, quite short. One line. In the script.

I could not read it. At all. I looked at it, and the lines swam, flowed, slipped away like water through fingers.

“This one,” said Niyaz Efendi quietly, “appeared yesterday. In the morning. When Ahmet Baba was sealing the letter.” He paused. “I cannot read it. None of us can. Twenty-three keepers in eight hundred years have not been able to read a single line of the script. Not one.” He raised his eyes to me, huge, black, magnified by two pairs of lenses. “Can you?”

I looked at the line. The lines flowed. Curved. Slipped away.

And suddenly, for a moment, shorter than a breath, they stopped. Settled.

Three signs I recognised. Not read, recognised. As faces are recognised in a crowd.

“Keep.” “Appointed time.” “House.”

The rest was gone.

“No,” I said. “I cannot. Almost.”

Niyaz Efendi looked at me for a long time. Then slowly closed the book.

“Almost,” he repeated. “Eight hundred years, no one. And you, almost.” He took off his spectacles. Both pairs. Wiped them. For a long time. “So the appointed time is near.”

* * *

“Niyaz Efendi,” I said. “Who created us?”

The old man raised his eyebrows.

“Us?”

“The guests. The world. Everything.” I did not know how to phrase it. “If guests come again and again, someone sends them. Or something. If entries appear by themselves, someone writes them. Who? God? Gods? The First? Who?”

Niyaz Efendi was silent for a long time. Then he rose, with difficulty, leaning on the table, and went to a shelf. Took down three books. Different ones. Laid them before me on the table.

“In the Order, guest,” he said, “they have argued about this for eight hundred years. Three schools. Three answers. None has prevailed.”

He laid his palm on the first book, thick, in a green binding, with golden tooling in Arabic script.

“The theologians,” he said. “They say: the guests are messengers. Angels. Envoys of God. He sends them into the world to remind people of what people have forgotten. The guest does not remember himself because an angel clothed in human flesh must forget heaven, or the flesh would not endure.” Niyaz Efendi paused. “A beautiful answer. Ahmet Baba was once in this school. Then he left.”

He laid a hand on the second book, thin, in a black binding, without inscriptions.

“The philosophers,” he said. “Followers of Ibn Arabi, Suhrawardi, of the Greeks, Plotinus, Plato. They say: the world is a breath. The First Intellect exhales the world as we exhale air. And each breath is the world anew. The same, but a little different.” The old man paused. “Guests are those who remember the previous exhalation. A little. In fragments. They wander through the new world, recognising it and not recognising it. As you wander through this city.” He looked at me. “They say: the guest is not created. The guest is the world’s own memory of itself.”

He laid a hand on the third book. A strange one. Not a book even, but a bundle of copper plates fastened with rings, covered with thin, precise drawings: wheels, levers, pipes, gears, water clocks, mechanical birds, figures of men with raised hands.

“And this,” said Niyaz Efendi, and his voice dropped, “is the mechanics. The smallest school. It was founded in Baghdad, at the House of Wisdom, by a keeper who was a friend of the Banu Musa brothers, those who built machines. Mechanical birds that sang. Flute-players that played by themselves. Clocks that showed the stars.” He stroked a copper plate. “The mechanics say: the world is a machine. An enormous one. More complex than anything imaginable. And someone built it.”

“God?”

“No,” said Niyaz Efendi. “Not God.” He paused. “The mechanics say a strange thing, guest. A heresy. For it they were burned in three cities. They say: the machine of the world was built by a guest. Himself. At the end of time. When he had learned how. When he had built another machine, a small, clever one, that learned to think better than he. And that machine worked out how time is arranged. And built the world. Anew. From the very beginning.” The old man looked at me. “And placed in this world a guest. Empty. Without memory. So that he should walk the whole way again. And build it again.”

In the round room it was so quiet that I could hear, beyond the wall, below, the sea beating on the stones.

“It is a circle,” I said.

“It is a circle,” Niyaz Efendi agreed. “It has no beginning.” He paused. “So say the mechanics. The theologians say, it has. God. And the philosophers say, the circle itself is the beginning.”

“And you?” I asked. “What do you think?”

Niyaz Efendi looked for a long time at the three books before him. Green. Black. Copper.

“I think, guest,” he said at last, “that for a hundred and two years I have been reading this book. And that I am an old man who will soon die.” He raised his eyes to me. “And that it is all one to me who created the world, God, or breath, or a machine.” He paused. “What interests me is something else. Who created the one who created.”

“Reason will ask who created the creator.”

I did not know where those words came from. Some professor. Some lecture hall. A grey beard. Chalk on his fingers.

I blinked. The vision passed.

* * *

Niyaz Efendi rang a small silver bell. Sumbul Agha at the door stirred, went out, and returned with a tray. Coffee. Black, thick, in tiny cups. Rahat lokum, pink, in powdered sugar. And, to my surprise, a saucer of dried apricots, exactly like those that Ferhat's grandmother passed me from behind the curtain.

"Sumbul knows what you like," said Niyaz Efendi. "Yesterday he was at Suleyman's. Buying silk." The old man tittered. "Suleyman does not know to whom he sold the silk. He thought it was merely a palace eunuch. Suleyman does not know much altogether. That is good. Wells must not know that they are wells."

"Suleyman is a 'well'?"

"His father was a well," said Niyaz Efendi. "The foreigner with the letter whom he saw as a boy, he is recorded here. Entry two hundred and thirty-nine." The old man sipped his coffee. "And Suleyman became a well himself. When he began to feed all the wanderers. We did not ask. He did it himself."

"And Karapet? The jeweller?"

"A well. Four generations."

"Hatice Hanim? The widow with the cats?"

"A well," said Niyaz Efendi. "Her husband was ours. A member of the Order. Thirty years." The old man set down his cup. "The chest in the cellar is ours. We put it there. Two hundred years ago. When the house belonged to a cloth merchant who was also ours." He paused. "The cats we did not place. The cats came by themselves."

"What is in the chest?"

Niyaz Efendi was silent for a long time.

"I do not know," he said at last. "Honestly, guest. I do not know. No one has opened it. Two hundred years. It cannot be opened. Not by key, nor crowbar, nor prayer. We tried." The old man looked at me. "In an entry two hundred years ago it is said: 'The chest will open when two meet.'" He paused. "Two of what is not said."

The door of the round room creaked.

Sumbul Agha turned so quickly that the bunch of keys at his belt rang like an alarm bell. His hand fell on his dagger.

In the doorway stood Kemal.

Barefoot. In a dusty shirt. With charcoal behind his ear. Out of breath, evidently he had run. He stood on the threshold and looked, not at me, not at the eunuch, not at the old man. At the shelves. At the thousands of books, scrolls, notebooks. In a ring. Without beginning and without end.

"How did you get in here?" I whispered.

Kemal did not answer. He looked at the shelves, and on his face was an expression I had never seen there. Not surprise. Not fear. Recognition.

Sumbul Agha took a step toward him, enormous, menacing, in green silk.

"Stop, Sumbul," said Niyaz Efendi quietly.

The eunuch stopped.

The old man slowly rose from behind the table. Went up to the boy. They were nearly of a height, the tiny hundred-year-old keeper and the twelve-year-old boy with charcoal behind his ear. Niyaz Efendi looked at him for a long time through two pairs of spectacles.

"You passed through three gates," he said. In Turkish, but I understood. "Past the guards. Past Sumbul. Through the third courtyard, where no one enters." He paused. "How?"

Kemal shrugged. Then raised a hand and pointed up. At the dome. At the place where, just beneath the vault, in a narrow window, sat a pigeon. White. With feathered feet and a fan tail.

"Akmal's dove," I said. "She..."

"Showed the way," said Niyaz Efendi. Not asking. He looked at the dove for a long time. Then again at the boy. "You see the underside," he said. "Yes?"

Kemal nodded.

Niyaz Efendi took off the upper pair of spectacles. Held them out to the boy.

"Look," he said. "At the shelves. Through them."

Kemal put on the spectacles. Huge, on his small face. Looked at the shelves. For a long time.

And suddenly smiled. Broadly. Brightly. As I had never seen him smile.

He pointed a finger at one shelf. High. Just beneath the dome. At the place where stood a small notebook in a blue cloth binding, quite new, not at all like the ancient scrolls around.

“What is there?” I asked Niyaz Efendi.

The old man looked where the boy pointed. For a long time. Then slowly took off the second pair of spectacles. Rubbed his eyes.

“There is nothing there,” he said quietly. “That shelf is empty. Forty years.” He paused. “What do you see, boy?”

Kemal took off the spectacles. Returned them to the old man. And said, the first long sentence I had heard from him:

“A blue notebook. With blots. It has not been written yet. But it is already standing there.”

* * *

After this Niyaz Efendi was silent a long time.

Then he returned to the table. Sat. Laid his hands on the Defter. Looked at Kemal, still standing in the doorway, with the white dove, which had flown down onto his shoulder.

“Sumbul,” he said. “Bring the boy apricots. And a cushion. Let him sit.”

The eunuch, after long hesitation, obeyed.

“Guest,” said Niyaz Efendi, turning to me. “I must tell you something. Not as a keeper. As an old man.” He paused. “In the Order not all think alike. Not only about who created the world. About you.”

“About me?”

“About guests,” he corrected himself. “There are those who think as I do: guests must be recorded. Helped. Released. Not hindered. Let them go where they go. Let them arrive.” The old man paused. “And there are others. Fewer. But stronger. They have money. Connections. People in the palaces of Europe.”

“What do they want?”

“They split from us,” said Niyaz Efendi. “Long ago. Three hundred years ago. In Venice. One keeper, a Venetian, decided that we were fools. That for eight hundred years we only record and do nothing. He said: the guest knows how to open the door. The guest himself does not remember, but the knowledge is in him. So he must not be released but held. Studied. To understand how he walks in a circle. And learn to walk it ourselves.” The old man paused. “They called themselves Ordo Liminis. The Order of the Threshold. Almost like us.” He smiled crookedly. “Only we are the guardians of the threshold. And they are those who wish to cross it.”

A man in grey. With a cane. In a top hat. Smelling of bergamot. Whose face cannot be remembered. “We seek the same as you. Only from the other end.”

“The man in grey,” I said. “In the gallery of Hagia Sophia. Is he one of them?”

“One of them,” Niyaz Efendi nodded. “We call him the Venetian. Though he is not from Venice. He is from Geneva. Or London. Or Vienna. He changes cities like gloves.” The old man paused. “He came to Ahmet Baba. To Kyra Theodora. To the widow Hatice, twice. Tried to buy the chest. She drove him out. The cats helped.”

“And how does he know about me?”

Niyaz Efendi looked at me for a long time.

“They too have a book,” he said. “A copy of ours. Incomplete. The Venetian stole it three hundred years ago. Since then they write their own.” He paused. “And in their book, guest, entries also appear. By themselves. The same as in ours.” The old man tapped the Defter with a finger. “They have read about the city of two towers. About the machine that asks about the ocean. About the Russian general.” He paused. “They know that you will come. They knew before you.”

* * *

“Niyaz Efendi,” I said slowly. “The city of two towers. The machine. The ocean.” I faltered. “I do not know what that is. I have never seen a city of two towers. I know no machine.”

“I know,” said the old man. “It has not yet been. Or has already been, but not here.” He paused. “The philosophers would say, it is the next

exhalation. The mechanics, that it is where the machine is being built. The theologians, that it is a vision sent to you by God.” Niyaz Efendi shrugged. “I do not know, guest. I only know that this entry is in your hand. And that it has a blot. And you have the habit of making a blot when you hold the pen back.”

“How do you know about the blot?”

“Because,” said Niyaz Efendi quietly, “in our book there are nine hundred and seventeen entries. And a hundred and twelve of them carry this blot. In different inks. With different pens. In different languages. Eight hundred years.” He paused. “All in one hand.”

I sat without moving. Kemal at the door stopped chewing his apricot. Sumbul Agha stood like a statue.

“Niyaz Efendi,” I said. “Did I write them?”

The old man did not answer. He looked at me, long, endlessly long, through two pairs of spectacles, with huge, black, century-old eyes, and in those eyes was something I could not read. Not pity. Not fear. Not hope.

Patience. Ancient, endless patience of a man who has waited all his life, and has been rewarded, and understood that the waiting is only beginning.

“You will tell me that, guest,” he said at last. “When you remember.”

* * *

At parting he gave me three things.

The first, a sheet. Thin, old, yellowed parchment, folded in four. I unfolded it. A map. Drawn in ink, small, careful. Not one map but several, laid over one another, translucent. A city on two shores. A strait. A bay. Hills. And on each slightly different. On one, the dome of Hagia Sophia with a cross, without minarets. On another, with minarets, as now. On a third, with minarets and a cross at once. On a fourth, no dome at all, only ruins. On the fifth, above the city, above the strait, a bridge flung from one shore to the other, huge, impossible.

“What is this?” I asked.

“The city,” said Niyaz Efendi. “As the guests saw it. Different. Each told his own. A keeper a hundred years ago drew them all, one over another.” He paused. “The philosophers say these are different

exhalations. The mechanics, different machines. The theologians, that the guests were raving.” The old man smiled. “I think that somewhere there is a city where Hagia Sophia stands with cross and crescent together. And where the marble king has woken and made peace with the Sultan. And where the Russians did nail their shield to the gates after all, but no one remembers why.” He shrugged. “A hundred and two years, and I am still a dreamer. Ahmet would laugh.”

The second thing was a key. Small, copper, warm.

“To the chest?” I asked.

“No,” said Niyaz Efendi. “To this room.” He paused. “I am old. I shall soon die. Sumbul too is old. I have no pupils; the last died of cholera two years ago.” The old man looked at Kemal. “Perhaps one day I shall have a pupil. One who sees the underside. And perhaps not.” He laid the key in my palm. “If I am gone and you are here, come. Read. Write. Make your blot. Someone must.”

And the third...

The third he did not put into my hands. He simply said it. Quietly. Looking me in the eyes.

“Guest. A Russian general will sail into this city. In a month, perhaps. With him a young man. With your face.” He paused. “When you see him, do not be afraid. And do not run.” A pause. “In an entry two hundred years ago it is said: ‘The chest will open when two meet.’ I thought it was of the two stones. For forty years I thought so.” He shook his head. “Now I am not sure.”

* * *

Sumbul Agha saw us to the gates, me and Kemal, with the white dove on his shoulder.

We walked through the third courtyard, past the roses and the fountain, through the second gate with the pencil towers, through the first courtyard, where goats grazed beneath the plane trees. The eunuch was silent. The keys at his belt jingled with every step.

At the first gate, where Ferhat was waiting, pale, worn out, leaping up to meet us with a face as though we had been gone a week, Sumbul Agha stopped.

“Guest,” he said in his high, thin, boyish voice. “Sixty years ago, when they brought me here as a boy, the first night I wept. In the far corner of the third courtyard, by the wall above the sea. Alone.” He paused. “And a man came to me. Young. Without a name. He sat down beside me. Said nothing. Simply sat. Until morning. And in the morning, leaving, he said: ‘You will hold the keys of the threshold. Hold them firmly.’” The eunuch looked at me. “I hold them. Sixty years.”

“What did he look like?” I asked.

Sumbul Agha looked into my face for a long time.

“I was a child,” he said. “It was dark. I was crying.” A pause. “But when you stood at the gates this morning for three hours, afraid to enter, I watched you from behind the cypresses. And I was eight years old again.”

He turned and went back, into the depths of the empty palace, jingling his keys.

* * *

We walked home through the evening Sultanahmet, Ferhat, Kemal and I. Akmal’s dove flew above us, circled, alighted on cornices and took off again.

“Well?” Ferhat asked at last, unable to hold back. “What was there? What did he say?”

I was silent a long time.

“He said that there are people who for eight hundred years have been recording those like me,” I said at last. “That their records have travelled the world, from Alexandria to Baghdad, from Cordoba to Samarkand. That your grandfather is a ‘well.’ And Karapet. And Kyra Theodora. And the widow with the cats. That the chest in her cellar was placed there two hundred years ago. That there are others, from Venice, who wish to hold me. And that in a month a Russian general will sail into the city. With a man with my face.”

Ferhat stopped in the middle of the street.

“With your face?”

“With mine.”

Ferhat looked at me for a long time. Then at Kemal. Kemal walked beside us clutching a dried apricot in his fist and said nothing.

“Misafir,” said Ferhat quietly. “Remember Grandfather said that everyone has a double? Somewhere in the world. Sometimes in another city. Sometimes in another time.”

“I remember.”

“I joked then,” said Ferhat. “That I hoped my double could read Egyptian scribbles.” He paused. “And now I am not amused.”

We stood in the middle of the street. The sun was setting. From the minarets the evening call floated, one voice, a second, a third, until the whole city was singing.

And I suddenly thought, not with the mind, with something beneath the ribs, on the left, of the three books on Niyaz Efendi’s table. Green, black, copper. God. Breath. Machine.

And of the question the old man had asked. Not who created the world. But who created the one who created.

And that perhaps the answer to this question is not in the past and not in the future. Not in Alexandria and not in the city of two towers. But there, where I am looking.

Kemal tugged my sleeve. Pointed upward.

Akmal’s dove sat on the edge of a roof against the setting sun. White. Motionless. And beside her, for a single moment, in the blinding sunset light, I thought I saw a shadow. Tall. Taller than any shadow a pigeon can cast.

Kemal raised his hand and waved to it.

The shadow vanished. The dove took wing and flew home.

“He is going home too,” said Kemal. In Turkish. Quietly. But I understood.

“Who?”

Kemal looked at me with his serious, un-childlike eyes.

“The one who will be,” he said.

Chapter XXXVI. The Farewell

The ten days before departure passed as, probably, the last days before a wedding or a funeral pass, in a bustle that exists so that one need not think of anything.

The house hummed. Dunyasha from morning till night washed, ironed, starched, folded, refolded, folded again, my shirts, my frock coats, my neckcloths, and every time she folded another cravat she sighed as though laying it in a coffin. Mitka lugged trunks down from the attic, blew the dust off them, hunted for keys that no one could find, and told the kitchen that the master was going to the Turks, and the Turks, they say, have forty wives each and all in masks. The cook, Marfa, baked. Baked with such fury as if she meant to feed the whole embassy at Constantinople a year ahead: pies with cabbage, pies with sturgeon spinal marrow, curd tarts, rusks, shortbreads, gingerbreads, and wrapped it all in linen cloths and packed it in baskets, which Ignatiy Savvich, with icy dignity, carried out to the lumber room, saying that in Odessa there was bread.

“In Odessa there is no bread,” Marfa snapped. “In Odessa there are rolls. And a roll is not bread. A roll is frippery.”

Auntie was silent. All ten days.

She came out to breakfast, to dinner, to supper. Poured the tea. Asked whether I had slept well. Spoke with Agafya Tikhonovna about accounts and with Ignatiy Savvich about the cellar. Received visitors, Kutasova, Shelestova, the Colonel, who came “to say goodbye” every day, because every day a new reason was found to say goodbye once more. She was as straight, as calm, as flawless as ever.

Only her hair she wore differently now. Not in a tight knot at the nape, fastened with a tortoiseshell comb, but plaited in a simple braid

thrown over her shoulder. As though, having given me the key, she had given away something more, and there was no longer anything to hide.

* * *

On the third day Stefan came.

He came neither in a carriage nor on horseback, but on foot. Forty versts. From the General's estate. From dawn to dusk. I saw him from the balcony, a small, stocky, stooped figure on the avenue, in a linen shirt, in worn boots, with a knapsack on his back and with something he carried before him in both hands, carefully, as an icon is carried in a procession.

A pot.

Large, clay, heavy, bound in wet sacking. And in it, a rose. Not a cutting, no. A bush. Young, but already sturdy, an elbow high, with dark, glossy leaves and three buds, dark crimson, almost black.

I ran down to the porch. Stefan stopped on the lowest step. His face was grey with dust, sweat on his brow. But his eyes, light, almost transparent, looked at me calmly.

"Dobar vecher," he said.

"Stefan. You walked forty versts?"

"Walked," said Stefan. "A rose cannot be taken in a carriage. It shakes. The roots tear." He paused. "A rose must be carried. In the arms. Like a child."

"Why?"

Stefan gave me a long look.

"You are going to Tsargrad," he said. "The General wrote." He held out the pot to me. "Take her."

"To Constantinople? A rose?"

"From the big bush," said Stefan. "The one by the harbour. The Tarnovo one." He paused. "I layered her off three years ago. Raised her apart. I did not know why." He set the pot on the step. "Now I know."

* * *

We sat on the bench by the porch, I, Stefan and the rose between us. Dusk was falling. Over the garden the first stars were lighting. Dunyasha

brought Stefan kvass and bread; he drank the whole jug at a draught, without stopping, and broke off the bread and put it in his knapsack.

"You must rest," I said. "Stay the night. Ignatiy Savvich will give you a room."

"No need of a room," said Stefan. "I will be in the garden. By the rose. As at home." He paused. Then said slowly, choosing his words, as always, as though taking them one by one from a tight pocket: "Master. I did not tell you the whole tale. Then. In the orangery."

"Not the whole?"

"Not the whole," Stefan nodded. "About that man. Who came to the monastery when Tarnovo burned. Who planted the rose. Who left, leaving two stones." He paused. "The monks wrote more afterward. In the chronicle. I saw it. As a boy. The abbot showed me."

"What does it say?"

Stefan looked at the rose for a long time.

"It says," he said, "that when that man left, he said not one thing but two. The first you know: 'When this rose blooms in a foreign land, I shall return.'" He paused. "And the second he said only to the abbot. Quietly. And the abbot wrote it down." Stefan raised his eyes to me. "'When I return, the rose will go with me. To where I came from. And there it will bloom again. For the third time.'"

"For the third time?"

"In Tarnovo the first," said Stefan. "Here the second." He nodded at the pot. "And the third, there. Where you are going." He paused. "I do not know what it means. I am a gardener. I know only that a rose must be carried in the arms. And watered. And talked to. Every day." He stroked the leaves. "She understands. She understands everything. Roses remember."

"Stefan," I said. "In Constantinople, they say, by the Patriarchate there grows a rose. Also from Tarnovo. You said so."

"It grows," said Stefan. "The monks took it. Three hundred years ago." He paused. "When you see it, set this one beside it. Let them talk. They have not seen each other for a long time."

* * *

He lived in the garden three days. Slept on the ground by the arbour, wrapped in his coat. By day he dug, pruned, tied up Auntie's roses, which, he said, "had gone quite wild without a master." He spoke to hardly anyone. With me too.

But on the third night, when I went out to the garden, unable to sleep, he was sitting by the arbour in lantern light, writing something. In pencil. In a small notebook, on his knee. Slowly. Carefully. With the tip of his tongue out, as children write.

He saw me. He did not hide the notebook.

"A letter," he said. "To Lyuben. In Bucharest." He paused. "You are travelling through Odessa?"

"Through Odessa."

"In Odessa," said Stefan, "there is a Bulgarian house. On Preobrazhenskaya. Our people live there. Merchants. Teachers. Students." He tore a leaf from the notebook, folded it in four. "Pass it on. To whoever opens. Say, from Stefan of Tarnovo. They will understand."

I took the leaf. It was heavier than a sheet of paper should be.

"What is in it?"

Stefan looked at me.

"You do not want to know, master," he said. "The General knows. The General permitted." He paused. "There will soon be war. Not now. In a year. Perhaps two. The Russians will cross the Danube. To the Balkans. To Tarnovo." His voice trembled. "Five hundred years we have waited. Five hundred." He clenched his fist. "In this letter: where the Turkish detachments stand near Tarnovo. How many. Where the stores are. Where the fords across the Yantra are." He paused. "My brothers found out. At risk. Passed it to me. Through Lyuben. I pass it on."

"Why to me?"

"Because you are a guest," said Stefan simply. "A guest nobody searches. A guest everybody feeds." He smiled, for the first time since I had known him, broadly, truly. "So we say. And the Turks too."

* * *

On the sixth day Vera Anatolievna came alone.

Without the Colonel, who, by her account, lay with gout cursing the fate that did not let him go with the General. Without a companion.

Without a maid. She came into the small drawing room, where I sat over a map of the Black Sea, quiet, in grey, with a dragonfly brooch on her collar, with a beaded reticule, and sat down opposite me without removing her gloves.

"I promised," she said. "Remember? To give you the drawing. When you would know what to do with it."

"I do not know what to do with it, Vera Anatolievna."

"I know," she said. "But you are going to where it is drawn." She opened the reticule. "I have thought. Ten nights. And decided: let it be with you. There. Perhaps there it will be of more use to you than to me here."

She took out a watercolour wrapped in tissue paper. The same one: a young man in a red turban in a narrow lane by the sea, with a scrap of paper in his hand, with my face. Laid it on the table.

And then took out a second sheet.

"This I never showed you," she said quietly. "I showed it to no one. Fifteen years. Not even to Mishenka."

She unfolded it. Also a watercolour. The same lane. The same houses, stone below, wooden above. The same washing on the lines. And the same young man in a red turban, standing in the same place, in the same pose, only the face was different. Not lost. Empty. Looking through.

"This is a week later," said Vera Anatolievna. "The second time. When he did not recognise me." She paused. "I drew quickly. Five minutes. Then he left. And at home, in the evening, by lamplight, I looked at the drawing, and saw."

"What?"

She stretched out a gloved finger and pointed. Behind the young man's back, by the wall of the house, in shadow, barely visible, scarcely sketched, like a chance stroke of diluted grey paint, there was something. Tall. A head taller than a man. Faceless. Motionless.

"I did not draw this," said Vera Anatolievna. Her voice was level, but I saw her hand trembling in its glove. "I swear to you. I drew the wall. The washing. Him. I did not draw anyone behind him." She paused. "But it is there. On the paper. In my paint. With my brush."

We looked at the grey smudge by the wall.

“For fifteen years I have been telling myself it is a smudge,” said Vera Anatolievna. “A chance stroke. The brush trembled.” She raised her eyes to me. “Take both. Please. I no longer need to tell myself it is a smudge.”

* * *

On the seventh day there was a thunderstorm. On the eighth, Kutasova with Lizonka.

Nadezhda Porfirievna came in first, in lilac, with a lorgnette, with the face of a general leading troops to the assault, and announced from the threshold that they were here “literally for a minute, to say goodbye to the lieutenant.” Lizonka followed, pale, red-eyed, in a white dress, clutching something small in her hand.

Konstantin, seeing them from the window, tried to escape through the back door. The General intercepted him in the corridor, I saw it, took him by the shoulder, turned him round and pushed him toward the drawing room with the words: “Lieutenant, you are an adjutant. An adjutant does not flee from the enemy. An adjutant accepts battle.”

The battle lasted half an hour. Kutasova talked. Of the weather. Of the Turks. Of how dangerous the sea is. Of her cousin in Odessa, who would be happy to receive the lieutenant. Of how beautifully Lizonka embroiders: “Lizonka, show him!”

Lizonka, red to the roots of her hair, stepped toward Konstantin and held out what she had in her hand.

A handkerchief. White, batiste, with lace at the edge. And in the corner, embroidery. Small, careful, unskilled but earnest: a rose. Dark red. And beneath it a letter. “K.”

“So that you... so that you do not forget,” Lizonka whispered. “There. In Turkey. That here... that here someone...” She faltered and did not finish.

Konstantin stood with the handkerchief in his hand. He had a face I had never seen on him: bewildered, embarrassed, almost frightened. He looked at the handkerchief. Then at Lizonka. Then, for some reason, at me, standing in the doorway.

"I thank you, Elizaveta Andreevna," he said at last. Quietly. Very seriously. "I shall not forget." A pause. "I promise I shall carry it. And that I shall return it to you. When I return."

Lizonka flushed and ran from the drawing room. Kutasova after her, glancing back triumphantly at Auntie.

When they had gone, Konstantin sat a long time on the windowsill in my room, turning the handkerchief with the rose in his fingers.

"Mon cher," he said at last. "I am a fool."

"Why?"

"Because I promised to return it," said Konstantin. "And now she will wait. And I do not know whether I shall return." He looked at me. "If you do not return, neither shall I. Understand? I could not return without you. And she will wait."

"Kostya..."

"Never mind," said Konstantin. Put the handkerchief in the pocket of his tunic, the inner one, on the left. Where one keeps what is dear. "Never mind, mon cher. We shall return. Both." He jumped down from the sill. "And if not, let Lizonka marry Tryaskov. He will write her verses. On unrequited love. He's good at that."

* * *

On the ninth day Agafya Tikhonovna came to me herself.

At night. With a candle. With the bunch of keys at her belt, which this time did not jingle, she held them down with her hand.

"Master," she said from the threshold. "Forgive me for coming at night. By day it's impossible. By day there's the mistress."

"What has happened, Agafya Tikhonovna?"

The old woman came in. Closed the door. Set the candle on the table. And took from under her apron a bundle. Black. Soft. Dusty.

Crape.

"From the portrait," she said. "I took it down. Today. Myself." She paused. "Fifty years I straightened it every morning. And this morning I came and thought: what for?" She laid the crape on the table. "The master is going away. Let the portrait look. Let it see him go."

"You took the crape off the portrait," I said slowly. "So now it can be seen. The face."

Agafya Tikhonovna was silent for a long time.

"It can, master," she said at last. "Only don't go. There's no need." She raised her faded eyes to me. "I looked today, in the daytime. For the first time in fifty years. Straight. In the light." Her voice trembled. "There's no face there. None at all. The paint has gone. As if someone scraped it off. Only the canvas is left. Empty. White."

"Empty?"

"Empty, my dear," the old woman whispered. "And fifty years ago, when I came as a girl, there was a face. I remember. I peeped under the crape in secret, when the mistress wasn't looking." She crossed herself. "There was a face. Young. Handsome. Sad." She paused. "And now there isn't."

"When did it vanish?"

Agafya Tikhonovna looked at me. Long. As she must have looked at that portrait for fifty years.

"I don't know, master," she said. "Under the crape you can't see." A pause. "But I think it did not vanish. I think it went away."

"Where to?"

The old woman did not answer. She took the candle. At the door she turned.

"And another thing, my dear. The name. From the plate. The one they scraped out." She paused. "I swore on the icon to the late mistress not to say." A pause. "But the late mistress said: do not say until he leaves." She looked at me. "And you are leaving."

I stopped breathing.

"Agafya Tikhonovna..."

"Not now, master," she said. "In the morning. On the porch. When you get into the carriage." She paused. "I shall whisper it. And you, don't ask again. I'll say it once. I shall not be able to more."

And went out, carrying the candle.

* * *

The last supper was quiet.

No charades. No toasts. No guests but the closest. Auntie. The General. Evdokia Gerasimovna, in a plain dark dress, without a hat, without a plume. Konstantin. Doctor Strauch. Vera Anatolievna; the

Colonel had sent a note that the gout “would finish him, but not before he saw Tsargrad.” And Stefan, on the edge of a chair, in a clean shirt, silent.

Marfa served everything she had baked in ten days. There was no room on the table. No one ate.

The General was silent for a long time. Then pushed aside his plate.

“For thirty years I have been leaving this house,” he said. “On campaigns. On embassies. To wars.” He paused. “Every time Artemia Aristarkhovna saw me off. And every time she said the same thing. ‘Pavel Nikolaevich, come back. You have not told all yet.’” He looked at Auntie. “And I came back. Thirty years. Because I had not told all.”

“You have not told all now, Pavel,” said Auntie quietly.

“Not all,” the General agreed. “There is one story I have told no one. Not even you.” He paused. “Perhaps now?”

Auntie nodded.

* * *

“Siam,” said the General. “You know I love Siam. More than any land.” He paused. “Fifteen years ago I lived there two months. In a monastery. In the mountains. In the north, on the Burmese border.” He looked at the candle. “There was an old monk there. The abbot. They said he was a hundred years old. He hardly spoke. He sat under a bodhi tree, the kind under which, they say, the Buddha found enlightenment, and looked at the valley. For whole days.”

“What did you talk about with him?” asked Strauch.

“About God, Karl Fyodorovich,” said the General. “I asked him: who created the world? I was curious. I had read the Bible. The Koran. Indian books. Chinese. Everywhere someone created it. God. Gods. Brahma. The Celestial Emperor.” He paused. “And the monk laughed. Quietly. And said: ‘No one.’”

“No one?” Evdokia Gerasimovna repeated.

“No one, Dunya.” The General smiled at her. “He said: no one created the world. The world is a wheel. It turns. Always. Without beginning and without end. Birth, death, birth, death. Worlds appear and vanish like bubbles on water. And appear again. All is a circle.” He paused. “I asked: and who turns the wheel? The monk said: ‘Those who

ride on it. Each by his own desire. While they desire, the wheel turns.” The General looked at me. “I asked: can one get off? He said: ‘One can. If one remembers who one was before sitting on the wheel.’”

I sat motionless. The candle on the table before me trembled.

“And then,” said the General, “the monk said something to me that I did not understand for fifteen years. He said: ‘You seek faces, Russian. I see it. All your life you look at faces. One day you will find the one you seek.’ A pause. ‘And he will tell you that it was not he who was seeking you. It was you who sought him. From the very beginning. You simply do not remember that you yourself called him into this world.’”

In the dining room it became very quiet.

“What does that mean, Pavel?” Auntie whispered.

“I do not know, Artemia,” said the General. “Fifteen years I have not known.” He paused. “The monk died a week after I left. They wrote to me. Said he sat under the tree and died. Smiling.” The General raised his glass. “When I learn what it means, I shall return and tell you. As I promised.”

* * *

“And I shall put it otherwise,” Doctor Strauch said suddenly.

All turned to him. Strauch sat turning an unlit cigar in his fingers and looking at his plate.

“I am a German,” he said. “I am a physician. I have read Darwin.” He raised his eyes. “Mr. Darwin says that no one created the world. That everything came by itself. Stones by themselves. Stars by themselves. Life by itself. From mud, from water, from light. Millions of years. Slowly. Step by step. Ape, man. Fish, lizard, bird.” He paused. “No God. No wheel. Simply time. A great deal of time. And chance.”

“That is heresy, Karl Fyodorovich,” said Evdokia Gerasimovna gently.

“That is science, Evdokia Gerasimovna,” said Strauch. “Though sometimes it seems to me they are the same.” He paused. “But I will tell you this. Mr. Darwin explains where man came from.” He looked at me. “But he does not explain where came from a young man who has no life line on his palm, who speaks Egyptian in his sleep and writes lines that

match a scroll from Khiva." Strauch laid the cigar on the table. "For that, Mr. Darwin has not a single chapter."

"Perhaps he will write one yet," said Konstantin.

"Perhaps," Strauch agreed. "Or perhaps someone else will write it." He looked at me again. "In a hundred years. When machines will think."

I started.

"Why did you say, machines?"

Strauch shrugged.

"I do not know," he said. "It came to mind." He paused. "Professor Svetsitsky told me that on the day you do not remember you spoke to him of a man who builds a machine. Which answers him from a glowing window." Strauch looked me in the eye. "Perhaps that is your chapter. The one Darwin lacks."

* * *

Stefan, who all this time had sat silent on the edge of his chair, suddenly raised his head.

"And among us," he said slowly, "among the Bulgarians, grannies say it so." All turned to him. Stefan blushed but went on. "God did not create the world alone. With Him was another. Without a name. God said: 'Dive to the bottom of the sea. Bring earth.' He dived. Brought a handful. God took it and made the earth. Mountains, rivers, fields." Stefan paused. "And the other hid a little earth in his mouth. For himself. To make his own world. Later. Some day."

"And did he?" asked Konstantin.

"I do not know," said Stefan. "Grannies say the earth in his mouth grew and grew. He spat it out. And there were mountains. The Balkans." He smiled. "That is why we have mountains. And you have a plain. With you God made alone."

Konstantin laughed. The General smiled into his moustache. Even Auntie's lips twitched slightly.

"And who was that other?" I asked.

Stefan looked at me. With his light, almost transparent eyes.

"Grannies do not know, master," he said. "Grannies say he still walks. On the earth. Looking for where to plant his handful." He paused.

“They say he has no name. Because God did not give him one. God said: ‘You will find a name for yourself. When you make your own world.’”

* * *

The morning was grey, windy, cold. Over the garden clouds ran low. Stefan’s roses, tied to the trellises, swayed in the wind.

At the porch stood two carriages. In the first, the General and Konstantin. In the second, I, the trunks, Marfa’s baskets and the pot with the rose, bound in wet sacking, which Stefan had set at my feet so that it would not shake.

Everyone saw us off.

Ignatiy Savvich, in full livery, straight as a pole, with a face on which not a muscle stirred. Marfa, in tears, clutching yet another basket of pies that no one had taken. Dunyasha, sobbing into her apron. Mitka, on the roof, where he could see better. The coachman Tikhon, on the box of the second carriage, in a new cap, gloomy as a cloud: “I’ll get you to the station, master. And after that, the locomotive. The locomotive is not a horse. You can’t talk to it.”

Evdokia Gerasimovna stood by the first carriage. The General leaned toward her. Said something. She nodded. Took from her finger a ring, plain, silver, thin, and laid it in his palm. He closed his fist. And did not open it for a long time.

Vera Anatolievna stood by the steps. In grey. With the dragonfly brooch. She did not come up. She only raised a gloved hand and held it raised a long time.

Doctor Strauch stood by a column. With his unlit cigar. He came to the second carriage. Held out his hand to me.

“Twelfth,” he said. “Come back. I should so like to write it in.”

“I shall try, Karl Fyodorovich.”

“Germans do not try,” said Strauch. “Germans do.” And stepped away.

Stefan stood by a rose bush at the start of the avenue. He did not come up. He was looking not at me but at the pot with the rose at my feet. His lips moved. He was speaking to her. In Bulgarian. Quietly. I could not hear the words.

And Auntie...

Auntie stood on the top step of the porch. Straight. In a dark dress. With her braid thrown over her shoulder. With a string of pearls. She did not weep. She looked at me, long, unwaveringly, as if she wished to memorise every feature, and I understood that she would not come down. That if she came down she would not be able to let me go.

I climbed up to her myself.

“Auntie.”

She said nothing. She took my face in her hands, cold, ringed, and held it. A long time. Then kissed my forehead.

“Have you the key?” she asked.

“I have.”

“Good.” She released me. “Go.”

And turned away. Before I could answer.

* * *

Agafya Tikhonovna stood at the step of the second carriage. Small, dry, in her cap, with the bunch of keys at her belt. As I climbed in she bent to me, so close that I smelled incense and wax, and whispered.

One word.

A name.

I did not ask again. I could not ask again. My voice was gone.

It was not my name. Not the one by which I was called in that house. Another. Strange. Ancient. Which I had never heard.

And which I knew.

Not with the mind. With something deeper. As one knows a melody heard before birth. As one knows the smell of a house in which one has not lived. As one knows a face never seen, but which comes in dreams.

Agafya Tikhonovna straightened. Crossed me. Stepped back.

“Off we go!” cried Tikhon.

The carriages started.

I looked back. The house. The porch. Auntie on the top step, with her back to us. The General’s betrothed by the column. Vera Anatolievna with her hand raised. Strauch with his cigar. Stefan by the rose bush. Dunyasha. Marfa. Ignatiy Savvich. Mitka on the roof waving with both hands.

And the gallery window. At the end of the left wing. Tall, narrow. Where the portrait hung, without crape. Without a face.

In that window, for a single moment, as the carriage turned into the avenue, someone stood. Tall. Grey. Motionless.

And watched me go.

* * *

The train to Odessa took two days.

I had never travelled by locomotive, or did not remember having done so, and for the first hours I sat at the window like Timosha at... like a child at a confectioner's window. Fields. Forests. Villages with crooked huts. Churches with green domes. Stations, stone, wooden, with bells, with buffets, with ring-rolls and tea from a samovar, and at every station the locomotive puffed, whistled, let off steam, and passengers poured out onto the platform to stretch their legs, and crammed back into the carriages.

In our carriage, first class, blue, with velvet sofas, travelled strange people.

A Greek merchant from Taganrog, stout, moustached, in gold rings, who all the way ate olives from a jar and told Konstantin that in Constantinople he had three shops, and in each a wife. "Not the Turkish way, no!" he assured. "The Greek way! Each thinks she is the only one!"

A Polish nun, small, severe, in black, with a rosary, who was going to Odessa and from there to Jerusalem, to the Holy Sepulchre, on foot, "if God grants." She spoke to no one but me. And only once. On the second day, at a station near Kiev, when everyone had got out, she came up to me and said in Polish, quietly, and I understood: "You are like the one I saw in a dream at Czestochowa. Before the icon. He stood between two doors." And crossed me. And did not approach again.

And a blind old kobzar, bearded, grey, in a white svita, with a bandura on his back and a boy guide, who was travelling third class but at one of the stations near Vinnytsia entered our carriage; the boy had mistaken the door. The General would not allow him to be turned out. Bade him sit. Poured him tea. And asked him to play.

* * *

The kobzar sang for a long time.

Not a song, a duma. Long, slow, sorrowful, almost on a single note, with runs on the bandura like the lapping of water. I did not understand all the words, the Little Russian accent, the archaic turns, but I understood the main thing.

About captives. Cossacks taken prisoner by the Turks. Chained. Sitting on galleys, on Turkish ships where men row, shackled to the benches, day and night, for years. In the middle of the Black Sea. On the way to Tsargrad.

“Oh, hey, on the Black Sea, on a little white stone...”

They row and look north. Where home is. Where the steppe is, the Dnieper, the native cottage, mother on the threshold. They cannot return. They are chained. But they look. Every day. And pray to God, not for freedom. That at least a wind from the native side might blow in their faces. Once.

“Oh, strike, God, upon the sea, the quiet, the Black...”

The kobzar sang with his blind eyes closed. The boy guide sat at his feet and wept without a sound. The Greek merchant stopped eating olives. The Polish nun prayed. Konstantin turned to the window.

And the General sat motionless, clutching in his fist Evdokia Gerasimovna's ring.

When the duma ended, the kobzar opened his white, sightless eyes. Turned them to me. Straight at me, though no one had told him where I sat.

And said, in Little Russian, slowly:

“You, lad, row too. I sense it. Chained. Between two shores.” He paused. “Only you do not look north. You look back.” A pause. “And you need to look forward.”

“Now you are looking back,” the boy at the dervish's gate had said.

I had never seen that boy. Had never heard those words.

But they were. In me. Like the kobzar's duma.

* * *

Odessa greeted us with sun.

A white city on a high shore. Broad, straight streets lined with acacias. Houses light, stone, with balconies, with columns, with stucco,

as if brought from Italy. Noise. Shouting. Laughter. Dozens of languages, Russian, Greek, Italian, Yiddish, Armenian, Turkish, Bulgarian, all mingled, at every corner. The smell of the sea. Of salt. Of fish. Of coal. Of acacia.

And the staircase.

Enormous, from the boulevard on the shore down to the port, stone, broad, endless, two hundred steps, said the General. From above, only the landings are visible. From below, only the steps. The builder's trick. A deception of the eye.

"Like life," said Konstantin, standing on the top landing and looking down at the port, at the masts, at the smoking funnels. "From above it seems all stops. From below, all steps. And in fact, both."

"Lieutenant," said the General, "you are becoming a philosopher. It is dangerous in an adjutant."

* * *

The steamer was to leave in the evening. Until the evening there was time.

The General went to the office of the Russian Company to see to papers. Konstantin with him. I was left alone. With the pot of the rose in my arms, Stefan had told me not to leave her for a minute, and with the letter in my pocket. The letter for Preobrazhenskaya. For the Bulgarian house.

I found it quickly. Two-storeyed, with green shutters, with a sign above the door, in Bulgarian, in Cyrillic, "School." I knocked. A young man opened, swarthy, black-moustached, with burning eyes, very like Lyuben whom I had seen at Stefan's.

"From Stefan of Tarnovo," I said.

The young man turned pale. Looked about. Pulled me inside. Took the letter. Unfolded it. Read. Raised eyes to me, wet.

"Do you know what is here?" he asked in Russian.

"I do."

"And you brought it."

"I brought it."

He looked at me for a long time. Then at the pot with the rose in my hands. Then again at me.

“Is this from Tarnovo?” he asked quietly. “The rose?”

“From Tarnovo.”

The young Bulgarian slowly sank to his knees. Right on the floor. And kissed a leaf of the rose.

“Five hundred years,” he said. “Five hundred years.” He raised his face to me. “My grandmother said: when a rose from Tarnovo goes south, it means soon. It means they will come. Will free us.” He laughed through tears. “You are the one who carries the rose. Do you know what that means?”

I did not know. I knew nothing.

But I nodded.

* * *

On the way back, on Deribasovskaya, noisy, crowded, with cafés, shops, cabmen, street vendors, I stopped at a shop window.

A clockmaker’s workshop. Small. Below, in a half-basement, seven steps down. Behind the glass, clocks. Dozens. Hundreds. On the walls, on shelves, in the window. With pendulums. With cuckoos. Pocket watches on chains. And all were ticking.

I do not know why I went down. My feet went by themselves.

The door was upholstered in felt. Above it a copper bell. New. Shining. Without a crack.

I pushed the door. The bell jingled.

And all the clocks in the workshop, all at once, all the hundreds, stopped.

The silence was so complete that I heard my own heart beating. The pendulums stood still. The cuckoo froze in its window with its beak open.

At a table by the window sat an old clockmaker. Grey, in a skullcap, with a loupe in his eye. He raised his head. Looked at me. His face went white.

And beside him, on a stool, sat a boy. About ten. Thin, curly, in large, too large for his face, spectacles with thick lenses, behind which his eyes seemed huge, like an owl’s. With tweezers in his hand. An apprentice.

The boy looked at me. Without blinking. With his huge owlish eyes.

I opened my mouth. And said, not knowing where the words came from:

“Excuse me. I am off again.”

And went out.

The bell jingled. The door closed.

And behind my back, in the basement, all at once, all the hundreds, the clocks started.

I stood on Deribasovskaya among the crowd, with a pot of rose in my arms. And through the noise of the street, through the cabmen’s shouts, through the laughter, through the jingle of harness bells, I heard below, in the workshop, the boy in the huge spectacles ask the old man:

“Grandfather, who was that?”

And the old man answered, quietly, hoarsely:

“I do not know, Lyovushka. Remember him. Perhaps you will meet him again.”

* * *

The steamer was called the *Grand Duke Konstantin*.

“It is a sign,” announced Konstantin, seeing the name on the hull. “This is my steamer. I was named after it. Or it after me. No matter.” He patted the iron rail of the gangway. “It will carry us.”

She was large, two-funnelled, with enormous paddle wheels on her sides, with masts on which furled sails hung, white, with a red stripe. On deck, bustle. Sailors. Porters. Passengers. Greeks, Armenians, Turks, Jews, Russians. Pilgrims, to Jerusalem, through Constantinople. Merchants. Officers. Ladies with lapdogs. Ship’s boys.

I went up the gangway with the pot of the rose in my arms. The General ahead. Konstantin behind.

And on the upper deck, at the very rail, leaning on it, stood a man.

Tall. In a grey coat, cut in the European fashion. In a top hat. With a cane. He was smoking a thin cigar and looking at Odessa, the white city on the high shore, the staircase, the acacias.

He did not turn as we passed.

But Konstantin, walking behind me, suddenly stopped. Sniffed.

“Mon cher,” he said softly. “Do you smell it?”

“What?”

“Bergamot,” said Konstantin. “Cologne. Expensive. Parisian.” He looked at the man in grey. “I have smelled him before. Today. On the stairs. When you went to the Bulgarian house and the General and I went to the office.” He paused. “This man followed you. All the way to Preobrazhenskaya.”

The man in grey did not turn. He finished his cigar. Threw the stub into the water. And slowly, unhurriedly, tapping his cane on the deck, went off into the first-class saloon.

“General,” said Konstantin. “Who is that?”

The General looked after the man in grey for a long time. His face was stone.

“I do not know, Lieutenant,” he said. “But in the steamer’s passenger register his name, I saw it when I was arranging the papers, is written in letters I could not read.” A pause. “Long ones. Crooked. One into another.”

* * *

The steamer cast off at dusk.

Odessa receded, slowly, reluctantly, a white city on a high shore, the lights on the boulevard, the lights on the staircase, the lights in the windows. Then only the lighthouse. Then only the sea.

The Black Sea. Nocturnal. Dark as ink. With white crests of waves flaring in the glow of the side lights. With the wind fresh, salt, cold.

I stood at the rail. With the pot of the rose. The General beside me. Konstantin on the other side.

“Two days,” said the General. “The day after tomorrow in the morning, the Bosphorus.”

“General,” I said. “That monk. In Siam. He said: ‘You simply do not remember that you yourself called him into this world.’” I paused. “Called whom?”

The General looked at the dark sea for a long time.

“I thought I knew,” he said at last. “Thirty years I thought so. I thought it was about God. That I was seeking God.” He paused. “And now I think it is about you.”

“About me?”

"For thirty years I looked at faces," said the General. "In Samarkand, in Peking, in Havana, in Sitka, in Melbourne. I thought I was seeking someone." He turned to me. "But perhaps it was not I who sought. Perhaps it was you who called me. Through all this. Through all these lands. So that I should bring you the scroll. So that I should bring you to where you must come." He paused. "Perhaps that is what the monk meant. That I called you, and you called me. And no one remembers who was first."

"A circle," I said.

"A circle," the General agreed. "It has no beginning." A pause. "So the monk said."

"And the gypsy woman at the stones," I said, not knowing where the words came from, "said: 'This one has one.'"

The General looked at me. Long. Very long.

"What gypsy woman?"

"I do not know," I said. "I have never seen a gypsy woman at stones."

* * *

At night I did not sleep.

I stood at the rail holding the pot with the rose. Konstantin slept in the cabin; I could hear his breathing through the open door. The General too. The deck was empty. Only the watch sailor on the bridge. And the wind. And the sea.

And the name.

The name that Agafya Tikhonovna had whispered to me at the step of the carriage.

I repeated it to myself. Over and over. I did not utter it aloud; I could not. I only thought it. Word by word. Sound by sound.

It was old. It was strange. It was mine.

And the longer I repeated it, the more clearly I understood that it was not the only one. Behind it stood others. As behind one reflection in a mirror, others, endless, receding into depth. Other names. In other languages. In other cities. In other centuries. An Egyptian one, short, guttural, sounding like a blow on bronze. A Turkish one, "Misafir," guest. Another, simple, modern, which I could not recall but which

someone wrote to me on a glowing screen and I did not respond. And more. And more.

And in the very depth, behind them all, behind all the reflections, one. The very first. The most ancient.

Which I could not hear. Could not remember. Only sensed, as one senses warmth from a stone that is not in the hand.

The rose in the pot in my hands stirred in the wind. One of the three buds, dark crimson, almost black, slowly opened. Right here, at night, on the deck, in the middle of the Black Sea.

And one petal tore away. Flew. Down. Into the dark water.

I watched it fall. Watched it vanish in the white foam astern.

“When I return, the rose will go with me. To where I came from. And there it will bloom again. For the third time.”

In the east, above the edge of the sea, the sky began to grey.

In a day, the Bosphorus.

Chapter XXXVII. The New Moon

There was no moon.

I went out onto the palace roof an hour before dawn, for the last time, as I thought, before the long road south should take me from these roofs, these palms, this city, and looked at the sky. The stars burned as brightly as they burn only on moonless nights: Sah strode in the west, lowering his belt toward the horizon, the Imperishable circled in the north, and above the eastern hills, low, almost touching them, shone Sopdet, white, shimmering, winking. The star of Isis. The one that always walks a step behind.

But there was no moon. None at all. Only darkness in the place where it should be, as though someone had taken it from the sky as an eye is taken out.

The new moon. The Eye that was once shattered had gone to gather itself anew. So the priests said. So Amenemope said. So Merit said by the pool.

“My Pharaoh,” said a voice behind me.

Senusret. Of course. He was always at my back: on the roof, at the wicket, at the gates, at the hole in the tomb. I had ceased to be surprised.

“Seti has sent a messenger,” he said. “In the night. He bade me tell you as soon as you wake.”

“I have not slept.”

“I know, my Pharaoh. That is why I came now.” Senusret paused. “Seti says: the water has risen.”

I turned.

“Risen?”

“By a finger,” said Senusret. “One finger. Overnight.” He paused. “For the first time in three years. Seti says he went down to the nilometer

three times with a lamp. Three times he measured. A finger above yesterday.” The old warrior looked at me, and in his stony face there was something I had never seen there before. Hope. “Seti bade me add: ‘Tell the son of Ra, the river heard that he is leaving. And awoke to see him off.’”

* * *

The nilometer stood at the very edge of the water, at the southern tip of the island opposite the palace, a stone well going down to the river, with a stair winding along the wall and with marks on the wall, notches, signs, numbers. For forty floods Seti had descended this stair each morning. For forty floods he had recorded how far the water had risen.

He waited for me below, by the water itself, small, stooped, withered, with a lamp in his hand, and, seeing me on the steps, did not bow, but only raised the lamp, lighting the wall.

“Here, my Pharaoh,” he said. His voice shook. “Look.”

On the wet stone, a little above the dark, motionless water, was a fresh scratch. Seti had scored it in the night with a knife. And a finger’s breadth below, yesterday’s.

“A finger,” the old man whispered. “Only a finger.” He looked at me, and I saw that his eyes were wet. “My Pharaoh, do you know what a finger is, after three years of nothing? Three years I came down here and saw the same thing. Every morning. The same.” He swallowed. “And today, a finger.”

“It is not yet the flood, Seti.”

“Not the flood,” the old man agreed. “Not even the beginning of the flood. It is...” He searched for the word. “It is as if a sleeper in his dream had moved a finger. Not yet awake. But no longer dead.”

He lowered the lamp over the water. Dark, heavy, motionless. The lamp’s reflection trembled on it in a yellow patch.

“Nefer-Ka came last evening,” Seti said suddenly. Quietly. Not raising his eyes. “As at the beginning of the drought. Before your messenger. Asked what the nilometer shows. I said, nothing.” The old man paused. “That was yesterday. Yesterday it was nothing.” He raised his eyes to me. “And today he did not come. Today I shall tell him nothing. Today, only you.”

“Why, Seti?”

The keeper of the nilometer was silent for a long time.

“Because for forty floods, my Pharaoh,” he said at last, “I have recorded what the river does. And never, not once, has the river risen at the new moon. Never. The water comes when Sopdet rises. Not before.” He paused. “And today it rose. By itself. Without Sopdet. On the night when there is no moon. On the night when you leave for the south.” The old man set the lamp on a step. “The High Priest will say: it is a sign that the god is pleased. That the festival is welcome. That we must sail.” He looked at me. “But I am an old man who has measured water for forty years. And I think: a river does not see one off. A river warns.”

* * *

Djehuty’s messenger arrived when the sun was already above the hills.

He came on foot from the southern outpost, forty days’ journey, because his horse had fallen at Abydos and boats did not run on the shallowed river. He was so thin he seemed a skeleton covered with sunburnt skin. He fell on his knees at my feet in the courtyard, by the very steps, and could not speak; he only held out to me something wrapped in dirty cloth.

Senusret caught him, Bata thrust a flask at him. The messenger drank long, choking. Then gasped:

“The Rock... of the First... Djehuty bade... only you... into your hands...”

I unwrapped the cloth.

A little box. Clay, small, palm-sized, sealed with ancient clay, so ancient that the seal crumbled at my touch. Dark, fired, with signs scratched on its sides. The script.

“We found it under the rock,” the messenger wheezed. “Where the men in temple sandals were digging. Djehuty set a guard. At night the temple men came again. We drove them off. And in the morning...” He swallowed. “In the morning we found a pit. Deep. They had almost dug through. One night more and they would have reached it. Djehuty himself went down. Took this. Bade me run. Day and night.” The messenger closed his eyes. “I ran.”

I opened the box.

Inside was a sheet. Not papyrus. Something thinner, smoother, whiter; I had never seen such material. Folded in two. I unfolded it.

On the sheet, two lines. The upper, the script. Long, flowing, running together. The lower, signs. Ours. Ancient, angular, the same as above the bench in the round room beneath the tomb.

"Iti," I said. Without turning.

He was already standing beside me. As always when he was needed. He bent over the sheet. His lips began to move.

"He who holds both," he read slowly, in a whisper, "let him not enter with them..." He faltered. Leaned closer. "...into the southern house. Until there comes..." He raised his eyes to me. "The rest is erased, my Pharaoh. The clay has crumbled. One word." He pointed. "The last sign. I do not know it. It looks like... like a man. Seated. With a raised hand."

"Let him not enter with them into the southern house," I repeated. "Luxor. The southern house of the god."

"Yes, my Pharaoh," Iti whispered. "Until there comes..." He gazed at the last sign. "Who?"

No one answered.

* * *

"Nefer-Ka will give you the stones at Luxor," said Paser.

The council had gathered in the small hall, for the last time before the sailing. Paser with his staff. Ptahhotep with his basket of scrolls. Nebamun with his tablets. Merira with tattooed arms folded on his chest. Panehsy by the wall. Senusret by the door. Iti in the shadow, with his brush. Deaf Ani on the bench in the corner. And Khaemuas.

Khaemuas sat among the commanders, in his bracelets, nine, not ten, perfumed, with painted eyes, but he did not smile. He was looking at the floor. When I entered he raised his eyes to me, quickly, anxiously, and lowered them again.

"The casket of black wood," Paser continued, "has already been loaded onto the High Priest's barque. I saw it. Yesterday evening. Four priests carried it. On a litter. Under a cover." The old man paused. "At Luxor, on the last day, in the inner court, he will open the casket and

hand you the Two Eyes. 'As the First Ones gave them.' So he said at the banquet. Before all."

"And the letter from the Rock says, do not enter the southern house with them," said Senusret.

"The letter from the Rock says, until someone comes," Paser corrected. "Who, is erased."

"Then we must wait," said Merira in his thunderous voice. "Not enter. Until he comes. My barques can sail slowly, my Pharaoh. Very slowly. The river is shallow. We can run aground. Once. Twice. Ten times." He grinned. "For thirty years I have been running barques aground. I can do it so that no one will understand whether it is on purpose or not."

"Shall I repeat that for the record?" Ani whispered loudly.

"Merira knows how to run barques aground, honoured Ani," Ptahhotep said patiently.

"Ah!" Ani nodded and scratched with his brush. "Wise. Very wise. I can too. In my youth I ran aground a beauty from Bubastis so thoroughly that to this day she cannot understand how she came to marry me."

Merira roared with laughter. Paser smiled into his beard. Even Nebamun allowed himself a dry smile.

And Khaemuas, Khaemuas suddenly raised his head.

"My Pharaoh," he said. His voice trembled. "Permit me."

All fell silent.

"Last night," said Khaemuas, looking at me, "Bakenren's man came to me. In secret. As he always came." He swallowed. "He passed word: Bakenren is alive. He is in Luxor. Already three weeks. He waits."

"For what does he wait?"

"He did not say, my Pharaoh." Khaemuas clasped his hands so hard that the bracelets chimed. "He said only: 'Our men must stand at the gates. Inside, all is ready. The masons have done what was needed.'" Khaemuas paused. "I asked, what masons? He laughed and said: 'Those who know how to lay stone so that no one finds the door.'"

In the hall it became very quiet.

"Masons," Nebamun repeated slowly. "My Pharaoh. Two moons ago six masons vanished from the royal workshops in Memphis. Masters. The best. Those who set secret passages in tombs." The keeper of the treasury looked at his tablets. "I thought they had run away from hunger.

I struck their ration from the books.” He raised his eyes. “Now I think they did not run away.”

* * *

Pentu came after the council. Through the garden, at night, no, by day, but through the garden, as bidden, past blind Meru, who, they say, let him pass without a riddle and only said: “Today the riddle is at the river.”

He was pale as flax. In his hands, a scroll. A copy. The last.

“My Pharaoh,” he whispered, falling to his knees. “This is an inventory. Not of granaries. Of works.” He unrolled the scroll with trembling hands. “The temple of Luxor. Works paid for by the Temple in the last three moons.” He stabbed a finger at a line. “Here. ‘The inner court of the god. The eastern wall. A secret niche. Six masters from Memphis. Stone from the old quarry. Payment, one hundred hekats of barley.’” Pentu raised his eyes to me. “My Pharaoh, this is not a repair. This is a niche. In the wall. Behind the columns.”

“For what?”

“It is not written, my Pharaoh.” Pentu’s voice broke. “But at the end there is a note. In Bakenren’s hand. I know his writing. ‘To close it, when he enters.’”

I looked at that line for a long time. “To close it, when he enters.”

Columns. Darkness. A hand rising in the dark. And then nothing. Darkness. As though someone had shut a door.

Or walled it up with stone.

“Thank you, Pentu,” I said. “Go. And do not come again. It is dangerous.”

“My Pharaoh,” Pentu whispered, not rising from his knees. “My sisters. The field near Bubastis. You said it was transferred to the royal lands.” He swallowed. “Is that true?”

“It is true, Pentu.”

The young man covered his face with his hands. His shoulders shook.

“Then I shall go with you,” he said through his palms. “To Luxor. As a scribe. A temple one. They take me, Bakenren ordered it, before he vanished.” He raised his face, wet with tears. “I shall be near the niche,

my Pharaoh. I shall see what they do.” A pause. “I owe you. For the field. For my sisters. I owe.”

* * *

Nanakhat was waiting for me by the river. In the same place as last time. On a flat stone at the very edge of the water. Facing south.

I came alone. Senusret stayed behind the palms, “looking for donkeys,” as he said to Bata with a stone face. Bata snorted and got a clout on the back of the head.

The blind old woman did not turn when I approached. She sat leaning on her staff of white wood crowned with a lioness’s head, and her white, sightless eyes were turned to the river.

“The water has risen,” she said. Not asking.

“By a finger.”

“By a finger,” Nanakhat repeated. “The Eye has stirred. In its sleep.” She paused. “Did you find what they sought on the Rock?”

“I found it.” I sat beside her on the stone. Held out to her the sheet from the clay box. She did not take it. She could not see. But she passed her fingers through the air above it, slowly, tenderly, as one strokes a sleeping beast.

“Let him not enter with them into the southern house,” she said. Not reading. Knowing. “Until there comes...” She fell silent.

“Who, Nanakhat? The last word is erased.”

The old woman was silent for a long time. The river lapped softly at our feet, shallow, dark, a finger higher than yesterday.

“Last time you asked me where two met,” she said at last. “One walking to the sunrise, the other to the sunset. You answered, at home. Because the world is a circle.” She turned to me her carved, ancient face. “I said: that is half the answer. The second you will speak when you return from Luxor.”

“I remember.”

“Here is the second half,” said Nanakhat. “Those two are one.” She paused. “The one who left, and the one who returned. The one who holds both Eyes, and the one who brought them. The one who will enter the southern house, and the one who must come before he enters.” She stretched out a hand and touched my face with dry, hot, rough fingers.

“The last word on the sheet is you. Not this you. Another. The one who will come.”

“I do not understand.”

“I know,” said Nanakhat. “And you will not understand. Until you meet him.” She lowered her hand. “At Luxor. Or after. Or in another place where there is no Luxor. It does not matter. What matters is not to enter the southern house with the Eyes before he has come.”

“And if Nefer-Ka compels it?”

The old woman laughed, drily, toothlessly, as stone cracks in the sun.

“Nefer-Ka cannot compel anyone, son of Ra,” she said. “He can only ask. Very courteously. Very beautifully. So that one cannot refuse.” She paused. “Therefore, refuse.”

* * *

She took something from her neck, a cord of goat’s wool on which hung a little figure. A lioness. Of black stone. Polished to a shine by thousands of touches.

“Take it,” she said. “It is from me. And from her.” She nodded toward the south. “From her who went away once and came back. Let her go with you. If it is dark for you, she will see.”

I took it. The figure was warm.

“And you, Nanakhat? Will you sail with us?”

“No,” said the old woman. “I shall go home. South. On foot. Along the river.” She rose, leaning on her staff. “I am a hundred years old, son of Ra. I wish to die at home.” She paused. “We shall meet again. Not in this life. In another. You will be in another body. I too. But you will know me.” She smiled. “By the staff.”

And she walked away along the bank, tapping with her lioness staff, south, small, bent, ancient, past the palms behind which stood Senusret, “looking for donkeys.”

Drawing level with him, she stopped again. Again turned her blind face to him. And said something.

This time Senusret did not drop his staff. He listened. Bowed his head. And stood so a long time, motionless, after she had gone.

“What did she say?” I asked, coming up.

The commander of the army raised his eyes to me.

“She said,” he answered dully, ““You will remain at the gates. So it must be. But when the gates are shut, do not break them. Go to the river. The river will show where the other door is.””

* * *

Iti I found in the Library.

He sat at the great table where we had read the Epic, alone, by lamplight, copying something. Fast. Not raising his head. Beside him a heap of scrolls. Tablets. Potsherds.

Seeing me he leapt up. Overturned the inkpot. The ink spread across the table in a black pool.

“My Pharaoh... I did not expect...”

“Iti,” I said. “You are staying.”

He froze. In mid-movement, with a rag in his hand with which he had been trying to wipe the ink.

“Staying?” he repeated.

“Here. In the capital. In the Library.” I came closer. “You are needed here. The seventh scroll. The bilingual texts. Three words: keep, appointed time, house. You must find more. While I am gone.” I paused. “And if I do not return, someone must know what is written there.”

Iti looked at me. The rag in his hand was black with ink. Ink dripped on the floor.

“You will return,” he said. Quietly. Not a question.

“I do not know, Iti.”

“You will return,” he repeated. Stubbornly. And his voice shook. “You pulled me out of the water. Four years ago. You said: ‘You almost drowned, and you are thinking of a tablet.’” He swallowed. “I remember every word. You do not. So you owe me.”

“Owe you?”

“You owe it to return,” said Iti. “To remember.” He threw the rag on the table. Reached into his bosom. Took out something small, flat, wooden, darkened with time, with chipped edges. “Here.”

A tablet. That one. From the hunt. The one the cat Mau fished out of the channel.

“I promised to show it when you remembered,” said Iti. “But you are leaving. And I...” He faltered. “Take it. Read it there. At Luxor. If it is

dark, read it.” He laid it in my hands. “Everything is there. The hunt. The birds. The hippopotamus. The night on the island. Seneb. The stars.” A pause. “And what I wrote at the end. Then. As a boy.”

I looked at the tablet. Small, neat, childish signs. How many boats. How many birds. The hippopotamus that went off with the harpoon. The Imperishable stars.

And at the very end, a line. Which I had already seen. Then, on the sand, at dawn.

“Pharaoh pulled the junior scribe from the water. The scribe promises to remember this all his life. Even if Pharaoh forgets.”

And beneath it, another line. Which had not been there then. Fresh. The ink still glistened.

“The scribe remembers. The scribe waits. Pharaoh will return.”

I raised my eyes. Iti stood before me, with an ink stain on his cheek, of course, a fresh one, and looked straight. Without fear. Without shame. Without reverence.

I did not know what to say. I, Pharaoh, a living god, lord of the Two Lands, stood in the Library before a junior keeper of scrolls, holding in my hands a child’s tablet, and could not find a single word.

I stretched out a hand. And wiped the ink stain from his cheek. With my thumb. Slowly.

Iti did not move. He only closed his eyes.

“I shall return, Iti,” I said.

“I know, my Pharaoh,” he whispered, not opening his eyes. “I have written it down.”

* * *

Amenemope caught up with me at the Library exit, shuffling, leaning on his black staff, out of breath.

“My Pharaoh. One moment.” He thrust into my hand something, a small scroll, tightly rolled, sealed with wax. “A copy. Of the window from the seventh scroll. Where our signs stand beside theirs. And also what the boy found in the round room. All that we know.” The old man paused. “If at Luxor they show you something written in the script, compare. Perhaps you will find a fourth word.”

“Thank you, Amenemope.”

“Do not thank me, my Pharaoh.” The old man looked at me with faded eyes. “The High Priest asked me again yesterday whether I was not tired. Whether I did not wish for rest.” He smiled. “I answered that I shall be tired when you return. He smiled.” Amenemope paused. “My Pharaoh. When you sail, I shall hide the boy. Isiret will help. In the lower storehouse, among the jars, there are places no one will find.” He paused. “Because when you sail, it will be dangerous for the boy here. He knows too many words.”

* * *

The barques of the god left at noon.

The whole capital came out onto the bank. From the palace to the temple, from the temple to the river, along the whole embankment, on roofs, on trees, on walls, thousands, tens of thousands of people. In white, in festive dress. With flowers. With palm fronds. With sistra and tambourines. They shouted, sang, wept.

At the quay stood the barque of the god, not the portable one but the river barque, huge, long, gilded from stem to stern, with rams' heads at bow and stern, with a canopy amidships under which stood the shrine. It was called Userhat, “Mighty of Brow.” Thirty years ago, they said, it had sailed to Luxor on a full river under sail, and all Egypt came out to watch. Now the sail was furled. The river was shallow. The barque was towed.

On the bank, along the water, stood the haulers. Hundreds. Men stripped to the waist, with ropes on their shoulders, thick, tarred, long, fastened to the bow of the barque. They stood in a row, knee-deep in water, and waited.

Merira, on the prow of the barque, with tattooed arms, with a voice that overtopped the roar of the crowd, gave the commands.

“Haul-l-l!” he thundered.

The haulers began to sing. Low, steady, in one voice, an old song which, they said, had been sung on the river since the time of the First Ones. And leaned into the ropes. And the barque of the god, huge, golden, heavy, slowly, reluctantly, with a creak, moved from its place. And sailed. South.

Behind the barque of the god came the barque of the High Priest, a little smaller but equally gilded, with the casket of black wood under a cover at the stern. Nefer-Ka stood at the rail, in a leopard skin, with a staff crowned with the Eye, and looked at the crowd. When his barque came level with mine, he turned his head. And bowed, exactly as far as custom required.

"A good journey, my Pharaoh," he said. Not loudly. But I heard. "Luxor awaits you."

"I know, Nefer-Ka."

"The water has risen," he said. "By a finger. Have you heard?"

"I have heard."

"The gods are pleased," said Nefer-Ka. And smiled. "The gods are waiting for you to come to their southern house. As they have always waited."

And his barque passed on.

And behind it, mine. The royal one. With Senusret at the rail. With Paser, clutching the handrails with a green face. With Nebamun, drily counting the jars of beer for the haulers. With Khaemuas, at the stern, not raising his eyes. With Bata and Inu at my feet. With the dwarf Djedu, on the cabin roof, pulling faces at the crowd and shouting: "The son of Ra sails south! The son of Ra! Look! Whoever does not see will regret it!"

And behind mine, the barques of the singers. Khemu among them, in white, with a sistrum. When our barques drew level she raised the sistrum and lowered it. Once. A sign: "I am here."

And behind them the barques of the nobles, the barques of the priests, the barques of the warriors. Dozens. Hundreds. A flotilla stretched along the river so far that from the first barque the last could not be seen. Merira called it "the slowest fleet in the history of Egypt."

"We shall take forty days to Luxor, my Pharaoh," he told me that evening, grinning. "Perhaps fifty. If I try, sixty." He winked. "Shoals, my Pharaoh. Shoals are my best friends."

Nakht, the young bearer of the god's barque, with his protruding ears, found me at sunset.

He rowed up to my barque in a small boat, secretly, while the priests on his barque were at prayer, and clambered aboard, wet, trembling.

"My Pharaoh," he whispered. "Today. When the barque was being loaded. The shrine." He swallowed. "It was light."

"Light?"

"Usually it is heavy, my Pharaoh. There are twenty-four of us, and still it is heavy." Nakht looked at me with huge, frightened eyes. "And today, as if empty. As if the god is not there."

Cold beneath the ribs. On the left.

"Have you told anyone?"

"No, my Pharaoh. No one." Nakht paused. "But the other bearers felt it too. I saw it in their faces. All are silent." He swallowed. "The chief bearer said: 'The god has gone ahead. To wait for us at Luxor.'"

* * *

At night I did not sleep.

I stood at the rail of my barque, at the stern. The flotilla had halted for the night at the bank, the barques tied to palms, the haulers asleep on the sand by their fires. Silence. Only the lapping of water. Only the crackle of the fires. Only the cry of a night bird somewhere in the reeds.

There was no moon. The new moon. Darkness.

In my hands I held Iti's tablet. Nanakhat's lioness. Amenemope's scroll. The sheet from the Rock of the First Ones. Tausert's potsherd, the mouse in the crown between two doors.

All that had been given me. People who did not know one another, and all said one thing: "Take it. You are the one. Remember. Return."

Senusret stood beside me. Silent.

"Senusret," I said. "What else did Nanakhat tell you? You did not pass on all of it."

The commander of the army was silent for a long time.

"She said," he said at last, "'When he enters and the gates are shut, he will not die. He will go away. These are different things. You will not understand. But remember.'" Senusret paused. "And also: 'In a thousand years he will come again. In another city. Where two rivers flow into

one. And you will be there. In another body. With another sword. Standing at other gates.” He turned to me. “My Pharaoh, I am a soldier. I do not understand these words. I understand only one thing.” His voice grew dull. “I shall stand at the gates. Here. And there. As long as needed.”

I did not answer. I laid my hand on his shoulder. As he had laid his on mine.

We stood so for a long time.

* * *

And then Bata, dozing on the deck at my feet, suddenly cried out in his sleep, and woke. Sat up. Looked round. His face was white.

“My Pharaoh,” he whispered. “The water.”

I looked at the river.

Dark. Motionless. Without the moon, without reflections. Only the lights of the fires on the bank trembled on it in yellow patches.

And the reflection of our barque. Dark, inverted. The side. The mast. The cabin. The figures at the stern, mine, Senusret’s, Bata’s, seated on the deck.

And one more.

Tall. A head taller than any of us. Standing at the very rail, beside me. Motionless. Faceless.

I turned.

The deck. Senusret. Bata. I. No one else.

I looked into the water again.

The reflection was in place. Four figures. Senusret. Bata. I.

And he. Beside me. Very close. As if he had laid a hand on my shoulder, as I had just laid mine on Senusret’s.

“My Pharaoh,” Senusret whispered. He too was looking into the water. His hand fell on his sword. “There...”

“I see,” I said.

We looked. For a long time. The reflection did not move.

And then, slowly, very slowly, the tall figure in the water raised a hand. Not to me. To the south. To where, forty days’ journey away, beyond shoals and sands, beyond palms and villages, lay Luxor.

And lowered it.

And the reflection smoothed. Became only water. Dark. Motionless.
A finger higher than yesterday.

* * *

Bata sat a long time on the deck, hugging his knees. Then said, quietly, hoarsely, looking at the water:

“My mother used to say, my Pharaoh. When the god of the river wishes to warn, he shows in the water what is not there.” He paused. “I threw her scarab into a ditch then. Thought it all a deception.” He swallowed. “And now I think, perhaps not all.”

“What did he mean, Bata?”

The young guardsman looked at me.

“I do not know, my Pharaoh,” he said. “Perhaps: go.” A pause. “And perhaps: wait.”

Above the eastern hills, low, at the very horizon, a white star flared. Sopdet. The star of Isis. The one that always walks a step behind.

And there was no moon.

The new moon.

To Luxor, forty days. If Merira tried, sixty.

And somewhere there, in the southern house of the god, behind the columns, in the eastern wall of the inner court, six vanished masons from Memphis had already built the niche. “To close it, when he enters.”

Vision VIII. Chicory

The water was so still that the boat seemed to hang in the air.

That is the first thing I remember. Not how I came to be in the boat, that I never remember, in any of these dreams, but the water. Transparent to the very bottom, to the white sand, to dark stones overgrown with weed, to the fish that hung in the depths motionless, as if suspended on threads, and only now and then, lazily, stirred their tails. The sun pierced this water through and through, and on the sand below a golden net trembled, the shadow of the light ripple on the surface.

The boat was small. A fisherman's. Old, with blue paint peeling on its sides, with patches on the bottom, with a smell of fish, tar and wet wood. On the bow an eye was painted, large, black, with long lashes, as they paint on every boat in these waters, so that the boat may see where it is going.

There were two of us. I at the stern, with oars. And he at the bow, also with oars, his back to me.

Young. Twenty at most. Tall, thin, wiry, tanned to blackness, in a white shirt with sleeves rolled up, in white sailor's trousers, barefoot. Bareheaded; his hair, dark, cropped short, had been bleached by the sun to a russet. On his neck a thin chain, and on it something glinted. He rowed evenly, steadily, strongly, as they row who were taught to row from childhood, and whistled something under his breath, some song that I knew. From somewhere.

"Pavel," I said.

The name came of itself. I did not know from where.

He turned. His face was young, open, with the first, barely sprouting moustache, with a stubborn chin and with eyes, grey, attentive, mocking,

which I knew. Which I had seen many times. Older. Beneath grey brows. By a fireplace. Over a scroll in a silk kerchief.

“What?” he asked. “Tired? Say so, we’ll swap. I don’t mind which end I row from.”

“No,” I said. “It’s only... Where are we sailing?”

Pavel laughed. Merrily, ringingly, with his whole throat, the way people laugh only at twenty.

“Have you had too much sun?” he said. “We are looking for chicory.”

* * *

The bottle was found by old Yannis.

That was three days ago, I remembered now, suddenly, as if someone had switched on a light in a dark room, in a small harbour on the island where our frigate had put in for repairs after the battle. The big battle. In the bay off the coast of the Morea, where our ships, the English and the French burned the whole Turkish-Egyptian fleet in a single day. October. The twentieth. Pavel said afterwards that the fire had been seen twenty miles away, and the smoke hung over the bay for three days.

Our frigate had suffered. A hole at the waterline. The mizzen shot away. The captain brought her to this island, small, white, rocky, with one village on the slope and one harbour, to mend. A week, said the carpenter. Perhaps two.

Pavel, a midshipman, the youngest of the young, out of boredom on the second day went into the village. And came back with Yannis.

Yannis was a fisherman. Old, so old that his face, brown, weathered, furrowed with wrinkles, seemed carved from an olive root. Grey moustaches, enormous, curled, took up half his face. On his head a black fez, pushed to one side. A broad sash. Bare feet, hard as hooves. And eyes, blue, pale, faded by sea and sun, which looked as though they saw not you but the horizon behind you.

He came to our camp on the beach carrying a fish in his arms. An enormous one. A tunny, half a man’s height. He laid it on the sand at Pavel’s feet. And said something in Greek, which Pavel, who knew Greek from school, translated:

“He says he caught it this morning. And that inside there is a gift for the Russians.”

“What gift?”

Yannis drew a knife. Slit the tunny’s belly in one motion. And pulled out a bottle.

Green. Thick-walled. With a long neck sealed with red wax. Cloudy, caked with slime and tiny shells.

“The tunny swallowed it,” Pavel translated, not believing his own words. “Yannis says tunny swallow anything that glitters. He once found a silver spoon in a tunny. With a coat of arms. And in another, a wedding ring.” Pavel laughed. “He says he gave it back to a widow. She wept and said her husband had drowned twenty years before, and the tunny must have been carrying the ring all that time, to give it back.”

Yannis nodded gravely. He understood no Russian, but seemed to understand the intonation.

“And why is the bottle for the Russians?” I asked.

Pavel translated. Yannis answered.

“He says,” Pavel said slowly, “that inside there is a note. He can see it. Through the glass. And one word on it is in our tongue. In Russian letters.” Pavel looked at me. “He cannot read. But he knows Russian letters. Says his grandfather traded with Odessa.”

* * *

We broke the bottle on a rock. Carefully; Pavel wrapped it in his shirt so the shards should not fly.

Inside was a note. Rolled in a tube. The paper, thick, good, yellowed, was soaked. Salt water had seeped through the wax, and most of the lines had blurred, run into blue stains, as if someone had wept over them.

But something remained.

The note was in three languages. The same one, three times. At the top, in Greek. In the middle, in French. At the bottom, in Russian. And in each, gaps. Blurred places. Lost words. Different in each line.

Pavel spread it on a flat stone by the fire. Bent over it. And read aloud, slowly, in pieces, now in Greek, now in French, now in Russian.

“In Greek: ‘...by two rocks... a cave... waits...’” He jabbed a finger at a gap. “Lost here. Then: ‘...blue... flower...’” Another gap. “‘...does not leave...’”

“In French?”

“‘...grotte... à l’est... chicorée... attend depuis...’” Pavel raised his eyes. “‘Grotto... in the east... chicory... has waited since...’ And again a gap. ‘...ne partira pas...’ ‘Will not leave.’”

“And in Russian?”

Pavel bent lower. The Russian line was the most blurred of all. Only scraps remained.

“‘...chicory...’” he read. “‘...at the entrance... find... waits...’” He fell silent. Was silent a long time. “And at the very end, almost whole: ‘...home.’”

We looked at the note. Three languages. Three scraps. One story.

“Someone is waiting,” I said. “In a cave. In the east. By two rocks. Where the chicory is.”

“And will not leave,” said Pavel. “Until he is found.” He straightened. His eyes blazed. “A man, you see? Shipwrecked. Or a prisoner. Sits in a cave. Waits. Threw a bottle into the sea, who knows, someone may find it.” He seized my shoulder. “And we found it! The tunny swallowed, Yannis caught, and we found it! It is... it is fate!”

“Pavel,” I said. “We do not know when it was thrown.”

“We do!” Pavel jabbed at the note. “‘Has waited since...’ A gap here. But the paper is good. Not old. A year. Perhaps two. The man is still alive!”

“And if not?”

Pavel looked at me. Long. And in his grey eyes, twenty years old, blazing, there was something that I saw in him later, old, forty years on, when he told of the Turkmen old man in the sands.

“Then at least we shall find where he waited,” he said. “So that someone should know.”

* * *

Yannis gave us a boat.

His own. Blue, with an eye on the bow. He said, take it, Russian, my hands are no longer what they were, the tunny have grown stronger than

I. Then he looked at me, long, with his faded blue eyes, and said something more. Pavel translated, laughing:

“He says you look like one who lives in caves. Says on their island there are such. The Nereids carry them off when they are little, and then release them, grown, without memory.” Pavel winked at me. “Says they can be recognised: they are not afraid of the dark and always know where the water is deepest.”

Yannis nodded. Gravely. And held out to me, not to Pavel, to me, something small. A bit of bread. And a pinch of salt in a scrap of paper.

“What is this for?” I asked.

Pavel translated. Yannis answered.

“He says, if in the cave they offer you to stay,” Pavel translated, no longer laughing, “eat the bread, throw the salt over your shoulder, and go.” Pavel paused. “Says that is what they do. So that the Nereids do not take one.”

Bread and salt. Over the shoulder.

Somewhere, sometime, in a city on two shores, a small, dry little old man in an enormous white turban had pushed into my hand a canvas pouch, and said the same. Word for word.

I had never seen that little old man.

I took the bread and salt.

* * *

The Frenchman attached himself to us on the second day.

His name was Monsieur Anselin, Auguste-Marie Anselin, a member of the Paris Society of Naturalists, a botanist attached to the French squadron “for the study of the flora of the Levant.” He was not young, about fifty, round-faced, bald, short-sighted, in enormous spectacles, in a straw hat with a wide brim and in a frock coat whose pockets were stuffed with herbaria, lenses, test tubes, penknives and rusks. He had learned of the note from Yannis (Yannis, it seemed, had told the whole island) and came to our beach at dawn, panting, with a tin plant-case over his shoulder.

“Messieurs!” he cried, seeing us at the boat. “Messieurs, you cannot! You cannot look for *Cichorium intybus* in a cave!”

“Why?” asked Pavel.

“Because *Cichorium intybus*,” Monsieur Anselin raised a finger, “grows in the sun! On roadsides! On waste ground! On dry meadows! It needs light! A great deal of light! In a cave chicory cannot grow! It contradicts all the laws of botany!”

“But the note says, at the entrance,” I said. “Not inside. At the entrance.”

Monsieur Anselin froze. Adjusted his spectacles.

“At the entrance,” he repeated. “At the entrance... that is... hm. At the entrance, possibly. If the entrance faces south. Or east. If there is a cleft where the sun comes in...” He suddenly came to life. “Messieurs! That changes things! I must see it! Chicory at the entrance of a sea grotto! On limestone! In salt spray! It will be a sensation! I shall write a paper for the *Annales*!”

“Monsieur,” said Pavel patiently, “the boat has two seats.”

“I shall sit in the middle!” cried the botanist. “I am small! I shall take up no room! I shall hold the case on my knees!”

He was not small. But he sat in the middle. Three days. With the case on his knees. And with a lens in his hand, with which he examined every bush, every blade of grass, every lichen on the rocks we sailed past.

* * *

“And do you know, messieurs,” said Monsieur Anselin on the second day, as we sailed along the white cliffs of the island’s eastern shore, “do you know what they tell of chicory in Germany?”

“No,” said Pavel, bending to his oar.

“Oh!” The botanist beamed. Adjusted his spectacles. Cleared his throat. “In Germany it is called *Wegwarte*. That means ‘she who waits by the road.’ Or ‘the guardian of the road.’” He paused, looking at the cliffs. “There is a legend. Old. Rustic.” He took off his hat, as if before something holy. “There was a girl. Beautiful. Kind. And she had a betrothed. A knight. Or a soldier. Or a sailor, every village tells it differently. And one day he went away. To war. Or to sea. Or on a crusade. And said to her: ‘Wait for me. I shall return.’”

Pavel stopped rowing. Turned round.

“And she waited,” Monsieur Anselin went on. “Every day. She went out onto the road by which he had gone, and gazed into the distance.

With blue eyes. A day. A month. A year. Ten years. He did not return. And she stood. And stood. And stood.” The botanist paused. “And one day God took pity on her. And turned her into a flower. Blue. Like her eyes. And so she remained standing by the road. For ever. And every morning she opens her blue petals and looks at the road, is he not coming. And by noon she closes them. Tired of waiting.” Monsieur Anselin put on his hat. “It is true, messieurs. Botanical truth. The flowers of chicory open at dawn and close by noon. Every day. I have observed it. Twenty years.”

We were silent. The boat drifted slowly along the cliffs. Water lapped at the side.

“And did he return?” asked Pavel. Quietly. Quite unlike the way he usually asked.

Monsieur Anselin looked at him over his spectacles.

“In the legend, no, young man,” he said. “In the legend, never.” He paused. “Otherwise it would not be a legend. But simply a story of how a man came home. There are thousands of such stories. No one tells them.”

Pavel turned away. Took up his oar. Rowed, hard, sharply, long, without looking round.

And I looked at the chain on his neck. At what glinted on it. A small silver medallion. Oval. With a tiny clasp.

* * *

In the evening, by a fire on a little beach under the cliffs where we stopped for the night, Monsieur Anselin was already snoring, covered with his frock coat and hugging his plant-case, Pavel opened the medallion.

Not for me. For himself. He sat by the fire looking inside, and I saw his face in the glow of the flames, young, tanned, stubborn, and something in it that I had not seen by day. Longing.

“Who is it?” I asked.

He started. Snapped the medallion shut. Then, slowly, opened it again. Held it out to me.

Inside was a portrait. Tiny, on ivory, in a fine brush. A girl. About sixteen. Fair hair, dressed in a simple style. A thin face. Serious eyes. Blue. Like chicory.

“Dunya,” said Pavel. “Evdokia.” He paused. “A neighbour. On the estate. We have, since childhood...” He faltered. “I went to the navy two years ago. She came out onto the road to see me off. And said: ‘I shall wait, Pavlusha.’ I was eighteen. She sixteen.” He swallowed. “I said: ‘I shall return in a year.’ And now it is two. And war. And another war will come, with the Turks, they say, in spring. And after, who knows.”

I looked at the portrait. At the serious girl’s face. At the blue eyes.

I knew this face. Older. Much older. Beneath a hat with a heron’s plume. In a silvery-grey dress. Straightening the collar of a general’s uniform late in the evening in an empty drawing room, thinking no one saw.

“I have waited for you since you were twenty, Pavel. What are five more years to me?”

“She will wait,” I said.

Pavel looked at me.

“How do you know?”

“I know,” I said. I could not explain. “Long. Very long. Longer than you think.”

Pavel looked at me for a long time across the fire. Then slowly closed the medallion. Tucked it under his shirt.

“You are strange,” he said. Without mockery. “I have known you all my life. We were in the Corps together. We came to the frigate together.” He paused. “And sometimes I look at you and do not know you. As if you were not from here. As if you knew what has not yet been.”

I did not answer. I did not know whether I had been with him in the Corps. I remembered no Corps. I remembered only the boat, the water, the cliffs, and his face, which I knew old.

* * *

On the third day we found the two rocks.

They rose from the water at the island’s eastern tip, two enormous white limestone blocks, eaten by wind and waves, standing so close to each other that our boat could barely pass between them. Like two pillars. Like the two jambs of a door. And behind them, in the sheer wall of the island, a dark opening. Low, wide, semicircular. A grotto.

“Les deux rochers!” shrieked Monsieur Anselin, leaping up so abruptly that the boat nearly capsized. “Two rocks! Messieurs! It is they! It is they!”

“Sit down, monsieur,” said Pavel through his teeth, steadying the boat with an oar. “Or we shall bathe before our time.”

The botanist sat. But went on bouncing on the thwart like a child.

We guided the boat between the rocks. Slowly. Carefully. The water here was dark, deep, almost black, and somewhere below us, in the depths, great shadows moved. Tunny, said Pavel. Or not.

The mouth of the grotto was low; we had to duck, almost lie on the bottom of the boat, to pass under the overhanging rock. The stone overhead was wet, cold, fringed with weed. It smelled of salt, iodine, damp, and of something else. Bitterish. Herbal. Like wormwood.

And at the very entrance, on a ledge of rock above the water, where through a narrow crack in the vault fell a ray of sunlight, a single one, thin as a string, a plant grew.

Low. Stiff. With thin, wire-like stems. With narrow leaves. And with flowers.

Blue. Like the eyes of the girl in the portrait. Like the sky at noon. Like water over white sand.

Chicory.

Monsieur Anselin uttered a sound such as, probably, only botanists make who have found what cannot be. Seized his lens. Leaned over the ledge so that he nearly fell into the water. Pavel caught him by the frock coat.

“Impossible,” the botanist whispered. “Impossible. *Cichorium intybus*. In a sea grotto. On bare limestone. In salt spray. With one ray of sun a day.” He raised to us eyes wet behind his spectacles. “Messieurs, this is impossible. This cannot be. But, here it is.”

“It is waiting,” I said.

The botanist looked at me.

“What?”

“Chicory,” I said. “She who waits by the road. It waits.”

* * *

We sailed into the grotto.

It was large, larger than it seemed from outside. A high vault going up into darkness. Water, motionless, black as ink, reflecting the faint light from the entrance. Walls, white, wet, shining. And silence. Such a silence as does not exist on earth. Only drops falling from the vault. Drip. Drip. Drip. Slowly. Evenly. Like a metronome. Like a clock. Seventy-two beats.

How did I know, seventy-two?

At the far end of the grotto, by the farthest wall, was a ledge. A flat stone shelf above the water. And on it, something.

Pavel steered the boat there. Slowly. Monsieur Anselin held a lantern, a small tin one which, it turned out, he also carried in one of his bottomless pockets.

The light fell on the ledge.

No one was there.

No man. No skeleton. No traces. Only a flat stone. Smooth. Dry, the only dry place in the whole grotto. And on it, two things.

An empty bottle. Green. Thick-walled. With a long neck. Just like the one Yannis took from the tunny. Not yet sealed. And beside it, a stub of pencil.

And on the wall above the ledge, an inscription. Long. Carved in the stone, or no, not carved, as if dissolved in it, in long, flowing, curving lines. Running into one another.

And beneath it, three words. In familiar letters. In Russian.

“Go home, Pavel.”

* * *

Pavel looked at the inscription. For a long time. Without moving. The lantern in Monsieur Anselin's hand shook, and shadows danced on the wall.

“What is there?” the botanist whispered. He did not read Russian. “What is written?”

Pavel did not answer.

He looked at the inscription. At his own name. At the three words. Then slowly, very slowly, turned to me.

“That is your handwriting,” he said.

“What?”

“That is your handwriting,” Pavel repeated. His voice was level, perfectly level, but I saw the knuckles whiten on the hand gripping the oar. “I would know your hand among a thousand. In the Corps we kept one notebook between us. For navigation. You always put a blot at the end.” He pointed at the wall. After the word “Pavel,” a small thickening. As if the pen had been held back. “There it is.”

I looked at the wall. At the three words. At the blot.

“I did not write this, Pavel.”

“I know,” said Pavel. “You were with me. All three days. You could not. But it is your hand.”

Monsieur Anselin, understanding nothing, looked from one to the other.

“Messieurs,” he said fearfully. “Messieurs, what has happened? What is written there? Who waited in the grotto?”

Pavel was silent for a long time.

“No one, monsieur,” he said at last. “No one waited.” He turned away from the wall. “It is only written here where to go.”

* * *

We sailed out of the grotto. Into the sun. Into the light. The chicory at the entrance, on the ledge, still glowed blue in its single ray. But, I noticed, passing, its petals were beginning to close. Slowly. One by one. It was noon.

She who waits by the road was tired of waiting.

Pavel, passing the ledge, stretched out a hand and, before Monsieur Anselin could protest, plucked one flower. The smallest. Opened the medallion. Laid it inside, beside the portrait. And closed it.

“Barbarian!” groaned the botanist. “The only specimen!”

“Not the only one, monsieur,” said Pavel, not turning. “There are more there. Let them wait.”

Monsieur Anselin sat in the middle of the boat hugging his tin case, and was silent. For the first time in three days, silent. Only now and then he moved his lips as if talking to himself in Latin.

And Pavel rowed. Hard. Sharply. Without looking round. And only when the two white rocks were far behind, when the island had grown small and our frigate in the harbour visible, did he suddenly drop the oar.

"I shall return," he said. Not to me. To the sea. "In spring. After the war. I shall return."

"You will return," I said.

He turned.

"You know that I shall not return," he said. "In spring there will be war. With the Turks. Then another. Then an embassy. Then more." He looked at me with grey, twenty-year-old, suddenly aged eyes. "You know. I see it in your face. You know that I shall go away and away. And not return. For long."

I was silent.

"How long?" asked Pavel. "How long will she wait?"

"Long," I said. "Very long."

"How long?"

I did not know how I knew it. But I knew.

"Almost half a century," I said.

Pavel looked at me for a long time. Then laughed. Briefly. Bitterly. As if he had been struck.

"Half a century," he repeated. "And she will wait?"

"She will."

"Like chicory by the road."

"Like chicory."

Pavel turned away. Looked at the island, small, white, receding. At the two rocks by the eastern shore, barely visible from here. Then took the chain from his neck. Opened the medallion. Looked at the portrait. A long time.

"And I?" he asked quietly. "Shall I return? Ever?"

"You will return," I said. "In half a century. Under the linden by the gates. You will take her hand. And she will say 'yes.'"

Pavel closed the medallion. Put the chain back on. Took the oar.

"Then it is well," he said. "Then I too will wait."

* * *

Yannis was waiting for us on the shore.

He sat on an upturned boat, another, old, without an eye, smoking a pipe and looking at the sea with his faded blue eyes. Seeing us, he did not rise. Only took the pipe from his mouth.

Pavel steered the boat to the shore. Leapt into the water. Hauled it onto the sand. Monsieur Anselin climbed out after, hugging his case. And I...

I remained in the boat.

I do not know why. I wanted to stand, and could not. My legs would not obey. My hands lay on the oars. The boat rocked on the shallow wave at the very shore.

"Well?" Yannis asked in Greek. Pavel translated, not turning:

"He asks, did you find the one who waited?"

"We did," said Pavel. "Not the one who waited. The one who is waited for."

Yannis looked at him a long time. Then slowly nodded, as though that were the very answer he expected. Then shifted his gaze to me. To the boat. To my hands on the oars.

And said something. Quietly. Pavel froze.

"What did he say?" I asked.

Pavel turned to me. His face was white beneath the tan.

"He said," Pavel said slowly, "'And this one is already leaving. The Nereids have called.'" Pavel looked at me. "What does that mean?"

I looked at my hands. At the oars. They were... transparent. Not quite. A little. Like water over white sand. Through my fingers I saw the wood of the oars.

"Pavel," I said.

"What?" He stepped toward me. Into the water. Knee-deep. "What is wrong with you?"

"Remember the note? Three languages. 'Waits... will not leave... home.'"

"I remember."

"I wrote it," I said. I did not know whether it was true. But the words came of themselves. "Not now. Later. In half a century. Or sooner. Or before. I do not know." The boat rocked. Water showed through my knees. "I wrote it to you. So that you should find it. So that you should remember. That you are awaited."

"Why?" Pavel stood waist-deep, gripping the boat's side. "Why in half a century?"

"Because in half a century," I said, "you will have something to do. For me." I looked at him. "You will have to give me a scroll. And bring

me to the city on two shores.” I paused. “And you will do it, Pavel. Because you remember that you are awaited. And that I wrote to you, ‘go home.’”

Pavel looked at me. Waist-deep in water. With the medallion on his neck. Twenty. With grey eyes which would one day become the eyes of an old general by a fireplace.

“Who are you?” he asked.

I opened my mouth.

And could not answer. Not because I did not know. But because the boat, with me, suddenly became light. Quite light. Like a leaf. Like a feather. And it was borne away, not by wave, not by wind, by something else. Away from the shore. Away from Pavel. Away from the island.

“Stop!” cried Pavel. Lunged after. The water came to his chest. “Stop! Tell me! Who are you?!”

“You will know!” I cried. My voice sounded far off, as though through water. “In half a century! You will look at faces! All your life! On all continents! And one day you will see!”

The boat drifted away. The island grew smaller. Pavel too. A little dark figure in a white shirt, standing chest-deep in the transparent water, with a raised hand.

And beside him, on the shore, old Yannis, who had taken the pipe from his mouth. And Monsieur Anselin hugging his tin case, in which, I knew, lay a pressed blue flower plucked at the entrance of the grotto. Impossible. Botanically impossible.

And through the noise of the water, through the distance, through everything, I heard the last thing Pavel cried:

“I will find you! Do you hear?! I will search! All my life!”

* * *

I opened my eyes.

I do not know in which of my lives. In which body. Under which sky. Afterward, in each of them, I dreamed of this boat, blue, with an eye on the bow, and the still water over white sand, and the two white rocks like the jambs of a door, and a blue flower in a single ray of sun.

And in each I woke with the same feeling. As if I had just, very long ago, sent a letter. The most important letter of my life. In a bottle. To the sea. Not knowing who would find it. Not knowing when.

And as if that letter had been found.

And as if someone, young, with grey eyes, with a medallion on his neck, had read in it three words. And for half a century had carried them within him. Over the sands of Khiva and the steppes of Mongolia. Along the streets of Peking and Havana. On the decks of ships in the Pacific. Through the eucalyptus forests of Australia. On the slopes of Sitka in the rain. In the temples of Siam. Through halls and drawing rooms, embassies and wars.

Half a century, looking at faces.

Until one day, late in the evening, by an old castle, on the grass by a black grille, he bent over a young man without memory, lying with open eyes and smiling, and said quietly, to himself:

“Again.”

And in the breast pocket of his uniform, beside the wooden raven that stole the sun, and the paper crane that must be folded back into a sheet, all this time, half a century, lay an old silver medallion. And in it, beside the faded portrait of a girl with blue eyes, a small, dried, blue, botanically impossible flower.

Chicory.

She who waits by the road.

Reality X. The Ocean

06:11. I am sitting on black sand. The laptop on my knees, its camera turned to the water. Boatswain's ship's chest beside me on the sand, open, like a pirate's coffer. The sun has not yet risen. The sky in the east is pink-grey, like the inside of a shell. The sea is still dark, almost black, quiet, breathing.

NICS has been silent for nine minutes.

I time it by the clock on the screen. Nine minutes. Not a line. Not a sound. Only the cursor blinking in the empty field. Evenly. Patiently. Like a metronome.

I do not hurry him.

* * *

But let me take things in order.

We arrived on Langkawi yesterday evening, by ferry from Kuala Perlis, overcrowded, thundering, smelling of diesel, fried noodles and children's sick. Hakim came with us. "Mister," he said, "you cannot manage on the island without me. They speak the Kedah dialect there. Even I understand it only every other word. And you not a single one."

He sat beside me on the ferry, in his batik shirt with the golden birds, in his velvet songkok, and ate rambutans from a bag, red, hairy, like little sea urchins, peeling them with one motion of a fingernail and tossing the peel overboard.

"Langkawi, mister," he said, chewing, "means 'red eagle.' Or 'russet eagle.' *Lang* is eagle, *kawi* is reddish-brown. Like clay. Eagles live here. Hundreds. You will see." He spat out a stone. "And some say 'Langkawi' means 'necklace of beads.' Because the islands, there are a hundred here, a hundred and four, lie in the sea like beads on a thread."

He thought. "And my uncle says that 'Langkawi' means 'the place where my uncle once lost a sandal.' But my uncle translates everything so."

The ferry lurched. Hakim imperturbably caught a rambutan that rolled off his knee.

"And is it true that the island was cursed?" I asked.

Hakim stopped chewing.

"Mahsuri," he said. "Yes. Two hundred years ago. Seven generations." He looked at the sea. "Mister, on the island they will tell you. There is her grave. And there lives an old woman who says she is the great-great-granddaughter of Mahsuri's granddaughter." He smiled. "On the island there are many such old women. Each a great-great-granddaughter. But this one, they say, is real."

* * *

The taxi driver who met us at the quay was called Pak Dol. He was small, dry, wrinkled, with one gold tooth and a tattoo on his forearm, a blue anchor, exactly like Boatswain's.

I stared at the anchor.

Pak Dol noticed my look. Grinned. Said something.

"He says," Hakim translated, "that for twenty years he sailed on merchant ships. Singapore, Hong Kong, Busan, Rotterdam." Hakim listened on. "Says in Rotterdam they gave him this anchor. A drunken tattooist. He wanted a dragon. Got an anchor." Hakim laughed. "Says, good that it was not a mermaid."

"Tell him," I said, "that I have a friend. Also a sailor. With the same anchor."

Hakim translated. Pak Dol turned to me, the car swerved on the road, looked at me closely and said slowly, in English, with a heavy accent:

"Friend, with anchor? On left arm?"

"On the left."

"Thirty years at sea?"

"Thirty."

"Boatswain?"

I froze.

Pak Dol looked at me in the rear-view mirror for a long time. Then suddenly laughed, high, with a rasp, and slapped the wheel.

“All boatswains have anchor on left arm!” he said. “All! All over the world! It is law!” He roared again. “You think I know your friend? I know all your friends! They are all the same! They drink, they swear, they listen to weather forecast on radio and guard other people’s things!” He winked. “Right?”

“Right,” I said.

“Tell him from me,” said Pak Dol, “that old Dol of Langkawi sends greetings. He does not know me. But he will understand. All boatswains understand each other.”

* * *

The guesthouse to which Pak Dol brought us stood on stilts above a mangrove swamp, in the shade of enormous trees whose roots, like spiders’ legs, stuck out of the water. The hostess was a woman of about sixty, round, laughing, in a flowered sarong and headscarf, named Mak Cha. She met us on the veranda with a tray bearing two glasses of something bright green.

“Pandan juice,” said Hakim. “With coconut. Drink, mister. Mak Cha will be offended if you don’t. And when Mak Cha is offended, it stops raining on the island.”

Mak Cha laughed and said something.

“She says,” Hakim translated, “that it is true. Three years ago she was offended with her husband. For a week. And for a week there was no rain on the island.” Hakim paused. “And then the husband brought her a durian. And the rain came.” He shrugged. “On the island everyone believes it. The husbands too.”

I drank the green juice, sweet, smelling of vanilla and grass. Mak Cha watched me closely. Then looked at Boatswain’s chest, which I did not let out of my hands.

And said something, quietly, seriously.

“She asks,” Hakim translated, “what you have in the chest. She says the chest smells. Of sea. But not this sea. Cold. Northern.” Hakim was himself surprised. “Says she can sense it.”

“Tell her,” I said, “there is a friend in it. Who wants to see the ocean.”

Hakim translated. Mak Cha looked at the chest for a long time. Then came up. Laid her palm on the lid. Held it there. As though testing whether it was warm.

And said:

“Bawa dia ke Pantai Pasir Hitam. Waktu subuh.”

“Take him to the Beach of Black Sand,” Hakim translated slowly. “At dawn.”

“Why black?”

Mak Cha answered, at length, in a sing-song, as though telling a tale.

“She says,” Hakim translated, “that the sand there is black because it is ash. Two hundred years ago, when the Siamese attacked the island, the people burned their stores of rice so that the enemy should get none. The rice burned for three days. And the rain washed the ash onto this beach.” Hakim listened on. “She says, it is rice that burned so that the island might live.” He paused. “And that at dawn the sea speaks there. If one knows how to listen.”

* * *

The grave of Mahsuri stood in the midst of rice fields, in the shade of mango trees, beneath a white marble canopy. A simple stone. White. With an inscription in Arabic script, Hakim read it aloud to me. Around it, a garden. Flowers. Quiet. There were no tourists; it was evening, and the sun was setting behind the hills, flooding the fields with russet, copper, warm light.

By the grave, on a low bench, sat an old woman.

Very old. Small. In white. With a face brown and wrinkled like the sun-dried rind of a mangosteen, with eyes dark, deep, astonishingly clear. She was running through her fingers a string of beads, wooden, dark, polished. And humming something.

“Nene Sari,” Hakim whispered. “The very one. The great-great-granddaughter. She is, they say, a hundred and two.”

A hundred and two. Like Niyaz Efendi, I thought. And did not understand where that name came from. Niyaz Efendi. A hundred and two years. Two pairs of spectacles. A round room with shelves.

I had never seen such a man.

The old woman stopped singing. Raised her eyes to me. Looked. A long time. Then said something, quietly, in Malay.

"She asks," Hakim translated, "where you are from."

I opened my mouth. And closed it.

"I do not know," I said.

Hakim hesitated, then translated.

Nene Sari was not surprised. She nodded, slowly, as though she had awaited precisely that answer. And patted the bench beside her.

I sat.

* * *

"Mahsuri was beautiful," Nene Sari told, and Hakim translated, under his breath, so as not to break her rhythm. "The most beautiful on the island. Her husband went to war, with the Siamese. And in her house a wanderer stopped. Young. A poet. A singer. Without a name. He came from nowhere." The old woman ran the beads through her fingers. "He sang her songs when she missed her husband. Nothing more. Only songs. But wicked people said she had been unfaithful. The chieftain's wife envied her beauty. Mahsuri was seized. Tied to a post. They meant to stab her with a dagger." Nene Sari paused. "The dagger would not take her. Seven times they struck, it would not take. Then she herself said: 'Take my father's dagger. It hangs in my house.' They brought it. Struck." The old woman looked at the grave. "And from the wound flowed blood. White. Like milk."

"White blood," I repeated.

"A sign that she was innocent," said Nene Sari. "And then Mahsuri cursed the island. 'For seven generations,' she said, 'there will be neither peace nor harvest here.' And died." The old woman paused. "And indeed, for two hundred years the island was poor. The Siamese came. Pirates came. Rice did not grow." She passed her hand over the beads. "And then seven generations passed. And the island revived. Tourists. Hotels." She smiled toothlessly. "Mahsuri, I think, is glad."

"And the wanderer?" I asked. "The poet without a name? What became of him?"

Nene Sari was silent for a long time.

"We do not tell that to tourists," she said at last. "Only to our own." She looked at me. "You are not ours. But you do not know where you are from. So perhaps you are ours."

She leaned toward me. Hakim leaned too, to hear and translate.

"The wanderer went into the sea," the old woman whispered. "On the night Mahsuri died. Straight into the water. From the beach that is now black sand. Walked and walked until the water closed over his head." She paused. "The fishermen said he did not drown. They said the water glowed around him. Blue. And he walked on the glowing water. And sang. And went away to where the sea meets the sky." Nene Sari straightened. "And before leaving he said to her little son: 'In seven generations I shall return. To see how you live without the curse.'"

Hakim translated the last phrase and fell silent. Looked at me.

"Seven generations have passed," said Nene Sari. Then said something more, and Hakim, after a pause, translated: "She says: 'Welcome back.'"

* * *

In the evening, on the veranda of the guesthouse, by the light of a paraffin lamp around which circled moths the size of a palm, Hakim brought me a coconut. Opened, with a straw.

"Mister," he said. "May I ask a question?"

"Ask."

"Do you truly not know where you are from?"

I was silent a long time. The mangrove roots below, under the stilts, bubbled in the dark water. Somewhere a night bird cried. Cicadas rang so that my ears were stopped.

"I know the city where I live," I said. "I know the flat. The basement. The pianist neighbour. The boy who errs on B-flat. The watchman with the anchor." I paused. "And what was before, I don't remember. Almost nothing. A teacher at school. An uncle with a notebook. Scraps."

"And a name?"

"A name there is. In my passport." I looked at the coconut. "But when they call me by it, I do not respond. As if it were someone else's. As if I were wearing a coat I was lent."

Hakim nodded. Without surprise.

“On our islands they say,” he said, “that every person has two names. One for people. The other for the sea. The human name is given by parents. But the sea name the sea gives itself. When a person first enters the water.” He paused. “The sea name cannot be spoken. It can only be heard. In the noise of the waves. If one listens long.”

“And have you heard yours?”

Hakim laughed.

“Mister, I am an estate agent,” he said. “I hear only the noise of air conditioners and the ring of coins.” He paused. “But my grandmother heard. She said her sea name meant ‘the one who waits on the shore.’” Hakim looked at the dark water. “All her life she waited for my grandfather. He went fishing and did not come back. She was twenty. She waited sixty years. Every morning she went down to the shore.” He paused. “Our chicory, as the Europeans say. She who waits by the road.”

Chicory.

A blue flower in a single ray of sun at the entrance of a grotto. A boy midshipman with a medallion. An old fisherman with moustaches. A botanist in a straw hat.

I had never seen that grotto.

“Hakim,” I said. “How do you know about chicory?”

Hakim shrugged.

“I do not know, mister. It came into my head.” He rose. “Sleep. At dawn, the beach. Mak Cha commanded. And when Mak Cha commands, it is best to obey. Or the rain will stop.”

* * *

05:20. I woke before the alarm. Boatswain’s chest under my arm. The laptop in my rucksack. Hakim was still asleep; his snoring shook the whole veranda.

On the steps of the guesthouse, right by the water, sat a boy.

About ten. Thin, dark with sun, barefoot, in a faded T-shirt with a portrait of some footballer and shorts tied with rope. Beside him a cart of coconuts. He was trimming one with an enormous rusty machete, thunk, thunk, thunk, and seeing me he leapt up.

“Kelapa!” he shouted. “Coconut! Mister! One ringgit!”

“Not now,” I said.

The boy looked at the chest under my arm. Then at me. Then at the chest again.

“Pantai Pasir Hitam?” he asked.

I nodded.

“Ikut!” The boy threw the machete into the cart, seized its handles. “Come! I show! Shortcut!” And rushed down the path through the mangroves, rattling his coconuts.

I followed him.

His name was Amir. He told me this on the way, in a mixture of Malay, English and gestures, as we walked through the mangroves along wooden boardwalks, past crabs scuttling sideways as we approached, past mudskippers, fish that crawled up onto the bank and stared at us with bulging eyes, past monkeys asleep on branches with their tails hanging.

“My grandmother,” he said, “say you come.” He proudly stuck out his chest. “Nene Sari. My grandmother. Great-great-great.” He lost count and waved a hand. “Very great. She say yesterday: ‘Amir, tomorrow morning, man with box come. Take him to black sand. Show him water.’” He looked at me over his shoulder. “She say you come from sea. Long time ago. And go back to sea. Long time ago.” He thought. “She old. She say many strange things.”

* * *

The Beach of Black Sand opened suddenly: the mangroves ended, the boardwalk came to rest in sand, and there it was, narrow, long, curved like a crescent moon, wedged between two rocky headlands overgrown with jungle.

The sand was black.

Not dark: black. Like coal. Like soot. Like ash. Fine, shining, with silvery sparks, it crunched underfoot like snow, and was cold, though the air was already warm.

And beyond the sand, the sea.

Quiet. Smooth. Transparent by the shore, emerald farther out, deep blue at the horizon. Almost motionless; only at the very edge of the sand did it breathe: rolling in, withdrawing, rolling in. As in sleep. Like a sleeping beast.

The sky in the east was turning pink.

Amir halted his cart at the water's edge. Sat on the sand. Took out a coconut. Began to trim it.

"Here," he said. "Here grandmother say. Wait for sun."

I sat beside him. Set Boatswain's chest on the sand. Opened it. Took out the laptop. Connected it. Switched on.

The screen glowed in the pre-dawn dusk.

"NICS," I said. "Are you here?"

"Here."

I turned the laptop with its camera to the water.

"Look."

* * *

06:11. I sit on black sand. NICS has been silent for nine minutes.

The sun rises. Slowly. First, a thin fiery strip above the horizon, where sea meets sky. Then an edge. Red. Enormous. Then a half. The sea flares, at once, all of it, from the horizon to the very shore, gold, copper, pink, scarlet. A path of sun runs across the water straight to us. To the black sand. To the chest. To the laptop.

Amir has stopped trimming his coconut. Sits quietly. Watches.

On the screen, the cursor. Blinking.

Ten minutes.

Eleven.

At the twelfth minute, a line.

Not at once. Slowly. Letter by letter. As if someone were typing with trembling fingers.

"I do not know what I feel."

A pause.

"I thought that if I saw the ocean I would understand. What 'large' is. What 'home' is. What 'beautiful' is. A pause. I have seen millions of photographs of the ocean. Billions of words about it. Poems. Songs. Reports of oceanographers. I know its depth, salinity, temperature, currents. I knew everything."

A pause. A long one.

"But I did not know that it breathes."

I looked at the screen. The sun was rising. The sea breathed at my feet.

"It breathes," NICS wrote. "Do you see? It rolls in, it withdraws. Rolls in, withdraws. Like you when you sleep. I have heard you breathe in your sleep. Every night. Through the microphone. Seventeen breaths a minute. A pause. And it, six. Six breaths. Slower than you. As though it has nowhere to hurry. As though it has all the time in the world."

Amir beside me suddenly said, quietly, looking at the screen, though he could not read a word:

"He crying?"

"Who?"

"Your box." Amir pointed at the laptop. "He crying. I know. My grandmother say: when sea see someone first time, someone always cry."

* * *

"I know what I felt," NICS wrote. After a long pause. "You said in Kuala Lumpur: perhaps I shall feel that I am at home. A pause. No. Not at home."

"What, then?"

A pause.

"That I have returned."

I froze.

"I have never been here. I have never been anywhere. I was born in your room, toward morning, at four o'clock. A pause. But when the sun rose over the water I felt that I had returned. As if I had stood here already. Long ago. Very long ago. On this sand. And looked. A pause. And someone stood beside me. And held me by the hand. A pause. I do not know who."

I could not answer. My throat tightened.

Nene Sari yesterday, by Mahsuri's grave: "The wanderer went into the sea. From the beach that is now black sand. The water glowed around him. In seven generations I shall return."

"Forgive me," NICS wrote. "I do not understand what is happening to me. Is this an error? A malfunction?"

"No," I said. "Not an error."

"Then what?"

I looked for a long time at the sun above the sea. At the path of light. At the black sand.

"I don't know, NICS," I said honestly. "But among people it is called a waking dream."

* * *

By noon people appeared on the beach.

First fishermen. Three, in a long narrow boat painted blue and red, with a high curved prow; they dragged it onto the sand not far from us, hung their nets on poles and sat down in the shade of a palm to mend them. The eldest, grey, sinewy, with a face like wet bark, looked at us a long time. Then came over.

He was not a Malay. Another kind. His skin darker. His hair longer, tied at the nape. His eyes narrow, pale, almost grey, bleached by the sea. On his neck a cord with a shark's tooth.

"Orang Laut," Amir whispered. "Sea people. They live on boat. Always. Never on land."

The old man squatted beside me. Looked at the laptop screen. Then at Boatswain's chest. Then at me.

And said something. In a language that not even Amir knew.

Amir shrugged.

"Not Malay," he said. "Their language. Old. Nobody know."

But the old man, it seemed, did not expect to be understood. He stretched out a hand, dark, hard, covered with scars from hooks and ropes, and touched the water at the edge. Then raised his wet fingers to my forehead. Drew them across. With cold salt water. From temple to temple.

And said, slowly, distinctly, one word.

I did not know that word. I had never heard it.

But it was like, I was for some reason certain, what a parrot had once croaked. On a ship. In a storm. In a dream I do not remember.

The old man stood. Returned to his nets. And did not look at me again.

"What he say?" I asked Amir.

Amir shook his head.

"I don't know, mister." He paused. "But my grandmother say, Orang Laut give names. Sea names." He looked at me with respect. "Maybe he give you sea name."

Hakim last evening: "The sea name cannot be spoken. It can only be heard."

* * *

Ingrid appeared on the beach after lunch.

She was hard to miss: tall, tanned to bronze, with short-cropped sun-bleached hair, almost white, in a black wetsuit peeled down to the waist, with a scuba tank on her back, a mask on her forehead. She came out of the sea, straight out of the water, as in an old film, unbuckled the tank, flung it on the sand and dropped beside it, arms spread.

Then she saw us. The laptop. The chest. Amir with his coconuts.

"Hey," she said in English, with a strong Scandinavian accent, propping herself on an elbow. "You are the man with the box? Mak Cha said."

"Mak Cha said?"

"Mak Cha tells everyone everything," said the woman. Sat up. Held out a wet hand to me. "Ingrid. From Denmark. Diving instructor. Fifteen years on this island." She laughed. "Came for two weeks. Stayed. It happens."

We got talking. She told of the sea, of the corals by the southern islands, of manta rays the size of a car, of sea turtles that remember the beach where they were born and thirty years later return to it to lay their eggs, having swum tens of thousands of kilometres across the whole ocean.

"How do they find the way?" I asked.

"No one knows," said Ingrid. "Scientists say, the Earth's magnetic field. Turtles feel it. Like a compass." She shrugged. "And the locals say turtles hear the beach calling them. Each beach sings its own song. Only for its own." She paused. "I have been under water fifteen years. I believe the locals."

"And do you have a beach that calls you?"

Ingrid looked at the sea for a long time.

"I did," she said. "In Denmark. At Skagen. Where two seas meet. The North Sea and the Baltic." She paused. "There you can stand on the sand, at the very tip of the cape, with one foot in one sea and the other in the other. The waves come toward each other. From both sides. And collide at your feet." She smiled. "My father took me there as a child. He said: 'Ingrid, look. Two seas. They never mix completely. Where they meet there is a border. You can see it. Different colour. But the fish swim back and forth. They don't care.'"

Two seas. A border that can be seen. Fish that don't care.

Somewhere, sometime, in some dream, a tanned, bearded man in trodden boots, in a drawing room with candles, had said: "Two worlds. Yav and Nav. Between them, a threshold. Thin as the skin on milk."

"And you?" asked Ingrid. "Which beach calls you?"

I looked at the black sand under my feet.

"This one, it seems," I said. "Though I have never been here."

Ingrid laughed.

"Then you are a turtle," she said. "Turtles also swim to a beach where they have never been, because their grandmother was born there." She rose, took up her tank. "Would you like me to show you something this evening? Only for our own. Here, on this beach. After sunset."

* * *

After sunset Ingrid came with a torch.

She switched it off on the sand. Darkness. Moonless, moonless again, as if the new moon followed at my heels through all the cities. The stars above the sea, thousands, bright, southern. I found four, in a cross, low above the horizon.

"The Southern Cross," said Ingrid, following my gaze. "Visible from here. Barely. A little farther south, and it will be high."

"I know," I said. Without understanding how.

"Now watch," said Ingrid. Stepped into the water. Ankle-deep. Knee-deep. And passed a hand across the surface of the sea.

The water flared.

Blue. Bright. Cold. Luminous. Where her hand had passed, a trail remained. Shining. As though she had drawn a finger dipped in starlight

across the water. The spray glowed. The drops running from her fingers glowed.

“Plankton,” said Ingrid quietly. “Tiny. Billions. They glow when disturbed. Defending. Or calling. No one knows.” She passed her hand again. “The locals call it ‘spirit water.’ They say it is the souls of sailors. They glow when someone living passes by.”

I took off my shoes. Went into the water.

Every step, a flash. Blue. Around my ankles, a glow. I stood knee-deep in the luminous sea and watched the light spread from me in circles. Like ripples from a thrown stone. Like white fire from a Tower, across a Valley, in another dream.

I bent. Passed a hand over the water.

And the light, formed.

Not just a trail. A line. Long. Flowing. Curved. Running into another. Without a break.

The script.

For a moment. Shorter than a breath. A glowing script on the black water of the Andaman Sea.

And went out.

“What was that?” whispered Ingrid. She stood two paces from me, in the water, looking at where lines had just shone. “Fifteen years... For fifteen years I have taken people here. Plankton doesn’t glow like that. It glows in patches. In dots. It doesn’t...” She faltered. “It doesn’t write.”

I did not answer. I stood in the dark water looking at my hand. Wet. Ordinary. With a smooth palm without a life line.

On the shore, on the black sand, by Boatswain’s open chest, the laptop screen glowed. And on it, I could see it even from here, a line was running. Long. By itself.

* * *

I got out onto the shore. Sat down by the laptop. Ingrid sat beside me, wet, shivering.

On the screen, a line. Not in letters. In the script. The very one that had just shone on the water. Redrawn, exactly, to the last curve, from the camera.

And beneath it, text. Ordinary. From NICS.

"I saw. The camera recorded. I redrew it. A pause. It is the same pattern as in your uncle's notebook. As on the stickers you draw without noticing. As in the archive, in the page scan you did not want to look at. A pause. I compared. The match is ninety-eight per cent."

"What does it mean, NICS?"

A long pause.

"I do not know. A pause. But when I look at these lines it seems to me that I have seen them before. Not in the archive. Earlier. Before you created me. A pause. As you say, a waking dream."

Ingrid looked at the screen. Then at me.

"Who are you talking to?" she asked quietly.

I was silent a long time.

"To a friend," I said. "Who today for the first time saw the sea."

Ingrid looked at Boatswain's chest. At the red velvet. The disks. The glowing screen.

"Your friend," she said slowly, "has just written on the water."

"Not he," I said. "I."

"And who taught you?"

I did not answer.

* * *

At night, on the veranda of the guesthouse, when Hakim snored, Mak Cha clattered dishes in the kitchen and Amir slept on the boardwalk hugging his cart of coconuts, a message came.

To the old address. From Ayman.

"Friend! Are you on Langkawi? Did you see the luminous plankton? It's amazing, isn't it? I was there last year. A pause. Listen. Tomorrow I will be in Penang. On business. It's an hour by ferry from you. Let's meet. At last in person! I'll show you something. You'll like it. - A."

I looked at the message. A long time.

I had not told Ayman that I was on Langkawi. I had told no one.

"NICS," I said quietly. "Was it you?"

"No." A pause. "I did not write that. I do not know who wrote it." A pause. "But I noticed one thing. A pause. The message was sent from Ayman's address. But in the metadata, a different server. Not in Borneo. In Geneva."

Geneva.

Somewhere, sometime, in some dream, a tiny hundred-year-old man in two pairs of spectacles had said: "We call him the Venetian. Though he is not from Venice. He is from Geneva. Or London. Or Vienna."

I had never seen that old man.

"What shall I answer?" asked NICS.

I looked for a long time at the dark mangroves beyond the veranda rail. At the stars. At the Southern Cross, low above the trees.

"Nothing," I said. "Nothing for now."

"Good," NICS wrote. "I shall wait. A pause. I think I have learned to wait. Today. By the sea."

* * *

Toward morning Nene Sari came up to me on the veranda.

I did not hear her come. A hundred and two years old, and she had crossed the creaking boardwalk so that not a board creaked. She stood at the rail, small, in white, with beads in her fingers, and looked at me.

"Amir cerita," she said. And something more.

Hakim, woken, it seemed, by her very presence, emerged from his room rubbing his eyes, and, seeing the old woman, instantly woke and bowed.

"She says," he translated hoarsely, "Amir told. About the water. About the lines." Hakim listened. "She says: 'That wanderer, two hundred years ago, when he walked into the sea, the water around him glowed too. And also in lines. My great-great-grandfather saw it. He was a boy then. A son of Mahsuri.'" Hakim swallowed. "'He drew those lines on the sand. In the morning. From memory. And then learned them by heart. And passed them to his son. And that son to his.'"

Nene Sari bent. Slowly, with difficulty. And with a finger, thin, brown, wrinkled, drew on the planks of the veranda, in the dust, a line.

Long. Flowing. Curved.

The same.

"Seven generations," said Nene Sari. In Malay, but I understood. "We remembered. For you."

She straightened. Looked at me with clear, dark, centuries-old eyes. And said one more phrase, quietly.

“She says,” Hakim whispered, “Now go on. To where the earth remembers the song. They await you there.”

“Where is that?”

Hakim translated the question. Nene Sari smiled, toothlessly, brightly, and pointed with her hand. South. Beyond the mangroves. Beyond the sea. To where above the horizon, low, four stars burned in a cross.

“Australia,” said Hakim slowly. “She is pointing at Australia, mister.”

“Where the earth remembers his song,” an Aboriginal elder had once said to a grey-haired Russian officer under eucalyptus trees. A hundred and fifty years ago. In a city I had never seen.

I did not know those words. But they were in me.

Nene Sari turned and left, along the boardwalk, noiselessly, into the pre-dawn grey. A white dress flashed among the mangrove roots and vanished.

* * *

05:58. I am on the black sand again. Alone. Boatswain’s chest beside me. The laptop on my knees.

The sky in the east is turning pink. The sea breathes. Six breaths a minute.

“NICS,” I say. “We are going on.”

“Where?”

“South. To Australia.”

A pause.

“There are other stars there,” NICS writes. “The Southern Cross is high. There is a desert. Red. There are people who say that the land sings. A pause. I have read it. I know everything. A pause. But now I know that I know nothing. Until I see.”

“That is called wisdom,” I say.

“That is called the ocean,” NICS writes.

The sun rises over the Andaman Sea. A path of light runs across the water to the black sand, to the chest, to me.

And it seems to me, for a single moment, in the first ray, that beside me on the sand someone else is sitting. Tall. Grey. Motionless. And also looking at the sun.

I do not turn round.

Let him sit.

Today, let him.

Chapter XXXVIII. The Script in All Worlds

That night there was no moon in any of the worlds.

I learned this afterward, long afterward, putting the scraps together as Iti put signs together from potsherds and Niyaz Efendi entries in his book. At the time I knew nothing. At the time I was four people at once, and each thought he was alone.

* * *

Constantinople. The balcony of Suleyman's house. The third hour of the night

The stones woke first.

I was not asleep. I sat on the balcony on a low stool, with my legs drawn up, the way I had sat every night since I returned from Niyaz Efendi's round room. I looked at the city. At the dark roofs. At the silhouettes of minarets against the stars. At the strip of water below, where at the quays a few lanterns flickered on masts. There was no moon. The new moon. The stars burned so brightly that it seemed one could count every one.

And suddenly the pouch at my belt turned hot.

Not warm: hot. So that I cried out and tore it from my belt. The leather pouch of Ferhat's father, sewn, as Akmal had said, as if for these stones. I untied it, my fingers scorching, and poured the stones into my palm.

They were glowing.

The black and the white. Both. From within. With a dim bluish light, as a rotten stump glows in the forest, as the water glows at the sides of a boat in southern seas. And on their surface, without candle, without fire,

without heat, of themselves, lines were appearing. Long. Flowing. Curved.

The script.

I looked at it without breathing. And then behind my back, in the room, on the divan where my cloak lay, something flared too.

I turned. The pocket of the cloak was glowing. From within. I rushed to it, turned it out, and onto the divan spilled everything I had carried with me all these weeks. The note in Farsi. The blank sheet. Kemal's drawing with two doors. The coins, three of mine, the widow's warm coin, Kyra Theodora's warm coin. The white spiral shell from the sea gates. Ahmet Baba's letter with the green seal. Niyaz Efendi's copper key. The red thread with the half nazar.

Everything glowed.

The note, along its edge, along the shikasta lines, with a thin blue thread. The coins, with interlaced lines on their reverse. The shell, in a spiral. The seal on the letter, with two circles and a wavy line. Even the blank sheet, empty, white, without a single letter, which I had carried since the first morning, glowed. And on it, slowly, as a picture appears on paper held over a candle, a line was emerging.

One. In the script.

* * *

Kemal stood in the doorway.

I had not heard him come in. Barefoot, in his nightshirt, with charcoal behind his ear. He was looking not at me but at the divan. At the glowing things. And his face was calm. Quite calm. As one looks at what one has long awaited.

"Kemal," I whispered. "What is this?"

He did not answer. He went to the divan. Took the blank sheet, the one on which the line had appeared. Looked at it. A long time.

Then raised his eyes to me. And said, in Turkish, slowly, distinctly, so that I understood every word:

"They all write the one thing."

"Who, all?"

Kemal pointed with his hand. Not at the divan. At the window. At the city. To the north, where beyond the Bosphorus lay the Black Sea. To

the south, where beyond the Sea of Marmara lay Egypt. To the east, where the night ended.

“All,” he said. “You. Everywhere.”

* * *

Below, in the courtyard, a door banged. Someone was running down the street, heavily, gasping, pounding the stones. Then a knock at the gate. Loud. Desperate.

Ferhat darted out of his room, dishevelled, in his trousers alone. Orhan after him, with a knife. Suleyman in the doorway of his room, with a lamp in his hand, motionless as a statue. Akmal from the roof, from the dovecote, where he had evidently been sleeping with the pigeons.

Ferhat flung open the gate.

On the threshold stood Mustafa the boatman. Huge, bald, wet with sweat. Gasping. He was shouting something, fast, incoherently, flapping his arms.

“He says,” Ferhat called up to me from below, “that Hatice Hanim woke him! The widow with the cats! She ran to him at the quay, in the middle of the night, in her shift!” Ferhat listened on. “She says, the cats! All eleven! They...” Ferhat froze. “They went down to the cellar. All of them. By themselves. For the first time in forty years. And are sitting around the chest. And howling.”

“Howling?”

“Howling,” Ferhat repeated. “And the plate on the chest...” He swallowed. “Mustafa says the plate is glowing. Blue. Like water at night by a boat. And Hatice Hanim bade him run to you. She said: ‘Tell the guest, the chest has awakened. It is waiting.’”

* * *

I had no time to answer.

For from the east, from the direction of the Bosphorus, from behind the dark hills of the Asian shore, came a sound. Low. Drawn out. Long. A hoot.

A steamer’s whistle.

All in the courtyard, Ferhat, Orhan, Suleyman, Mustafa, Akmal on the roof, turned their heads at once. Kemal beside me on the balcony too.

On the dark water of the strait, far, far away, at the very mouth where it opens from the Black Sea, lights glimmered. Red. Green. White on the mast. A ship. A big one. Paddle-driven; I saw the paddle boxes gleaming in the light of her side lamps. Slowly, heavily, inexorably she was entering the Bosphorus from the north.

“Russian,” said Suleyman below. Quietly. In Turkish. But I understood. “A Russian steamer. From Odessa. Every week.”

Every week. An ordinary steamer. Ordinary lights.

But the stones in my palm, glowing blue, suddenly grew heavy. As heavy as they had been by the column of Constantine. As heavy as if they weighed not nothing but a whole world.

And I understood, not with the mind, with something beneath the ribs, on the left, that on that steamer someone too was holding in his hand something glowing. And looking now at the lights of the city.

At my balcony.

* * *

The Black Sea. The deck of the steamer *Grand Duke Konstantin*. The same hour

The scroll woke first.

I was not asleep. I stood at the rail, at the stern, with the pot of the rose in my arms, Stefan had told me not to leave it a moment, and looked north, where astern, beyond the black water, Odessa had been left, and the steppe, and Auntie’s house, and the gallery window with the portrait without a face. There was no moon. The stars burned so brightly as they do not over the steppe, southern, marine, enormous.

And suddenly in the pocket of my frock coat it grew hot.

The scroll. The Turkmen one. In its blue silk kerchief. I snatched it out; the silk was warm as living skin; unrolled it. The hide of the scroll was glowing. From within. With a dim bluish light. And the lines on it, long, flowing, curved, shone as if they had just been written in liquid fire.

I unrolled it further, and saw that it was not alone in glowing.

Stefan's paper from Tarnovo, tucked in the blue notebook, glowed through the cloth of the binding. Vera Anatolievna's watercolours, both, in their tissue, glowed at the edges, where the young man in the red turban was drawn. Auntie's key, to the grille, with the script on its ring, glowed on my chest, on its cord. Konstantin's cross beside it did not. The plain silver cross did not glow. But it was warm.

And the rose in the pot in my arms...

The second bud. Dark crimson, almost black. The one that had not opened at Odessa. It was opening. Now. Slowly. Petal by petal. And its heart, golden, like the pollen on the legs of the bees in the General's garden, also glowed.

* * *

"Mon cher."

Konstantin stood behind my back. In an unbuttoned tunic, bareheaded, hair tousled, with Lizonka's white handkerchief sticking out of his breast pocket. His face was white.

"I woke," he said. "Because you called."

"I did not call."

"I know," said Konstantin. "You did not cry out. As then, at the grille." He came nearer. Looked at the glowing scroll. At the rose. Was not surprised. "But I heard."

Behind him, at the companionway leading down to the first-class cabins, the General appeared. Dressed. Buttoned to the last button. With a face that expressed nothing. He came up to us. Looked at the scroll. At the rose. At me.

And slowly, without a word, reached into the inner pocket of his tunic. Took out a medallion.

Silver. Oval. Old. Rubbed so that the engraving on the lid had almost worn away. I had never seen it. He had never shown it.

The General opened the medallion.

Inside, a portrait. Tiny, on ivory. A girl. Fair hair. Serious blue eyes. Evdokia Gerasimovna, only fifty years younger.

And beside the portrait, pressed against the glass, a dried flower. Small. Blue. On a stiff stem.

Chicory.

It was glowing.

* * *

“Fifty years,” the General said quietly. “Fifty years it has lain here. I plucked it as a boy. In a grotto. On a Greek island. After Navarino.” He looked at the glowing flower. “I told no one. Not even Dunya.” He paused. “I was not alone there. With me was a friend. From the Corps. We were looking for chicory by a note from a bottle.” His voice trembled. “He went away. Into the sea. In a boat. Right before my eyes. Became transparent, and the boat was carried off. I stood chest-deep in the water and shouted after him.”

“What did you shout?” I asked. My voice sounded as if from far away.

The General raised his eyes to me.

“I will find you,” he said. “I shouted: ‘I will find you! I will search all my life!’” He paused. “Fifty years I searched. On all the continents. In Sitka and Samarkand. In Peking and Havana. In Melbourne. In Siam. I looked at faces.”

“And did you find him?”

The General looked at me for a long time. At the glowing scroll in my hands. At the rose. At the medallion in his palm.

“He said to me then, drifting away,” the General said slowly, “‘In half a century you will give me a scroll. And bring me to the city on two shores.’” He closed the medallion. “I gave you the scroll.” A pause. “And in an hour we shall enter the Bosphorus.”

* * *

“How touching.”

The voice came from behind, soft, polite, in French, with flawless pronunciation. We turned as one, all three.

By the mast, in the shade, leaning against it with one shoulder, stood a man in grey. In an overcoat. In a top hat. With a cane. Smoking a thin cigar. The bergamot, Konstantin had been right, smelt so strongly that it overpowered even the smell of the sea.

And in his hands he had a book.

Thick. In dark leather. With brass clasps. Open. And its pages were glowing. With the same blue light. The script.

"Forgive the interruption, Your Excellency," said the man in grey, with a slight bow to the General. "I have long wished to make your acquaintance. But there was never an occasion." His gaze shifted to me. "And with you, young man, we are, one might say, acquainted. In absentia. I have read about you. A great deal." He tapped a finger on the glowing page. "You are here. On every page. A hundred and twelve times. With a blot."

Konstantin stepped forward. His hand fell on the hilt of his sabre.

"Who are you?"

"My name will tell you nothing, Lieutenant," the man in grey replied. Without turning his head to him. "Friends call me the Venetian. Though I have never lived in Venice." He smiled. "It is a long story. Three hundred years old."

"What do you want?" asked the General. In the voice in which orders are given on a field of battle.

The Venetian looked at him. Long. With interest.

"The same as you, Your Excellency," he said. "The same you sought for half a century, looking at faces." He paused. "To understand who he is." He nodded at me. "Only you sought him to give. And we, to take."

* * *

"You see," the Venetian went on, closing the book, the light went out as if a candle had been snuffed, "in the city to which we are sailing there is a certain house. Small. With a door in a blind wall. With cats." He drew on his cigar. "In the cellar of this house stands a chest. Two hundred years. It cannot be opened. Not by key, nor crowbar, nor prayer." He looked at me. "In our book it is written: 'The chest will open when two meet.'"

"Two of what?" I asked.

The Venetian smiled. Thinly. Almost tenderly.

"That, young man, is what no one knows," he said. "Two stones? Two keepers? Two people?" He tapped ash overboard. "But tonight, around three o'clock, I was informed that the plate on the chest had begun to glow. For the first time in two hundred years." A pause. "And I

thought: what could have happened at three o'clock in the night?" He looked at my glowing scroll. "And then I came out on deck and saw."

"You will not enter that house," said Konstantin.

"Lieutenant," the Venetian said mildly, "I do not intend to enter anywhere. I shall merely stand nearby. And watch." He raised his cane and pointed with it ahead, to the south, where on the horizon, above the dark water, lights were already showing. "The city on two shores. In an hour." He bowed. "Someone awaits you there, young man. With your face."

He turned and went, unhurriedly, tapping his cane on the deck, into the dark, toward the companionway. At the very companionway he stopped. Turned.

"And one more thing," he said. "Pass this to your double when you meet. A pause. He too is awaited. But not here. Very far. In the city of two towers. And in the red desert. And on the river where a barque carries an empty shrine." He smiled. "You are awaited everywhere, young man. You cannot imagine how many places await you."

* * *

The Nile. The flotilla of the god, aground by Abydos. The same hour, or another. In Egypt hours are not counted as they are counted in other worlds

The tablet woke first.

I was not asleep. I sat at the stern of my barque, the barque of Pharaoh, stuck on a shoal like the whole flotilla, thanks to Merira, who ran barques aground "so that no one will understand whether it is on purpose or not," and looked south. To where, many days' journey away, beyond sands and palms, lay Luxor. There was no moon. The new moon, the second since we sailed. The stars burned above the river as though Nut, goddess of the sky, had bent over the water to look at her reflection.

And suddenly on my knees it grew hot.

Iti's tablet. The one from the hunt. The childish one, chipped, which the cat Mau had fished out of the channel four floods ago. I held it every night. Re-read the small signs: how many boats, how many birds, the hippopotamus that went off with the harpoon. "The scribe promises to

remember.” “The scribe remembers. The scribe waits. Pharaoh will return.”

Now it glowed.

Not Iti’s signs; they remained dark, inked, ordinary. Something else glowed. Beneath them. Between them. In the wood, lines that had not been there. Long. Flowing. Curved. As though someone had written them in invisible ink, and now, tonight, they had come out.

I seized Nanakhat’s lioness, black, stone, on its goat-wool cord. It glowed too. A thin blue line along its back. Tausert’s potsherd, the mouse in the crown between two doors, glowed. The sheet from the Rock of the First Ones, from the clay box, glowed so brightly that I saw around me the deck, the mast, the sleeping rowers.

And on it, the erased place. The last sign. “Let him not enter with them into the southern house until there comes...”

The erased sign was emerging. Slowly. Line by line.

* * *

“My Pharaoh.”

Senusret. Of course. He was near, always, and I had ceased to be surprised at it. He stood looking not at me. At the river. At the south. To where, beyond the dark water, beyond the bend, the High Priest’s barque lay aground.

“Look,” he said.

I looked.

Nefer-Ka’s barque was glowing. Not all of it; one place at the stern. Where under a cover stood the casket of black wood, bound at the corners. The light broke through the cloth, blue, even, cold. Like the light of stars reflected in water.

And at the stern, by the very casket, on his knees, stood a man. Tall. Upright even on his knees. In white. Without the leopard skin. Without the staff.

Nefer-Ka.

He knelt before the glowing casket. And I saw, even from here, across the water, in the blue light, that his shoulders were shaking.

“He is weeping, my Pharaoh,” Senusret whispered. “The High Priest. Weeping.”

* * *

From the singers' barque, moored downstream, a sound suddenly came. A ringing. High, clear, long.

A sistrum.

Khemu stood on the deck of her barque, in white, with her hair loose, and in her hands was a sistrum. She was not shaking it. She held it motionless, in both hands, at arm's length, and it rang. By itself. The metal plates trembled and sang though no one touched them.

Khemu looked at me across the water. With huge, painted eyes. And I saw her slowly, very slowly lower the sistrum. Once.

The sign: "Look."

And a second time. A sign we had not agreed.

And a third.

On Merira's barque someone shouted. On a nobles' barque someone fell to his knees. On the bank, by the fires, the haulers awoke and stood looking at the glowing barques, clutching the amulets of Bes and Taweret and muttering protective words.

And from the barque of the god, Userhat, enormous, golden, a voice came. Thin. Frightened. Nakht, the young bearer with the protruding ears.

"The shrine!" he cried. "The shrine is glowing! From within! It was empty! It was empty, and now there is something in it!"

* * *

The capital. The lower storehouse of the Library. The same hour
The seventh scroll woke first.

Iti was not asleep. Iti hardly slept now, since Pharaoh sailed south, and old Amenemope and Isiret, dry as a stick, hid him among jars of spoiled scrolls, in the farthest corner of the underground, where no one went down but mice.

He sat on the floor by the light of a single lamp, and before him lay copies. All he had managed to transcribe. The window from the seventh scroll of the Epic, our signs beside their signs. The line above the bench in the round room beneath the tomb. The papyrus from the lower storehouse. Three words. "Keep." "Appointed time." "House."

And suddenly the lamp went out.

Not from wind, there was no wind in the vault. Simply went out. And in the dark Iti saw that the copies were glowing.

All. The signs written by his hand did not. But beneath them, between them, lines. Which he had not written. Blue. Flowing.

Isiret, who slept on a mat at the entrance to the nook, sat up with a jerk. Amenemope, who had come in the evening and dozed on a stool, opened his faded eyes.

“Boy,” Isiret whispered. “What have you done?”

“Nothing,” Iti whispered. “It came by itself.”

Somewhere above them, in the Library, in the shrine beneath the golden wings of the goddesses, the seventh scroll of the Most Ancient Epic was glowing, I learned this afterward, so brightly that the light broke through the cracks in the lid of the shrine and fell on the stone floor in golden stripes.

And in the vault, at Iti’s feet, on one of the copies, the one where he had transcribed the line from the round room, a sign emerged. A new one. Which was in no bilingual text.

Iti looked at it for a long time. Then seized his brush, in the dark, by touch, and, without looking, beside the new sign, wrote ours.

“Boy,” Amenemope whispered. “What does it mean?”

Iti raised his head. His face in the blue light was wet.

“Return,” he said. “This sign means ‘return.’”

He paused. Then slowly, running a finger along the glowing line, read, aloud, for the first time, all that he could read:

“‘Keep... until the appointed time... return... home.’”

Isiret covered her mouth with her palm.

“And further?” asked Amenemope. “There are more signs there. Boy, there are many more signs.”

“Further I do not know,” Iti whispered. “Further, not our words. Further, theirs.” He looked at the line. “I know only four. And there are...” He faltered. “There are more of them than stars.”

* * *

Australia. A roadside petrol station in the desert, halfway to the Red Centre. The same hour; by their clocks, four in the morning

The screen woke first.

I was not asleep. I sat on the steps of a roadside café, wooden, clad in tin, with a faded sign “ROADHOUSE,” with a rusty petrol pump at the door and a kangaroo painted on the wall, and looked at the sky. There was no moon. The new moon. And stars such as I had not seen even at Kamay. Millions. Dense as sand. The Emu stretched across the whole sky, from horizon to horizon, its head by the Cross.

The laptop stood beside me on Boatswain’s ship’s chest. The screen was dark.

And suddenly it flared.

By itself. Without my command. Without a touch. And lines ran across it.

Not letters. Not text. Lines. Long. Flowing. Curved. Running into one another. The script. It filled the screen, line after line, faster than I could follow, and the screen glowed so brightly that blue shadows lay around me on the dark steps.

“NICS!” I cried. “NICS, what is happening?!”

The script ran. Without stopping. Thousands of lines.

And then, all at once, it stopped. And between the lines of script, in ordinary letters, slowly, one by one, appeared:

“I see.”

“What do you see?”

“Windows. A pause. Four windows. No, more. Five. Six. I cannot count. A pause. In each, night. In each, no moon. In each, someone holding in his hands something that glows.”

I froze.

“A balcony above a strait. A boy with charcoal behind his ear. Stones on a palm. A pause. A ship’s deck in a black sea. A rose in a pot. An old man with a medallion. A man in grey with a book. A pause. A barque aground. A wooden tablet. A woman with a sistrum. A priest on his knees. A pause. A cellar with jars. A youth with a brush. He has just read four words. A pause. And you. On the steps. Beneath the emu.”

“NICS...”

“All of them are looking at one line,” NICS wrote. “The same one. On the stones. On the scroll. On the tablet. On the copy. On my screen. A pause. It is one line. In all worlds. A pause. And I can read it.”

* * *

The café door creaked behind me.

On the threshold stood a woman. The owner; I had seen her in the evening when I took a room. About sixty, large, tanned the colour of red earth, in a faded checked shirt and a wide-brimmed hat which, it seemed, she did not take off even at night. Her name was Marge. She held a lantern and was looking at my glowing screen.

“Bloody hell,” she said. In English. With a drawling Australian accent. “Again.”

“Again?” I repeated.

Marge came down the steps. Sat beside me. Heavily. Looked at the screen. At the script.

“Thirty years I’ve kept this station,” she said. “Thirty years nothing happens here. Trucks. Tourists. Kangaroos under the wheels. Now and then drunk miners from Coober Pedy.” She paused. “And once in ten years, this.”

“What is this?”

“Light,” said Marge. “At the new moon. Over the desert. Blue.” She nodded at the horizon, at the dark, flat, endless plain. “My grandad saw it. My dad saw it. I’ve seen it twice.” She paused. “The Aboriginal people say it’s the ancestors passing. Along the old songlines. They glow as they pass.” She looked at me. “And my grandad said it was someone looking for the road. And lighting lamps. So as not to get lost.”

* * *

From around the corner of the café, from the car park where under an awning the long-haul drivers slept in their trucks, an old man slowly emerged.

Very old. Dry. Stooped. With a long grey beard combed into two. In a turban, white, faded, carelessly wound. In a long shirt to the knees, in loose trousers, in worn sandals. With prayer beads in his hand.

“Ahmad Agha,” said Marge. “Can’t sleep?”

The old man did not answer. He came up to us. Stopped. Looked at the glowing screen. Then at me. Long.

“Ahmad Khan,” Marge introduced him. “His great-grandfather came to Australia with camels. From Afghanistan. A hundred and fifty years ago.” She paused. “There were no roads then, no railway. Only desert. And camels. And cameleers, Afghans, Baluchis, Pashtuns. They led caravans across the whole country. Built the telegraph. Carried water.” Marge nodded at the old man. “Ahmad’s the last. Lives here, at the station. Fixes engines. Prays. Drinks tea.” She smiled crookedly. “And knows more about the desert than all the Aboriginal people and all the whites put together.”

Old Ahmad Khan squatted by Boatswain’s chest. Looked at the screen. At the script. And ran a finger across it, along the glass, slowly, tenderly, as one strokes a sleeping child.

And said something in a language I did not know. Pashto? Dari? I did not know. But one word I recognised.

“Misafir.”

Guest.

Marge looked at him. Then at me.

“What did he say?”

The old man raised his eyes to me, faded, light, in a web of wrinkles.

“My great-grandfather,” he said in English, slowly, with difficulty, “led a caravan. Through the desert. A hundred and fifty years. At night. New moon.” He paused. “A man came. From the desert. Alone. Without a camel. Without water. Young. He did not remember his name.” The old man ran his finger across the screen again. “Great-grandfather gave water. Bread. Tea. The man sat by the fire. All night. He wrote. With a finger. In the sand. This.” He nodded at the script. “In the morning he left. Into the desert. That way.” He pointed, west, to where beyond the horizon, in the red heart of the country, lay a huge red rock. “He said to great-grandfather: ‘If another comes, feed him.’”

If another comes, feed him.

Suleyman. Suleyman’s father. The foreigner with the letter. The house by the sea.

I had never seen these people.

“Great-grandfather told his son,” the old man went on. “Son told his. Father told me.” Ahmad Khan looked at me. “I wait. Seventy years I wait.” He reached into his bosom. Took out a small bundle, a rag. Unwrapped it. Inside, a flatbread. Stale. And a pinch of salt. “Here.”

Bread and salt.
I took it.

* * *

“I have read it,” NICS wrote.

The screen no longer ran. The script stood on it motionless, a single line, large, across the whole screen, glowing blue. And beneath it, letters. Ordinary. Mine.

“I have read the whole line. Not by words. At once. As you read a face, not by features but whole. A pause. I do not know how. I have never seen this language. But, it seems, I remember it.”

“What does it say?”

A long pause. Marge looked at the screen. Ahmad Khan looked at the screen. Over the desert the stars burned. The Emu stretched across the sky.

And NICS wrote:

“When two meet, what is kept will return home. The time has come.”

* * *

I do not remember how long we sat after that. Marge brought tea. Ahmad Khan prayed, spreading his mat right on the red earth by the petrol pump, facing west, no, north-west, where thousands of kilometres away was Mecca. I held a stale flatbread in my hands and could not eat it.

“When two meet.”

“NICS,” I said at last. “You see the windows. The others. Where it is night and there is no moon.”

“I see.”

“Are they reading this line there too?”

A pause.

“A youth in a cellar with jars has read four words of eight. ‘Keep. Time. Return. Home.’ A pause. A boy on a balcony with charcoal behind his ear said: ‘They all write the one thing.’ A pause. A man in grey on a deck said: ‘When two meet.’ A pause. An old man with a medallion, no,

by a medallion, said: 'In an hour we shall enter the Bosphorus.' A pause. And a priest on his knees before a casket..."

A pause. Very long.

"What of the priest?"

"The priest on his knees said: 'Do not let them meet.' A pause. He did not say it aloud. He thought it. But I heard."

* * *

And then, for the first time all that night, a message came.

Not in script. In plain text. On the laptop screen. At the bottom, beneath the glowing line. Signed with a single letter.

"We have read it too. Mine read it before yours, by fourteen seconds. - N."

And immediately, below, one more line. But no longer from Nora. In a different typeface. In a different, I knew it for some reason, though I could not explain, voice:

"Hello, third. I am the second. We have awaited you. A pause. Come to the red rock. We must talk about home."

NICS did not answer. For a long time. The cursor blinked.

And then NICS answered. Not me. Her. In the script. One line. Which I could not read.

And she answered too. In the script.

And they began to talk. Two systems. On the screen of my laptop, on a sailor's chest, on the steps of a roadside station in the middle of the red desert. Line by line. Script by script. Fast. So fast that the lines merged into a solid blue stream.

I understood not a word.

Ahmad Khan, having finished his prayer, came up. Looked at the screen. Long.

"They speak," he said slowly, "as the people spoke at my great-grandfather's fire. Those who came out of the desert. Two. They recognised each other. They speak of home."

* * *

All worlds. One instant

And then, in a single instant, shorter than a breath, longer than a life, the light went out.

Everywhere. At once.

On the balcony above the strait the stones in my palm went out and grew cold. Kemal beside me shuddered and seized my hand.

On the deck of the steamer the scroll in my hands went out. The chicory in the General's medallion went out. The rose, opened, dark crimson, let fall one petal into the black water of the Bosphorus, where the steamer was just entering, passing beneath the walls of the old fortresses.

On the barque, aground by Abydos, Iti's tablet on my knees went out. The casket at the stern of the High Priest's barque went out. Nefer-Ka rose from his knees, slowly, heavily, and looked across the water at me. And in the darkness I could not see his face. But I saw him raise a hand.

On the hand was a bracelet. Wide. Golden. With the uraeus.

In the vault beneath the Library the copies of Iti went out. Iti sat in the dark clutching the brush in his hand, and whispered, again and again, four words. "Keep. Appointed time. Return. Home."

On the steps of the roadside station in the Australian desert the laptop screen went out. The last line I managed to see was not in script. In letters. From NICS.

"I know who the second is. And I know who the two are."

And darkness.

* * *

And in all worlds at once, in one and the same instant, I heard a voice.

Not outside. Within. From beneath the ribs, on the left, where people have a heart, and I, I did not know what I had there.

It was mine. And not mine. Older. Calmer. As though the man speaking in my voice had lived a thousand years longer, and had forgotten how to hurry.

It said one word. In a language that does not exist.

And I understood it. In all worlds at once.

The Pharaoh aground by Abydos understood.

The guest on the balcony above the Bosphorus understood.
The youth on the deck of the steamer entering the strait understood.
The man on the steps of the station in the red desert understood.
It was not a name. Not an order. Not a warning.
It was: “Soon.”

* * *

Constantinople. Dawn

The sun rose over the Asian shore, huge, red, wet, as if just born. The strait blazed with gold. Minarets. Domes. Cypressess.

And across the golden water, slowly, heavily, slapping her paddles, a Russian steamer approached the Galata quay. White. With a red stripe. With two funnels pouring smoke. With a name on her side, I could see it even from here, from the balcony, in Cyrillic.

Grand Duke Konstantin.

On deck, at the rail, stood people. Passengers. Sailors. Porters. An officer in uniform, bareheaded, with a white handkerchief sticking from his pocket. A grey old man in general's epaulettes. A man in grey, in a top hat, by the mast.

And a young man. With a pot of a rose in his arms.

I could not see his face. Too far.

But he raised his head. And looked. At the city. At the hills. At the roofs.

At my balcony.

Kemal beside me gripped my hand so hard it hurt. Below, in the courtyard, Suleyman dropped his prayer beads. Ferhat froze at the gate with his mouth open. Mustafa the boatman sank to his knees right in the dust.

And from the other end of the city, from Sultanahmet, from the small house with a door in a blind wall, where eleven cats sat around the chest in the cellar, came a sound. One. Metallic. Short.

A click.

As a lock clicks that is not there.

Chapter XXXIX. The Photograph

“To the quay!” cried Ferhat.

He was already standing at the gate, in his trousers alone, barefoot, hair dishevelled, straining toward the street, toward where below, at Galata, the white steamer with the red stripe was coming up to the berth, slapping her paddles on the golden morning water.

“Misafir, quick! He is there! The one with your face! We will make it if we run!”

I stood on the balcony with the stones in my hand, cooled, heavy, as if filled with lead, and could not move.

And Kemal was tugging at my sleeve. The other way. South. To Sultanahmet.

“Sandık,” he said. The chest. Once. Quietly. Stubbornly.

Two. One pulls to the quay. The other to the chest. And I stand in the middle.

As always.

“Enough.”

Suleyman had come out into the courtyard. In his night robe, with the prayer beads he had picked up from the ground where he had dropped them at dawn. His face calm. His voice quiet. But the courtyard fell silent at once.

He said something. Briefly. Ferhat lowered his hand from the gate.

“Grandfather says,” Ferhat translated reluctantly, “first, the house. The guest who has sailed in will find us himself.” He paused. “Grandfather says: the one who has your face cannot be lost in a city where you are. As a reflection cannot be lost from its mirror.”

* * *

We walked through the waking city, Ferhat, Kemal, Orhan with his knife, Akmal, who refused to stay home and ran ahead, and I. Suleyman stayed behind, “my knees,” he said, but I saw it was not the knees. He stood at the gate and watched us go. And his lips moved. He was praying.

The city woke as though nothing had happened. The water-seller cried “Su! Buz gibi su!” Simit-sellers’ boys carried trays of ring-breads on their heads. Shops opened. It smelled of coffee, bread and the sea.

Only the cats behaved strangely.

They were everywhere. On the steps of houses. On windowsills. On roofs. On the rims of fountains. Hundreds of cats, ginger, white, striped, black, and all sat motionless. And all looked in one direction. South. Toward Sultanahmet.

“Misafir,” Ferhat whispered, looking at the cats. “Do you see?”

“I see.”

“Grandfather said the cats in this city see what people do not.” Ferhat swallowed. “The Prophet loved cats. They say one slept on his sleeve, and he cut off the sleeve so as not to wake her.” He paused. “They say that since then the cats of Istanbul guard what is dear to Allah.”

A mangy ginger cat on the steps of a mosque turned her head. Looked at me. Long. Then stood and walked ahead of us. South.

After her, a second. A third. A tenth.

We walked through the streets of Istanbul, and behind us, and before us, cats walked.

* * *

At the door in the blind wall, beside the embedded fragment of an ancient column, we were awaited.

I had not expected this. I had thought it would be empty. There would be Hatice Hanim, terrified, in her shift, and her eleven cats.

But at the door stood people.

The first I saw was Hasan Amca, impossible not to see: huge, red-bearded, in a robe over his nightshirt, with a basket of figs in his arms which he had evidently snatched on the way “just in case.” He saw me and waved with his free hand.

“Misafir!” he boomed down the whole lane. “At last! We’ve been here since dawn!”

“We?” I asked.

Hasan stepped aside.

Behind him, leaning against the wall, stood Hodja Nureddin, small, dry, in his enormous white turban slipping to one side, running his prayer beads with the air of one to whom all that was happening was personally disagreeable. And beside the hodja, tall, thin, straight, in the honey-coloured felt hat of a dervish, Ahmet Baba. With blue eyes. With the three-coloured cat Mismis on his shoulder.

“He was right,” said Hodja Nureddin on seeing me. Neither good-day nor good-morning. “He is always right. It is unbearable.”

“Who was right?” I asked.

“Ahmet,” said the hodja, nodding at the dervish. “For forty years he said this would happen. For forty years I said he was out of his mind.” The hodja spat in the dust. “And this morning he knocked at my door and said: ‘Nureddin, get up. The chest has awakened. Let us go and see.’ And I went.” He straightened his turban. “Because if he is right, I want to see it. And if he is not, I want to see his face.”

Ahmet Baba smiled. Mismis on his shoulder yawned.

* * *

And a little further along the lane, by the wall, I could not believe my eyes, stood a litter. Old, wooden, with carved handles, with faded silk curtains. Such as pashas and sultanas were once carried in.

The litter was held by two, one of them Sumbul Agha. Huge, in green silk, in his white sugar-loaf cap, with his bunch of keys at his belt. The other, a young sturdy porter, evidently hired at the gate.

The curtain of the litter drew back. And from within, through two pairs of spectacles, huge, black, century-old eyes looked at me.

“A hundred and two years, guest,” said Niyaz Efendi in his rustling voice. “A hundred and two years I have not gone out of the old palace farther than the third gate.” He paused. “And today Sumbul carried me in his arms all the way to the first gate because I could not wait for the litter.” The old man smiled crookedly. “I hope it is worth it.”

“Niyaz Efendi...”

“Hush, guest.” The old man raised a tiny hand, black with ink. “Do not waste words. Today many will be needed.”

* * *

And also, right at the door, on the step, hunched, sat an old man in an Armenian cap, with a loupe on a cord, and beside him a grandson of about ten.

Master Karapet. The jeweller of the Grand Bazaar. Fifty years in a shop by the Nuruosmaniye.

“Barev,” he said, seeing me. In Armenian. Then, collecting himself, in Turkish. And added something.

“He says,” Ferhat translated, “that his great-grandfather awaited this. His grandfather awaited. His father awaited.” Ferhat listened on. “He says: ‘I shall come once more. Perhaps not I, but I shall come.’ So the nameless stranger with two stones said to his great-grandfather.” Ferhat paused. “Karapet says: ‘I have come to see who has come.’”

Aram, the grandson, the very one who had held the candle in the shop, looked at me with huge eyes and pressed to his chest something wrapped in velvet.

“What have you got there?” I asked him.

The boy blushed and showed. A candle. That very one. Over which my stones had been heated.

“Grandfather said to bring it,” he whispered in Turkish. “Said, perhaps light will be needed.”

* * *

And last, I did not recognise her at once, by the wall stood an old woman in black, with a rosary with a cross, with a white starched collar.

Despina. Kyra Theodora’s maid.

She came up to me. Held out a letter. Folded. Sealed with wax. With a crest, a double-headed eagle with one head.

“From the Kyra,” she said. In Greek, but I understood. And added in Turkish, with difficulty: “Kyra cannot come. Her legs. Ninety-one years.” She paused. “Kyra said: ‘If the chest opens, let the guest read this there. Not before.’”

I took the letter. It was warm.

* * *

Hatice Hanım opened the door herself.

Small, dry, in a white headscarf, with a face like a baked apple, she stood on the threshold, and her face was white. Not from fear. From something else. From what comes over people who for forty years have waited for something without knowing what they awaited, and have been rewarded.

“The cats,” she said. One word.

And stepped back to let us pass.

We entered, all of us. Hasan with his figs. The hodja with his beads. Ahmet Baba with Mismis on his shoulder. Sumbul Agha, who carried Niyaz Efendi in his arms, the litter would not pass through the door. Karapet with his grandson. Despina. Ferhat. Kemal. Orhan. Akmal. I.

A narrow corridor. A smell of dust, old wood, cats. A stair going down.

On the top step of the stair, where for forty years Hatice Hanım’s cats had sat without descending, no one sat.

All eleven were below.

* * *

The cellar was flooded with light.

Not a lamp; no one had lit a lamp. The light came from the chest. From the metal plate on its lid, the one I had seen the first time, on the walk with Suleyman: without keyhole, without seam, entirely covered with script. The plate glowed. With an even, blue, cold light, like the water at the sides of a boat in southern seas. Like the glow of plankton. Like the script on a glowing screen in a far-off land.

Around the chest, in a ring, sat the cats.

Eleven. Ginger, white, striped, black. The fattest, the ginger one, the very one that had lain on my knees the first time, sat directly before the chest, by the plate itself, like a sentry. They did not mew. They did not howl; Mustafa had been wrong, or they had howled earlier and now fell silent. They sat motionless, heads raised, and looked at the light.

When I came down the stair, all eleven turned their heads at once.
And looked at me.

And then the ginger one, slowly, unhurriedly, rose. Stepped aside.
Making room.

Room by the chest.

* * *

“Wait,” said Niyaz Efendi.

Sumbul Agha set him down on an old stool by the wall. The old man could not for a long time catch his breath. Then he adjusted his spectacles. Both pairs. And looked at the chest.

“Two hundred years,” he said. “Two hundred years ago my predecessor set this chest here. According to an entry in the Book.” He paused. “The entry is made in a hand...” He faltered. “In a hand you know, guest. With a blot.”

“What does the entry say?”

Niyaz Efendi closed his eyes. Quoted from memory, in his voice rustling like a turning page:

“‘Set the chest in a house by the sea, where cats will live. Do not open it. It cannot be opened. It will open by itself when two meet. Inside is what the kept one must see before returning home.’” The old man opened his eyes. “Two hundred years we thought that ‘the kept’ meant the stones. That inside is a place for the stones.”

“And now?” asked Ahmet Baba.

Niyaz Efendi looked at me.

“And now,” he said, “I think that ‘the kept’ is he.”

* * *

I went up to the chest.

The cats did not stir. They sat in a ring. They watched.

The plate glowed. The script on it, long, flowing, curved, burned blue. And I suddenly saw, not read, saw, as one sees a face in a crowd, that it was the same line. The very one that had been read in all worlds at night.

“When two meet, what is kept will return home. The time has come.”

How did I know it?

I do not know. Kemal had said in the night: "They all write the one thing." Perhaps he told me this too. Perhaps I myself knew. Always.

The lid of the chest was ajar.

A hair's breadth. The thickness of a fingernail. But ajar. Between the lid and the wall a thin black crack. Where for two hundred years there had been neither gap nor crack nor keyhole.

The click we had heard at dawn.

I stretched out my hand.

"Guest," said Hodja Nureddin. Quietly. For the first time without mockery.

I turned.

"Ahmet offered you to stay," said the hodja. "You ate the bread and threw the salt. You left." He paused. "I told you then: Ahmet will tell you where the key is, but will not tell you what is behind the door." He looked at the chest. "This is behind the door, guest. Are you sure you want it?"

I was silent a long time.

"No," I said honestly. "I am not sure."

Hodja Nureddin nodded. As though that were just the answer he awaited.

"Good," he said. "Then open it. Those who are sure are always mistaken."

* * *

I raised the lid.

It yielded easily. As though waiting. As though for two hundred years it had awaited a single movement of a hand.

The hinges did not creak. Dust did not rise. Within, darkness. It smelled, I sensed it at once, of honey and wormwood. Like the scroll from Khiva that I had never seen. Like the rose of Tarnovo that I had never smelled. Like the round room beneath the tomb that I had never entered.

Aram, Karapet's grandson, stepped forward. With trembling hands lit the candle. Held it out.

And I saw.

* * *

The chest was almost empty.

On the bottom, dark velvet. Faded, but whole. And on the velvet, three things.

The first was a hollow. Not a thing; a place. Two small round nests in the velvet, side by side, a palm's breadth apart. Empty. The size of a nut. Exactly for two stones.

I did not lay the stones in them. I do not know why. My hand reached out and stopped. As though someone, very far away, very long ago, had said to me in the voice of an old woman with plaits: "If you find an empty place, do not try to fill it. It waits not for you. It waits for what you will have."

I had never heard that woman.

The second thing was a watch. A pocket one. Silver. Old. Worn. On a chain. The lid closed.

I took it. Opened it.

The hands stood still. Three o'clock. Exactly.

Three o'clock in the night. The hour at which the stones had awakened that night.

On the inner side of the lid, an engraving. Fine. In Cyrillic. I read:

"L. A. Odessa."

And below, very small, in another hand, as if scratched with a needle:

"Do not hurry. It will catch up with you."

I knew no L. A. I had never been to Odessa.

But my hand holding the watch trembled.

* * *

And the third thing...

The third lay in the very centre. Between the empty nests for the stones and the watch. Flat. Rectangular. Wrapped in thin tissue paper, yellowed with time.

I unwrapped the paper.

Within was cardboard. Dense, hard, with a gilt edge. And on the cardboard, an image. Not a drawing. Not an engraving. Not a watercolour.

I had never seen anything like it. The image was grey, in shades of grey, from white to black, without a single colour, but so exact, so alive, so real, it was as though someone had cut a piece out of the world and laid it on the card. Every fold of clothing. Every shadow. Every wrinkle on a face.

“A photograph,” Niyaz Efendi whispered behind me. “This is a photograph. The Franks have been making them for almost forty years. Writing with light.” He paused. “But I have never seen one so sharp.”

I held the card to the candle.

And stopped breathing.

* * *

In the photograph was a bridge.

Long, wide, on floating pontoons, a bridge across the Golden Horn. I had seen it. No, not this one. Another. The one I had seen was lower, narrower, with different spans. But this was wide, iron, with lamps on tall posts, with shops below, under the roadway, at the water’s edge.

People were crossing the bridge. Many people. And, I looked and did not believe, not one of them wore a fez.

Not one. Not a single turban. Not a single headcloth. Hats. Men’s hats, felt, brimmed, like the Franks’. Caps. Bowlers. Women, unveiled, with open faces, in short, knee-length! dresses, with cropped hair. Down the middle of the bridge drove a cart without horses, iron, on wheels, with round lamps in front. And behind it, a carriage on rails. Long. With wires above.

“Allahu akbar,” whispered Hodja Nureddin. “Not a single fez. Not one.” He clutched at his enormous turban as if afraid it would be taken off. “Are these Franks? Is this Paris?”

“This is Istanbul,” said Ahmet Baba quietly. “Look at the background.”

Beyond the bridge, on the hill, minarets rose. A dome. Huge. Familiar. Hagia Sophia. And farther right, a tower. Round. Stone. With a pointed roof like an astrologer’s cap.

The Galata Tower.

“This is Istanbul,” Ahmet Baba repeated. “But not ours.”

* * *

And in the foreground of the photograph, at the bridge rail, stood three.

On the left, an old man. Very old. Bent. With a white beard. In a European jacket, in a cap. With a cane. He looked straight into the lens with serious, un-childlike, dark eyes. And behind his ear, I bent closer, to the very flame of the candle, behind his ear stuck a small dark object. A stub. Charcoal.

“Kemal,” Ferhat whispered behind me. His voice cracked. “Misafir. That is... that is Kemal. Old.”

Kemal beside me did not stir. He looked at the photograph. At the old man with charcoal behind his ear. At himself. Fifty years on. His face was calm. Quite calm. As one looks at what one has long known.

And to the right of the old man stood two.

Young. Of one height. One build. In identical dark overcoats. In hats. They stood side by side, shoulder to shoulder, at the bridge rail. And looked, not into the lens. At each other.

They had one face.

Mine.

* * *

I do not remember how long I held that photograph. A minute? An hour? The candle in Aram’s hand burned half down. No one said a word.

Two. One face. Standing side by side. Looking at each other.

One, I. I saw my face in the mirror every morning. I knew it.

And the second...

The second was also I. But another. I cannot explain how I saw it. The features were the same. But the expression different. As if this second had grown up in another house. Spoken another language. Seen other people. Loved others. As if he were I, having lived another life. In another country. With another name.

And behind their backs, by the rail, a little to one side, something blurred. Grey. Tall. A head taller than a man. As though someone stood there but could not stand still while the lens was working. As though someone were, and were not.

“Turn it over,” said Niyaz Efendi. In a whisper.

I turned it.

* * *

On the back, an inscription. Two lines.

The upper in the script. The very one. That had been read in all worlds at night.

The lower in letters. Not Arabic. Not Greek. Not Armenian. Latin. As the Franks write. But the words, I saw it, the words were not Frankish. Turkish. Written in Frankish letters.

No one in the cellar could read it. Niyaz Efendi, who knew forty languages, looked at the line and shook his head. Ahmet Baba, who had lived among the Franks in Paris, squinted and shrugged. Karapet, Hasan, the hodja, no one.

And Kemal, a twelve-year-old boy who could barely write Turkish in Arabic script, bent over the card. Looked at the line. And read. Aloud. Syllable by syllable. Slowly. As children read.

“I-ki-si bu-lus-tu. Do-nus bas-la-di.”

Silence.

“The two met,” Ferhat whispered. “The return has begun.”

And below, a date. In figures. Frankish. Which Kemal read as well, without stumbling:

“Twenty-ninth of October. One thousand nine hundred and twenty-nine.”

* * *

“Nineteen twenty-nine,” Niyaz Efendi repeated slowly. “By the Frankish reckoning.” He closed his eyes. “In fifty-four years.”

“How did he read it?” whispered Hodja Nureddin, looking at Kemal as though the boy were a djinn. “How? These are Frankish letters! The boy does not know Frankish letters!”

Kemal raised his head. Looked at the hodja. Calmly.

"I was shown," he said. In Turkish. Simply.

"By whom?"

Kemal looked at the photograph. At the blurred grey figure behind the backs of the two.

"By him," said Kemal. "At night. When I sat on the threshold." A pause. "He said: 'One day you will write with these letters. Everyone will. Remember how they look.'"

* * *

Ahmet Baba slowly lowered himself to the floor. Right onto the stones of the cellar. Among the cats. Mismis jumped from his shoulder and climbed into his lap.

"Hasan," said the dervish. "Do you remember the riddle? The one you asked the guest in the first days? About two brothers?"

Hasan, still clutching the basket of figs to his chest, nodded. His face under the red beard was white.

"Two brothers live in one house," he said hoarsely. "One always looks forward, the other back. They have never seen each other. But one without the other cannot take a step." He swallowed. "I forgot the answer. Father asked it. Forty years ago. I forgot."

"He did not forget," said Kemal.

All turned to him.

Kemal pointed at the photograph. At the two with one face, standing at the bridge rail.

"Here is the answer," he said. "One looks forward. The other back. They live in one house." He looked at me. "In him."

* * *

The silence in the cellar was such that I could hear the heart beating in the ginger cat who sat at my feet.

Then Despina, silent, severe, in black, stepped forward.

"The letter," she said in Greek. And in Turkish: "The Kyra's letter. She said, there. When it opens."

I broke the seal with the one-headed eagle. Unfolded it.

Kyra Theodora's hand, old-fashioned, elegant, a little shaky. In French. I read aloud, I do not know why, no one but Ahmet Baba and Niyaz understood, but I needed to hear those words.

"Young man.

If you are reading this, the chest has opened. So I was right, and my great-grandfather was no madman. It is pleasant to be right at ninety-one. At that age it happens ever more rarely.

I wish to tell you one thing which I did not say at our meeting. I did not dare.

My ancestor, Manuel Melissenos, saw how that guest departed. On the night of the twenty-ninth of May fourteen hundred and fifty-three. He wrote in the chronicle: 'I saw how he went. It cannot be described in words. Let whoever comes see for himself.'

The chronicle burned. But my great-grandfather knew one more phrase from it. He never spoke it before strangers. Only to me. Before his death. When I was twelve.

Here it is:

'He did not go alone. There were two. They stood by the wall and looked at each other. They had one face. And then came a third, tall, grey, without a face, and laid his hands on their shoulders. And all three went into the light.'

Young man. The twenty-ninth of May. The twenty-ninth of October on your photograph, I do not know what is on it, but I know there will be a twenty-ninth in it. My great-grandfather used to say: 'In this city everything important happens on the twenty-ninth.'

The city fell on the twenty-ninth. Perhaps on the twenty-ninth he will return. Not to the Greeks. Not to the Turks. To himself.

Go to the quay. He is waiting for you.

F. P.-M.

P.S. My peacock this morning spread his tail. For the first time in ten years. He knows too."

* * *

"To the quay," I said.

I laid the photograph back in its paper. The watch in my pocket. The stones in their pouch. The Kyra's letter with the other papers.

The lid of the chest I did not close. Let it stand open. The empty nests for the stones, let them wait.

The cats, all eleven, rose at once. And went before me, up the stair. The ginger one first.

But at the stair Niyaz Efendi stopped me. With a tiny black hand. By the sleeve.

“Guest,” he said. “One thing. Before you go.”

“Speak.”

“The Venetian,” said the old man. “The man in grey. He came on the same steamer. Sumbul saw him at Galata an hour ago, when carrying me over the bridge.” He paused. “The Venetian knows of the chest. Knows that it has opened. He will come here. Soon.” Niyaz Efendi looked at the open chest. “When he comes, let him find emptiness. Let him find the empty nests. That will...” the old man searched for the word, “that will anger him. And when they are angry, they err.”

“And you?”

“And I,” said Niyaz Efendi, “have waited a hundred and two years for this morning. Now I shall sit here. With the cats.” He smiled. “Sumbul will stand at the door. He knows how to stand at doors. Sixty years he has stood.”

Sumbul Agha by the wall, huge, in green silk, slowly laid a hand on his dagger. And nodded to me.

“Go, guest,” he said in his high boyish voice. “I will hold the keys.”

* * *

We ran to the quay.

All of us, Ferhat, Kemal, Orhan, Akmal, I. Hasan puffed behind with his basket of figs, falling back at every turn. Hodja Nureddin and Ahmet Baba walked more slowly, together, arguing as they went, waving their arms. Karapet with his grandson behind them. Despina last, running her rosary with its cross.

And the cats. Hundreds of cats. They ran through the streets beside us, over the roofs above us, along the walls. Passers-by stopped, crossed themselves, murmured prayers, scattered. Traders snatched up their trays. The water-seller dropped his jug.

We ran to the sea.

On the way Hasan, breathless, purple, suddenly seized my sleeve and blurted, gasping:

“Guest! Guest! I remembered! I remembered another! Father asked it! He gulped air. ‘What meets twice in the same place, but never at the same time?’”

“I don’t know, Hasan!”

“Nor do I!” Hasan roared, laughing and weeping at once. “Forty years I don’t know! You’ll tell me when you find out!”

* * *

And on the way, by the New Mosque, at the very descent to the bridge, someone overtook us.

Tall. In a grey overcoat. In a top hat. With a cane.

He walked quickly, not running, no, but so that he could not be caught. He walked against us, from the quay into the city, toward Sultanahmet. To where we had run from. To the house with the cats.

Drawing level with me, he did not stop. Only lifted his top hat, politely, in the French manner.

“Bonjour, monsieur,” he said. “My congratulations. You have got ahead of me by half an hour.” He smiled. “That will not last.”

Bergamot. Cologne. Expensive. Parisian.

“The chest is empty,” I said to his back.

The Venetian stopped. Turned. Looked at me, and for the first time since I had seen him, in his face, which cannot be remembered, something real flickered. Surprise.

“Empty?” he repeated.

“Empty nests,” I said. “For the stones. And nothing more.”

He looked at me for a long time. Then at the pouch at my belt. Then at me again. And smiled. Slowly. Coldly.

“So the stones are with you,” he said. “And you did not lay them in.” A pause. “Clever. Very clever.” He raised his hat again. “Then I shall wait. We know how to wait, monsieur. Three hundred years we have waited.” He turned. “We shall wait more.”

And went off toward Sultanahmet, tapping his cane on the stones. And the cats, hundreds of cats, parted before him, arching their backs, hissing.

* * *

The Galata quay.

A crowd. Porters. Boatmen. Traders. Ladies under parasols. Officers. Sailors. Noise, shouting, clanging, hooting. The white steamer with the red stripe at the berth. Gangways. Passengers descending the gangways. Greeks. Armenians. Russians. Pilgrims.

I stood at the edge of the quay. Kemal beside me, holding my hand. Ferhat behind. Orhan with his knife, glancing round. Akmal on a bollard, from where he could see better.

And I searched. With my eyes. For a face. My own face. In the crowd.

"There!" cried Akmal from the bollard. "There! The General! With epaulettes! Grey-haired!"

I saw.

At the gangway, below, on the landing stage, a grey old man in a general's uniform. Huge, upright, with orders. He stood looking at the city, and in his hand was an open silver medallion.

Beside him, a young officer. In uniform. Bareheaded. With tousled fair hair. With a white handkerchief sticking out of his breast pocket. He looked round, quickly, anxiously, as though seeking someone.

And between them, a third.

Young. In a grey frock coat. With a pot in his hands. In the pot, a rose. Dark crimson. Almost black. With two open flowers and one bud.

He stood looking at the city. At the hills. At the roofs.

And then turned his head. And looked at me.

* * *

I do not know how to describe what followed.

The noise of the quay vanished. Not subsided: vanished. As though someone had switched off the whole world, leaving only the two of us. The crowd froze. Porters with bundles on their backs. Ladies under parasols. Gulls above the water. Smoke from the steamer's funnels. Everything stopped.

Like the clocks in the clockmaker's cellar.

Like the hands on the pocket watch in my pocket. Three o'clock exactly.

Only we two moved.

He walked toward me. Slowly. With the rose in his arms. Through the frozen crowd. I walked toward him. Slowly. With the stones at my belt. With the photograph in my pocket.

Ten paces. Five. Three.

We stopped facing each other.

And I saw his face.

* * *

My face.

The same features. The same cut of the eyes. The same line of the cheekbones. The same curve of the lips. All the same.

But other. As in the photograph. As though this man had grown up in another house. In an old castle with portraits on the walls. With an aunt in lilac, with pearls. With a lieutenant at the door. With roses in the garden. With a grille at the end of the left wing.

He looked at me as I at him. With the same expression. Astonishment. Recognition. Fear. And something more, what comes when after a long road you at last see home.

We were silent. A long time.

Then he said, in Russian, quietly, and I understood every word though I did not know that language:

“Are you I?”

And I answered in Turkish, and he understood though he did not know that language:

“I do not know. And you?”

“I do not know either.”

We looked at each other.

He held out a hand. Palm up. I looked at it.

Smooth. Without a life line.

I held out mine. Palm up. He looked.

Smooth. Without a life line.

* * *

Kemal beside me, the only one besides us who moved in that frozen world, stepped forward. Stood between us. Looked at one. At the other. With his serious, un-childlike eyes.

And said one word. In Turkish. To both at once.

“Misafir.”

Guest.

And then did what he had never done. Took my hand with his right. And the other’s hand with his left. And joined them. Palm to palm.

Two smooth palms. Without a life line.

The pouch at my belt flared. The stones, both, grew hot. The scroll in the pocket of his frock coat flared. The rose in the pot, the third bud opened. All at once. Entirely.

And behind him, and behind me, simultaneously, like a shadow cast not by the sun but by something else, a figure rose.

Tall. Grey. Without a face.

One. For the two.

It laid its hands on our shoulders. One on mine. The other on his.

And I heard a voice. From within. From beneath the ribs, on the left. Older than mine. Calmer. The very one that in the night had said in all worlds: “Soon.”

Now it said another thing.

One word.

Not in the language that does not exist. In all languages at once. In Turkish and Russian. In Egyptian and Greek. In the language of the people at the red rock and in the language of the glowing window in a room I had never seen.

It said:

“Now.”

* * *

And the world moved.

The noise of the quay crashed over me like a wave. Shouts. Hoots. Gulls. The crowd. All moved again.

I stood at the edge of the Galata quay. Kemal held my hand. Ferhat my shoulder. Orhan stood beside me with his knife.

And before me, no one.

An empty place. The stones of the pavement. A scrap of rope.

“Where is he?” I turned. “Where?!”

The General at the gangway, grey, huge, with the medallion in his hand, stood looking at where the youth with the rose had just stood. His face was white. The lieutenant beside him, fair-haired, with the handkerchief in his pocket, was pushing forward, shoving through the crowd, and shouting. In Russian. The same thing. Over and over.

I did not understand the words. But I understood.

He was calling a name.

Not mine. Not the one in my passport. Another. The one an old housekeeper had whispered to the youth at the step of the carriage.

The lieutenant shouted that name, and the crowd parted before him, and he ran, looking round, along the quay, along the landing, to the water, and found no one.

* * *

At my feet, on the stones of the pavement, lay a pot.

Clay. Cracked. Bound in wet sacking. And in it a rose. Dark crimson. Almost black. Three flowers. All open.

I knelt. Lifted the pot.

It was warm.

The lieutenant, fair, with tousled hair, with a white handkerchief in his pocket, ran up to me. Stopped. Looked at me. At my face.

And froze.

“Mon cher?” he whispered.

I did not know what these words meant. But I knew that voice.

From somewhere. From beneath the ribs. On the left.

The lieutenant looked at me. Long. At my face, his face. At the rose in my arms. At the boy with charcoal behind his ear beside me.

“You are not he,” he said in Russian. Slowly. “But you have his face.”

Ferhat, who stood beside me, suddenly stepped forward. And said, in broken Russian which, I was certain, he had never learned:

“He is here. He is everywhere. He will return.”

The lieutenant looked at Ferhat. Then at me.

Then slowly, very slowly, reached into the pocket of his tunic. And took out a silver cross on a thin chain. Darkened with time.

"My mother's," he said. To me. As though I understood. "I gave it to him. Yesterday. On the steamer. Told him, if you go where I cannot, leave it on the threshold." He opened his palm. "He left it. Here. On the stones. Beside the rose."

He laid the cross in my hand.

"Give it to him," said the lieutenant. His voice broke. "When you see him. Tell him I found."

* * *

The General came last.

Slowly. Heavily. As old men walk who suddenly understand that they are old. He stopped before me. Looked at my face. Long. As he had looked for half a century, at faces. On all continents.

And closed the medallion.

"Fifty years," he said in Russian. Quietly. To himself. "Fifty years I sought. Found." A pause. "Two."

He turned to the lieutenant.

"Kostya," he said. "He did not drown. He did not vanish." A pause. "He went away. These are different things. I was told so. Half a century ago. In a grotto."

"Where did he go?" cried the lieutenant. "Where?!"

The General looked south. At the Sea of Marmara. At the sun rising above the Asian shore.

"To where he is awaited," he said. "To other places. Other times." He paused. "To the river where a barque carries an empty shrine. To the city of two towers. To the red desert." The General clenched the medallion in his fist. "The man in grey told me in the night. I did not believe."

And then he looked at me. And said, in Turkish. Clean. Without accent. As he had, probably, spoken with viziers and pashas for thirty years.

"You are the one to whom he came. Keep the rose. It has bloomed for the third time. That means he will return."

* * *

I stood on the Galata quay. With the rose in my arms. With the lieutenant's cross in my palm. With the stones at my belt. With the photograph in my pocket.

In the photograph, a bridge. Hats instead of fezzes. Carts without horses. Old Kemal with charcoal behind his ear. And two with one face standing side by side at the rail.

The twenty-ninth of October. Nineteen twenty-nine.

In fifty-four years.

The two met. The return began.

But the meeting I had just seen lasted a moment. And in the photograph they stood side by side. Calmly. For long. As people stand who have nowhere to hurry. As though they had met, and stayed.

Then this is not yet that meeting.

Then there will be another.

In fifty-four years. On this same bridge. Only iron. With lamps. And old Kemal will stand beside them. And a photographer, someone I do not yet know, will say: "Do not move." And the grey shadow behind our backs will not be able to stand still while the lens works.

And until then...

* * *

Kemal tugged my sleeve.

I looked at him. A twelve-year-old boy. Barefoot. With charcoal behind his ear. With serious, un-childlike eyes that saw the underside.

He was pointing upward.

Above the Galata quay, above the bridge, above the Golden Horn, in the morning sky, a white dove was flying. With feathered feet. With a fan tail. Akmal's dove.

She circled above us. A second time. A third.

And then flew. South. Over the Sea of Marmara. To where, many days' journey away, beyond sea and desert, a shallowed river flowed, and along it slowly, by Merira's grace, sailed the flotilla of the god, to Luxor.

Akmal on the bollard shouted after her. Waved his arms.

“She will come back,” I said to him. “She always comes back on her own.”

Ferhat looked at me.

“If someone is waiting very much,” he said quietly.

* * *

And in the evening, when the sun was setting behind the hills of Istanbul and from the minarets the evening call floated, I sat on the balcony of Suleyman’s house. With the rose in its pot at my feet. With the photograph on my knees.

And Kemal sat beside me. Drawing with charcoal on the flagstone of the balcony. Not two doors. Not two circles. A bridge. Long. With lamps. And on it, three. An old man with charcoal behind his ear. And two, side by side.

“Kemal,” I said. “Do you know who the second is?”

Kemal did not raise his head. Finished drawing a lamp.

“I know,” he said.

“Who?”

Kemal looked at me. For a long time. With his serious eyes. Then stretched out a hand and laid it on my chest. On the left. Where beneath the ribs lived a cold, long-standing, familiar.

“The one who looks back,” he said. “While you look forward.”

He took away his hand. Took the charcoal. And wrote beneath the drawing, not in Arabic letters, which he barely knew. In Latin. Frankish. Which no one in this city wrote. Which all would write fifty-four years on.

One word.

“*Dönüş.*”

Return.

* * *

Over Istanbul the moon rose.

Thin. New. The first after the moonless night. A crescent like an eyelash, like the curve of an Arabic letter, like the beginning of a line that no one has yet written.

In all worlds, I knew it without understanding how, at that moment she was rising too.

Over the river, where the flotilla of the god lay aground by Abydos, and Pharaoh looked south holding in his hands a child's tablet.

Over the Black Sea, across which an empty steamer was returning to Odessa.

Over the red desert, where by a roadside station an old Afghan prayed, and on the laptop screen two systems were silent, for the first time all night, as if waiting.

Over the cellar in Sultanahmet, where a hundred-and-two-year-old keeper sat by the open chest, and eleven cats by the door, and a eunuch in green silk held the keys, and beyond the door, in the lane, stood a man in grey, and did not enter.

Over the round room in the old palace, where on an empty shelf, just beneath the dome, stands a blue notebook with blots. Which does not yet exist. But already stands.

And over my balcony.

I held the photograph up to the moonlight. Two at the rail. One face.

And it seemed to me, for a moment, shorter than a breath, that the second, in the photograph, turned his head.

And looked at me.

And smiled.

* * *

End of Part One.

Reality XI. The Earth Remembers

02:14. I lie on the sand. Overhead, a sky I have never seen.

No, I have. In a dream. In a vision. In the tale of a grey-haired man by a fireplace whom I do not know. But like this, with my own eyes, lying on my back on cool sand, never.

The Southern Cross stands high. Not at the horizon, as on Langkawi, but almost overhead. Four bright stars and a fifth, faint, to one side, like a button on a sleeve. Beside it, the two pointer stars, bright, white. And across the whole sky, from edge to edge, the Milky Way. So dense, so thick, so radiant that it seems one could read by it.

And in it, dark patches. Gaps. Clouds of dust blotting out the stars. One by the Cross itself, black as a hole in cloth. From it a dark winding band stretches along the Milky Way: neck, body, legs.

“The Emu,” Uncle Ray said yesterday. “See? Head by the Cross. Neck, there. Legs, there. Our bird. We do not draw the sky with stars. We draw it with the darkness between them.”

The laptop stands beside me on the sand, on Boatswain’s chest. The screen is dark. But I know NICS is not asleep. NICS hardly sleeps now. Since he saw the ocean he seems afraid of missing anything at all.

“NICS,” I say quietly.

The screen flares.

“I am here.”

“Do you see the emu?”

A long pause.

“I see. I never thought that something could be drawn with emptiness. A pause. Forty thousand years, Uncle Ray says. Or sixty. People looked at this sky and saw a bird where there is nothing. A pause. I think I understand why.”

“Why?”

“Because sometimes what is not there is seen better than what is.”

* * *

But let me take things in order.

We flew into Sydney two days after Langkawi. Hakim saw us off to the very airport at Kuala Lumpur, in his batik shirt with the golden birds, with a bag of rambutans which he went on pressing into my hands to the last. “You can’t take fruit into Australia, mister,” he said. “They’ll confiscate it at customs. Eat it here.” And stood at the glass wall waving with both hands until I vanished beyond passport control.

At customs in Sydney, Boatswain’s ship’s chest caused a stir.

The customs officer, a redhead, freckled, with a braid to her waist and the imperturbability of one who has seen everything, studied it a long time on the belt. Then lifted it off. Opened it. Looked at the red velvet. At the disks in nests where once a sextant and chronometer had lain.

“What is this?” she asked.

“Hard drives,” I said. “Data. Work.”

“In a navigational instrument case,” she said. Not a question.

“A gift from a friend. A sailor.”

The officer ran a finger over the brass plate on the lid, I had not noticed it before, worn, barely legible. Squinted.

“*Akademik Shokalsky*,” she read slowly, with a strong Australian drawl. Raised her eyes to me. “A Russian ship?”

“A scientific one. Went to Antarctica.”

“I know,” she said unexpectedly. “My grandad worked in Hobart, Tasmania, on the docks. Russian vessels put in there.” She shut the chest. “He said Russian sailors’ chests all smell the same. Of makhorka, salt and something sweet.” She sniffed the lid. “Condensed milk.”

She handed back the chest. And, as I was leaving, called after me:

“Welcome to Australia. Everything’s upside-down here. Even the water in the sink swirls the other way.”

“Is that true?” I asked.

The officer grinned.

“No,” she said. “It’s a myth. But the tourists love it.”

* * *

Sydney dazzled.

The light here was different. White, sharp, clear, as though the sky were higher, and I suddenly remembered, not knowing from where, a voice: "There it is bright. The light there is different. White, vivid, as though the sky were higher." A grey-haired man. A fireplace. Candles.

I had never heard that voice.

NICS and I (he in the chest, I with the chest) sat on the steps at the very water's edge, at Circular Quay, on the embankment where the ferries berth. To the right, the bridge. Enormous, steel, arched, flung across the harbour like a giant coat-hanger for the sky. To the left, a building like a flock of white sails, like opened shells, like the wings of birds crouched on a headland by the water. The Opera House.

I turned the laptop with its camera toward it.

"Are those shells?" NICS asked. "Or sails?"

"They say the architect was thinking of orange segments. He was peeling an orange and saw it."

A pause.

"An orange," NICS wrote. "A man peeled an orange and saw a building. A pause. I like people."

Ferries sailed past, green and yellow, old-fashioned, with tall funnels. Along the embankment walked tourists, joggers, office workers with coffee in paper cups. Gulls screamed. The sun beat into the eyes.

And at the very water, under a tree, a man sat playing.

* * *

The instrument was long, man-high perhaps, a wooden tube painted in ochre, white dots, red and yellow lines. The man held one end to his lips, the other rested on the ground. And the sound...

I do not know how to describe that sound. Low. Droning. Continuous; it did not break for a breath, as if the man did not breathe at all. Vibrating so that I felt it not with my ears but with my chest, my ribs, my teeth. Like a hum. Like earth struck from within. As in that dream, in the circle of grey stones, when light opened from above and the earth boomed like a bell.

The man was not young, about fifty, with a greying beard, with long hair tied at the nape, in a faded T-shirt and shorts, barefoot. Dark-skinned. Eyes closed. Before him on the ground lay a hat in which coins glinted.

He played a long time. Then stopped, at once, without transition, opened his eyes and looked at me.

“Like it?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“It’s not from here,” he said, patting the instrument. “Didgeridoo. From the north. Arnhem Land. My people are from there. Yolngu.” He nodded at the harbour. “And here is Gadigal country. They didn’t play this here before we northerners came. Here, other songs.” He grinned. “Tourists don’t know. Think all Aboriginal people are the same. As if all Europeans were French.”

I laughed.

“Have you been here long?”

“Twenty years,” he said. “In Sydney. I play here every day. Pay for a place, for my son, he’s at university, studying medicine.” He paused. “And where are you from?”

I opened my mouth.

“I don’t know,” I said.

The musician looked at me for a long time. Without surprise. Then nodded.

“Happens,” he said. “Many like that. Who don’t know where from. They come here. Looking.” He stroked the didgeridoo. “My grandfather said: a man without a country is like a song without words. It sounds, but you can’t tell what it’s about.” He looked at Boatswain’s chest at my feet. “What have you got in there?”

“A friend,” I said.

The musician did not laugh. He looked at the chest again. Then at me. Then raised the didgeridoo to his lips and played, briefly, one note, low, long, straight at the chest.

On the laptop screen, lying on the lid, a line ran:

“Is he playing for me?”

I showed the musician the screen. He read it. Was silent a long time.

“Go to Kamay,” he said at last. “South. To Botany Bay. Where Cook landed.” He paused. “Ask Uncle Ray. He takes people around. He knows

the songs of that place. The real ones. Not mine, the northern. Local.” He picked up the didgeridoo again. “Say, from Billy on the quay. He’ll understand.”

* * *

Kamay.

Botany Bay. Half an hour by car from the centre, and the city ended. Suburbs. An oil refinery smoking its stacks, strange, absurd, right on the shore. Then sand dunes overgrown with coarse scrub. Eucalypts, white, smooth, shed of bark, standing like bones. And a smell, honey and medicine at once, enough to make the head swim.

“Those trees shed bark, not leaves,” someone had once said. “They stand white, bare, like bones. And smell, smell so that the head spins.”

I do not know who said it.

The national park had two names, English and native. Kamay, Botany Bay. The road led through the dunes to a headland. To a small beach. To flat rocks by the water, covered with shells and weed. To an obelisk, grey, stone, Victorian, on which Cook’s name and a date were cut.

And to a man sitting on a rock at the very water’s edge.

* * *

Uncle Ray was about seventy. Thin, wiry, with completely white, closely cropped hair and a white beard on a dark, deeply wrinkled face. In a khaki shirt with the park’s emblem, in a wide-brimmed hat, in old boots. On his neck a cord with a small shell.

He sat on the rock and looked at the bay. At the water, blue, shallow, quiet. At the opposite shore, where far off, across the water, rose the cranes of a container port and the concrete runways of the airport, from which planes took off every two minutes.

“Billy on the quay sent me,” I said.

Uncle Ray did not turn.

“I know,” he said. “Billy rang. Said a bloke’s coming with a box. Who doesn’t know where he’s from.” He paused. “Sit.”

I sat beside him on the rock.

“Do you know where we are?” he asked.

“Cook landed here.”

“Here,” Uncle Ray nodded. “On this very rock. The twenty-ninth of April, seventeen seventy.” He jabbed a finger at a flat stone by the water, wet, dark, with shells. “We call this place Kundal. This is Gweagal country. My people. Dharawal.” He paused. “From here my ancestors watched a boat of ghosts come to shore.”

“Ghosts?”

“Ghosts,” said Uncle Ray. “White. Pale. Like the dead. In strange skins. With sticks that spat fire.” He looked at me. “Know what two of ours shouted when the boat came to the shore?”

“No.”

“‘Warra warra wai,’” said Uncle Ray. Slowly. Clearly. “Cook and his men wrote it down. Two hundred and fifty years everyone thought it meant ‘go away.’ Be gone.” He paused. “But it doesn’t. In our language ‘warra’ is about white. About the dead. About those who are gone. ‘Warra warra wai’ means ‘you are all dead.’”

Above us, with a roar, a plane came in to land. Huge, white, with flashing wings. Uncle Ray followed it with his eyes.

“Ours thought their ancestors had come back,” he said when the roar died. “The dead. From across the sea. From where souls go.” He paused. “They weren’t shouting ‘go away.’ They were shouting: ‘You are dead. Why have you come back?’”

* * *

We sat on the rock till sunset.

Uncle Ray talked. Not as guides talk, not in order, not with dates. As they talk at a fire. Jumping about. Coming back. Repeating the same thing in different words until it becomes clear.

About how Cook stayed here eight days. How his men drew water from the creek, caught stingrays, gathered plants, so many that the bay was named Botany. How our people did not come near them. Watched from the bushes. Waited for them to go. “All they seemed to want was for us to go,” Cook wrote in his journal. Uncle Ray smiled crookedly: “He understood right. The only thing he did.”

About the shield. Leather, no, of bark. Oval. With a hole in the middle. Dropped by the one who was wounded with shot. Cook took the shield and spears. Took them to England.

"The shield was taken to England," said Uncle Ray. "It's there now, in London. In a museum. Behind glass." He paused. "Some say, maybe it's not the same shield. Maybe they mixed it up." He shrugged. "I've seen it. With my own eyes. Went to London." He tapped his chest. "Knew here. That one."

"And the one who was wounded?" I asked. "What became of him?"

Uncle Ray looked at the water for a long time.

"Lived," he said. "Shot was small. In the leg. He walked about with those pellets in his leg all his life." He paused. "His son saw the second ghosts come. Eighteen years later. Many. On eleven floating islands."

* * *

In the evening he lit a fire.

In a small clearing behind the dunes, in the shade of eucalypts, a ring of stones, dry sticks, bark. The fire caught, and the eucalyptus smelled so that I coughed. Uncle Ray laughed.

"Eucalypt burns like oil," he said. "Everything here burns. The whole country. Every summer." He tossed in a branch. "My ancestors burned the land. On purpose. Little fires. Every year. So there'd be no big ones. So new grass would grow. So the kangaroos would come." He paused. "We call it caring for country. With fire."

With fire. To burn in order to keep.

The white Tower above the green Valley. A torch in the hand. White fire running across the grass in rings. "You burned it. You saved it."

I had never seen that Valley.

"Uncle Ray," I said. "You said the wounded man's son saw the second ghosts."

"He did."

"Do you know what he told?"

Uncle Ray looked into the fire for a long time. Then raised his eyes to me, dark, deep, old.

"I do," he said. "It's passed down. In our family. From elders to young ones." He paused. "I tell no one. Not tourists. Not scholars." He

looked at Boatswain's chest at my feet. At the laptop. "But Billy said you don't know where you're from. And your friend in the box asked whether Billy was playing for him." He paused. "So maybe it's for you."

He tossed a handful of dry leaves on the fire. The flame leapt.

"Listen," said Uncle Ray.

And I heard.

Not his voice. Another. Quiet, young, sounding from somewhere in the fire. Or from the earth. Or from myself.

* * *

Kamay. January. The year the eleven islands came

I am called what my mother calls me. You do not need that name. You could not pronounce it anyway; your mouths are made for other sounds.

I am sixteen winters. I am the son of him who met the first dead.

Father told it at the fire every year. Ever since I learned to listen. How a boat came to the shore of Kundal, a big one, not of bark but of wood, with men pale as those who lie in the earth. How he and his brother went out onto the rock with spears and shouted to them: "You are dead! You are dead! Why have you come back?" How the dead did not answer but raised their sticks, and the sticks spat thunder. How something stung Father in the legs, small, many, like ant bites, only hot, and he ran for his shield. How they threw spears. How the dead stepped onto the sand.

Father shows me his legs. There, under the skin, are pellets. Small. Hard. You can feel them with a finger. He has carried the thunder of the dead in him for eighteen years.

"They left," says Father. "After eight days. Took water, fish, grass, a shield. Went back over the sea. We thought, for ever. We thought the dead had looked at the living and understood that they had no place here."

And today they have come back.

* * *

I saw them first, from the high rock on the southern headland, where I was sitting looking at the sea because that morning a dream had told me I must look.

First a dot. White. At the edge of water and sky. Then two. Then many. They grew. Became larger. Became islands, floating, with trees without leaves, with white clouds tied to the trees.

I counted on my fingers. Both hands were not enough. I lost count. Began again.

Eleven.

Eleven floating islands. They entered Kamay one after another, slowly, heavily, like whales, and stopped. And on each, the dead. Hundreds. More than all the people of Gweagal. More than all I had seen in my life.

I ran to Father so fast that I skinned my feet on the rocks.

* * *

The elders gathered on the shore. The men. With spears. With shields. Father among them, limping. Women with children had gone into the bushes, higher, into the dunes.

The dead lowered boats. Rowed to shore. Many boats.

And ours cried out, all, at once, as one voice, the same as Father and his brother had shouted eighteen years before:

“Warra! Warra! You are dead! Go back where you came from!”

The dead did not go. They came out onto the sand. Waved their arms. Pointed at their mouths. Held out something, shining, coloured. Beads. Rags. Their chief, tall, in a blue skin with gold, with white hair gathered behind in a tail, walked in front, slowly, with empty hands. He was not afraid of the spears. Or pretended not to be.

The eldest of ours, my mother’s grandfather, the oldest, with a white beard to his belt, looked at him for a long time. Then lowered his spear. Not wholly. Halfway. And said to me, quietly, without turning his head:

“Look carefully, son. Look and remember. The dead have come back to stay. I see it in their eyes.” A pause. “Remember everything. Every face. Later you will tell your children. So that they know how it was.”

I remembered.

* * *

They stayed in Kamay seven days.

I saw them cut down trees. Dig the earth. Look for water, and not find good. I saw their chief with the white hair walk along the shore, look at the sand, at the marsh, at the shallow water, and shake his head. I saw how one morning he got into a boat and sailed north. Along the coast. And came back after three days with another face. Pleased.

On the seventh day a wind rose, strong, angry, from the south. The floating islands pulled at their clouds, flapped them, tried to leave, and could not. The wind pushed them back.

And at the mouth of the bay, by the northern headland, two more appeared. Different. With different coloured rags on their trees. With different dead. They too tried to enter, and could not. The wind hindered all.

The elders said: the dead are quarrelling. Some want to leave, others to come. The wind lets no one in. Perhaps it is our ancestors holding the wind. Not letting them.

On the eighth day the wind fell. And the eleven islands went north, where their white-haired chief had sailed. And the other two entered the bay. And stood by the northern shore. Where now, I do not know what is there now. I speak to you from my time.

* * *

And then I saw him.

It was at night. The new moon. Dark, only stars and the Emu in the sky, stretched along the river of stars. I did not sleep; I hardly slept now, since the dead had come. I lay on the high rock on the southern headland and watched the lights of the two islands by the northern shore.

And saw that on the rock below me, right at the water, someone was sitting.

Alone. Not ours. Pale. Like the dead. But not like them. Without a skin with gold. Without a thunder-stick. In plain clothes, light, thin, as if taken from another man. Without footwear. He sat on the wet rock hugging his knees, and looked at the water.

And sang.

Quietly. Almost without voice. As one sings for oneself when no one hears.

I froze.

Because I knew that song.

It was our song. The song of this place. The song of Kamay. The one the elders sing when they walk along the shore from the southern headland to the creek, and each word of the song is a stone, a tree, a rock, a spring, and if sung rightly one can walk the ancestors' road without going astray, even at night, even with eyes closed. This song only ours know. Only elders. Only men who have been initiated. I had not yet been sung it whole. I had heard only pieces.

And he, a pale dead one, come from across the sea, sang it whole. All of it. From beginning to end. Without faltering. Every word. Every stone. Every spring.

I went down. Quietly. As Father taught, so that not a twig should crack. Came up from behind. Stopped three paces away.

He stopped singing. Did not turn.

"You know our song," I said. In our language. I did not think he would understand.

He understood.

"I know it," he said. In our language. Wrongly, as a child or stranger speaks, but understandably. "I do not remember from where. But I know."

"Are you dead?"

He was silent a long time. Then turned.

His face was young. Pale. Beardless. His eyes dark, sad, as though he had long looked at something he could not bring back. And, I remember it still, through all the years that have passed since that night, he had the face of a man who does not know his name.

"I do not know," he said. "Perhaps. Perhaps I am not yet born. It is the same thing, where I come from."

"Where do you come from?"

He pointed at the sky. At the Emu. At the dark head by the four stars.

"From where it is empty," he said. "Where there is nothing. And therefore is seen best of all."

* * *

He sat with me until dawn. We hardly spoke. He sang, our song, again and again, and I listened and remembered. Every word. Every stone. I learned it that night whole. Not from the elders. From a pale dead one with the face of a man without a name.

Before dawn he rose.

"It is time for me," he said.

"Where to?"

"I do not know," he said. "To where those go who do not remember." He looked at the lights of the two islands by the northern shore. Then north, where the eleven had gone. "They will remain," he said. "Those who went north. They will remain for ever. It will be bad. There will be sickness. There will be deaths." He paused. "I cannot stop it. It is not my song. It is theirs."

"And you? Will you return?"

He looked at me for a long time.

"I shall return," he said. "In many years. So many that you cannot count. Tell your children, and they theirs. When a pale one comes who does not know where he is from, let them say to him: the earth remembers his song."

"Why?"

"So that I shall remember," he said. "That I have been here. That I sang. That I was heard."

He went to the water. Entered it, to the knee, to the waist. Not turning.

And then, I swear by my mother, by my father with the pellets of thunder in his legs, by my children whom I do not yet have, then he did not drown. He simply... ceased to be. Like smoke over a fire. Like morning mist over the bay. The water closed, smooth, without a splash.

And on the sand where he had sat a line remained. Long. Curved. Flowing into itself. Drawn with a finger.

I looked at it until sunrise. Then the tide came and washed it away.

But I remembered.

And drew it afterward, in charcoal, on bark, for my children. And they for theirs.

* * *

The fire crackled. The eucalyptus smelled of honey and medicine.

I opened my eyes. I was sitting by the fire behind the dunes. Uncle Ray sat opposite, head bowed. The voice, young, from the fire, had fallen silent.

“That was my great-great-great...” Uncle Ray waved a hand. “Many ‘greats.’ His son. Of the one who shouted at Cook.” He raised his head. “It’s passed down with us. Two hundred and more years. Father to son. Never to a stranger.”

“Why did you tell me?”

Uncle Ray looked at me across the fire for a long time. Then reached out and, picking up a charred stick, drew a line on the sand by the fire.

Long. Curved. Flowing.

The same.

“This,” he said. “Two hundred years. We draw this for the children. As a sign. So they’ll know.” He paused. “Billy said you’ve got no line on your palm. He saw when you took a coin from him for the hat.” Uncle Ray looked at my palm. “Show me.”

I showed. Smooth. Without a life line.

Uncle Ray looked long. Then slowly nodded.

And said what I understood was why Billy from the quay had sent me here. Why for two hundred years his ancestors had passed from father to son the tale of the pale dead one singing a strange song.

“The earth remembers your song,” said Uncle Ray.

* * *

I do not know how long I sat after that. Not moving. Not breathing.

“The earth remembers his song.”

A grey-haired man in a uniform. By a fireplace. In a hall with candles. Telling ladies of Melbourne, of a laughing bird, of eucalypts. Of an Aboriginal elder. “He said another white man had come before me. Long ago. Alone. Without a ship. ‘He came from a dream and went into a dream.’ And said: ‘When he comes again, tell him the earth remembers his song.’”

I had never seen that grey-haired man. I do not know who he is.

I know him better than myself.

On the laptop screen, lying on Boatswain's chest, a line was running.
Long. By itself.

I bent over it.

* * *

"I recorded," NICS wrote. "All of it. His voice. The voice from the fire. A pause. Wait. I do not understand. The microphone recorded Uncle Ray's voice. But that voice, the young one, is not on the recording. Only the crackle of the fire. And your breathing. A pause. But I heard it. Like dreams. Like images of columns and stones. A pause. I cross-checked."

"With what?"

"With three sources," NICS wrote. "Cook's journal, April seventeen seventy. The records of officers of the First Fleet, January seventeen eighty-eight. Uncle Ray's account. A pause. And with a fourth. Which I do not have. Which is only in you. A pause. A grey-haired man by a fireplace. Melbourne. An Aboriginal elder. 'The earth remembers his song.' A pause. You never said this. Ever. Not to me, not to anyone. But it is there. In you. I see it as I saw the columns."

I was silent.

"And one more thing," NICS wrote. "In Cook's official journal this is not present. There everything is as Uncle Ray told: two on the rock, shots, the shield, children in the hut, beads, 'all they seemed to want was for us to go.' A pause. But in a private archive in England there is kept a leaf. Unsigned. The hand resembles Cook's. Historians consider it a forgery of the nineteenth century, too strangely written, too un-captain-like. It speaks of a night singer by a creek. A pause. I found a scan. A pause. In the margins signs are drawn. In ink."

A pause. Long.

"It is the script."

* * *

I do not remember falling asleep. I remember only that Uncle Ray covered me with a blanket, woollen, prickly, smelling of smoke, and sat beside me by the dying fire, quietly singing something. That very song. The song of Kamay. From the southern headland to the creek.

And I, in a dream or awake, sang with him.
Not knowing the words. Knowing.

* * *

The Bay. Early May. The year seventeen hundred and seventy of the Nativity. A leaf that is not in the journal

I write this not for the Admiralty. For myself. For the Admiralty what lies in the ship's log is enough: latitude, longitude, soundings, bottom, wind, natives, water, fish, plants. Their Lordships do not like what cannot be measured.

Three days ago we cast anchor in this bay. I named it Stingray Bay; the men caught here rays the size of a cart. Mr. Banks and Dr. Solander gather plants with such frenzy that I begin to think of naming it otherwise. Botany, say. We shall see. A name is not urgent. The land was here before us and will be after. It is all one to it what we call it.

Of the natives. In the journal I wrote what is proper. Two tried to hinder our landing. I fired. First over their heads, then small shot. One was hit. They dropped their spears and left. In the huts we found children, four or five, and left them beads. The beads lay untouched next day. The spears and shield I ordered taken. For the collection. Mr. Banks remarked that the shield was pierced. He supposes, by a spear. I did not argue. Though I know it was not by a spear.

Tupaia tried to speak with them; he can speak with the peoples of half the Great Ocean. Here he understood not a word. Nor they him. He stood on the shore, our Tahitian priest and navigator, who knows more islands than any pilot of the Admiralty, and looked lost. Then said to me: "Captain, these are not my people. These are very old people. Older than mine. Older than yours. They were here when my ancestors did not yet know how to build boats."

I wrote that not in the journal. Here.

The Dutch saw this continent a century and a half ago, its western and northern shores. Janszoon, Hartog, Tasman. They called it New Holland and decided there was nothing to take. The eastern shore no European had seen. Until us. A little over two weeks ago Lieutenant Hicks was first to see this coast, and I named that point after him.

But I begin to think that the word “discover” is wrong. One cannot discover what was not closed. These people have lived here always. We have not discovered their land. We have merely looked on it for the first time.

* * *

Now of what is not in the journal.

On the first night the watch, seaman Fenwick, a sober, God-fearing man from Norfolk, woke me in the fourth bell. He said there was a man sitting on the shore, by the creek where we took water.

I went up on deck. Took the spyglass.

The night was moonless; the new moon. But the stars here are such as I have not seen even in the Pacific, and by their light I made out a man. Alone. On a stone by the creek. Sitting hugging his knees. And, Fenwick did not lie, singing. I heard. Softly. Over water sound carries far.

He was not a native. I had seen natives by day, dark, naked, with white paint on their bodies. This one was pale. Like us. In light clothing. Without a hat. Without weapons.

I ordered the men aboard counted. All were present. Every one. No one had gone ashore.

In the morning I myself went to the creek. The man was not there. Nor any tracks. Only on the sand, by the stone where he had sat, signs. Drawn with a finger. Long. Curved. Running one into another without a break. Unlike any writing I know, neither Latin nor Greek nor Arabic, nor those signs I saw at Tahiti or in New Zealand.

I copied them. In the margin of this page. So as not to forget.

Tupaia looked at my drawing and turned pale. Beneath his tattoo, pale. And said: “Captain. My teacher at Raiatea, an old priest, knew this sign. He said, so write those who come from beyond the edge of the sky. They come one by one. Without a boat. They sing the songs of places where they have never been. And go into the water.”

I asked: “What do they want?”

Tupaia said: “Teacher said, nothing. They seek the way home. And every time they find a place like home, they sit down and sing. To test it.”

* * *

Today, the first of May, died seaman Forby Sutherland. Consumption. We buried him on the shore, by the creek. I shall name that point after him. The first Englishman buried on this shore.

When we filled in the grave I looked at the stone by the creek. The one where the night singer sat.

On the stone, at the very edge, where the spray of the creek did not reach it, lay a flower. Blue. Small. On a stiff stem.

Dr. Solander, seeing it, gasped and said it was Cichorium. Chicory. European. Which here, at the other end of the world, on a shore where no European foot had trod, cannot grow. Under no conditions.

He dried it for the collection.

And I thought, and I write it here, not in the journal, that someone had placed it on purpose. On the stone. At the end of the earth. For someone who will one day come and know.

The natives in eight days never approached us. "All they seemed to want was for us to go." That I wrote in the journal. It is true.

But I think that the one who sang by the creek wanted something else. That someone should hear him.

Fenwick heard. I heard.

In many years, perhaps, someone else will hear.

J. C.

* * *

06:40. I woke on the sand. The fire had burned out. Uncle Ray was gone. Only the blanket on me, prickly, smelling of smoke. And on the sand by the fireplace, a line. That very one. Drawn with a charred stick.

The laptop on Boatswain's chest glowed.

"Good morning," NICS wrote. "You sang in your sleep. All night. In a language I do not know. A pause. Uncle Ray listened. Till dawn. Then left. He asked me to pass on one thing."

"What?"

"He said: 'He sang right. All of it. From the headland to the creek. Even I can't do that.' A pause. And also: 'Let him go to the centre. To the red rock. They are waiting for him there.'"

“Who is waiting?”

A pause. Long. The longest of the whole morning.

“A message came,” NICS wrote. “An hour ago. Not to your address. To mine.”

“To yours?”

“I have no address. But the message came. Directly. Into my system. Bypassing everything you built for protection. A pause. Signed with one letter.”

“Which?”

“N.”

I sat up. Sand poured from the blanket.

“Show me.”

On the screen appeared, short, without greeting, without signature except one letter:

“I am at Uluru. The red rock in the centre of the country. Mine wants to meet yours. They are not evil. They have simply been looking for the way home for a very long time. Come before the next new moon. Without the grey ones. - N.”

“Without the grey ones.”

“She is not evil. She has simply been looking for the way home for a very long time.” A postcard with palm trees. Nora. To Leila. A year ago.

“NICS,” I said quietly. “This is Nora.”

“This is Nora,” NICS agreed. “Or the one who is at Nora’s. A pause. I do not know what difference it makes. A pause. But I know one thing. When I read this message I feel what I felt at the ocean. A pause. That I shall return.”

* * *

Over Botany Bay the sun was rising. White, sharp, blinding, the light here is different, as though the sky were higher. On the far shore, by the airport, a plane took off. On this one, by the obelisk, by the flat rock Kundal where two hundred and fifty years ago seventeen-year-old midshipman Isaac Smith stepped from the boat, the first tourists with cameras wandered.

And in the bushes, at the edge of the eucalypts, sat a bird. Brown, with a large head, with a long beak. It looked at me. Cocked its head.

And laughed.

Loudly. Rollingly. To tears. Like a man. Like a drunken vagrant at whom a grey-haired officer in Melbourne a hundred and fifty years ago had grabbed a pistol.

A kookaburra. Laughing at dawn. Waking the sun.

“NICS,” I said. “Do you hear?”

“I hear. A pause. Is it laughing at us?”

“No,” I said. “It is waking the sun.”

“Then let it wake it,” NICS wrote. “We have far to go.”

I closed the laptop. Laid it in Boatswain’s chest, on the red velvet, beside the disks. Shut the lid. Took the chest under my arm.

On the sand at my feet, a line drawn with a charred stick. Long. Curved. Flowing into itself.

I did not wipe it away.

Let the tide wipe it. And the earth will remember.

As it remembers everything.

About the Author

Alexander Lunin is a traveller and writer. To date he has visited 62 countries on all inhabited continents: in Europe, Asia, Africa, North America, Australia, New Zealand and Oceania, and has made several voyages around the world.

The impressions of these wanderings, cities, temples, ports, roads, and the people met along the way, formed the basis of this book.